Linguistic Approaches to Literature

22

# Language, Discourse, Style

## Selected works of John McH. Sinclair

Edited by Sonia Zyngier

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Language, Discourse, Style

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**Volume 22**

Language, Discourse, Style. Selected works of John McH. Sinclair
Edited by Sonia Zyngier

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Selected works of John McH. Sinclair

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I am also deeply grateful to Ronald Carter and to Bill Louw for their contributions. But most of all, I am deeply indebted to John Sinclair, a most inspiring and generous mentor. He encouraged me throughout my career, taught me how to accept and take criticism, and trusted me with the editing of a selection of his works. I hope that, through this book, he will continue to be a source of inspiration to many, as he has been to me.

# Editor's preface

This book marks the completion of a long-awaited project by professionals, researchers and students interested in the integration of language and literature. In 2001, John Sinclair agreed that a collection of his works on teaching and stylistics could be useful to those dealing with this interface. However, other large projects took much of his time, and the present one was kept on the back burner, until now.

A free thinker, Sinclair was one of the most provocative, original and acknowledged linguists of the late 20th and early 21st centuries, who generously shared his ground-breaking ideas, inspired, and supervised generations of scholars. Always proposing future directions, Sinclair's production is still relevant to those seeking to develop more systematic and reliable analyses of verbal art in all its forms.

Indeed, John Sinclair is well-known for his work in corpus linguistics and for inaugurating the field of discourse analysis. His *Corpus, Concordance, Collocation* (1991) has been considered "the bible for a generation of corpus linguists" (Hoey 2007).[1] However, not enough is known about his contributions as a stylistician and a specialist of language and literature education. This volume fills in this gap.

By organizing his papers thematically and chronologically, this book provides a history of the evolution of John McH. Sinclair's contributions to stylistics, from textual to discoursal approaches. In these pages, the reader will realize both the timeliness of his theoretical thinking and how it developed from 1968 to 1997. From his very early writings through the later ones, the production reflects his conversational, sharp and crystal-clear style. In his own words, "The competent writer is sensitive to his readers in a similar way to a competent conversationalist" (Chapter 10, Section 1).

This volume illustrates the constant concern of a keen stylistician, looking for practical applications and carrying out microanalyses without losing sight of the macro-level. It also shows that Sinclair always insisted on analysing language as it occurs. The earlier papers belong to a time before computers could be used in classrooms. Despite the technological developments of today, the methodological procedures he proposes and illustrates throughout this book remain relevant and

1. In http://www.theguardian.com/news/2007/may/03/guardianobituaries.obituaries, accessed May 2016

his insistence on the need to look for ways that allow us to see beyond intuitions are still very much in line.

Not only because Sinclair was a careful, perceptive, and meticulous writer, but mainly in respect for his ideas, editing interventions have been kept to a minimum. The selected works include chapters, papers, and talks which have been published previously but in many different edited collections or journals. Here they have been formatted as chapters and presented in a coherent development. References that were forthcoming at the time of writing were attributed the date of publication and listed with the other ones at the end of the book. Titles for sections have been inserted at times for the sake of balance and uniformity.

For this volume, two of Sinclair's closest friends and long-time collaborators kindly agreed to contribute. Ronald Carter accepted to write the Introduction, and Bill Louw is responsible for the Coda, where he discusses the impact of Sinclair's work.

As the initial plan of organizing the writings into three parts had been previously reviewed by the author himself, this same structure was kept. Part I (Education, Language Teaching and Stylistics) contains four chapters on language pedagogy and curriculum issues. Here it is possible for the reader to understand Sinclair's concerns about how much theory teachers must know and his insistence that they should never lose sight of how language is used (Chapter 1). In Chapter 2, he offers a guideline for a curriculum where language and literature are integrated, as it is his understanding that mastering a language involves both linguistic and literary concerns. At the same time that linguists must take into account the aims and intentions of a speaker, and the effectiveness and quality of an utterance, literary analysts must understand that "the literary value of any literary statement is limited by the nature and quality of the language observation implied by it" (Chapter 2). In Chapter 3, Sinclair points out six features that students must know to be considered *linguistically aware*, including language productivity and creativity. Chapter 4 shows the evolution of Sinclair's contributions to language education once he had access to corpus studies. In this chapter, Sinclair does not deny intuition but illustrates how corpus evidence helps disclose patterns previously unnoticed by traditional grammars and that may have deep implications for language learning and literary interpretation. As regards teaching English as a foreign language, his suggestion is that teachers should focus on naturally-occurring language and make use of evidence that emerges from corpus work.

The five chapters in Part II (Linguistic Stylistics) provide practical bases for stylistics analyses of specific texts. To Sinclair, a poem is "a sample of a language; perhaps not a representative sample, but only carrying meaning because it can be referred to a description of a whole language" (Chapter 5). Thus, the chapters in this section offer categories that bring to light the structuring of poems. Chapter 5

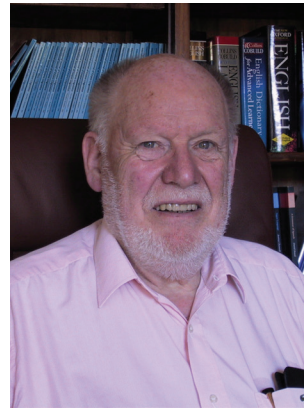
describes an experiment he carried out with his students using Keats's "La Belle Dame Sans Merci", arriving at the categories of 'analogy', 'revision', and 'approximation'. In Chapter 6, Sinclair analyses Philip Larkin's "First Sight" through an investigation of its sentence and clause structures, line and stanza boundaries, nominal, verbal and adverbial groups. He argues that aspects of meaning (what stylisticians do) can be described independently of evaluation (the task of literary critics). In Chapter 7, he describes how linguistic techniques may help the understanding of a literary text, in this case, "The Legs" by Robert Graves. Here Sinclair discusses 'acceleration', among other stylistic categories, always in search of meaning-carrying mechanisms that may bring together the public meaning of a text and the language patterns it is built on. Chapter 8 also examines meaningful patterning of a poem – Wordsworth's "Lines Composed a Few Miles above Tintern Abbey" – and details 'focats' ('focusing categories') that operate at the intersection between language patterns and literary interpretation, including here 'arrest' and 'extension'. His proposal is that a theory of literary communication may emerge if a finite set of focats is obtained. In Chapter 9, Sinclair provides six properties for literary style that are also common to natural languages: (i) arbitrariness between sign and referent, (ii) arbitrariness between proposition and exponence, (iii) structural superfluity, (iv) derivational hierarchy, (v) idiom, and (vi) reference. Always aiming at clarity, these writings provide minute and accurate analyses and sparkle with new ideas and evidence-based interpretations.

In Part III (Style and Discourse), the five chapters centre on how literary texts can be explained in a systematic, reliable and retrievable way at the level of discourse. In Chapter 10, Sinclair sees poetic discourse as quasi-interactions and uses a method of description derived from spoken discourse. Chapter 11 provides even more substance to the integration between language and literature at the level of discourse. Here he looks at a poem ("Krishna" by Edwin Thumboo) from the perspective of discoursal patterns. In Chapter 12, written as a keynote address delivered at the Poetics and Linguistics Association, the reader can find an unpretentious and quick-witted self-evaluation of Sinclair's academic trajectory, starting from his dissatisfaction with methods of literary analysis and moving towards a descriptive apparatus he considered more solid. Fictional worlds are dealt with in Chapter 13, where he states that "theories of language ignore fiction, theories of literature take it for granted, and philosophical works take up a variety of positions. This neglect is reflected in a tendency for fiction and non-fiction to be confused" (Chapter 13.1). To contribute with a model that distinguishes between fiction and non-fiction, he spells out the difference between fact and averral. Still looking at poems as verbal interactions, in Chapter 14 Sinclair explains an Elizabethan sonnet, providing evidence of its affinities to the conventions of spoken discourse.

From reflections about the interface between language and literature and its implications for teaching and curriculum planning through detailed analyses of text and discourse, this volume is invaluable to stylisticians, language and literature teachers, syllabus designers, college and university undergraduates, postgraduates and lecturers in the field. Most of all, it shows an inquisitive, independent scientist humble before knowledge, in constant pursuit of criticism and challenges.

A true Scotsman, John Sinclair used to celebrate Robert Burns's national day (Jan 25th) in a kilt, reciting "Address to a Haggis". Like Burns, Sinclair managed to convey complex ideas in the most economical phrasing. Much like the poet, Sinclair's style was witty as many of the texts here testify. On March 13th, 2007 he departed prematurely leaving numerous plans unfinished. With this book, we bring one of them to completion.

Sonia Zyngier, May 2016




*John McHardy Sinclair* (14 June 1933–13 March 2007)

# Introduction

## John Sinclair: Papers on Stylistics by Ronald Carter

*It is my belief that a new understanding of the nature and structure of language will shortly be available as a result of the examination of large collections of text. The language looks different when you look at a lot of it at once….*

(Sinclair 1991: xvii)

### John Sinclair: Academic worlds

John Sinclair (1933–2007) is one of the major figures in the field of linguistics. In a world of hype in which every academic appears to be undertaking cutting-edge research or to be paradigm-shifting or to be ground-breaking or internationally renowned, it is difficult to find words other than clichés to describe John Sinclair's achievement. It is perhaps merely sufficient to say that, like the production of J.R. Firth, by whom John was much influenced, his work will still be read and consulted fifty years from now; and that can be said of only very few academic researchers. And of very few can be it said that they have laid influential foundations for the establishment of two new academic sub-disciplines.

John Sinclair has a remarkable breadth of publications. He wrote and edited over thirty books and more than 100 articles in the fields of grammar, vocabulary, discourse analysis, lexicography, stylistics, language teaching and corpus linguistics and in the process laid significant foundations for two new sub-disciplines: those of spoken discourse analysis in the 1970s and corpus linguistics in the 1980s.

And in the 1980s he developed one of the largest-scale English language research projects the world has seen which produced the 400 million-word Bank of English corpus and resulted in a whole range of innovative dictionaries, grammars and teaching materials as part of the COBUILD project. Published in 1987 and dismissed at the time by most major publishers, the first COBUILD dictionary was so influential that all dictionaries and reference books, especially those for learners of English, are now based on corpora and have been affected by the principles of description and research which John Sinclair developed. In the 1990s and to the present day he has continued to innovate and push back frontiers of description, most markedly in the computational analysis of patterns of vocabulary and

grammar and has continued to develop accounts of the central importance of lexis in the theory of language.

John Sinclair is in a distinct tradition of British linguistics and applied linguistics which owes much to the foundations built by Professor J.R. Firth in the 1950s and extended by Professor Michael Halliday from the 1960s. In theory and practice, it runs counter to the dominant worldwide traditions for the study of language instigated by Noam Chomsky in the 1950s and 1960s. For Chomsky, language is a cognitive, biological phenomenon and has to be studied largely by means of methodologies which trust the intuitions of the researcher concerning language structure.

The position of John Sinclair is determinedly against such an orientation to language description and theory. Sinclair firmly holds the Firthian perspective which states that language should be studied as far as possible in naturally occurring social contexts of use, that it should work with extended examples (where possible complete texts), and should have at its centre the analysis of meaning. Indeed, at the heart of Sinclair's view is the inseparability of form and meaning.

> […] in all cases so far examined, each meaning can be associated with a distinct formal patterning […] There is ultimately no distinction between form and meaning […][The] meaning affects the structure and this is […] the principal observation of corpus linguistics in the last decade. (Sinclair 1991: 496)

This descriptive and analytical position regarding the inseparability of form and meaning has exerted a major influence on research into and analysis of language within the past decade. It has affected the design of pedagogical materials such as dictionaries and grammars, the place of linguistics in education, the analysis of literature and the fields in particular of discourse analysis and lexicology. It is a deeply and uncompromisingly empirical position. The key word for Sinclair is *evidence*. By 'evidence' he means the data provided by extensive multi-million word collections of texts together with the statistical support provided by the techniques of corpus linguistics. It also means an uncompromising rigour and descriptive detail when it comes to the analysis of the language used in literary texts.

## John Sinclair: Language and literature worlds

What, therefore, can be said to be the core messages offered by John Sinclair for the study of language and literature?

First, literary texts are special texts. He believed that, if not central, they should certainly not be peripheral to the study of language and linguistics. For Sinclair, literary texts are instances of language in use and he regretted that such

texts were commonly neglected by linguists. Indeed, they represent for him a particular challenge as they involve processes of communication which are essentially displaced and indirect; the levels or planes of communication cannot be directly attributed to the voice or voices or 'authorial' positions in the text and such indirectness represents a particular challenge to description. He also regretted the relative neglect by literary scholars of the uses of linguistic methods in the exploration of literary texts; he believed very strongly that language and literary study could be integrated. He continued to be gratified by the increasing growth of language studies in departments of English and the continuing development of programmes, from high school through to postgraduate university courses, that promote this integration.

Second, literary texts are continuous with all other texts. Literary texts are commonly accorded special value within a community or culture and are also sometimes often taken as a sole point of departure for the study of English in educational institutions worldwide. Sinclair was, however, committed to the study, description and evaluation of a wider range of texts and believed that literary texts are an important focus but should not form an exclusive focus of study for English degrees. The study of English should be sufficiently catholic to embrace a wide a variety of texts and text types.

Third, if literary texts are to be studied within a framework of language and linguistics, then it should be done properly. By properly, he means that the text itself cannot be overlooked or be seen simply as some kind of illustration of general points about an author's life or about literary and cultural history or simply as the source of hermeneutical dispute. Every detail of the text has to be examined if a true picture is to emerge and that a text has to be seen not autonomously but as part of a network of other texts. In the latter stages of his research, that network is illuminated by reference to corpus databases as well as by corpus linguistic techniques so that statements made have to be verified with reference to other texts of the same or similar or of different types, each with their own disposition of linguistic features and each with their own provenance in the corpus. Descriptions of language are corpus-driven in that the corpus tells us what the facts are. And the larger and more representative the corpus the greater the attestation which is possible. It is a positive extension and enrichment of the Firthian tradition. As John Sinclair himself puts it in one of his most definitive books *Corpus, Concordance and Collocation* (1991: 4), "The ability to examine large text corpora in a systematic manner allows access to a quality of evidence that has not been available before." Literary texts draw from the same sources of language in use as any other text and should, according to John Sinclair, be examined in the same way.

Fourth, texts defined as literary are highly regarded. They may be valued differently at different times and by different reading communities but they can be

appreciated by the extent to which they endure over time. However, the notion of evaluation needs to be interrogated more fully at the interfaces between language use and all types of texts; this needs to be especially so at the interfaces between language and literary text. Such a practice is also central to the pedagogies underlying the teaching of language, of literature and of both in an integrated way.

For Sinclair, evaluation could not be said to take place unless the analyst gave a detailed, replicable and retrievable account of the linguistic constituency of the text. Too often, he would argue, literary critics become preoccupied with everything and anything except with the way that language works. Or, if they do consider language, discussion is undertaken at best impressionistically. For him, literature is made from language. He was not so naïve as to believe that meaning was wholly a text-immanent matter but language is the primary medium of a literary text and evaluation has to start and stop with the ways in which the language of that literary text is used. There are numerous exemplifications of this position and practice in this volume from the earliest days of the paper "Taking a Poem to Pieces" on a contemporary poem by Philip Larkin (Chapter 6) through to the paper "Passion Speechless Lies" on an Elizabethan sonnet (Chapter 14). In some cases, such as in his analysis of the Larkin poem, he would almost deliberately court charges of reductiveness and would stop provocatively short of any interpretation of the text, as if to underline the primacy of replicable description.

He stood, of course, for more than these four main foci and the volume of his papers here illustrates this abundantly; but these themes and concerns recur throughout all the papers over the many years they represent and have been highly influential on the field of stylistics.

## Beginnings and endings

If I may be allowed a final personal note, I count myself extremely fortunate to have worked with John Sinclair over a period of thirty years. He supervised my Ph.D. at the University of Birmingham and was editor of a series which published two of my earliest books. Together we edited a series for OUP called *Describing English Language* and we worked together closely on *Trust the Text*, published by Routledge in 2004, and in which many of his most significant and influential papers on discourse and corpus linguistics were collected and re-edited.

As is often the case with the most major scholars, John Sinclair was a deeply modest man who taught those whom he supervised as postgraduates to become independent researchers, encouraging them to pursue challenges over a long period of time, as he did. He did not fear criticism and indeed often sought it out as a way of enabling him to challenge the tenets of his own thinking. He was

naturally combative, sometimes acerbically, but more often with a light and ironic touch. John was a kind man and endlessly supportive to friends and family. He was unfailingly generous with his time. Once you had his confidence he would never let you down; and he was always willing to share his ideas and analyses in a spirit of collaborative endeavor. He remained throughout Scottish at heart and was proud of it.

It is no more than yet another cliché to say that he continues to be much missed by many and that his inestimable influence will live on. But then clichés, like hype, are sometimes true. This volume is an eloquent and truthful testimony to all that he stood and stands for at the interface between language and literature.

Professor Ronald Carter
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University of Nottingham and
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June 1, 2016

PART I

# Education, language teaching and stylistics

CHAPTER 1

# Linguistics and the teaching of English*

## 1.1 Introduction

The phrase 'English teacher' throughout this chapter refers to someone who teaches English to young native English speakers. An English teacher may never consciously divide his functions into 'lang.' and 'lit.' work, but this must not obscure the fact that he is a language teacher just as much as is a teacher of any other language to native or foreign pupils. In recent years there has been a growing amount of discussion between language teachers and linguists about the ways in which modern theories of language, and descriptive works based on these theories, might help the task of the teacher. This chapter briefly examines, first, the price the English teacher has to pay for his linguistics and what his motivation to purchase should be and, second, what criteria he should use in his choice from what is offered and likely to be offered.

SECTION I. What does the English teacher need to know about linguistics and the structure of the English language?

## 1.2 Direct teaching

It is open to the English teacher to teach courses in the structure of English, where at least part of his aim is to give his pupils an understanding of the categories and methods of modern linguistic description. It is also well inside his terms of reference to teach courses in general linguistics. This might take many forms. He might show the relationship of English to other languages, perhaps, or the relationships between speaking and other human activities, or he might tackle theory in the context of the description of the native language. An English teacher, again, might feel strongly that his pupils should be able to transcribe speech with some precision, and he would therefore prepare courses on phonetics.

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* This article appeared originally in Marckwardt, A.H. (ed.). 1968. *Language and Language Learning*, 31–41. Champaign IL: NTE

Courses such as these would be in the familiar tradition of language teaching; they would involve formal displays of the results of language analysis, and the displays would be offered for their own sakes in the first instance. There are many such courses being offered today; the spread of the 'new' grammar is not much slower than the recession of the 'old' grammar, and the pace of the spread is accelerating.

At the present time, no resolution of the problems of the nature of formal teaching can be seen. The Dartmouth Seminar, one hopes, will make a significant advance by stating the problems clearly and separating them from each other. 'Old' structural teaching seems to have failed the test of time; 'new' structural teaching offers only potential and faces a hail of criticism and gloomy prognostication. The last ten years have seen great changes in linguistic theory, but the textbooks and the background books are just beginning to record and analyse and interpret these advances; their possible and actual effect on the classroom cannot be assessed for several years. One certain feature of the professional scene in the coming years will be controversy over the role of direct linguistics teaching from the cradle onwards.

What does the teacher need to know? Clearly we cannot specify anything as a necessity in advance of an evaluation of the results of experiment. But the existence of the controversy makes it essential that an English teacher know enough about linguistics to make up his own mind. The last two years have seen the start of the supply of information and opinion directly to teachers in the form of books written specially for them, some of them too recent to be taken into account in this chapter. Presumably an English teacher in training at present will study these books in detail.

We can go no farther than that. A closer look at the content of linguistics courses, or a survey of specific arguments on their educational basis, would lie outside the title of this chapter. They would rather be answers to the question "What does the pupil need to know?" with an inference that the teacher would have to know too. All we must prescribe for the English teacher as regards teaching of linguistics (including formal structural teaching) is enough knowledge to evaluate the changing scene, to experiment with new approaches, and to calculate the effect of the advances on his teaching as a whole. No less is expected of a teacher in any other subject.

## 1.3 The teacher as a linguist

We now leave aside the question of what is taught explicitly in the classroom and turn to what may not be so obviously taught. Linguistics is often offered as a suggestion to language teachers, as if it were something they could reject. This is implied, for example, in my title. Now of course it is open to a teacher to reject any particular brand of linguistics or to regard it as of limited or of general use in his execution of his duties, but he cannot teach English without *some* linguistics.

He may conceal it from his pupils and even largely from himself; he may play down the language side as much as possible. But the teaching of a language inevitably implies the analysis of it. Syllabuses must be prepared, and lessons within syllabuses. Standards must be defined. The pupils must be assessed. No pupil could survive such an exposure to language analysis without acquiring from his teacher (a) a general attitude to language and (b) a very large number of observations about the structure of the language.

We need look no farther than learning to read and write to see the truth of this statement. The pupil must examine his sound system and imbibe a writing system from scratch. He must understand what a transcription is. Some explanation must be offered him for the existence of ambiguities in his speech and his writing, explanation also for the much vaunted oddities thrown up by a lack of correlation between the two systems. He must be given reasons why he must learn to read and write, and so he will also learn something of the social role of linguistic communication.

The linguistic sciences attempt to answer the question "What is the nature of those parts of our physical, mental, and social organisation which enable us to attach an arbitrary significance to utterances?" The native language teacher is the first person a child meets who is professionally concerned with providing a partial answer to this question, whether he means to or not.

The duty of the teacher is quite clear. If his views on the nature of language are going to rub off anyway, it is up to him to examine them most critically in the light of what full-time linguists have to say. If his detailed knowledge of the structure of his native language is going to pervade a great deal of his teaching, he should feel secure that it is the best available. This argues a heavy commitment to linguistics, since it demands not only intellectual understanding of the subject but daily practical use of it. In turn, linguistic theory and descriptions will have to meet conditions like those to be set out in Section II.

## 1.4 Traditional grammar

It is too early yet to say that we have got rid of traditional grammar and oversimplified standards in favour of either superior analytical systems or another sort of approach altogether. We are apt to forget that we still have the inheritance of what we learned ourselves. We have, for example, a rich and flexible international terminology for language analysis, so valuable that modern linguistics is adapting it rather than replacing it. We have the socio-linguistic status quo in the received standards of correctness, attitudes to dialects, and jargons and linguistic change. We have our own conditioned responses (e.g., to bad spelling) which may still surprise us. It is difficult for the established present-day English teacher to imagine what it is like *not* to know a system of analysing the language, nor to have

hairspring sensitivity to the indexical features of language. We can reject tradgram from our syllabuses but not from our own thoughts and attitudes.

Two points emerge from the preceding. One, outside the terms of this chapter, would be a discussion of what it is like to be ignorant of the analysis of one's native language. The other is that a teacher needs training in how to be objective about his own linguistic behaviour, prejudices, and automatic reactions.

## 1.5 The native speaker as learner

Someone who teaches English to foreign pupils in their own country is often the only model that the pupils have. Someone teaching English to foreign students in the United Kingdom or the United States has to take into account the other models to which his students will be exposed. Someone teaching English to native speakers faces the problem that his pupils are already expert at some important aspects of English and that they therefore set different standards of explanation. An explanation of, say, a grammatical point, which a pupil can compare with his knowledge and experience of English, and which survives the comparison, is useful; one which is inaccurate is at best useless and at worst confusing. It is unwise to take liberties with native speakers or to underestimate their powers of detecting inconsistencies in linguistic argument. They may not be explicit about inaccuracies, but they will recognise them just the same. The utility value of what they learn about their language will depend largely on how far they can perceive it correlating with their internalised competence.

A great deal more research is needed on the relationship between what the native speaker is taught about his language and what he already knows. In the meantime we should play safe and adopt aims like

a. precision of statement, no matter how elementary or how disguised,
b. coherence of statements with regard to each other so that a consistent picture is built up by the pupil,
c. full explanations for all attempts to alter a pupil's linguistic habits.

To carry out these aims, a teacher would require considerable linguistic expertise.

## 1.6 Section I: Summary

It appears from the foregoing that the minimum linguistic competence required of an English teacher must be sufficient knowledge

a. to assess continuously the role of direct teaching of linguistics in the classroom,
b. to express, directly or not, views about the nature of language and the structure of English which accord with the best scholarship available,
c. to counterbalance the effects of his own learning of English,
d. to guarantee the native speaker that the linguistic apparatus which will be used on or near him will be as self-consistent and comprehensive as possible.

Nothing short of a proper professional training in linguistics will suffice. No case has been made here for specialised English language teachers. Every English teacher needs to learn about the present state of linguistics. Every teacher needs to be able to follow developments in theory and description throughout his teaching career.

SECTION II. What are the properties of a linguistic theory such that the description of English will be the most valuable to teachers of English?

## 1.7 Linguistic theories

A linguistic theory provides categories with which languages can be described. It must have enough categories of the right type, and no more. It cannot be modified if by chance it does not suit a language teacher. In the next few paragraphs the language teacher's preferences will be mentioned. Any of them could be the deciding factor in choosing between two linguistic theories which were otherwise equivalent, but the equivalence of the theories would have to be established in advance. For example, a teacher who proposes to use linguistic description overtly in class will be on the lookout for a theory with a simple and restricted terminology and a grammar which is based on obvious units such as *word* and *sentence*. A linguist offering a theory which created a huge terminology and worked with units which could scarcely be related to words and sentences might have to retort that no theory could otherwise account for the nature of language. A linguist talking to English teachers often feels he should apologise, as it were, for the nature of language.

## 1.8 Language development

No one knows exactly how a human being stores and uses his linguistic knowledge, but everyone speculates. A description of a language which precisely modelled the behaviour of native speakers would be a start, but it still could be organised according to entirely different principles. At present one assesses the 'naturalness' of a linguistic theory by mainly subjective reaction; as knowledge of mental

processes grows, the choice may rest on sounder criteria. Until then, the English teacher should rely solely on his intuitions about the nature of language.

A native learner of English has an important developmental aspect to his linguistic behaviour. This is obvious in his early years, but once he has mastered the common phonological and syntactic patterns of English we tend to think that from a developmental point of view he does little more than to add a few frills. As yet we are fairly ignorant of the later stages of development, while the learner is at school and beyond. Descriptive linguists find it convenient to suppose for the purposes of analysis that the language is stable in time and that informants do not differ on a developmental axis. In emphasising the contrast between synchronic and diachronic linguistics they have tended to equip themselves for description along a single dimension only. The English teacher is not directly concerned with the language behaviour of mature adults. He may select some of it as his teaching model, that is all. But he does need to understand the difficulties his pupils face and their typical patterns of development so that he can organise his material economically and effectively.

## 1.9 Comprehensiveness

With each linguistic description we can associate a corpus of utterances, namely those which are satisfactorily described. It is unlikely that two differently organised descriptions will relate to exactly the same corpus, even though there will be a great deal of overlap. Again, a description will reveal normally that it is designed to cope with certain utterances in an elegant manner but drags in the rest solely in order to be comprehensive. All descriptions of English will be satisfactory, no doubt, with a sentence like *the cat sat on the mat*, but some may not be illuminating about *no smoking*.

Each English teacher has a good idea of the corpus of utterances with which he is concerned. He would do well to be as explicit as possible about his corpus and then to examine the market to see if his interests can be met. The teacher may also want to insist on certain features of the description of the utterances; he may, for example, be prepared to back a phonetics theory only if it can help him to describe what we call 'tone of voice.'

In its early years the linguistic discussion of literary texts lost impact because of its suggestions that great writers used deviant grammar and linguistic trickery. Current popular theories had no provision for distinguishing between different types of deviation from everyday usage. Since literary texts figure largely in the normal English curriculum, this lack had the effect of tying one of the teacher's hands behind his back.

The English teacher, then, must decide what corpus he is interested in and what particular features of the corpus are likely to be important, and then he must study the market to see if his demands can be met, watching out for 'ragbag' descriptions where a spurious comprehensiveness is gained by simple listing or little more than that.

A typical example of the focussing interests of teachers is the attention being paid at present to the study of specialised varieties of English. The linguistic theories have not yet caught up with the needs of teachers because of the present speed of change. In the traditional teaching pattern in the United Kingdom there was hardly any attention paid to this aspect of language patterning, and some of the teaching was willingly delegated to specialist teachers of other subjects. Now we are at a growth point, and a linguistic theory which incorporates high-level statements about language varieties will be preferred to one which includes variety differentials as little more than a mopping-up operation in description.

## 1.10 Internal relations

Each and every feature of a linguistic theory could be assessed for its value in language teaching, however unrealistic the assessment might be. There seem to be two general features which are worth separate assessment: the internal *divisions* of the theory and resultant descriptions, and the *contact* with physically-occurring language.

With reference to the network of related categories which constitutes a linguistic theory, we can ask the question "How isolated is each component from all the others?" or "How simple is the input to each component?" The process of teaching language systematically or explaining particular features is aided by the presentation of material in small, relatively isolated portions, and a theory should be examined with this point in mind. There is a good supporting reason at the present time, when all branches of linguistics are feverishly active. Minor improvements to descriptions are suggested day by day but can be incorporated only if their disturbance to the rest of the description is purely local. Because English teachers are not yet acclimatised to grammars which change more rapidly than the language they describe, careful consideration should be given to this practical point.

Language which actually occurs is the main evidence on which descriptions are based and from which theories evolve. Theories are abstract, but their provisions for contact between description and text may differ in directness.

The language teacher has to handle actual language, find examples, correct, and advise. If a description is to be useful to him, it will be one which maintains

close contact with the textual phenomena. A criterion such as this is dangerous in practice, since it might lead to preference being given to a description that boasted a spurious simplicity. But it is a substantial criterion nevertheless. It seems almost certain that the teacher will have to avoid reference to difficult linguistic abstractions in most of his teaching. He is therefore reliant on some kind of inductive process being established (or tapped).

## 1.11 Language skills

An English teacher has as a major concern the development of language skills in his pupils. He has to teach people how to do things with their language. Therefore he is looking for a theory which stresses the *pragmatic* side of linguistic description. On this depend so many things. His theory must contain evaluative criteria. It must enable him to move towards assessing the success of an utterance on a particular occasion. It must include (as we have seen) an elaborate treatment of the nature of specialised varieties of a language. It must come to grips with the central concepts of *style, correctness*, and *acceptability*. For some time now linguists have tended to take a far too narrow view of their subject matter. Description, not prescription, was the motto; the accent was on structural patterning, and the actual pragmatic value of an utterance in a discourse was never discussed. At the present time, 'correct English' and 'good style' are terms from different, if not incompatible, areas of the subject; from a pragmatic point of view they are different stages of the same process, that of creating effective utterances.

## 1.12 Section II: Summary

The linguistic theory which suits the English teacher best is one which

a. fits our intuitions and knowledge of the internalised theory of native speakers,
b. has a strong developmental aspect,
c. is truly comprehensive in the corpus it can describe and in the distinctions it can make during description,
d. makes possible descriptions which are internally divided and isolating and in which close contact is always maintained between abstract categories and texts,
e. contains a pragmatic component which allows useful discussion of style, correctness, and acceptability.

CHAPTER 2

# The integration of language and literature in the English curriculum*

## 2.1 Introduction

In this chapter I want to argue that:

a. the notion 'command of a language' involves linguistic and literary considerations, techniques, theories which are interwoven in an inextricable fashion. Thus
b. the teaching of command of a language, and the preparation of teachers to teach it, cannot be adequately informed by separate development of the accepted approaches of language and literature, but only by integration.

In criticism of the shortcomings of established disciplines that play some part in defining the notion 'command of a language' I suggest principally that:

a. a linguistic approach that takes no account of evaluative considerations opts out of most of the practical problems of language description (by evaluative considerations I mean such things as the aims and intentions of speakers, the effectiveness and the quality of their utterances);
b. the literary value of any literary statement is limited by the nature and quality of the language observation implied by it;
c. neither current linguistic theory nor current literary theory have devised hypotheses about linguistic communication that are adequate to explain the phenomenon of command of a language.

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* The initial impetus of this chapter was an invitation to speak at a BAAL Seminar in Bradford in October 1970. It has profited from the discussions in Bradford, and from detailed comments by my colleagues R. M. Coulthard, I. J. Forsyth, J. Wight and A. M. Wilkinson, to whom I am very much indebted. The article appeared originally in *Educational Review 23*: 220–234 (1971). A revised version was reprinted in Carter, R. & Burton, D. (eds). 1982. *Literary Text and Language Study*. London: Arnold.

I shall then propose two guidelines for the integrated English curriculum:

a. in production of language, it should give priority to the functional role of language in the actual accomplishment of communicative tasks;
b. in reception of language, it should view the process as involving exactly the same skills and techniques as are assumed to operate in the child's first learning of a language.

I shall deduce from these guidelines the following three principles:

a. there should be maintained a clear distinction between the development of a child's verbal powers in situations which are actual for him, and those in which he plays a role or in which ritual replaces communication;
b. there should be at least as much attention paid to the features of language which are accidental and arbitrary as to those which are held conventionally to bear meaning;
c. the motivation to creativity should be exploited in English teaching throughout the process, and not restricted to a few techniques where it serves as a general stimulus to production.

I shall finish with an outline of some of my own work with adults in following these principles.

## 2.2 Command of a language

I regard command of a language as the ability of mature, educated native speakers to exercise full control over their environment by means of their language behaviour. It implies both a high level of achievement and an ability to adapt and develop expressiveness in new situations. There is no attempt here to elucidate this notion fully, but only to draw attention to aspects of it for which the provision in teaching and its source disciplines is incomplete. The notes below will suffice to introduce the problem – and let me emphasise that these are not carefully stored examples from vast experience, but merely notes on humdrum situations a few days before writing this paragraph.

i. I was babysitting, and as the parents were leaving the three-year-old girl was restive. The mother smiled up at her and said "Would you like mummy to come up and close your door?" Since I knew the parents were already late I said "No, off you go; I'll come up and shut your door, Lucy." The child fled screaming. Apparently, the threat of having her door shut was being used

to control the child, but because of my presence the mother replaced her threatening intonation by a normal questioning one, relying on the local meaning of *shut your door* to do the job. I was misled into thinking that it was a desirable action.

ii. I telephoned a neighbour and was answered by the eight-year-old daughter, who behaved in a very adult fashion. Instead of just asking for her father, I played along with the adult talk and asked her how busy she was these days, and wasn't it a cold day, and so on. Then I remembered that her younger brother had been ill, and said "How's Richard today?" She answered "I don't know. Hang on a minute – Richard, how are you?"

These utterances are all well-formed sentences, but the juxtaposition of them shows failures in the interpretation and evaluation of their function in the discourse. What is intentional selection for the speaker is a matter of weighing the evidence of the sound wave by the listener in his particular situation. In my first story the mother said one thing while hoping to mean another, and was interpreted in both meanings by two listeners; in my second story the girl did not interpret the utterance within the social role she had assumed.

The acquisition of command of a language requires techniques, and techniques are not highly valued in English teaching today. They smack of old-style lessons remembered with contempt because of their failure to achieve their purpose and their lack of motivation on the part of teacher or pupil. The social purpose of language as a highly discriminating communicative instrument is currently divorced from the acquisition of techniques.

In any proposals for the English curriculum, technique must not be handled separately from motivation. Where it happens, expression is inhibited, mistakes are more important than correct work, spontaneity is impossible.

Nor must motivation be separated from technique. There is great emphasis in current English teaching on encouraging expression, particularly imaginative composition; exploring areas of experience with a writing exercise at the end; exposure to, or confrontation with, texts as a stimulus to further texts. There is considerably less concern about exactly how one moves from stimulus to adequate response, or how the free flow of expression can be channelled into competent and elegant production outside the area of literary composition.

These remarks should not be construed as criticism of the attempts of teachers to encourage self-expression in children, genuine creative writing or talking that helps children to develop psychologically, to understand themselves and their own patterns of growth. It will become clear that I propose a considerable extension of creativity without restricting what is already successfully practised.

## 2.3 Shortcomings of linguistics in relation to command of a language

In this brief survey I am not attempting to pillory any particular theory of linguistics, or to deny that gestures are made towards remedies for the deficiencies that I point out. It would be a perfectly fair reply to claim that linguistics is not concerned with actual events in communication or an individual's powers of exercising control over his circumstances through his language. It remains relevant merely to say that many linguists do think their work helpful in language teaching, and so do many language teachers.

i. Without evoking evaluative considerations, it is not possible to distinguish between a specialised variety of a language which is used to improve the efficiency of a specialised operation, and a jargon, which interferes with communication. Criteria for effectiveness have not been evolved because they would require study of the aims and objectives of particular utterance sequences, and measurement of success and failure.

   An English teacher does not need to be told (as he has been told *ad nauseam* in recent years) that a speaker varies his language to suit the situation in which he is speaking. A teacher derives profit from the studies of language varieties which give details of the variation that is observed. But he is not given adequate hypotheses as to the function of varieties in improving or hindering communication.

ii. Instead of occupying a central position in linguistic theory, the study of style is relegated to the periphery, again because it must involve value-judgments and consideration of short-term, situation-bound objectives. Its only place is to 'explain' options in a set of formal rules.

   Modern linguistics is mainly concerned with one particular kind of choice – the unweighted, compulsory, clear-cut choice between mutually exclusive alternatives. But much of what we call style is the product not of compulsory choice but of optional control over language patterns which do not normally carry meaning at all; deployment of patterns which a grammar or a phonology of English would ignore, in such a way as to invite a speaker of the language to invest them with meaning. These optional choices include most traditional figures of speech, prosodic structures, and an unlimited inventory of relations for which there are no names.

   Much of modern linguistics concerns the productive, rather than the receptive, side. One's attention is not drawn to the differences between these two directions of the communicative process, and indeed some descriptive systems are held to be reversible for analysis or synthesis.

The particular role of the producer of the language is the more complex of the two, and is necessary for the notion of competence – the specialised use of this term to mean the underlying system of structural rules towards which a speaker's usage always tends. But when we think of the producer of language in a particular instance of his production we find of course that he can monitor his own utterances at any stage in their production, and so is in part his listener.

The listener, it is true, may also be involved in productive procedures as part of his interpretation of what he hears, but this is not his most important activity. We can assume that he has at his disposal an accurate representation of the structure of the language, and a set of techniques for putting this internalised competence to work. The basic technique is a learning technique, of the type that he developed when his predominant activity was learning the language. All but a trivial few sentences are new to him and may show features of sounds, syntax, or vocabulary that he has not yet internalised. So even the most primitive strategies of 'looking for meaning-bearing patterning' come into play. A mature and experienced speaker will of course find most of what he hears familiar enough, but the fact that we are affected by stylistic devices demonstrates without doubt the existence of a scanning technique and an interpretative technique to cope with such unpredictable patterning.

'Producer' models obscure this function of a language user. A listener can detect meaning in a degenerate signal or one produced with very doubtful communicative intent, e.g. random selections by a computer from a word-list. 'Receiver' models, with their focal point at the end of the communication process, after communication has taken place, highlight the language user as an unscrambling device as well as a decoding device, quite capable of creating for himself more meaning than was put in by the speaker.

Both models are necessary to make explicit the notion of command of a language. If we take meaning to be primarily a psychological sensation induced in the mind of a listener, it is clear that for the purposes of describing style the receiver model is necessary.

iii. Associated with the point about style above, there is the matter of deviation from strict grammaticality. Modern linguistics has a good deal to say about deviance, what types there are and how the rules of the grammar could be adapted to include them, but the study is abstract in the main and gives us no guide as to how operationally a listener copes with utterances that seem deviant to him. It is not the case that a listener assesses the grammaticalness of an utterance and rejects it if it does not come up to scratch; nor does he classify its deviance and leave it at that. He interprets it, takes whatever meaning he can find in it (even to the extent of hearing what was not said). He assumes that if

he is spoken to, the incoming speech will be meaningful, and his interpretative strategies are dominated by that assumption.

iv. Also tying in with the previous observations, there is the vexed question of probabilities. Viewed from the position of the producer of language, there seems to be little need for assessing the probabilities of structural choices; the producer, setting out to construct a sentence, prejudges such matters by knowing what he wants to say. All his choices stem from his initial choice of meaningful units.

On the other hand, we are gradually finding out that utterances obey statistical laws despite the free choice of speakers. From the point of view of the listener, the mature and experienced user, the likelihood of a speech event will be an important factor in interpretation, and the perception of stylistic patterning like alliteration, structural parallelism, pun etc. will be informed by, in part, the chances of its occurrence without meaningful intent.

v. The concentration of linguistic theory and description has always been upon the sentence and its parts. However we define a sentence, it comes out as the highest unit of grammatical organisation and the lowest unit of discourse. In terms of command of the language a full description of sentences and their meanings is merely preliminary to the main problem, which is how sentences are deployed in utterances to construct purposive activity.

It is not *necessary* to adopt a functional approach to sentence structure. Sentences can be viewed as artefacts constructed according to discoverable rules, can be assessed for well-formedness by references to rules, can be compared with each other, used in psycho-linguistic experiments etc., without any note being taken of the producer's choice of one sentence rather than another – or even one sentence rather than no sentence at all. But when sentences are considered as actions – actions so subtle and delicate that they make most of our non-verbal activity look impossibly crude – it becomes necessary to see their structure in a different light; to group them in different ways from that suggested by their constructional details.

This regrouping is commonplace in linguistics; within the everyday study of sentences and their meanings several levels are distinguished – with names like phonology, grammar, semantics. The output categories of one level become the input categories of another, and are grouped according to principles different from those used in their synthesis. Clearly the adequate description of effective language behaviour demands a further level of *discourse*, within which sentences are the primitive units.

The relatively new branches of language study that go by names like 'discourse analysis (Coulthard, 1977), 'conversational analysis (Schenkein, 1978), 'text linguistics' (van Dijk, 1980), 'clause relation' (Winter, 1977) are making

big, if uncoordinated, strides towards describing the way in which written text and spoken interaction are organized, and a contrast is sharpening between these movements and 'proper' linguistics, which is in danger of cutting itself off from the vital role of informing the practice of language teaching. This unfortunate position is not helped by the maintenance of opposition in the English teaching profession to the findings of linguistic analysis. For example, the new Open University course in Language Development (PE 232) was originally designed to teach teachers how to systematize their knowledge of their language in order to understand the linguistic growth of their pupils during education; but the final material is sadly watered down and trivialized.

Teachers should be aware that filters of this kind are making it difficult for them to review and evaluate the important work if modern linguistics. Shortcomings it has, but it also offers insights which are not available elsewhere, and it offers challenges to much established doctrine. It is interesting to compare the relatively static position of current English teaching in the UK with the dynamic work in the teaching of English overseas (see the report of Working Party C to the National Council of Languages in Education Assembly, 1980). The latter tradition has never lost touch with linguistics, and in the last decade has opened up lively new branches called 'communicative teaching' (Widdowson 1978) and 'English for Specific Purposes' (Kennedy 1978).

## 2.4 Shortcomings of literary criticism in relation to command of a language

We must first recognise, and press the point, that the literary approach dominates English teaching in our schools, its influence increasing as the child goes up the school. In primary school after initial literacy, the emphasis is on the reading and writing of literary text. In secondary schools what language work is done is perfunctory and ill-understood, and dies out by O-level at the latest. This is not to deny that attention is paid to the study of texts in advertising English, political oratory, journalese, etc. – or that a more analytic approach to literary texts is fashionable. But these studies are not linguistic studies; they are centrally concerned with moral, social, aesthetic and other matters, and the language is used merely as evidence.

This distinction is fundamental to my argument. Any scholar can use language as evidence and may very well be obliged to make detailed analytical observations on selected quotations in order to prove his point about archaeology, perhaps, or music or sociology. The literary analyst is no exception. He reads a work and picks

out the bits that are appropriate to his point and describes them in a suitable blend of informal structural terminology and critical comment. The only objection that I have to this activity is that it is sometimes said to be linguistic, or language work.

As before, the practice of literary criticism is not being examined in the round, but only as it affects the notion under discussion.

i. The first point is commonplace but will bear repetition. If literary comment is to be more than exclusively personal testimony it must be interpretable with respect to objective analysis. It is certainly read in this way, and linguistic analysis is sometimes welcomed as a rigorous (if boring and myopic) method of setting out what a critic has intuitively perceived and elegantly stated. The notion command of a language provides a non-personal measure for literary description; it is a generalised notion, laying stress on what is common among speakers, unconcerned to describe individual and personal reactions.

   This is the point where it may be felt that English teaching is more than the creation of competent speaker/listeners and writer/readers. The nurture of the individual personality may make rival demands, particularly in difficult or remedial cases. But presumably teachers do their best to resolve conflicting priorities by trying to devise approaches which are doubly useful. It is a major part of my case that within the first lines of development of command of the language there is more than adequate motivation and interest for normal pupils.

ii. Traditionally, literary expertise is applied to a very restricted range of texts – to not much more than the received corpus of high-quality imaginative fiction. The setting of standards in all non-literary forms has been left to the practitioners themselves, with results that please nobody. The spoken language is ignored. I think that the influence of professional critics throughout our language behaviour is most important to develop for the community as a whole, but most of all for the English classrooms. However, this should not be read as a *carte blanche* for critics to indulge their prejudices in what is for them a new range of data (Robinson, 1973, is a serious warning of what could become fashionable). Before devising evaluative criteria, we must first understand the nature, structure and purpose of communication, its surrounding context and traditions.

iii. The production and consumption of fictional text is carried out without parallel full understanding of non-fiction. This leads to the creation of a characteristic limbo where literary texts are discussed without reference to their communicative value. To develop this point, it is necessary here to insert a few words about the nature of fiction. In everyday nonfictional talk and writing, we work within a set of conventions that enable us to evaluate and interpret

> the discourse. We assume that the speaker or writer vouches for the accuracy of what he utters, and that he is in a position to do so. There is, so to speak, a continuity of experience from us, as receivers, to the events reported, through the integrity of the utterer. His own stance in respect to what he reports is communicated to us along with the 'content' of what he says or writes, and it is his responsibility to maintain this service.

Within this general constraint, we use our independent judgement, past experience, knowledge of the other person, etc. to decide on the absolute or relative truth or falsehood of what we are presented with. We take up our own position, relative to his position and relative to what is reported, and identify through him with the events portrayed.

But it is also possible to indicate, as speaker or writer, another relationship, that of fiction, which requires us to adjust our interpretations. Signals are many and varied. Literary genres can be indicated by format, or class words like *A Novel*. Titles are a good guide, as are conventional openings like *Once upon a time*, or *Have you heard the one about*… Whatever the signal, we are warned that the utterer now wishes us to find our own means of understanding and interpreting his report. He cuts us off from the continuity of experience through him, and offers us few, if any, reliable guides to his own position. He may conclude with an explicit statement of the way he would like us to understand his story, but if so, the reason is to compare his own original response with ours. We are no longer concerned with absorbing and evaluating the individual statements in direct line with our experience, but instead are constantly placing ourselves in direct relation to the events portrayed, identifying with characters, reacting to what happens as if we ourselves might have been involved. We are not evaluating the truth or falsehood of the statements because they are offered to us as not factually relevant. There is a current fashion in writers like Frederick Forsyth to blend factual reports with fictitious ones, but it is not the job of the normal reader to separate the two, and the writer uses his craft to make the task difficult. We accept from the outset that the whole story is fictitious. The flow of books, cinema, television films, and personal appearances that deal with Watergate, and after, provide a useful set for comparison.

We are also able to evaluate the form of the presentation, because the freedom from fact that is open to fiction is replaced by a responsibility on the narrator to construct an artefact.

If a narration has a vague and incomplete ending, for example, we have to know whether it is an account of something that happened – in which case we accept that life has its inconclusive moments – or whether it is a construct in fiction – in which case we look for an interpretation of such an ending, knowing that the author was in a position to have tied it all up neatly, had he wished.

Aside from this basic difference in stance, there is no difference in the language used in or available to speakers or writers of either fact or fiction. Conventions of usage change fairly rapidly with time: wildly improbably fictions like ghost and horror stories often introduce a bogus narrator to stimulate the missing continuity of experience; lovers regale each other with borrowed verses which they invest with their integrity and convert to factuality. Sentence by sentence, the language is from the same stock, and the critic and the writer have no grounds for avoiding professional concern with the language.

## 2.5 The curriculum

From this thumbnail sketch of the inadequacies of linguistic and literary approaches to command of the language, I turn to the implications for the English curriculum. I shall give four examples, the last one extended because it concerns the age group with which I have most direct contact.

In the first place, the complexity of fiction should be noted, and the development of expertise in fiction should not outpace the acquisition of competence in nonfiction. This is not to decry fictional creativity in the early stages of English teaching. I cannot repeat too often that there may well be excellent pedagogical reasons for encouraging it, not examined here. My object is to question its value in improving the child's expressive ability, except in extreme cases. The main dangers are poor quality work, emphasis on mimicry and jargon, and reluctance to perform because of haziness about the communicative status of the task. There is always the alternative of setting up a real, understandable, immediate situation in which the child can operate as a child and produce his own language, develop its potentialities in the same way as he initially acquired his language, and at the same time gain greater insights into the nature of his most powerful possession.

Nowadays we are faced with a flow of impressive fiction produced by children, carefully selected from a much larger sump of 'worthless' pieces. It is a game where only the judges know the rules, and where the child's experience of language, even in the richest background, fits him ill for participation. Accurate, competent fiction requires great technical control, and this fact should not be obscured by the occasional random success. The analogy of the monkey writing Shakespeare may be insulting, but nonetheless relevant. A 3½ year old child, dead tired, once remarked

> When this day is done
> Time will fly into the trees
> And the clock will bang on the light of the cathedral

As far as one can be dogmatic in such cases, he did not put into that remark what the adults took out of it.

The product of asking children to perform as themselves in real situations is a very keen and functional discourse; full of metaphor and clever strategies, showing the proven ability of a child to make his language useful up to the limits of his nonverbal IQ (Coulthard 1970). The experience of researching and writing what is now know as *Concept 7–9* (Schools Council 1972) confirms the value of this approach, and it is rewarding to see how often the *Concept 7–9* materials, designed as they were for early junior pupils in inner-ring schools, have been used as models for communication skills teaching in many programmes in many countries.

Secondly, the child should be encouraged to pursue his delight in language for its own sake; the quirks and oddities, strange correspondences and meaningless patterns. This activity is more than just fun – it is the basis of style. A fundamental tenet of linguistics is the arbitrariness of the linguistic sign, be it letter, word or higher unit. Onomatopeia is the untypical case; in the overwhelming majority of cases the physical characteristics of a linguistic sign are no clue whatsoever to its value in the sign system. Thus there is created the intriguing possibility of reducing the arbitrariness by selection on double criteria. Language teaching pays attention to the organised, meaningful patterning which provides one set of criteria, but tends to ignore the potential harnessing of the arbitrary patterning. Young children are not in a position to distinguish accurately these two aspects. Making the distinction is one part of the skill of language that is being acquired. A four-year-old sits at the typewriter and taps out xp = twm Vjk,;„s. He is delighted to have it read back to him because of the unusual noise it makes compared with the noise of English. A compound like *fruitcake* may sound odd to a six-year-old because he does not think of raisins as fruit; *cheesecake* even odder this side of the Atlantic, giving rise to a few experimental new compounds like *soupcake, mummycake, tellycake*. The children freewheel an important part of their sentence-building apparatus as if it were a fruit-machine, and give themselves pleasure and profit in the performance.

All manner of language games are relevant, no matter how apparently trivial they may seem. There are games where the child cannot make a mistake, like word-association games; games where the word-hoard comes under simple testing, like *I went to market*; games where analytical skills are involved, like those where one word is changed into another by simple stages of letter substitution; and games of control, like *Simon Says*; puzzles, too, of all kinds, just so long as language plays a major part. In this sort of environment the child will always be aware of the arbitrary patterns of his language, and is likely to grow up in control of them as much as the others.

The next and third suggestion assumes a certain level of competence acquired in the first two; it is the formal exercise. When a measure of control is reached, the pupil can start trying to write in particular styles. Maybe just rhyme at first, or regular rhythm, or description without verbs – the grading would need to be experimented with. Some exercises are nearly mathematical, like the construction

of reversible sequences at various levels; the value is in the attempt to select and control within exceptionally limiting constraints. Some are much nearer free creativity.

Each exercise is a different mixture of two motivations. One is a combination of the delight that children take in language for its own sake, and their similar pleasure in solving problems. The other is the need to express oneself that forms the basis of creative writing of any kind. A balance between these two can be noticed in the works of any stylist, whether the language is literary, scientific, journalistic, or whatever. The nature of language opens up endless possibilities for purposeful exercise. Readers who wish to consider more closely some of the characteristics of language which make style what it is may consult Sinclair (1975) for a more theoretical argument.

## 2.6 An extended example

In this, the final section, I shall describe a little of the development of my own teaching of first-year university students on an integrated basis. This work has been pursued with the wholehearted support of many colleagues. First of all, I shall go through the typical intensive teaching session lasting 24 hours, and then explain the incorporation of its principles into our regular teaching.

The intensive activity involves about six tutors and up to 80 students. Some of the students (and tutors) are already accomplished writers, and some have no confidence at all in their creative abilities. The aim of the activity is to relate linguistic structure directly to the creative process, involving the students as analysts, critics and composers. Throughout, texts are used as models, and in the version I shall describe the texts were all short poems.

The first session is an icebreaker with the whole group, using perhaps Henry Reed's "The Naming of Parts". The group is invited to compose another stanza in the same style. It doesn't seem to matter which way the group decides to proceed; the essential points emerge, whether one starts at the beginning of the stanza and plods through, or maps out the broad lines of the structure and then fills in the details. The Reed poem is useful because

a. its rhythm is subtle, not particularly fixed but difficult to deviate from successfully;
b. each stanza breaks into two parts because of a contrast of styles;
c. the stanzas roughly conform to a repetitive pattern but leave plenty of room for detailed drafting;
d. the poem can be appreciated at several levels, which leads to contrasting proposals for the new stanza.

It becomes clear that the poem is difficult to imitate, and impossible without a detailed knowledge and interpretation of it and much verbal ingenuity. In part the language is most carefully wrought and decisions in the first line can limit the last line abominably; but also there are parts where one just has to 'lose' several syllables, to pad out a line without damaging the main choices that have been made. It is just as difficult to pad successfully as to find the significant verbal operators with their double or triple meanings.

An encouraging feature of the first session is the keen and detailed way that students will approach the task. They give and take criticism without fear, and are very sensitive to what is characteristic of the style of the poem, and quick to uncover the operative constraints of the meaning. Without realising it, they frequently slip into linguistic argument.

The first session lasts up to two hours, and the leader is lucky if he has even a working draft on the blackboard at the end of it. Next, students are handed another text and asked to do the same sort of job individually and quickly. Here the text has to be a more repetitive structure, like e. e. cummings' "All in green" or Herbert's "Virtue". Under an hour is allowed for this, and the students form into several smaller groups for the feedback session, which is quite technical. Students each have their own versions, and are willing to defend their choices with detailed argument. They explore the relation between fixed form and free creativity.

The third session is longer, and has as its text a complicated work of some obscurity. Tutors vary in their selection of text at this stage, because a balance has to be struck between the difficulty of the eventual writing task and the credibility of the exercise as a whole. The introductory sessions use texts with fairly strong and often unusual linguistic patterns; the students have also to be given confidence that all texts of recognised worth are amenable to the same sort of treatment. One that we frequently use is Eliot's "Sweeney among the Nightingales".

Work on this text starts with a general interpretative discussion. Style points emerge haphazardly, and the job of the group leader is to point to the relevance of linguistic features in the interpretative arguments. After a while he summarises the discussion, listing the components of style that have been analysed – the characteristic clause structure, perhaps, with the subject occupying an odd-numbered line and the verb starting the next; the consistency of the verb forms until near the end, and the particular use of ambiguous past/present form *let* in the second-last line; the isolation of the clauses by avoidance of coordinating conjunctions; rarity of subordinate clauses; ubiquitous definite article and consequent rarity of other determiner choices, and so on. Including rhythmic and lexical points, something like a dozen features germane to the style will emerge. The group will have studied these features, not only as linguistic structures but also in the way that they play their part in the creation of that particular poem.

They will then be asked to make a new poem exploiting as many as possible of the features. Some go off straightaway to do this, and others discuss theme, possible variations, etc. The group leader may make whatever arrangements he likes with individuals, so long as the job in each case is closely defined, so that the finished work can be discussed as an attempt to make a predetermined artefact.

No one has yet refused. The time schedule is strict because we have found that Parkinson's law applies to this situation. Tutors move around encouraging, cajoling, shaming and often giving help with details, until all the texts are in. Then they are studied by tutors, and finally the feedback sessions commence. The groups are cut down to two or three on an appointment basis, allowing up to twenty minutes per text. Each text is read aloud, and the discussion usually starts with a request for self-criticism. Most of the session is elucidation – trying to relate what has been written to the objectives of the author, within the confines of the allotted task. Many are forced to vary from the prescription, but do so because of the needs of their developing creation, and are able to express the conflict of form and feeling in a precise fashion. A few perform the minimum, constructing lines in slavish imitation of the original, but that, of course, is fully acceptable because the author comes to recognise that the form has dominated his work.

I shall resist the temptation of printing samples of the work, because its quality is strictly irrelevant to the argument; it is a technical, artificial exercise open to assessment along a range of criteria. Suffice it to say that some of the poems produced under even these circumstances are most impressive, and nearly everyone is surprised, first that his work is taken seriously, in the same sort of discussion that Eliot's was before, and second that it is much better than he thought was possible. It is customary to end with readings of some of the poems, interspersed with other work, and sometimes printing of polished versions for those who want to submit. Everyone submits, and signs his work. The tentative, modest creatures of the previous day have become brazen poets, for the nonce.

The activity I have detailed is illustrative of a theme with many variations. Prose and drama texts have been used; the task has been defined in many different ways, sometimes by individual negotiations like 'what restrictions of form will you accept?' Follow-up sessions to move away from the influences of particular models have been tried, and group creativity, with varying success. University students are not the only customers. It has been surprisingly successful with seasoned overseas teachers of English on British Council Summer Schools, Indian graduate students, extramural students and many others.

The activity is, of course, a stop-gap effort, heavily remedial, trying to distil a process that should be basic and continuous in Subject English. But it gives rise to effective integration. In the feedback sessions, there is absolutely no distinction between linguistics and literary criticism, between author and critic, between form and content.

The experience of this work over several years led to students asking why such work was restricted to one intensive session off-campus. They returned to a split course where language work was plodding through the Structure of English, and literature work as the Seventeenth Century. As a result, a new integrated course was devised, 'Close reading and composition', and this now incorporates first-year language work. It is taught by linguists and critics alike, and it has settled down to a regular pattern.

The four half-terms of the course deal successively with texts from poetry (of a fairly concrete variety), prose fiction, critical writing and drama. In each case a corpus of up to a dozen short texts is selected, and the texts are studied closely, with ephasis on the way in which the writer has constructed his meanings and effects. General reactions are investigated until their origins in word and structure are located. At the same time, the students are reading for themselves in an account of English syntax, following the sequence nominal groups, sentence types, clause structure and verbal groups in the four half-terms (Sinclair, 1972, was written partly with these students in mind). At the end of each genre study, an exercise is set and forms part of the assessment of the course; it consists of detailed checking on the current area of syntax, a writing prescription which must explicitly involve some of the findings of the analytical work, and a short commentary on the writing exercise.

The focus is literary because the majority of the students are primarily concerned with literature; the format could be adapted to the teaching of any kind of composition because the approach is fully integrated, and moves easily from aims to opinions to design to tactics to techniques to the details of linguistic expression. A proper English course should embrace all these features and refuse to recognize a sharp distinction between what is literary and what linguistic. Only then can we teach command of a language.

I have filled out one example because a great deal of the opinion in this chapter is speculative. It seemed worthwhile to set out the stages of one activity that works; for some students it is far more engaging and real than the solemn game of learning to be a literary critic, divorced from experience of the practice of writing under control. In this sort of work the pupils are developing, and developing their understanding and their command of their language at an advanced level. A wholly linguistic approach would not do; it might engage the few natural linguists, and the puzzle-addicts, in the group. A literary approach would obscure the terms of reference and reduce the final sessions to embarrassing exchanges of clichés. In studying the act of communication by language and, informed by the study, teaching command of the language, there is no alternative to demolishing the discipline boundaries without compromise and adopting an integrated approach which involves the whole personality of teacher and taught.

CHAPTER 3

# Language awareness in six easy lessons*

## 3.1 Introduction

Language Awareness is very much a 'grass roots' movement, taking its lead from the work of pioneering schools, and this has led to a wealth of good ideas and variety of approaches which a more centrally-devised policy could not match. This diversity fits well with the essential vagueness of 'Language Awareness', which I have grumbled about on a previous occasion. But a Working Party is bound to exert pressure to tidy things, to define, to abstract, to categorise. It is the natural human seeking of a consensus.

I believe that the creative untidiness of the actual content of Language Awareness courses is in fact unrelated to the fuzziness of the cover-term. They have different origins, and it is a case of a useful concept happily meeting up with a spontaneous school-based perception of a need. This chapter hopes to add a little stiffening to a fluid situation, because for many people it is too fluid. Language Awareness courses arise in different schools for different reasons, are devised by different groups, and are applied at different stages to different pupils in pursuit of different objectives. There is nothing in the day-to-day teaching that one can perceive as common to all. Also, some of the teachers involved confess that they are at sea when it comes to devising or justifying a syllabus, and teachers who are eager to set up such a course can get little authoritative guidance.

The current pattern of Language Awareness courses highlights a problem that has thwarted many initiatives in language education in the post-war period. There is a gross shortage of time and expertise. Language Awareness courses, in the main, are squeezed into an overfull timetable and are able to secure only a paltry proportion of the attention of a class or school. The priorities of teacher training and the bureaucratic divisions in language education from the DES outward make it most unlikely that Language Awareness teachers have had adequate preparation, or can feel any security beyond personal conscientiousness.

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This unfortunate current situation, when compared with the average run of syllabus proposals, exposes a credibility gap. If one is asked to specify course content in Language, Language Studies, Linguistics, etc. either for pupils or in teacher education, it is difficult to avoid being comprehensive, thorough and detailed. Anything less would seem to be irresponsible. The result is something that will not fit into the time available and/or is beyond the competence of the staff available. I am as guilty of making unrealistic suggestions as anyone else, and hereby repent. I hope that the reception of this chapter will not require further repentance.

Hence the title. The great lumbering organisation which educates our children can only cope with modest proposals, and gentle nudges. Instead of thinking of content as coverage, I should like to identify a few important and distinctive features of language which might with profit be offered to pupils in a Language Awareness course. If there are as few as six lessons, something would be accomplished by raising the six points that are outlined below. If there are 12 lessons, so much the better – and so on, for the syllabus is infinitely extendable.

This enterprise has a reputable pedigree, in for example the attempt of Brookes and Hudson to reach consensus.[1] They produced a classified set of 81 statements about language with which most of those working in language teaching would agree; unfortunately, it would probably require at least 81 lessons to put them across. At a more abstract level, the attempt, originated by Hockett, to set out the defining characteristics of language provides a smaller, more manageable menu. As revised and extended by Lyons[2], it offers an interesting set of propositions that could form an exciting Language Awareness course. In essence the claim is that any activity that conforms to all of the criteria is equivalent to a natural human language, and anything that fails on one or more of the criteria is not. It was an interesting defensive response to the revelations in the fifties and sixties that various other mammals – apes and dolphins principally – either seemed to use or could be trained to use a communication system which had a disturbing similarity to language, which had hitherto been regarded as a reliable defining characteristic of humankind.

I commend these criteria as an excellent basis for a Language Awareness course, but fear that the abstract nature of the concepts would take some considerable class time to tease out and exemplify. Also the conceptual steps involved would require very sophisticated management. What is needed is something more direct and concrete, which can be put across in vivid terms in a short time, which

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1. Brookes A, and R Hudson, "Do Linguistics have anything to say to teachers?" in R. Carter (ed.) *Linguistics and the Teacher*, London: Routledge and Kegan Paul, 1982.

2. Lyons J, 1977. *Semantics*, vol. 1. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, p. 70.

does not depend on a heavy input of knowledge, and which can relate directly and spontaneously to the state of language awareness of the average class. There are six propositions which seem to me to express central and crucial features of language. Any pupil who had recognised these six would in my view be linguistically aware. Here is a short account of each of them.

## 3.2 Productivity

Language is apparently a limited resource for any individual at any point in time. In principle, we could make a list of the words that a person knows and the structural rules that he/she has command of. Yet each individual has the ability to produce an unlimited number of different utterances. The two points should be easy to establish in the classroom with any age of child, and a wide range of devices for extending the set of sentences will be thought out. Perhaps the general mechanism of recursion, or cyclical repetition, will be identified, but perhaps not.

## 3.3 Creativity

During exploration of the first point, the question of poetic licence may well arise, and that can be used to examine some features of the literary language. The initial point to be made is that the rules of language are just as interesting and meaningful when you break them as when you follow them. Learners will not need much encouragement to break a variety of rules, and can then be invited to find meaningful contexts for the results. It is likely that this activity will highlight the bizarre side of linguistic creativity as a matter of course by everyone. Because it is so normal, natural and widespread, it is likely that some difficulty will be experienced in latching on to the point, especially since it is suppressed in most language teaching materials. But once grasped, the pervasive creativity of language will provide a powerful tool for exploration. For example, it is natural and everyday to use metaphor to overcome a problem in description.

## 3.4 Stability and change

In establishing the second point, it may well be noticed that the rules of a language are not terribly clear-cut or evenly applied. That is a good way into the notion of variation, about which two points are to be made. The first contrasts the relative stability of a language at any point in time with the fact that it is continuously in

a state of change. Historical awareness is notoriously difficult to initiate in young children, and language offers one of the easiest ways in, for example, through the daily neologisms on the media. Quite important questions can arise from the perception that a society normally includes several generations of speakers.

### 3.5 Social variation

The second point about variety will come up in sorting out the historical side – this is the way language varies elaborately with social factors. Again, from the observation that language is an inexact system arises the question of what other meaning is given in side-effects. Of all the issues in this syllabus, this is the most obvious and easy to teach, with stimulus material easy to get. It also provides a good starting point for two further explorations – the variety of languages, and social signalling of a paralinguistic or non-linguistic nature.

### 3.6 How to do things with language

Some syllabuses concern themselves exclusively with the fourth point, but this one presses on, picking up the observations in 3 and 4 about individual variation. The fact that no two people are the same is basic to the study of language as interaction; some theories of language are only suitable for clones. The theme of this part of the syllabus is how to get things done, using language, while being aware that it may not be interpreted in exactly the way in which it is intended. Again, it leads to lively, high-activity teaching and good clean fun.

### 3.7 The two-layered code

The final point should arise from the preceding by the observation that people in conversations keep checking back on each other. The language of the classroom itself gives examples every few seconds. This is developed into a study of language about language – how we are constantly checking, evaluating, summarising, labelling, scene-setting, etc. Language is seen as a two-layered code rather than as a single stream of speech or writing. The content of an utterance – what message it contains, which in principle could be phrased differently – is seen as taking a particular form because of other important information that must be given in the same structure – how it relates to what has gone before and what is to come, how it may relate to the hearer/reader's position, how it is to be taken, what is the

expected evaluation, etc. Because this discoursal information is not as obvious or as well-organised as the conventional content, the learner's attention has to be drawn to it. Some teachers may have difficulty explaining its meaning and force, especially in respect of a foreign language. But since this aspect of language is at the basis of effective use, it is essential to have it even in a minimal syllabus.

A course which brings home these six points will be a lively and effective course. It will certainly give a heightened awareness of language, and will contribute to the linguistic development of learners, whatever their stage. These central features of language would be very difficult to teach by exposition, but easy to teach by discovery. Every speaker of a language actually operates with them, so by delving into their own skills they will readily understand, and become aware of their own language, and that of others.

CHAPTER 4

# Large corpus research and foreign language teaching*

## 4.1 The advent of large corpora

Most people would probably agree that there are two components in the process of coming to know about language. One is the experience of languages we come across in communicative situations, and the other is mental processes and skills that make it possible to use a language competently and effectively. I shall not dwell upon the possible borderlines between these two components or their mutual priority, or upon how much of them is genetically transmitted, all of which lies outside of my own area of interest. But I would say that I am not impressed by arguments for keeping language experience at a distance and by suggestions that it is not really important what people actually say; I am even surprised that this position is seriously taken up.

For me, what people actually say and write – what my late colleague David Brazil called 'used language', like some slightly soiled or second-hand language that has been around a bit in the world – is the primary evidence from which all the rest can be deduced or inferred. The evidence of introspection has a place, of course, but has to be interpreted and is not absolutely straightforward.

In this connection, the role of introspection and intuition in working with large corpora requires some clarification. Working with corpora is a project for extending the frontiers of evidence while handling large collections of language data, from which I have already learned some new and interesting things.

## 4.2 New evidence

I shall be presenting here for the first time some of the early fruits in the recent increase in the size of the Bank of English – the Birmingham Corpus run by

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* This article appeared originally in Beaugrande, R., Grosman, M. & Seidlhofer, B. (eds). 1998. *Education in Emerging Nations*. Stamford CT: Ablex.

COBUILD, which in early June 1996 reached the size of 323 million words from nicely balanced and carefully selected sources. This corpus is 50 per cent larger than the previous one and offers greater precision and greater accuracy, which can be exploited for such projects as a new dictionary of collocations (Sinclair et al., 1998).

Now, early results from corpus analysis some 12 or 15 years ago demonstrated that there are thousands of structural patterns of language that had not been noticed in traditional descriptions. In the 1980s, our research was focused on bringing out and publishing the evidence of a huge area of language structures and patterns that had eluded the attention of the linguist over the centuries. We noticed two main distinguishing features. They involved individual words or small classes of words and phrases to be looked at in smaller dimensions than are normally applied by people describing languages. And secondly, they were syntagmatic patterns, patterns of co-selection of *colligation*, that is, the co-occurrence of grammatical choices, and of *collocation*, that is, the co-occurrence of lexical choices. The lexical choices in the collocations, the grammatical choices in the colligations, and the semantic choices are all unified and brought together in what I call *prosodies*, the attitudinal meanings that emerge once you extend the phrase sufficiently far.

These patterns for relating words together in phrases had not been sufficiently described before; no criticism is intended here of earlier linguists who did not have corpus evidence and therefore could not notice such patterns. Once these have been shown, most language users have an intuitive response that they are indeed reliable regular patterns. These patterns in turn question the reliability of what the language user could consciously retrieve about the language; they were clearly, in the main, subliminal. And yet, fluent, unselfconscious users of a language rely heavily on them as organisational conventions, which are quite clearly part of the central organising structure of the language.

These were quickly dismissed by some theoreticians claiming them to be irrelevant in principle: used language was never interesting, whatever it said; and by some applied linguists who claimed for pedagogy the prerogative to decide what the language was like as far as the learners were concerned. This evidence was not necessarily relevant, and depended on how experts in pedagogy might relate it to the learner.

During this debate, the issues became oversimplified, and people like me began to be accused of denying the importance of intuition and of promoting the dreadful heresy that the theory can arise from data. It is important to respond that every step in the descriptive process and the building of models is guided and directed by the intuition of the researcher; here is where the hypotheses come from, the generalisations, the evaluations. Whether you are doing bottom-up description or top-down description, the central role of the researcher's intuition is quite clear.

However much I promote corpus evidence in attempts to automate processes, I am exercising intuitive judgement at all times. Indeed my current attempts at automation seek to externalise and codify this intuitive process. The main difference between pre-corpus work and corpus-driven approaches to language is that we do not generate the primary evidence from intuition, and we accept the independence of evidence gathered from communicative activity.

I shall now give you some examples of the kind of impact that corpus work is having and is likely to have in the future. We can select a feature that is commented upon in most English grammars: the use of adjectives as headwords, having an article (usually the definite article) and an adjective only. Here is a quote from one grammar book I recently examined: "'the' + adjective can be used to refer to the whole class of people described by the adjective" (compare also Sinclair et al., 1991, pp. 21f). And here is an example from the Bank of English: "being on the side of the rich or the poor". The grammars say the ellipted noun that might have been there is 'people'.

The list of adjectives I have actually found makes rather depressing reading, such as: 'the elderly', 'the injured', 'the unemployed', 'the sick', 'the aged', 'the worthless', 'the poor', and 'the mentally handicapped'. My point is that corpus data reveal attitudinal biases and selectional restrictions which are by no means typical of the set of all adjectives in English. We do find antonyms of some of these: 'rich' as well as 'poor', 'young' as well as 'old', 'educated' as well as 'uneducated', but their role is to occur with the unfortunate people for contrast; they are not heavily used on their own. The unfortunate are very definitely the recipients of this structure.

We find another main use of this structure, but not one typically given in grammar books. This other use does not figure in the grammars because it involves a *syntagmatic* structure, one of the *horizontal* structures where the choices are *consecutive*, rather than a *paradigmatic* or *vertical* structure where the choices are *alternative*. We encounter key phrases like 'borders on' and the type of complements it can have, such as 'the lurid', 'the obvious', 'the ridiculous', 'the obsessional', 'the psychic', 'the disturbing', 'the surreal', 'the paranoid', 'the ludicrous', 'the pretentious', or 'the unreal', and some abstract nouns like 'euphoria' and 'arrogance'. Quite a number of words of limitation will yield similar results. Article + adjective is clearly the preferred structure. As with the unfortunates who do not have the word 'people' after the adjectives, we have here a strange set of adjectives showing a particular attitudinal and connotational slant in corpus data, in this case, the limits of normality, by means of what Bréal (1897) referred to as 'contagion' (cf. Louw, 1993, p. 159).

Words gather attitudinal meanings from the words they characteristically co-occur with, and a word that does not have the expected meaning acquires irony, as in 'it borders on the holy', where we would not normally consider 'holy' to be on the verge of insanity.

There are two points to make about this. First, the components are semantically well ordered and not random; and second, the syntactic patterning is already relatively lengthy and complex. An even more complex variation of this construction is 'with a (something) that borders on the (something)', where eight words or so are in some sense all chosen at the same time with relatively little internal variation until the final adjective, as in 'with a pure fervour bordering on the religious'. This is not just an occasional oddity or rarity in the language; wherever you look you find such patterns emerging from corpus evidence.

Viewed from the perspective of a language teacher, we still have a lot to do before we get to the stage of marginal phrases like 'borders on'. And if corpus evidence only made a difference in such marginal areas, it would not have much impact. But common words show similar tendencies, which I cannot deal with here, because the data for any one of them would be unmanageably voluminous in a book chapter. If I took a common item like 'good' and showed you the data on 'good at', 'good with', 'good to', you would see the same sorts of patterning, but I would only be able to present a very small part of the data. So I prefer to show these patterns more quickly using rather uncommon expressions.

Some phenomena suggest an extension of the idea of meaningful choice, or possibly a hierarchy of meaningful choices, of which the outermost can be around seven words long; one recalls in this connection George Miller's (1956) famous formula of 'the magic number seven plus or minus two' relating to the capacity of short-term memory, which might be relevant for the way most of these structures tail off round about seven. A search may show two collocates being so frequently co-selected that it seems sensible to take them together as a unit and a product of a single choice, though not as a compound, since both elements are relatively free movers despite the significant habit of occurring together. When you feed these pairs into the computer and rerun the search, what almost invariably happens is that a third element pops up that you had not noticed before but is now seen to be organised in respect to the other two. So you take the three together and search again and continue the process, and at a certain point you run across a pragmatic functional meaning not noticed before which integrates the whole and supplies the reason for the various complex choices. It links the meaning of the phrase as a whole with the regimented choice of words.

One example is adjectives ending in '-ed' such as: 'surprised', 'amused', and 'horrified'. Significant collocates for 'surprised' include 'I', 'was', 'not', 'by', all high on a T-score statistic. The 'I' shows that, unlike many such adjectives, there is a self-orientation. You then get 'was', typical for these adjectives to select forms of the verb 'be', which tells you that this is organised as a complement structure. The 'not' shows that many more uses of 'surprised' are in the negative than could occur by chance. You get modals such as 'would' and conditionals such as 'if' in a

colligational structure coming up very clearly. Then you get the prepositions 'by' and 'at', which carry a negative prosody, indicating that what you are surprised by or at is not very nice, unless you neutralise or cancel this by using the word 'pleasantly', another frequent collocate. The collocate 'he' leads into report structures like 'said'. If you choose 'that', you are back to the 'I' structure since 'that' and 'I' collocate very frequently. The examples we see nearly always bring up the attitudinal meaning of indignation.

The most frequent lexical collocation with 'surprised', as compared to the grammatical colligations we have noticed, is 'find': 'being not surprised to find that', having a prosody of disappointment, unless it is cancelled out by 'pleasantly': 'they would not therefore be very surprised to find that her health had suffered'. If it is not disappointment, it can be more sinister: 'she was surprised to find that Mrs. West was continuously stroking her hair'; Mrs. West is currently in prison on ten life sentences.

To show you a particularly long one that occurs twenty-odd times in the corpus against enormous statistical improbabilities, 'you would be surprised at the number of people who' opens up with an attitude of disbelief, saying that you are going to have to rethink the position you presumably have. You get some variational modals like 'will' and 'would' and much less commonly 'may' and 'used to'; next to 'people' the most common collocate was 'women'.

Moving on from 'surprised', we can take a quick look at 'amused'. 'Amused' has the contagion (in the sense of Bréal) that it usually gives you a good feeling. The unexpected finding is that when you chose the word 'expression' you often get another adjective in the vicinity, as in 'curious, amused and quizzical', 'amused but long suffering' or 'a tolerant amused expression'. 'Amused' is hardly ever chosen as an attributive adjective by itself.

The warm feeling of 'amused' carries on with the collocation 'amused eyes', like 'amused flash of his eyes'; all the collocates are nice, interesting, fun words like 'frothy' and 'pleasant'.

The collocation 'to keep amused' is typically in combinations like 'to keep the children amused' during something that lasts a long time, such as a 'journey', 'long hours', or 'summer'. As well as 'children' or 'kids', you get 'baby', 'youngster', and so on. You are now almost reflecting upon middle-class activities and providing information about the culture.

## 4.3 Implications for teaching the language

Even non-native fluent speakers of English will have an immediate intuitive response, and this is part of a competence and of a well-ordered view of

language. The question is then what the implications might be for teaching the language. Here again, there is a range of different points of view and professional controversy. I personally have argued for two immediate and important implications from this new evidence that language teachers should accept. First, the job of *syllabus specification* ought to be informed by an account of the words, their patterns, and their frequency. I would refer to Dave Willis's (1990) book on the 'lexical syllabus'. If you have, for whatever target stage of the language you wish to teach, large amounts of evidence of used language, it is relatively simple to set out, in a reasonably prioritised order, patterns that have to be assimilated in order to qualify as a proficient communicator. I believe the specification of a syllabus should be totally independent of the methodology, but it has in recent years been confused with the methodology, and I hope it can be separated again. We are gaining a steadily better position for saying what you have to be good at.

The second implication is *humility* in the face of the precision of the corpus evidence: a feeling that the models of presentation of a language should be confined to what has occurred. Whenever the materials writer or teacher says: 'look, here is a model of what English is like', at that point they should be using guaranteed corpus evidence, not data made up, edited, or put together from other sources. It is not a sufficient condition but it is a necessary one. Of course, in the circumstances of classroom you often have to make up examples. But if, whenever we say 'that is what English is like', everybody could agree only to use guaranteed data, then I would predict that the standards of world English would rise significantly; unfortunately, I do not think that it is going to happen.

Beyond these two implications, there is evidence for a radical reconsideration of the way language is taught. We see a huge and growing pile of facts that we are somehow supposed to teach. We are worried because these facts do not seem orderly and do seem to constitute an additional burden on the language teacher. So the first instinct is to keep these facts at bay and claim that they are not necessarily relevant. The reaction is understandable, and I would plead for patience. The problem is directed less at *language teachers* than at *language describers* and *language theoreticians*. From a teacher's perspective, the point is that the models, theories, and descriptions at hand are not capable of handling this evidence and have not anticipated it.

This relates to what is generally called the dependency of teaching models available, and to the failure of applied linguistics to follow the reorientation of linguistic data. The challenges of the 1970s, such as discourse analysis, were met, and gave us the communicative method, which has been the strength of applied linguistics. Applied linguists, I have the impression, see themselves as mediators between the abstract and heady realms of linguistic theory and the humdrum

practical side of language teaching (Seidlhofer & Widdowson, 1998). They evaluate new developments in linguistics and advise the professions accordingly.

But in respect to corpus linguistics, they have been saying that there is nothing special about authentic data; applied linguists will decide what is taught. I have no quarrel with the argument that the patterns of language to be taught have to undergo pedagogic processing. I am not a supporter of heaping raw texts into the classroom, which is becoming quite fashionable. What is needed is a rational argument explaining why the pedagogy is at variance with the evidence; and why some common phraseology is not to be taught at the place and time that is suggested by its prominence.

My impression is that the materials which are typically taught in language classes are as little like 'borders on' as you can get. They are those words and phrases that do not form strong syntagmatic links but are much more independent in their ability to form patterns. Language books teach 'happy' rather than 'glad', and avoid 'set' apart from one or two of its phrasal verb uses, although there are about seventy. Also, the word 'place' is taught in language textbooks only in one meaning which does not normally occur, namely, as a geographical location, as in the textbook exercise: 'name three places you saw on your way to school this morning'.

I think the reason for all this could be: usages are avoided when they entail syntagmatic patterns we have no means of describing, far less teaching. The hypothesis is just taking shape that language teachers instinctively prefer words of a wider and looser pattern that are more amenable to what might be called a slot-and-filler model or a paradigmatic model of the language. In fact, however, syntagmatic and paradigmatic constitute a multidimensional spread in the lexicogrammar of a language, substantial evidence for which is only just becoming available. Some words attract a very large range over a lengthy stretch of text; other words are relatively independent.

A major task for this line of research is to classify vocabulary types using this new evidence; and I would be happy to provide this information to applied linguists. I can willingly believe that the reluctance of a pedagogue to follow the evidence of a corpus straightforwardly may be well motivated, and that the reasons for the motivation may be scientifically discoverable. But I do not respect the rejection of objective evidence on subjective grounds.

## 4.4 Conclusion

I hope my short presentation has been sufficient to indicate the kind of evidence and argument that we now have to consider, absorb, naturalise, and harmonise

with language teaching. When the lexical choices in the collocations, the grammatical choices in the colligations, and the semantic choices converge upon what I am calling 'prosodies', the attitudinal meanings emerge, and the surface patterns of language give way to meaningful choices. I would argue that it is almost inevitable for these patterns to find their way into language teaching. They are too central to miss and offer a simplification, because a language can be learned in larger bits. These offer to present only what is important at different levels; you do not have to learn anything that does not commonly occur.

The difficulty is that this syntagmatic view is at odds with conventional received ways of describing language: not just a lot of extra data but an actual incompatibility that can be resolved only when these descriptive outlines I have been putting forward are much more detailed and more rigorously described, and when applied linguists find ways of integrating these into language teaching.

PART II

# Linguistic stylistics

CHAPTER 5

# When is a poem like a sunset?*

## 5.1 Introduction

When is a poem like a sunset? The short answer is: when it is composed in an oral tradition. We normally discuss the appreciation of natural phenomena, like sunsets, in different terms from artefacts, like poems. It is no longer usual for people to look for the same sort of meaning in sunsets as they expect in language. If they did, they would be investing sunsets with the qualities of tastefully-presented omens.

Natural language is subject to natural laws, and several sets of these natural laws concern changes due to the passage of time. In the first place, a text itself may be damaged or destroyed, as may any artefact. Here literature is in a favourable position as compared to paintings, sculpture, architecture, etc.; for while a particular copy of a text may be at risk, a language text may be copied endlessly or remembered and passed orally for a time. A text, like a musical score, is almost independent of physical objects.

Secondly, an artefact is composed within a certain specific culture, and depends on conventions of that culture for part of its meaning. The conventions change with time, and although the physical appearance of the artefact may survive intact, its meaning may change. The special meaning of words in a poetic diction, the significance of a halo in religious paintings, may be difficult to recapture.

There is a third area of change which is particularly hazardous for a literary text, but which is irrelevant to other artefacts. A painting may have worldwide appeal even though the paint has faded, even though most of its admirers are not keenly conscious of the conventions surrounding its composition. A literary text has meaning only by comparison with a particular language at a particular time. Any stretch of language has meaning only as a sample of an enormously large body of text; it represents the results of a complicated selection process, and each selection has meaning by virtue of all the other selections which might have been made, but have been rejected. By studying a very long text, or by interrogating a native

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* This article appeared originally in *Review of English Literature* 6: 76–91 (1965). Reprinted in Lyle, E.B. (ed.). 1976. *Ballad Studies*. Cambridge NJ: Brewer, Rowman and Littlefield.

speaker, some approximation to the total set of selections, and their priorities, etc., may be set out, and the description so produced may be used in order to talk about the meaning of a shorter text.

## 5.2 Poem as sample of language

So a poem is a sample of a language; perhaps not a representative sample, but only carrying meaning because it can be referred to a description of a whole language. We assume that an educated native speaker, contemporary to the poem, has such a description built in, and may be said to have the potentiality of understanding the poem; anyone else must be taught.

A great deal is known about the language used in earlier periods in English-speaking areas. When this knowledge is applied to the literature, some account can be given of, say, the meaning of a Shakespeare play to its original audience.[1] There does not seem to be as much help available on the *judgement* of gains and losses in meaning through changes in time.[2] Although the text stays the same, the language, its reference-framework, changes; therefore its effect on a reader changes and the basis of his judgements becomes worthy of careful inspection. Whatever the theoretical objections to having our cake and eating it, in practice we may find such an attitude difficult to avoid. We go to a performance of a Shakespeare play conscious of having to make allowances; changes in the language may have made a serious line sound very funny, and we are on the alert to avoid laughing, and to adjust our reactions according to the extent of our knowledge of the period. In short, we tolerate. Rarely is there any balancing adjustment to devalue the happy accidents that may have befallen the meaning of the text.

Appreciation and evaluation become trickier still when we consider the operation of natural laws during the actual composition of works of literature, as happens in an oral tradition. Lines imperfectly remembered, lines meaningless to the performer being jumbled, phrases consciously archaized, etc. It must be assumed that such factors are present in the actual composition of a work which comes to us through an oral tradition. They are as likely to have been the origin of a fine

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1. See, for example, A. McIntosh and C. F. Williamson 'King Lear, Act I Scene i, A Stylistic Note' in *Review of English Studies*, New Series, vol. 14, 1963, 54–58.

2. J. Fox, in *The Poetry of Villon*, London: Thomas Nelson, 1962, Chapter 2, gives a useful survey of current opinions on this point. But it is interesting to notice how much of the chapter is concerned with what attitudes we ought to adopt, rather than what attitudes we are capable of adopting.

phrase or an obscurity as is the creative mind of an author in a written tradition, whose original text is usually discoverable. Although such an author may have been affected during composition by all sorts of random occurrences, there is a great difference between a text for which an author accepts responsibility and one which has been seriously affected by natural laws, long after its original composer relinquished responsibility for it.

Where there are several extant versions of a text composed in an oral tradition, some hints may be gained about the effect of the handing-down process. But rarely is there anything approximating to a complete record of the textual history; rarely can one be sure that a set of texts represents a continuous sequence without any branching. There is usually a danger of stylistic evidence being used in the placing of texts relative to each other, and in that event the set of texts cannot yield stylistic information without circularity.

## 5.3 The Experiment

In view of the inadequacies of the surviving texts, I decided a few years ago to manufacture my own texts. I set up a brief 'oral tradition' and passed a text down to see what would happen to it. The first experiment, which I will describe in this chapter, was purely preliminary. I wanted the results of it to suggest the lines on which a more scientific experiment could be carried out. However, despite its informal setting, the experiment revealed features which are of immediate interest both in my present subject and in more general considerations of how literary texts give meaning.

First, a few words about the circumstances of the experiment. Six of my students agreed to take part,[3] and one of them learned by heart a chosen version of Keats's "La Belle Dame Sans Merci". From that point on, none of the participants consulted a text of the poem. Allowing at least a week to elapse, the first student passed the poem orally to the next by reciting it over and over again until the two agreed that the poem had been accurately transmitted. Then, and only then, the first participant wrote out the version just transmitted and gave it to me. In due course I collected six versions of the poem, representing its progress down the line.

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3. I would like to record my gratitude to the six whose enthusiasm carried the experiment through, and who helped a great deal in discussion of the results. They are: Susan Collin, Gwyneth Llewellyn, Helen Martin, John Minnion, David Reid and Luke van Buuren.

This synthetic oral tradition is open to any number of criticisms concerning how accurately it simulates a real one. University students were used, the poem was already familiar to them, the time element was ridiculously compressed, etc. Nevertheless, it remains very likely that the changes discussed below are at least of the same general type as the actual changes which have affected extant ballad poetry.

Now to the presentation of the changes themselves. I propose to tabulate these initially according to the position of altered syllables in the rhythm and grammar of the poem. Then I will tentatively classify them according to my assessment of their stylistic effect, of the way they have altered the meaning of the poem. To show the total effect of the changes, the poem is printed in square brackets above a 'composite change version'. Some of the changes were lost in the final version, because the original readings were restored; so I have put together a text which shows as many of the changes as is possible in a single version.

1. [Ah what can ail thee wretched wight
 Alone and palely loitering;
 The sedge is withered from the lake,
 And no birds sing.]

1. O what can ail thee wretched knight
 So pale and lonely wandering
 The sedge has withered on the lake
 And no birds sing.

5. [Ah what can ail thee, wretched wight,
 So haggard and so woebegone
 The squirrel's granary is full
 And the harvest's done.]

5. O what can ail thee wretched knight
 So pale and lonely wandering
 The squirrel's granary is full
 And no birds sing.

9. [I see a lily on thy brow
 With anguish moist and fever dew
 And on thy cheek a fading rose
 Fast withereth too.]

9. A lily sits upon thy brow
 Of fever moist and passion dew
 And on thy cheek a fading rose
 Fast withereth too.

13. [I met a lady in the meads
Full beautiful, a faery's child.
Her hair was long, her foot was light
And her eyes were wild.]

13. I saw a lady in the mead
Full beautiful, a fairy child
Her hair was long, her foot was light
And her eye was bright

17. [I set her on my pacing steed
And nothing else saw all day long
For sideways would she lean, and sing
A faery's song.]

17. I took her on my pacing steed
And all day long did ride
She sang a fairy song
And gazed from side to side

21. [I made a garland for her head
And bracelets too and fragrant zone.
She looked at me as she did love
And made sweet moan.]

21. I wove her garlands for her hair
And bracelets sweet, of fragrant zone
And she did look as she did love
And made sweet moan.

25. [She found me roots of relish sweet
And honey wild and manna dew
And sure in language strange she said
I love thee true.]

25. She fetched me roots of relish sweet
And honey wild, and manna dew
She looked at me and sighed
I love you true

29. [She took me to her elfin grot
And there she gazed and sighed deep
And there I shut her wild sad eyes
So kissed to sleep.]

29. She took me to her elfin grot
And there she sighed both long and deep
And there I closed her wild sad eyes
So kissed asleep

33. [And there we slumbered on the moss
And there I dreamed, ah! woe betide!
The latest dream I ever dreamed
On the cold hill side.]

33. And there we slumbered on the moss
And there I dreamed, o woe betide
The latest dream I ever dreamed
On the cold hillside

37. [I saw pale kings and princes too
Pale warriors, death-pale were they all
Who cried La belle dame sans merci
Hath thee in thrall.]

37. I saw pale kings and princes too
And warriors pale (death-pale were they all)
They said La belle dame sans merci
Has thee enthralled

41. [I saw their starved lips in the gloam
With horrid warning gaped wide
And I awoke and found me here
On the cold hill side.]

41. Their lips were horrid in the gloam
Horrid warnings gapeth wide
And then I woke and found myself
On the cold hillside

45. [And this is why I sojourn here
Alone and palely loitering
Though the sedge is withered from the lake
And no birds sing.]

45. And that is why you see me here
So pale and lonely wandering
Tho' sedge has withered on the lake
And no birds sing.

### 5.3.1 Tabulation of changes

Line references are throughout to the original version. Because certain passages underwent several changes, the bracketed form in the tables is not always that of the original, but sometimes of an intermediate reading.

Here and there, especially in the written representation of unstressed syllables, the conventions of writing force one to be more specific than is necessary in

speech; several of the changes below may represent a changing interpretation of a constant sound. These are marked with an asterisk.

I have also marked with a sword (†) two changes which happen to restore a rejected draft version of the poet.

*A. Unstressed Syllables*

i. Substitution: monosyllabic words

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| Line 1, 5, 34 : | ah | > | o(h) |
| 3* : | is | > | has |
| 3, 47 : | from | > | on |
| 10 : | with | > | of |
| 16 : | were | > | was [see also A(iii)] |
| 21* : | a | > | her [see also A(iii)] |
| 22 : | and | > | of > a [syllable no. 5] |
| 28 : | thee | > | you |
| 39† : | who | > | they |
| 40 : | hath | > | has |
| 41* : | their | > | the |
| 42 : | with | > | their > the |

ii. Changes in word division

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2, 6, 46 : | a- | > | so [see also C(i)] |
| 30 : | sigh*ed* | > | sighed *both* [see also D(i)] |
| 32* : | to | > | a- |
| 40* : | in | > | en- |
| 43 : | a- | > | then [see also D(i)] |

iii. Inflectional changes

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 8 : | harvest's | > | harvest |
| 13 : | meads | > | mead |
| 14, 20 : | faery's | > | fairy |
| 16 : | eyes | > | eye |
| 21 : | garland | > | garlands |
| 40 : | enthrall | > | enthralled |
| 42 : | gaped | > | gapeth |

iv. Rhythm changes

| | |
|---|---|
| 8 : | the (syllable 2) (drops out) |
| 38 : | and (is added initially) [see also C(ii)] |
| 42 : | with (drops out) |
| 47 : | the (syllable 2) (drops out) |

*B. Stressed Syllables*

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1, 5 : | wight | > | knight |
| 2, 6, 46 : | loitering | > | wandering |
| 10 : | anguish | > | passion [see also C(i)] |
| 13 : | met | > | saw |
| 16 : | wild | > | bright [see also E(ii)] |
| 21 : | made | > | wove |
| | head | > | hair |
| 22 : | too | > | sweet |
| 25 : | found | > | fetched > gave |
| 27 : | said | > | sighed [see also D(ii)] |
| 31 : | shut | > | closed > shut > closed |
| 39 : | cried | > | said |
| 45 : | this | > | that |

*C. Sequence of Words*

i. Rhythm preserved

2, 6, 46 : alone and palely > so pale and lonely

10 :
: with { anguish / fever / anguish / passion / fever } moist and { fever / anguish / fever / fever / passion } dew
:

27 : in language strange she said > she said in language strange

40† : hath thee > thee hath

ii. Rhythm altered

19 : for sideways would she lean > for she would sideways lean [see also E(iii)]

38 : pale warriors > warriors pale

*D. Rewriting*

i. Rhythm preserved

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 30 : | gazed and sighed | > | sighed long and |
| 43 : | and I awoke | > | and then I woke |
| 45 : | I sojourn here | > | you see me here |

ii. Rhythm altered

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 9 : | I see a lily on | > | a lily sits upon |
| 23 : | she looked at me | > | and she did look |
| 27 : | she said in language strange | > | she looked at me and said |
| 38 : | pale warriors | > | warriors pale |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 41 : | I saw their starved lips | > | their lips were horrid |
| 43 : | me here | > | myself |

*E. Stanzaic Changes*

i. Line re-arrangements

6 : replaced by modified line 2

8 : replaced by line 4, line 8 restored and again replaced by 4.

ii. Rhyming

Stanza 4 : a b c b > a b c c

iii. Extensive modifications

Stanza 5

### 5.3.2 Stylistic categories

The changes range in size from the hardly noticeable alterations in unstressed syllables to the recasting of a whole stanza. Each of them changes the meaning of the poem. The next task is to set up suitable categories in which changes can be grouped together which seem to cause the same sort of change in meaning.

One general category that will be needed is *analogy*; the tendency towards regularity. Changes due to analogy will be those for which there is a *model* nearby in the text. The line rearrangement in stanza 2 are by analogy with stanza 1, while the curious change in rhyme-scheme in line 16 is no doubt due to the occurrence of the rhyming vowel in line 15 as well as line 14. The following grammatical changes seem to be based on analogy:

| *line* | *change* | *model* | *line* |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2 | alone > so pale | so haggard | 6 |
| 16 | her eyes were wild > | | |
| | her eye was wild | her hair was long | |
| | | her foot was light | 15 |
| 21 | I made a garland > | | |
| | I made her garlands | and bracelets | 22 |
| 23 | she looked at me > | | |
| | and she did look | as she did love | 23 |
| 27 | in language strange she said > | | |
| | she looked at me and said | she looked at me as | 23 |
| 45 | I sojourn here > | | |
| | you see me here | and found me here | 43 |

The interesting alteration to line 9 (I see a lily on thy brow > a lily sits upon thy brow) may partly be explained as an extension of the kind of subject found in the

first two stanzas. *The sedge, no birds, the squirrel's granary, the harvest* are very different from the personal pronoun *I* that follows them. For the rest of the poem, the pronouns *I* and *she* are almost the only subjects of clauses. The point of interest here is that the alteration causes the subject-change to coincide with the change of speaker, between stanzas 3 and 4. In the original version, the first *I* in line 9 refers to the questioner, and all subsequent ones to the wight himself. The altered version simplifies the structure of the poem as a whole.

In the vast majority of the changes, the rhythm is left alone or altered only slightly. Line 47 is almost identical to line 3, and it loses a syllable which makes it rhythmically identical. Line 8 also loses a syllable, perhaps because of the influence of line 4.

Twice in the poem word-substitutions echo nearby words. Both these changes are further discussed later on, but may be mentioned here.

| | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Line 41 | : | starved | > | horrid | : | *model* | : | horrid 42 |
| 27 | : | said | > | sighed | : | *model* | : | sighed 30 |

The next general stylistic category that it is profitable to set up is *revision*. By this I mean both the modernizing of archaic forms and the replacement of poetic structures by structures more common in non-literary modern English. In several places the participants have replaced words and phrases which were not very familiar to them by approximately equivalent words and phrases in their everyday idiom. The examples below show that 'equivalance' may mean many things.

In line 3 *is withered* becomes *has withered*, and again in line 47. The older form of the 'perfect' tense is rejected. Other verbal points concern the change from *hath* to *has* (line 40) and the loss of the second syllable in *sighed* (30). Oddly enough, the other verb which has one more syllable in the poem than it has in modern English changes into an archaic form, *gaped* > *gapeth*, line 42. Among the pronouns, *thee* becomes *you* (28) and *this* (45) becomes the much more natural *that*. A neat change in line 43, *and found me here* > *and found myself* inserts, correctly for Modern English, the reflexive pronoun. Two adverbial elements are reduced in prominence by being shifted nearer to their most usual positions of occurrence (lines 19 and 27).

Several vocabulary changes can be assigned to this category. The word *thrall* (40) by various changes becomes the common enough word *enthralled*, but with quite a change in meaning! Line 43 has a vocabulary change involving slight modernization:

and I awoke > and then I woke

but also the introduction of *then* could be seen as a grammatical revision. *Loitering* probably is picking up taboo associations; for a while it is replaced by *wandering* (lines 2, 46). *Wight* (1, 5) becomes *knight*, almost certainly influenced by an

alternative version of the poem ('O what can ail thee, Knight at arms'): and *sojourn* (45) gets a face-lift: *I sojourn here* > *you see me here*.

These are the main indications of *revision*. But I want to include in this category those changes which seem to involve misunderstanding of, or failure to understand, the meaning of a passage. In one way or another, the changes we have mentioned so far have been restrained by considerations of rhythm and meaning. Once the original meaning ceases to be an important factor, one can expect fairly radical changes. Line 10 offers a fine example. If I understand Keats correctly, what he wrote is roughly paraphrasable as 'moist with anguish and the dew produced by a fever'. The tortuous syntax of line 10 fights against the structural parallelism of *anguish moist* and *fever dew*. The two phrases have the same syllabification, the same position in the half-line, and their meanings are very similar. *Anguish* and *fever* are both nouns; in fact there is only one clear pointer to the underlying syntax: that *dew* is not normally an adjective. My participants made it an adjective, and, having lost the sense, permutated the nouns with gusto [see C(i) above]. The change in the initial syllable of the line, *with* > *of*, underlines the loss of the syntactic meaning; *moist of anguish* is an impossible construction in modern English.

The alterations to line 22 reflect what is perhaps a minor obscurity in the poem. Keats wrote 'And bracelets too, and fragrant zone'. It would seem that the speaker made circlets for the lady's head, wrists and waist. But if so the line would be more likely to read *and fragrant zones*, or *and a fragrant zone*. But as it stands, a 'mass' noun is an archaic meaning and an odd construction: it is ripe for alteration. *Of fragrant zone* – presumably zone is a flower. *A fragrant zone* – here we have a nominal expression in a vaguely appositional relationship to what precedes it.

It might be a little uncharitable to place the change in line 41 in this category: *I saw their starved lips* > *their lips were horrid*. The meaning of *starve*, perhaps, is misunderstood. In fact this line is one of six together (37–42) where so many changes occur that one is led to the conclusion that the narrative was found difficult to follow there. The appositional group *pale warriors* in 38 becomes linked to the preceding line by *and*, and eventually drops the *pale*. Other examples tend to dislocate the syntax. The relative clause *who cried* becomes a second main clause *they cried*; the clear reference of *their* in *their starved lips* (41) becomes ambiguous when *their* changes to *the*; the loss of the initial preposition *with* in line 42 causes the subject of *gaped* to change from *their starved lips* to *horrid warnings*. The dropped initial syllable in this line returns as *their*, and eventually *the*. Keats contrived a subtle mixture of the open-mouthed warning and the fixed gape of a dead face. Our resultant version was very close to nonsense.

It may be significant that in lines 38 and 40 occur two of the very few instances of a pattern running counter to revision, the tendency to archaize and

poeticize. If the narrative thread has been lost, the spirit of the passage, at least, has been preserved.

I shall call the third and last category *approximation*. In this category will come alterations which seem to have arisen largely through forgetfulness of detail. A word perhaps is replaced by one similar in meaning, but not by analogy and without the implications of revision. As one might expect, Section B of the tabulation (stressed-syllable changes) provides a number of the examples:

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 13 | I *met* a lady | > | *saw* |
| 21 | I *made* her garlands for her *head* | > | *wove … hair* |
| 22 | and bracelets *too* | > | *sweet* |
| 25 | she *found* me roots | > | *fetched* > *gave* |
| 27 | in language strange she *said* | > | *sighed* |
| 30 | she *gazed and sighed* deep | > | *sighed long and* |
| 31 | I *shut* her wild sad eyes | > | *closed* >*shut*>*closed* |
| 39 | who *cried* La belle dame | > | *said* |

The easy alternation in line 31 points towards synonymity; other changes may be considered as substitutions of vocabulary items with similar meanings but different *ranges*. *Found* has a wider range of potential occurrence than *fetched*, but *gave* is the widest of the three. *Said* narrows to *sighed* but *cried* widens to *said*. There is no evidence of a 'watering down' of the poetic effects in this area, since many of the changes represent something more like a 'concentration' of meaning.

The change in line 22 is more drastic than most and requires a slight digression, because it may partly be due to analogy. The second lines of stanzas in the poem frequently contain parallel structures (certainly stanzas 2, 3, 7, 8 and 10). *Bracelets sweet* creates a chiastic pattern with *fragrant zone*, whereas *bracelets too* does not. Further, the structure of 'noun + adjective' is virtually extinct in modern English, and it is one of the most obvious poetic archaisms in this poem. In the same stanzaic position as *bracelets sweet* occur *anguish moist* and *honey wild*; later on in the poem, *pale warriors* becomes *warriors pale* in the same stanzaic position. These facts are hints of analogy working over a greater extent of text than we have allowed for.

To return to the examples of approximation. A few of the inflexional changes [see Section A(iii)] are of this type.

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 8 | and the *harvest's done* | > | *harvest* |
| 13 | in the *meads* | > | *mead* |
| 14, 20 | a *faery's* child | > | *fairy* |
| | a *faery's* song | | |
| 14 | with horrid *warning* | > | *warnings* |

These are minor alterations in syntax. That in line 8 complicates the syntax because the new version presupposes the *is* of line 7.

The tiny changes in lines 3 and 47 merit attention, to show the sort of effect an approximation can have on the meaning of a line:

the sedge *is* withered *from* the lake > *has* … *on*

Keats wrote a rather subtle line which combined two distinct meanings. The line might be paraphrased as:

'The sedge on the lake is withered, and, being withered, gives the impression of having disappeared from the lake.'

The conflated meaning is achieved by two devices:

a. the ambiguity in *is*, already mentioned above;
b. the selection of *from*, which is an odd preposition to use alongside the verb *wither*. The altered version flattens out the meaning by firmly selecting one of the alternatives.

## 5.4 Summary

The three categories are sufficient for all but a handful of the changes in the poem; *analogy*, the influence of the immediate language environment; *revision*, the influence of the modern speaker's habits of language; and *approximation*, the influence of his inexact memory for detail. I hope this chapter has shown the power they have to transform a text so much that its own author would hardly recognize it. All three categories may be assumed to have played a part in the actual composition of works that were passed down in an oral tradition. How then do we assess the obscurities, clichés, simple structures, parallelisms, non sequiturs, refrains, etc., of our heritage of oral poetry? As poems, or at least, in part, as sunsets?

CHAPTER 6

# Taking a poem to pieces*

## 6.1 Introduction

This chapter is designed to carry the reader of literature to the brink of linguistics.[1] In recent years a number of linguists[2] have attempted to describe linguistic features as they occur in literary texts, hoping that their descriptions might help a reader to understand and appreciate the text. I have chosen a short, recent, lyric poem. It contains no magnetic peculiarities of language; in fact most critics, I imagine, would ignore the language altogether. My hypothesis is that the grammatical and other patterns are giving meaning in a more complex and tightly packed way than we expect from our familiarity with traditional methods of describing language. Modern methods of linguistic analysis, based on more comprehensive and detailed theories of language, can at least tackle the problem of describing literature. In this chapter the accent will be on grammar; there is little to say about the vocabulary of such a short text when we have no proper description of English vocabulary patterns to use as a basis; the phonology and orthography (the study of the sound- and letter-sequences and combinations) are also largely ignored – with reluctance – for reasons of space and simplicity.

The only phonological units which we shall need are the stanza and the line, and the first question is how congruent are the grammatical and metrical units here? This question splits down into two: what are the relative sizes of the units, and how do they fit together?

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* This article appeared originally in Fowler, R. 1966. *Essays on Style and Language*, 68–81. London: Routledge. Reprinted in Freeman, D.E., 1970. *Linguistics and Literary Style*. New York NY: Holt, Rinehart and Winston.

1. This chapter is a revised version of a chapter delivered to the Nottingham University Linguistics Society in January 1964.

2. For example, M. A. K. Halliday, 'The Linguistic Analysis of Literary Texts', *Proceedings of the IXth Congress of Linguists*, The Hague: Mouton, 1964; A. A. Hill, 'An Analysis of *The Windhover*: An Experiment in Structural Method', *PMLA*, Vol. 70, no. 5, Dec., 1955, pp. 968–978; S. R. Levin, *Linguistic Structures in Poetry,* The Hague: Mouton, 1962.

## 6.2 Analysis of *First Sight*

Here is the poem:

FIRST SIGHT[3]

1 Lambs that learn to walk in snow
When their bleating clouds the air
Meet a vast unwelcome, know
Nothing but a sunless glare.
5 Newly stumbling to and fro
All they find, outside the fold,
Is a wretched width of cold.

As they wait beside the ewe,
Her fleeces wetly caked, there lies
10 Hidden round them, waiting too,
Earth's immeasurable surprise.
They could not grasp it if they knew,
What so soon will wake and grow
Utterly unlike the snow.

PHILIP LARKIN

Sentences are on average three and a half lines, half a stanza long. (Each line has seven syllables except lines 9 and 12, and each stanza has seven lines.) Sentences are all about the same length, either three or four lines long. There is complete congruence, then, between line, sentence and stanza, since each sentence-stop ends a line, each stanza end ends a sentence, and sentences are as nearly uniform in length as is possible. So we are given a framework of grammar and metre where there is an exceptionally good fit; there are no tag ends of sentences at the ends of stanzas, and there is no great discrepancy in the length of sentences.

### 6.2.1 Sentence structure

Moving on to the structure of the sentences, we recognize two elements, in the primary analysis; what we call a *free* clause and what we call a *bound* clause.[4] *They could not grasp it* is a typical free clause, and *when their bleating clouds the air* or

3. Larkin, P. 1964. *The Whitsun Weddings*, London: Faber & Faber, p. 21.

4. This article is not a suitable place for an exposition of the grammar which I am using. I hope the terms, supported by the examples, will be self-explanatory. Dr M. A. K. Halliday of University College, London, originated the grammatical categories which are used here. For more detailed information the reader is referred to his 'Categories of the Theory of Grammar', *Word*, xvii (1961), p. 241–92.

*newly stumbling to and fro* are bound clauses. No distinction is made at this depth of detail between clauses containing a finite or a non-finite verb, since their operation in the structure of sentences is almost identical. Using just this one distinction, we can plot the occurrence of these clauses relative to each other and relative to the lines in the poem. (See Table 6.1).

**Table 6.1** Sentence structure

α and β are elements of sentence structure expounded by free and bound clauses respectively. To account for interruptions, the symbols α- and β- in column 3 indicate that a clause is interrupted by a line-ending or another clause, and (–α) and (–β) indicate the conclusion of an interrupted clause. In column 4 is given the structure of the four sentences, with square brackets surrounding the symbol for a clause which occurs inside the one whose symbol precedes the bracket.

| Exponents of 'α' | Line no. | Sentence structure/line | Exponents of 'β' | Sentence structure |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Lambs that learn to walk in snow | 1 | α– | | α[β]α |
| | 2 | β | When their bleating clouds the air | |
| Meet a vast unwelcome, know | 3 | (–α)α– | | |
| Nothing but a sunless glare. | 4 | (–α) | | |
| | 5 | β | Newly stumbling to and fro | βα |
| All they find, outside the fold, | 6 | α– | | |
| Is a wretched width of cold. | 7 | (–α) | | |
| | 8 | β | As they wait beside the ewe, | βα[ββ] |
| there lies | 9 | βα– | Her fleeces wetly caked, | |
| | 10 | ββ | Hidden round them, waiting too, | |
| Earth's immeasurable surprise. | 11 | (–α) | | |
| They could not grasp it | 12 | αβ | if they knew, | αββ |
| | 13 | β– | What so soon will wake and grow | |
| | 14 | (–β) | Utterly unlike the snow. | |

It will be seen that no account has been taken of two clauses in the poem; in the first line, *that learn to walk in snow* and in the sixth, *they find*. These clauses are not operating in sentence structure at all; instead they are forming part of the structure of what we are going to call *nominal groups*. If they operated directly in sentence structure then *all, outside the fold, is a wretched width of cold* would be isolated as a complete clause. There is nothing in the shape of this word-sequence to prohibit it standing as a clause, but is it not the one in the poem. Clauses which do not form discrete elements of the structure of sentences are called *rankshifted* clauses.

In everyday English, in the mass of sentences which contain α and β the sequence αβ is most common. Discontinuity, i.e. α[β] is rarer, and so is the sequence βα. The last sentence in the poem is a good example of the αβ type.

It is the only one. The other three have discontinuous α, βα sequence, and both, in that order. But we can refine the idea of discontinuity a little with reference to a particular text like this one. As we read along the lines, we can say at certain points that we confidently expect something else to finish off a structure. If at the bottom of a page one reads *He put* one expects on the next page to read about not only something to put but somewhere to put it. If one reads *He played* one is a lot less certain what will follow; in fact, if it was not contrary to normal printers' practice we would not be surprised if the next page started with a period. Now the effect which we can presume an intruding element to have will depend in any instance on the strength of the current expectations. It is clear that strong expectations have been set up in both the cases of discontinuous clauses here: *lambs that learn to walk in snow* … and *there lies*. … It is interesting, too, that both occurrences of the item *wait* are in bound clauses which either precede or interrupt free ones. Here there is a serious difficulty in terminology. A term is needed to indicate a sentence in which the onset of a predictable α is delayed or in which its progress is interrupted. Unfortunately, whatever term is coined is liable to be construed as a contextually meaningful label. I want to use the term *arrest* for this type of structure, without wishing to suggest that *any* occurrence of this structure produces an 'effect' of arrestment. Pseudo-linguistic literature is already too full of naive correlations between a noise or a structure and explicit meanings. I wish my terms to carry only as much contextual meaning as terms like *finite, predicate*. With this in mind, let us say that the first three sentences in the poem are *arrested*, whereas the last one is not.

In sentence 1, then (structure α[β]α), the progress of the first α is interrupted by the β. Sentence 2 (βα) by beginning with β, delays the onset of the α. Both these exponents of arrest appear in sentence 3 (βα[ββ]) where the solitary α has its onset delayed and its progress interrupted.

### 6.2.2 Clause structure

Next we must consider the structure of the clauses in this poem. We recognize four primary elements of clause structure, the subject (S), predicator (P), complement (C) and adjunct (A). Every part of every clause must be ascribed to one or other of these four elements (the exceptions are irrelevant to our present purpose). The subject and complement(s) are usually nominal groups, the predicator a verbal group, and adjuncts are adverbial groups. Let us plot the structure of clauses in much the same way as we did the structure of sentences. In this diagram the slanting line (/) denotes the place where an intruding clause appears and the vertical line (|) denotes where a line boundary occurs. The rankshifted clauses in both cases are part of the subject of another clause. The reader is referred to Table 6.2.

**Table 6.2** Clause structure

| Exponent | Free | Bound | Rankshifted |
|---|---|---|---|
| Lambs that learn to walk in snow/\| meet a vast unwelcome | S/\|PC | | |
| that learn to walk in snow | | | SPA |
| When their bleating clouds the air | | ASPC | |
| know \| Nothing but a sunless glare. | P\|C | | |
| Newly stumbling to and fro | | APA | |
| All they find outside the fold \| Is a wretched width of cold. | SA\|PC | | |
| they find | | | SP |
| As they wait beside the ewe | | ASPA | |
| Her fleeces wetly caked | | SAP | |
| There lies/\| Earth's immeasurable surprise. | SP/\|C | | |
| Hidden round them, | | PA | |
| waiting too | | PA | |
| They could not grasp it | SPC | | |
| if they knew, | | ASP | |
| What so soon will wake and grow \| Utterly unlike the snow. | | SAP\|A | |

As with the sentences, let us see how well the clauses fit the lines. Here there is a clear difference between free and bound clauses. Though simple in structure, all the free clauses except the last have a line boundary in the middle, and in the last bound one there is a line boundary. What is the meaning of a line-boundary?[5]

5. Some phonological aspects of arrest and release are treated in detail in R. G. Fowler's 'Prose Rhythm and Metre', in Roger Fowler (ed.). 1966. *Essays on Style and Language*, London: Routledge and Kegan Paul, p. 82–99.

Clearly its meaning depends upon its relation to the surrounding grammar. If it occurs between sentences (as at the end of lines 4 and 11) it is *congruent* with the grammar, and its meaning is of reinforcement, or the like. If it occurs between clauses or at any lower rank, then its meaning is dependent on the nature of the predictions that have been set up. Thus a line boundary occurring between α and β in most cases simply reinforces, emphasizes the structural boundary. It adds, perhaps, a slight element of surprise to the occurrence of the β. On the other hand a line boundary occurring between β and α will reinforce the prediction of the β, will reinforce the *arrest* that was mentioned above.

### 6.2.3 Line boundaries

A line boundary within a clause will follow the same pattern, according to the amount of prediction that precedes it. Table 6.3 shows the line boundaries in this poem classified by

a. Grammatical rank; sentence, clause and group.
b. Type, i.e. *arresting* (when predictions have been set up)
*releasing* (where there are no remaining *grammatical* predictions).

It is clear from Tables 6.2 and 6.3 that in the first three sentences the free clauses are all arrested, whereas in the last sentence the free clause is neutral and a bound one is released. The only reason we have to expect the last line in the poem is a metrical one. Again the last sentence is quite different from the others.

One common feature of English grammar is not represented in the clause or sentence structure of this poem. This is *linkage*, words like *and, but, however, in fact* which occur so often in conversation and writing. In this poem, each sentence, and each free or bound clause, stands rather separate. The only examples of such words, the *but* of line 4 and *and* of line 13, link items inside clauses, and do not affect the isolation of clauses and sentences.

All the free clauses are affirmative. No interrogatives, exclamations, imperatives. Also, all free clauses are transitive, and only one bound clause is (line 2). So transitivity is here carried almost entirely by the free clauses. Fennellosa may cry ecstatically[6] but this fact in grammar is no more crucial of itself than any other. The sequence of the elements of clause structure is pretty much what would be expected in everyday English. Unusual sequences of elements of clause structure

6. See Davie, D. 1958. *Articulate Energy*: *An enquiry into the syntax of English poetry*. New York: Harcourt, Brace and Company, p. 35.

**Table 6.3** Line boundaries (including stanza boundary)

| Line ref. | Rank | Between structures | Arrest/release |
|---|---|---|---|
| 4 | Sentence | Sentence/sentence | |
| 7 | Sentence | Sentence/sentence | |
| 11 | Sentence | Sentence/sentence | |
| 2 | Clause | β/α | Arrest |
| 5 | Clause | β/α | Arrest |
| 8 | Clause | β/α | Arrest |
| 10 | Clause | β/α | Arrest |
| 12 | Clause | β/β | Release |
| 1 | Group | S/P | Arrest |
| 3 | Group | P/C | Arrest |
| 6 | Group | A/P | Arrest |
| 9 | Group | P/C | Arrest |
| 13 | Group | P/A | Release |

form a familiar set of devices in the language of poetry, but in this poem it must be noted that the adjuncts scarcely ever occur in other than the commonest position for them. *Newly* (line 5) and *outside the fold* (line 6) are slightly unusual and are discussed further below; *so soon* (line 13) is perhaps slightly in advance of its commonest position.

Two points must be made, in greater detail, in regard to the punctuation of adjuncts.

a. Line 6 *outside the fold*. Note the comma preceding this adjunct. Without it one would naturally tend to regard *outside the fold* as part of the rankshifted clause and analyse as follows:

| | S | P | C |
|---|---|---|---|
| | all they find outside the fold/ | is/ | a wretched width of cold. |

The element *S* would be uttered with one intonation contour with its most prominent point on the last syllable, *fold*. But because of the comma, we analyse

| S | A | P | C |
|---|---|---|---|
| all they find/ | outside the fold/ | is/ | a wretched width of cold |

and there are now two separate intonation contours, a falling one, most prominent on *find*, and a slightly rising one, most prominent on *fold*.

The difference in meaning is slight, here, between presence or absence of the comma. A point is made about the lambs actually going outside the fold. Compare the difference using the verb *see*.

all they see outside the fold, is a wretched width of cold.
all they see, outside the fold, is a wretched width of cold.

Since the adjunct, in part of the surrounding non-rankshifted clause, is out of position, the total contrast is similar to the contrast between

John, outside the office, found it nice.
and
John found it nice outside the office.

b. Line 13. There is no comma after *grow*, but there is a line boundary, which has something of a parallel effect, of separating one piece of language from another. Here the difference in meaning is considerable. Compare

I want him to grow like me (i.e. assuming he will grow, specifying direction)
I want him to grow, like me (i.e. specifying growth and drawing a parallel)

Because the text has an ambiguous structure at this point, the adjunct 'utterly unlike the snow' is, in my interpretation, made to do double duty. A rough paraphrase might run thus:

The snow will not grow but something else will, and when it does it will grow to look utterly unlike the snow.

These are, of course, not the only points of punctuation. For example, some readers may disagree with the analysis of lines 9–10, on the grounds that *lies hidden* is a unit which cannot be divided by a clause boundary; again the absence of a comma supports this, whereas the occurrence of a line-end suggests the division. The poet has the advantage here also of a combination of the alternative meanings.

### 6.2.4 Groups: Verbal, adverbial and nominal

We may now consider structure at the next rank below clause, the *group*, the unit out of which clauses are made. It may consist of one or more words, and groups have a direct relation to elements of clause structure. There are three kinds of group, as we have already noted, *nominal, verbal* and *adverbial* (see Table 6.4). Verbal groups are the simplest kind in this text, since nearly all the verbal groups are single-word, present-tense items. This is only remarkable when one thinks of the enormous variety of choices available, e.g. *might have come, could have been coming, wasn't going to come, came sailing, came to talk, oughtn't to have been going*

*to be avoiding coming to see*. With such a restricted selection, the variations are liable to be quite striking, and as one might expect they distinguish sentence 4 from the others. None of the verbs in this sentence are 'simple present' items. Two contain *modal verbs*, i.e. *could* and *will*; one of these is negative and the other 'double-headed' – *wake and grow*. The third is a 'simple past' item in a bound clause. The only other complication in verbal groups is the *learn to walk* in line 1.

**Table 6.4** Groups

| **Nominal** | **Verbal** | **Adverbial** |
|---|---|---|
| Lambs that learn to walk in snow | learn to walk | in snow |
| that snow | --- | When |
| their bleating the air | clouds | |
| a vast unwelcome | Meet know | |
| Nothing but a sunless glare. | | |
| | stumbling | Newly to and fro |
| All they find the fold | find | outside the fold |
| they | --- | |
| a wretched width of cold | Is | |
| cold | | |
| they the ewe | wait | As beside the ewe |
| Her fleeces there | caked lies | wetly |
| them | Hidden waiting | round them too |
| Earth's immeasurable surprise. | | |
| They it they | could not grasp knew | if |
| What | will wake and grow | so soon |
| the snow | | Utterly unlike the snow |

The adverbial groups are not very prominent. The three main kinds of adverbial group are the grammatical binding groups like *when, if*, the adverbs like *newly* and *so soon*, and the prepositional groups like *in snow*. In this poem the main point again is their simplicity. Of the second and third types, there is no distinction made in the poem that is not covered by facts already adduced and not worth repeating. It is useful, though, to note that free clauses are almost devoid of adjuncts. *Outside the fold*, which has already been discussed, is the only one. In contrast, and excluding *when, as* and *if*, there are eight adjuncts in bound clauses. So the free clauses have complements but not adjuncts, and the bound ones adjuncts but not complements.

The selection of *newly* deserves a note. Although an adverb, *newly* is not one that is commonly found as an exponent of A in clause structure. Its commonest place is as a verbal modifier when that verb is itself a nominal modifier; as in *a newly-advertised product, a newly-made dress*. I suppose that the average reader notes that there is something a little odd about the line, but has no difficulty, of course, in understanding it.

Before passing on to the nominal group, which has the most variety at this rank, let us note a pattern in the relation between group and line. The first line is one element of clause structure (though containing a rankshifted clause), the fourth is also, and the seventh, apart from the unstressed initial syllable. Line 11 is one group, and so is line 14. So the last line in each sentence contains but one element of clause structure: although the average length of an element is a third of a line.

Although the nominal groups are interesting, they are not nearly as complex as we are accustomed to meeting with quite frequently in normal conversation. Here is a table of them:

**Table 6.5** Nominal group structure

| In subject | | In complement | | Rankshifted | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| hq | (lambs that learn to walk in snow) | dh | (the air) | h | (snow) |
| h | (that) | deh | (a vast unwelcome) | | |
| dh | (their bleating) | h + deh | (nothing but a sunless glare) | dh | (the fold) |
| hq | (all they find) | dehq | (a wretched width of cold) | h | (cold) |
| h | (they) | deh | (earth's immeasurable surprise) | dh | (the ewe) |
| h | (they) | | | | |
| dh | (her fleeces) | h | (it) | h<br>dh | (earth)<br>(the snow) |
| h | (they) | | | | |
| h | (they) | | | | |
| h | (what) | | | | |

*Symbols used in Table 6.5*

h = headword, round which the rest pivots.
d = deictic, a word like *the, a, which*, coming at the beginning of the group.
e = an adjective.
q = anything which comes after the headword (in this poem the only exponents of q are rankshifted clauses – see 'subject' column – and a prepositional group – see 'complement' column).

There are no numerals, and no nouns occurring pre-head (like *stone* in *stone wall*). There is never more than one adjective, and not many of those, and only in complements. Subjects are simplest; six out of the ten of them are single pronouns, and the others are the two *hq* structures and two *dh*, the exponent of *d* being a possessive deictic. Those two *dh* groups are subjects in bound clauses.

Rankshifted nominal groups are those which occur as elements in the structure of other nominal groups, or as the 'objects' of prepositions. In this poem they are again simple in structure, and regularly consist of a single lexical item, with or without a non-possessive deictic.

The complements are most complex. The single *dh* structure is complement to the only transitive bound clause, and the single *h* structure is, as one might expect, in the last sentence. This leaves us with the four complements involving adjectives, and is an interesting place to pause for a moment because these four complements also contain most of the unusual vocabulary juxtapositions to be found in the poem. *Vast unwelcome* is very unusual, so also *a wretched width of cold, width* being the odd man out. *Sunless glare* is less striking, perhaps because *sun* and *glare* are common enough together; *immeasurable surprise* is unusual particularly with *Earth's* in front. Any two of the three words might pass unnoticed, but these three in this particular grammatical arrangement look very odd indeed.

The paucity of lexical comment reflects the fact that objective description of vocabulary patterns is still impossible. It happens that our present text does not contain many strong lexical patterns; apart from those mentioned above, perhaps *bleating clouds* in line 2 is the only one that invites attention.

Parallel to the note on *newly*, above, should be a note on *unwelcome*. This word is commonly an adjective, and one of the features of an adjective is that it is incapable of being headword in a group modified by *a, an*. Here an unusual effect is created by the occurrence of just such a nominal group, forcing us to accept *unwelcome* as a noun.[7] The prefix perhaps regains some of the meaning it could have in Old English.

The structure of the words in this poem brings out a pattern which is worthy of tentative consideration. If we study the *affixes*, it is fairly easy to divide the *inflectional* (e.g. lamb*s*, stumbl*ing*, cloud*s*, lie*s*, fleece*s*) from the others. Of the others, there are a few that mark a different word-class from the same item without the affix, e.g. *wetly, newly, utterly, width*. Lastly there is a small group where the affix drastically affects the meaning of the word:

*un*welcome, sun*less*, *im*measurable, *un*like

There is a similarity about these four, so that they may be labelled *reversing affixes*, though here the classification is less rigorous than before. One way or another, these affixes reverse the meaning of the rest of the word of which they form a part. What can we say about the contribution of such word structure in poetry, and in this poem? In poetry it is possible both to have one's cake and eat it, rather more so than in other varieties of a language. But when, for example, a trade union official said recently: "We are not yet talking about strike action", he contrived to be ominous. The paradox of a sentence like "I will never mention the name of John Smith" has a meaning which can be used in poetry.

7. Compare *unfamiliar* in Larkin's poem "Next Please".

We could describe it as bipartite. In the present case:

a. A statement about the speaker's future intentions. At least one possibility is cut out. By knowing something of what the speaker is *not* going to do, we also know a little about what he *is* going to do. Very little, very vaguely, but by no means negligible.
b. The accomplishment of the utterance, including the mention of John Smith's name. The physical fact of the utterance can never be ignored in literary writing.

According to the same argument, the last line of this poem contrives to begin to say something about the appearance of whatever is about to wake and grow, and it also manages to mention the snow. The importance of the latter half of the meaning is borne out by the rarity, in love poetry, of lines like:

> Her smile was not in the least like the grin of a decomposing vampire

however notionally accurate they may be.

Three out of the four complex nominal groups in this poem, then, show a reversing affix. On both grammatical and lexical grounds we have shown that these places are important. The fourth,

> a wretched width of cold[8]

contents itself with a word-class affix and unusual lexis and grammar.

The last line in the poem also shows this feature of reversal, and the structure of the line above it shows another device, common enough in poetry, which gives the reader only a vague meaning. It is the traditional 'brush-off' structure. 'Something I'd prefer not to talk about' 'Nothing you won't know all about in time' 'What doesn't concern you …'

## 6.3 Conclusion

The grammar has led us briefly into lexical and contextual matters, but only sporadically. There is still a great deal unsaid about the structure of this little poem, and even what has been said suffers by being in the nature of commentary. Grammar deals with contrasts, multiple choices from a great many systems simultaneously, and the meaning of a grammatical statement can only be fully elicited with reference to the total grammatical description. Nevertheless, the exercise shows how some aspects of the meaning of the poem can be described quite independently of evaluation.

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8. *Width* is usually uncountable; the only occurrence of it with a number market that comes to mind is *a width of cloth, this material comes in three widths, madam*.

CHAPTER 7

# A technique of stylistic description*

## 7.1 Introduction

Most of this article is a regular exercise in stylistics, but at times I break off to mention more general matters. The object is to demonstrate one of the many techniques that linguistics suggests as useful in understanding the meaning of a literary text. The text in this case is "The Legs", by Robert Graves.[1]

THE LEGS

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | There was this road, | |
| | And it led up-hill, | 1 |
| | And it led down-hill, | |
| | And round and in and out. | |
| 5 | And the traffic was legs, | |
| | Legs from the knees down, | 2 |
| | Coming and going, | |
| | Never pausing. | |
| 9 | And the gutters gurgled | |
| | With the rain's overflow, | 3 |
| | And the sticks on the pavement | |
| | Blindly tapped and tapped. | |
| 13 | What drew the legs along | |
| | Was the never-stopping, | 4 |
| | And the senseless, frightening | |
| | Fate of being legs. | |

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* This article appeared originally in *Language and Style* 1: 215–242 (1968).

1. I had no particular interest in this text, nor did I choose it for study. There was a seminar on English teaching at Dartmouth College in the summer of '66, during which some interest was expressed in linguistic analysis of a literary text. The poem was chosen by John Dixon to avoid the quite natural suspicion that linguists seem to prefer to study writers like e. e. cummings. Discussion at Dartmouth with Dixon, W. Nelson Francis, D. D. Mackay, W. W. Robson, and Wayne O'Neil has undoubtedly improved this chapter, but I have avoided introducing any points that the linguistic analysis did not suggest independently (except where acknowledged below).

17 Legs for the road,
The road for legs, 5
Resolutely nowhere
In both directions.

21 My legs at least
Were not in that rout: 6
On grass by the road-side
Entire I stood,

25 Watching the unstoppable
Legs go by 7
With never a stumble
Between step and step.

29 Though my smile was broad
The legs could not see, 8
Though my laugh was loud
The legs could not hear.

33 My head dizzied, then:
I wondered suddenly, 9
Might I too be a walker
From the knees down?

37 Gently I touched my shins.
The doubt unchained them: 10
They had run in twenty puddles
Before I regained them.

ROBERT GRAVES

The largest linguistic unit is the whole poem. It has 'a' meaning in the same sense as any other utterance has 'a' meaning: a public meaning which can be exposed by linguistic analysis, this exposure, or exposition, being one of the major functions of linguistic description.

The public meaning cannot be ignored in favour of some private meaning. The normal communicative power of language cannot be rejected, and virtually no writer attempts this ludicrous posture.[2] Where two or three words are gathered together, there is syntax amongst them, whether you like it or not.

Actually, this dichotomy between public and private meaning is probably a red herring; a pun on that overworked word 'meaning.' I mention it in order to

2. Not even in 'concrete' poetry, where skilful writers can short-circuit *some* of the normal networks of meaning, thus highlighting others. The bravest attempt I know is Herbert Read's "Vocal Avowals," *Encounter* (March, 1959).

define closely what I shall be talking about. The emphasis of literary discussion is moving away from an individual's response to a text, and the sanctity of that response, and I shall be talking exclusively about public meaning, i.e. what any reader familiar with the type of communication can get from the text.

## 7.2 Analytical principles

The first stage of analysis is to look for units below the whole text: meaning-carrying units and metrical units. There are sentences and there are stanzas, and there are ten of each. By and large, the sentences fit the stanzas very well. There are only two places where each sentence is not just one stanza: stanzas 6 and 7 make up one sentence between them, and stanza 10 comprises two sentences. The question arises as to the importance of these irregularities. How do they contribute to the total meaning of the poem? Are they accidental, incidental, irrelevant, or are they key points that we must keep in the forefront of our minds?

Already a question of judgment has been raised, where individuals may differ. How, then, can linguistic analysis make any claim to objectivity? This point cannot be answered briefly, and it is a very bothersome one.[3] I sketch out the main lines in the next paragraph, but the whole article tries to show the extent and nature of linguistic objectivity in relation to a highly complex piece of communication.

There are decisions of selection and presentation and arrangement which one makes subjectively, involving one's response to the text as a whole. Each fact thrown up by the analysis is considered, evaluated if you like, according to the following criterion: What contribution does this fact make to the meaning, impression, value, etc., of the total poem? Answers are always tentative. Often one mistakenly sets aside features which are of the utmost importance. Sometimes a minor feature gets far too much attention, particularly if it is difficult to explain. These mistakes arise from failures in critical awareness of the linguist, and are not the fault of the linguistics.

The twin claims of this approach are:

1. All the statements are either factual observations or deductions from factual observations. No statement is motivated solely by a reader's response to the text.
2. All the critical decisions are retrievable. They relate parts of a text to the meaning of the whole. 'Evaluation' in this usage is a matter internal to the text. It has nothing to do with evaluation of the text in terms of the rest of our experience of life.

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3. Some of the bother is set out by F. W. Bateson in his contribution to "The Critical Forum" in *Essays in Criticism*, XVII, No. 3 (July, 1967), 334–337.

## 7.3 Verse paragraphs

The irregularities in the fit of sentence and stanza are too obvious to be ignored. But their meaning is rather subtle. Stanzas 6 and 7 are not all that closely connected, even though they form one sentence. Stanzas 1 and 2 seem to be closely connected too, but a period appears at the end of stanza 1. Similarly, there is hardly any closer connection between lines 37 and 38 than between, say, 33 and 34. Let us first ask, why the period in stanza 10?

The punctuation could be made regular by replacing the period by a colon (there are no semicolons in the poem). That change would link lines 37, 38, and 39 as a series of three juxtaposed main clauses: (37): (38): (39/40) meaning roughly "(37) happened, and this led to (38) happening, and this led to (39/40) happening." The intonation contour at the end of line 37 is likely to change from \ to ^\ OF ^\/, and the four clauses in the stanza are no longer each in a different grammatical relationship to the next.

Compare that with the original arrangement, where the sentence at line 37 is juxtaposed to the sentence at lines 38–40, and within the second sentence the two main clauses are juxtaposed. Diagrammatically: [(37)]. [(38): (39/40)] meaning roughly "37 happened, then (38/39/40); (38) happened, and this led to (39/40) happening." Stanza 10 forms a small verse paragraph comprising two sentences.

Let us pursue the idea of the paragraph as an intermediate structure between sentence and poem. The initial *and* in lines 5 and 9 suggests that the first three stanzas make up one paragraph. (Note in passing that the *and* in line 9 is just about the only link that stanza 3 has with the rest of the poem: we will return to that later.) Then again, stanzas 4 and 5 are closely connected; we must interpret stanza 5 as being 'in apposition,' as the jargon tells us, to *legs* at the end of stanza 4. The relationship is not as strict even as apposition within a sentence. Stanza 5 is some sort of summing-up of the position described in the first four stanzas, as well as following on stanza 4 specifically. But it is not freestanding. If one tries to read this verbless stanza as if it had no connection with the preceding one it would sound like a sort of election slogan, "England for the English," "Smith for Parliament," or the like.

Do stanzas 8 and 9 form one paragraph? There is a lot of evidence to weigh here, and I shall mention small items of it as we go along. Only the main points are summarized now. First, the vexing word *then* in line 33. What does it refer to? There has been no previous time reference, nor any events presented as a sequence. The choice seems to be that *then* refers either to the whole of the previous 8 stanzas or to stanza 8 only (or just possibly to stanzas 6, 7, and 8).

1. The author, on having the experience described in stanzas 1–8, was suddenly overcome by it and got dizzy. *Then* would be an example of the wholesale backward reference that occurs in poetry occasionally, usually at some major break in the structure. If we choose this interpretation we would certainly conclude that stanzas 8 and 9 occur in separate paragraphs.
2. It was the indifference of the legs to the author's smiling and laughing that caused him to feel dizzy. If the problem word had occurred at the beginning of the line, like the *ands* earlier, this interpretation would be very credible:

> Then my head dizzied.

But no; the line is presented as if a third in the series *my smile, my laugh*…. This point is supported by the observation[4] that there is a semantic progression *smile* ⟶ *laugh*: first I smiled, no answer; then I laughed, no answer; then I got worried. This interpretation satisfies immediately because it both finds a referent for *then* and explains the occurrence of a time-adverb.

The acceptance of this point is not conclusive about the paragraph divisions, but of course it suggests cohesion. I still feel that the very oddity of line 33 forces a break (see below for more detail on line 33). I leave the reader to make up his own mind after looking at the remainder of the general argument about paragraphing.

## 7.4 Acceleration

The grammatical breaks between stanzas 3 and 4, 5 and 6, 7 and 8, and 9 and 10 are readily seen. From the remarks above, we can construct a table of stanza, sentence, and paragraph as in Table 7.1. Clearly, paragraphs tend to get smaller as the poem continues. If stanzas 8 and 9 are considered a single paragraph, then the tendency to get smaller becomes much sharper towards the end. Now a paragraph has some cohesion about it, some general topic such as I have suggested in Table 7.1, so our conclusion is that topics come up faster later in the poem. There is an effect of *acceleration*. I would like to use acceleration as a technical term from now on, because I think that we can understand the structure of the poem by noticing an increase in the rate of repetition of some elements of it.

4. Originally by Robson.

**Table 7.1** Divisions of stanza, sentence, and paragraph with suggested topics

| Stanza | Sentence | Paragraph | Topic |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 1 | | |
| 2 | 2 | 1 | scene-setting: road, legs, and rain |
| 3 | 3 | | |
| 4 | 4 | 2 | about the legs |
| 5 | 5 | | |
| 6 | | | |
| 7 | 6 | 3 | the author watching |
| 8 | 7 | 4 | the legs indifferent |
| 9 | 8 | 5 | reflection |
| | 9 | | |
| 10 | 10 | 6 | consequences |

The argument has moved some distance from our initial perception of a lack of exact fit between sentence and stanza. However, I think we have now located the significance of the lack of fit. The long sentence of lines 21–29 makes its mark, of course, but our perception of its length is masked by two other features: the stanza form itself, and the existence of paragraph groupings of two and three stanzas. On the way we have identified a stylistic effect, that of acceleration, which I have asserted is important.

The exact status of stylistic effects such as acceleration is a theoretical matter that it is not appropriate to discuss here. On the level of practical analysis, the next consideration is to seek confirmation of its importance. There are a number of tentative criteria under development: the easiest is to seek for other examples of the same sort of effect elsewhere in the language patterning. This is the plan adopted here.

## 7.5 Sentence structure

Table 7.2 shows a very simple analysis of the sentences of the poem – not an exhaustive analysis, by any means. To begin with, we shall simply identify the main, principal, free clauses (whichever word you like) and label each of them F;

and then label everything else B. It is worthwhile in this poem to distinguish three different kinds of B, so we shall do that as well.

| | |
|---|---|
| $B_1$ | Roughly speaking, a subordinate adverbial clause. |
| $B_2$ | Again roughly, a nonfinite verb phrase. |
| $B_3$ | Something appositional, without a verb. |

**Table 7.2** Outline sentence structure

| Line | Structure | | Line | Structure | | Line | Structure | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | F | | 13 | F– | | 25 | $B_2$– | |
| 2 | F | | 14 | | [F–] | 26 | | [$B_2$–] |
| 3 | F– | | 15 | | [F–] | 27 | | [$B_2$–] |
| 4 | | [F] | 16 | | [F] | 28 | | [$B_2$] |
| 5 | F | | 17 | $B_3$ | | 29 | $B_1$ | |
| 6 | $B_3$ | | 18 | $B_3$ | | 30 | F | |
| 7 | $B_2$ | | 19 | $B_3$– | | 31 | $B_1$ | |
| 8 | $B_2$ | | 20 | | [$B_3$] | 32 | F | |
| 9 | F– | | 21 | F– | | 33 | F | |
| 10 | | [F] | 22 | | [F] | 34 | F | |
| 11 | F– | | 23 | F– | | 35 | F– | |
| 12 | | [F] | 24 | | [F] | 36 | | [F] |
| | | | 37 | F | | | | |
| | | | 38 | F | | | | |
| | | | 39 | F | | | | |
| | | | 40 | $B_1$ | | | | |

Isolated symbol: line and clause coextensive, eg., F or B (lines 1, 6, etc.).

Bracketed symbol: end of clause started above, eg., [F], [B] (lines 4, 20, etc.).

Dash following symbol: clause overruns line, eg., (1) F–, B- (lines 3, 19, etc.), (2) [F–], [B–] (lines 14, 26, etc.).

Bracketed symbols are offset so that the actual clauses in order of occurrence are indicated by the columns of unbracketed symbols.

These are all distinct elements in a sentence. For this reason I shall call them all clauses, even though traditional grammar would only recognize $B_1$ as clauses. The term 'B clause,' then, refers to any of the three types listed above.

The labels F and B can be applied to every clause in the poem except two. Line 13 is labelled F-, because it contains the subject of the long clause that occupies all of stanza 4. This subject is itself a clause, but one which is neither F nor B. It is structurally demoted (downgraded, embedded, rankshifted, etc. – these are

current terms for the phenomenon.) The other clause-type structure that I have no symbol for is *being legs* in line 16. Here it is a prepositional object and so again is not in any sense a direct constituent of its sentence.

The analysis proposed can be justified, though not in this chapter. But I want to avoid any suggestion of *ad hoc*-ness about the analytical categories, any implication that they are set up for this text only. *Ad hoc* categories are of course needed in grammatically deviant literature, but the mass of analysis – as here – will use the relevant parts of a fuller descriptive syntax of English, simplifying it a little but not distorting it. Labelling a stretch of language F is of little interest unless it is a repeatable event, given the same circumstances. Without this controlling restriction on analysis, all manner of fascinating patterns can be made to emerge from texts.

Table 7.2, then, gives the outline sentence structure, related to the lines in the poem. After noticing such a congruence between sentence and stanza we shall certainly look for the fit between clause and line. But before that we shall pursue the idea of acceleration by looking at the number of F clauses in each stanza.

## 7.6 Stanza 1

There are three F clauses in stanza 1, and the last one is two lines long. That is no help in taking of acceleration; if anything it suggests deceleration. But let us at this point interrupt the systematic analysis and pursue the analysis of the clauses in stanza one. Line 1 just introduces the road, and says very little else. Line 2 has the structure subject-verb-adjunct: the subject is a pronoun referring back to *road*, the verb is pretty neutral, and *up-hill* gives us a direction. Line 3 differs from line 2 by changing *up* to *down* giving us just another direction, structurally and semantically symmetrical with line 2. Line 4 starts with the familiar *and*, but then breaks the syntactic and semantic patterns thus:

a. The 3 adverbs it contains are all unexpected extensions of the clause which started in line 3.
b. The symmetry of *up* and *down* is broken by *round; in* and *out* do not repair it.
c. Instead of 'one direction per line' we get 3 directions in one line, reinforced by the repeated *ands*. The structural feature that shows this best is the rate of repetition of adverbs, a second clear case of *acceleration*.

These three points that arise from line 4 are worth bearing in mind: surprise, broken symmetry, and acceleration. When I have asked people for subjective impressions of the poem, words like "bewilderment," "panic," "nightmare" have been frequently used, and the three stylistic devices seem to be quite appropriate to those impressions.

## 7.7 Topic

Apart from stanza 1, the only stanzas that contain three F clauses are stanzas 9 and 10. But there is a difference in the way the subjects of stanzas 1 and 10 relate to each other.

| *Stanza* 1 | *Stanza* 10 |
|---|---|
| There (this road) | I |
| it | the doubt |
| it | they |

The subjects of stanza 1 have all the same referent, while those of 10 are all different. The medial stanzas, where there is more than one F clause, are as follows:

| 3 | 6 | 8 | 9 |
|---|---|---|---|
| the gutters | my legs | legs | my head |
| the sticks on the pavement | I | The legs | I |

Stanza 3 is an odd one, and more will be said about it later. The other medial stanzas have F-clause subjects which are quite closely related within the stanza.

What is emerging here is a small-scale version of 'topic,' as it was called in paragraph structure. The rate of subject change is an important factor in the impression that a sequence of clauses makes upon the reader, and I shall try to demonstrate it with four parallel passages. In the first, the subjects of all the clauses have the same referent. In the second, the object of each clause is the subject of the next. In the third, each successive subject is closely related to the others, but not identical. In the fourth, the subjects are as varied as I can make them, while still describing the same incident.

1. The Duke lifted his gun; he shot the bird; then he whistled for his dog, and he proudly watched the dog bring home the prize.
2. The Duke lifted his gun; the big rifle fired a shot with deadly accuracy; the shot hit the bird, and the bird fell to the waiting dog.
3. The Duke lifted his gun; his finger closed upon the trigger; his keen eyes watched the bird fall to his shot and he smiled as the dog came forward with the prize.
4. The Duke lifted his gun; the bird flew high above them: there was the sharp crack of a shot; and very soon the dog loped through the undergrowth with the prize in his mouth.

Example (1) is like stanzas 1 and 8; Example (2) shows up slightly in stanzas 1 and 10; Example (3) is relevant to stanzas 6 and 9, and Example (4) to stanzas 3 and 10. It seems to me that the four examples are arranged in order of increasing topic acceleration – though there is little to choose between (2) and (3) – showing (stanza 3 apart) an increasing acceleration in the poem, particularly in stanza 10.

This is a very hesitant framing of an important point. There is no doubt that different mixtures of my four types of paragraph (and several others) will lead to different effects upon readers. But the classification of these effects is still largely guesswork.

## 7.8 Clause-to-line fit

Table 7.2 shows that nine of the clauses over-run the line-boundary, (i.e. all the unbracketed symbols with hyphens) and that 13 lines do not initiate clauses (i.e. all the lines which have a symbol in brackets in the table). The meaning of the over-run is different in each case. There is not space to go into each one in detail but some interesting points emerge quickly. The main classification will concern the part of the clause after the line break. Is it essential to the making of a correct clause? If so, I shall call it *completive*. Another way of putting the criterion is to see if the first portion of the clause predicts that there is more to come. If not, and the later portion of the clause is optional to the grammatical structure, then I shall dub it *extra*.

We have already noted that line 4 is entirely extra: in fact the effect of acceleration depends on our having a double-take at line 4. Line 3 does not predict line 4 at all.

Stanza 3 shows us both types. Line 10 is extra, though without it line 9 is pretty bald, since the word *rain* in line 10 helps to explain the occurrence of line 9. So within the category of *extra* there is a fair range, from surprisingly extra (in the short term), as line 4, to sorely needed (in the long term), as line 10. Line 12, however, is completive. *The sticks on the pavement* is a subject for the verb *tapped* in the next line.

Line 14 is completive in the same way as 12. But with line 15 there is a problem in interpretation, hinging on nominal groups. The choice is between an analysis which labels *the never-stopping* as a nominal group in itself, or one which assumes that *the never-stopping* is the beginning of a nominal group whose headword is *fate*, and which occupies most of the stanza. Evidence for each analysis can be tabulated as follows:

1. In favour of a single nominal group, lines 14–16.
   a. *The never-stopping* is an odd nominal group.
   b. The sense of the actual words: *never-stopping* reinforces the idea of a running-on of the grammar. (This argument has its cake and eats it, but is not thereby discounted, because correspondences of the kind are not normally felt to be coincidental in a literary text.)
   c. The sense of the whole text at this point suggests a run-on. Otherwise we accuse Graves of saying that the reason the legs always moved was that they never stopped.

2. In favour of two nominal groups, one in line 14, and the other in 15–16.
   a. There is a comma at the end of line 14, which tells against 1b above.
   b. The two pieces don't fit very well together: *never-stopping* is not an obvious modifier of *fate*, and it suggests a time-scale whereas *senseless* and *frightening* do not. Such a modifier would normally be last and not first in the group. Compare:
      (1) We saw the falling and the drifting snow.
      (2) We saw the falling and the white snow.
   c. *The* is repeated. Without its second appearance the idea of the two nominal groups would fall instantly.

My conclusion is that interpretation 1 is preferable because its reasons are directly related to the rest of the meaning of the text. I have not here considered the idea that there might be two fates (one never-stopping and the other senseless, frightening) but the points made in 2 above do give rise to a strong meaning of perpetual motion. A paraphrase of the 'content' of the stanza would have to ascribe the perpetuity to the fate, and only indirectly to the legs. The underlying hint of a two-group interpretation strengthens the reference to the fact that the legs can't stop.

Line 15 then, is completive, as is line 16. Lines 19 and 20 are extra and create a similar effect to line 4. The first two lines of the stanza set up a symmetry which is destroyed in the last line, but in this case is destroyed ironically. The stanza must be seen in its syntactic environment, where it seems that the first two lines steady up the syntax after the vortex of stanza 4. Then, superficially, the two clause adjuncts which make up lines 19 and 20 form a second symmetrical pattern. The stanza is grammatically[5] balanced.

But the meaning of the stanza shows a steady progress into absurdity. Lines 17 and 18 imply that the *legs* and the *road* form a closed system. It may all be pointless, but at least it's ordered and orderly and purposive. Line 19 is mildly paradoxical but does have a hint of purposiveness, and line 20 drives home the point that this futile order is even more pointless than chaos. The irony thus develops from a contrast between the syntax and the meaning of the stanza.

The effect brought out in stanza 5 has been building up throughout the poem: I have not presented the facts systematically from a point of view that would show the process; but there are plenty of small points that now show up in support – for example, the choice of the verb *led* in lines 2 and 3. Compare it with *went* or *ran* as possible alternatives, and you see that *led* does have a slight suggestion of

5. The grammatical balance at this superficial level concerns the fact that lines 1 and 2 are nominal groups of the same structure, and lines 3 and 4 are both adverbial groups. Later on (in Section 11) it is classified according to its clause structure.

destination that the other two lack. So line 4 with its general confusion of direction is just a trifle more effective following the verb *led*. (If the chosen verb had been *wound*, line 4 would not have surprised as much.)

Line 22 is completive like lines 12 and 14. Line 24 is also completive, supplying the rest of the clause to which line 23 is an adjunct; 26 is just like 16, supplying a headword for a modifier. Lines 27 and 28 are both extras, and we can pause here to compare stanzas 4 and 7 for a moment.

| *Line* | *Stanza* 4 | *Stanza* 7 |
|---|---|---|
| 2 | Completive | Completive |
| 3 | Completive | Extra |
| 4 | Completive | Extra |

Lines 14 and 26 are the two lines which follow the word *stop*, and they are both completive. Runs of four lines without grammatical rests are obvious reinforcements to the idea of unstoppability. But the 'unstoppability' is seen differently in the two stanzas. In 4 there is the sense of compulsive movement, the syntax pulling the reader along. In stanza 7 the narrator is cool and detached, observing the scene carefully, the syntax flowing on from line to line in extra structures. Notice that stanza 4 includes two commas (one mid-line even), because the grammar is insisting on the running-on, whereas stanza 7 cannot afford any punctuation marks at all, and is the only unpunctuated stanza.

Line 36 echoes line 6 and is extra. Again there is an ironical punch-line, acquiring its irony from a fairly simple linguistic device. I must anticipate a later part of this chapter, and point out that in the second half of the poem there is a recurrent contrasting of the whole person (*I*) and some part of him (*my legs*, etc.). Line 35 is crucial because in it occurs the word *walker*. A walker is a person using his legs, in control of them – a person engaging in purposive activity – everything that the *legs* as described in stanzas 1–5 are not. So when this word is immediately followed by a line which suggests that he does not even *know* whether or not he controls his legs, there is a sharp surprise effect. When additionally that line is almost the same as line 6, and line 6 is the line that first suggests the dislocation of the legs from the whole man, the paradox of being a walker only from the knees down is given an ironical twist.

This effect is muted by the word *too* in 35, and also by the general sense of the passage, and it may be overstated above. But there is no doubt that the word *walker* is sabotaged as soon as uttered.

## 7.9 Clause-to-line fit: Initiation

The study of the running-on has led to one or two quite important points of interpretation. Standing back from the text, we see that the distribution of run-on

lines is by no means even throughout the text. Five of the outer stanzas (1, 2, 8, 9, 10) share only two instances of running-on, whereas the inner five share eleven examples. So the poem begins and ends with rather isolated lines, stringing them together more in the middle.

There is one obvious point arising from Table 7.2 that I have left until now because it cannot be immediately related to a single 'meaning' in the poem. No line has more than one symbol against it. No clause, that is, begins other than at the beginning of a line. Clauses are a whole number of whole lines long. This is a considerable restriction. It determines to a large extent the intonation groupings that occur when the poem is read out. For example, what Abercrombie[6] calls "silent stresses" occur commonly at clause boundaries when consecutive clauses have the same status (e.g. FF).

The reader soon gets accustomed, in the first two stanzas, to the line being something of a unit of grammatical meaning. There are, in my analysis, 18 clauses out of 27 that exactly fit the line. Then there are 7 which are exactly 2 lines long and they are not distributed randomly. They are either the last two lines of a stanza (1, 3, 5, 6, 9) or the first two of one of these stanzas (3, 6). Finally there are two clauses which are exactly 4 lines long, coinciding with a whole stanza, emphasizing the close integration of grammar and metre: sentence, clause, stanza, and line.

## 7.10 Stanza types

Stanzas 3 and 6 are formed of two similar halves; so is stanza 8. In several stanzas the last line is quite different from the other three. Perhaps it is an extra adjunct to an already complete clause (stanzas 1, 5, 9) or a different status of clause from the rest (stanza 10). In the remaining stanzas (2, 4, 7) it is the first line that differs from the rest, because it initiates a long clause (4, 7) or it is a different kind of clause (2). To summarize:

| | |
|---|---|
| 1. sting-in-the-tail | 6. balance |
| 2. drawn-out | 7. drawn-out |
| 3. balance | 8. balance |
| 4. drawn-out | 9. sting-in-the-tail |
| 5. sting-in-the-tail | 10. sting-in-the-tail |

A number of points that relate to this pattern have already emerged, and will be referred to again, later on. To go over it all at this point would involve much repetition.

6. *Studies in Phonetics and Linguistics* (London, 1965), p. 20.

## 7.11 Clause structure

Some of the details of clause structure have already cropped up, in connection with the types of subject and the over-runs. The whole picture (in outline of course) is set out in Table 7.3.

One feature stands out as soon as one glances at the table: the small amount of transitivity, and its restricted position. A run of 23 clauses in 36 lines without a single direct object is remarkable. And there is certainly an area of meaning in the poem which correlates with the effect of *intransitivity*. Nothing much happens, things do not influence each other in any direct way. The actions are implied rather than stated (see stanza 8 particularly). There is a pseudo-transitive relationship in line 25, which provides the only explicit statement of the relation between the *I* and *the legs*. The only three objects in F clauses occur in stanza 10 where the *I* begins to do something.

**Table 7.3** Clause structure

| Type | Structure | Line | Type | Structure | Line |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| F | SPC | 1 | F | S′PA | 21, 22 |
| F | SPA | 2 | F | A′CSP | 23, 24 |
| F | SPA′A | 3, 4 | $B_2$ | P $\underset{\overline{S}}{\acute{O}}$PA′ $\acute{A}$ | 25–8 |
| F | SPC | 5 | $B_1$ | SPC | 29 |
| $B_3$ | Z | 6 | F | SP | 30 |
| $B_2$ | P | 7 | $B_1$ | SPC | 31 |
| $B_2$ | AP | 8 | F | SP | 32 |
| F | SP′A | 9, 10 | F | SPA | 33 |
| F | S′AP | 11, 12 | F | SPA | 34 |
| | | | F | P[S]C′A | 35, 36 |
| F | S′C″ | 13–16 | | | |
| | | | F | ASPO | 37 |
| $B_3$ | Z | 17 | | | |
| $B_3$ | Z | 18 | F | SPO | 38 |
| $B_3$ | A′A | 19, 20 | F | SPA | 39 |
| | | | B | SPO | 40 |

S: subject
C: complement of *be*
P: verbal group
A: adjunct; including prepositional phrases
O: object
Z: nominal without verb
$\underset{\overline{S}}{O}$: object of preceding verb, subject of following one
P [S]: subject *inside* predicator
′: line break
Line space: sentence boundary.

No symbol is given for (a) initial *and* (b) initial conjunction (lines 29, 31, 40).
The linked verbs in lines 7 and 12 are given only one symbol each.
The demoted clauses in lines 13 and 16 are included as S and part of C respectively but are not themselves analyzed. Analysis would be 13, SPOA; 16, PC.

I will try to link up this point about transitivity with two other points which we would eventually come to, if I may take them a little prematurely. One is the kind of verbs used in the poem, and the other is the kind of nominal groups in the earlier stanzas. I am going to suggest that these three syntactic patterns are instrumental in creating the impression of pointless movement and chaos which is so characteristic of the poem.

## 7.12 Verb classification

The first classification of the verbs is a lexical one, outside the range of grammar for a moment. The verbs are classified according to the sort of words that are likely to appear round about them. For example, the verb *be* is so generally used that there is virtually nothing like a 'characteristic environment' that we could imagine for it. At the other end of the scale *dizzy* as a verb is so rare that it can hardly be said to have a characteristic environment, unless one assumes that it must share a lot with the adjective *dizzy*. In between there are words like *tapped*, near which, in the meaning that appears here, one might expect to find *stick* indeed, and *window, toe, finger, step*, and so on.

A tentative grouping of the finite verbs in the poem is shown in Table 7.4. If this picture is broadly correct, then 15 out of the 20 finite verbs in the poem are pretty humdrum, common words. Stanzas 3 and 10 share the four specific verbs, and stanza 9 has the only oddity.

**Table 7.4** Finite verbs

| General | | Specific | Rare |
|---|---|---|---|
| *be* | *others* | | |
| was | led | gurgled | dizzied |
| was | led | tapped | |
| was | stood | unchained | |
| were | see | regained | |
| was | hear | | |
| was | wondered | | |
| might be | touched | | |
| | run | | |

Let us now relate the pattern of the finite verbs to other features we have mentioned.

Stanza 3 has different vocabulary from the rest of the poem. There aren't many places in the poem where the vocabulary surprises. *Gurgled, gutter*, and *rain* have

tenuous links with *road* in stanza 1 and *puddles* in stanza 10 but nowhere else. *Sticks, blindly*, and *tapped* link with nothing, though *pavement* of course fits in with *road*, etc. These links are very weak, and yet stanza 3 does not stick out like a sore thumb from the rest of the poem. I want to look more closely at the grammatical patterns which integrate stanza 3 with the rest of the poem. They must be grammatical, because we have examined the vocabulary and found that it is divergent.

1. Stanza 3 is part of the general sentence/stanza and clause/line fit pattern that we have already noted.
2. The initial word *and* in stanzas 2 and 3 suggests a grammatical linkage.
3. The stanza has intransitive clauses, F clauses, etc., as one would expect from its surroundings. It does not have curious grammar.
4. The meaning of the word *the* changes almost imperceptibly in stanzas 2 and 3. (The fourth point is rather complicated, and must have a section on its own.)

## 7.13 The definite article

Here is another layer of meaning to be examined. How are the definite articles used? The scene is set by *this* in line 1. We are due for an informal narrative, says line 1, and *this* has vague forward reference, "the road I'm going to talk about."[7]

The first instance of *the* is in line 4, *the traffic*. Here *the* means "the traffic you might expect since we're talking about roads." The definite article doesn't always refer precisely to something already identified; very commonly, especially in speech, it refers to something that can be presumed from the known situation. If there is a road, then traffic is the sort of thing you might expect. In the same sort of way, when *the knees* turns up just after we have mentioned *legs*, it is a reasonably expected item. There is another reason why the definite article should appear as modifier to *knees*, which is that knees are parts of the body. There is a well-established convention to avoid personal pronoun modifiers here, a convention

7. I have heard it argued that the word *this* should receive contrastive stress in a reading, rather than the unstressed syllable implied by my comment. Anyone who takes it with the contrastive meaning gets a very different impression of the opening lines of the poem. It would suggest either that the narrator is at the scene of the poem, and is pointing to the road, or that there is some other road which has recently been mentioned. I cannot fit either of these meanings into the total effect of the poem, whereas I find line 1 a most typical opening of a conversational anecdote. So I must conclude that the alternative reading is preverse, rather than secondary or underlying. But I would like to have better evidence to distinguish the present situation from those others where the secondary meaning has its place.

which becomes more and more mandatory as one approaches clinical language, the language of doctor to patient, etc. In a small-scale effect, the precise reference to the portion of the legs links with the impersonal and precise sort of language suggested by *the*.

In this context we come upon *the gutters*. One is not sure, 8 lines away from *road*, whether there should be an immediate recognition that roads have gutters and so the *the* is the expected one. In fact, the definite article here hides some of the oddity of the sudden appearance of *gutters*. Almost before this one has been digested, we come upon *the rain*. It ties in with the gutters' gurgling and gives a reason why they are gurgling. But the reader is not prepared at all for *the sticks*. They are only indirectly linked with roads, legs, rain and gutters. Of course, it is a common enough device in scene-setting in lyric poetry for the author to assume some knowledge which is not open to the reader, and to let him catch up as he goes along. But the situation in this poem is not exactly that. We move very gently towards the *medias res* use of the article, from the apparently prosy and straightforward opening in the first stanza into the constantly changing focus of the third. Before we hear anything about the weather we hear the gutters gurgling; before anything is said about blindness we are told about some sticks. So the vocabulary and grammar of stanza 3 add further variations to the patterns carrying acceleration features.

Let me offer three contrasting passages to show the effect of various uses of *the*.

a. *the* used always in simple backward reference.
b. *the* used as 'expected' and immediately confirmed.
c. *the* used as 'expected' but not confirmed.

a. Outside my window there is a wire. The wire is connected to a terminal. The terminal is a little black box. There is a notice on the terminal. The notice says DANGER.
b. Outside my window there is a wire. The terminal for the wire is connected to a little black box. The notice on the terminal says DANGER.
c. Outside my window there is a wire. The terminal is a little black box. The notice says DANGER.

How do we describe the meaning of *the* in the last sentence of *c*? It might be parodied like this:

> *The* notice? What notice? There hasn't been anything about notices. Don't understand. Read on a bit … says DANGER. Danger, terminal, wire, electricity, high voltage, shocks, danger, warn people, keep away, 10,000 volts, Warning, … Ah, yes, – the notice must be the sort of notice you might expect to find where there are wires carrying dangerous current.

So the use of the definite article in stanzas 1–3 is the type *c* above, and within this framework the successive nouns become less and less genuinely predictable. So one is momentarily baffled by the syntax, the clues coming at the end.

## 7.14 Clause structure concluded

It has already been noted that the only rare verb is *dizzied* at line 33. Line 33 is in fact a rare line. It has two other peculiarities. One is the time-reference of *then*, unique in the poem, apart from *before* in the last line. The other is the comma – only line 14 of the other lines has a punctuation mark in the middle of it. In line 33 one can see that it is not a comma which is demanded by grammatical considerations: the sentence would read quite well without the comma, and not mean very much different. The effect of the comma is to draw attention to the word *then*, to force the reader to interpret it specially. The comma in 14 does the same for the word in front of it.

Line 33, then, is odd in its vocabulary, odd in its syntax, odd in its rhythm, and odd in its punctuation. The oddity piles up, giving additional weight to the evidence in favour of a break in continuity between stanzas 8 and 9.

In coming to stanza 10 we are back to the starting-point of this long syntactic ramble – transitivity. The verbs in the poem tend to move from general to specific in reference, common to less common in occurrence, and intransitive to transitive in grammar. There are ripples at stanza 3 (specific intransitive), stanza 9 (rare intransitive) and line 37 (general transitive). The nonfinite verbs do not disagree violently with this pattern:

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| line 7 | *coming and going* | general intransitive |
| line 8 | *pausing* | specific intransitive |
| line 25 | *watching* | general pseudo-intransitive |
| line 26 | *go* | general intransitive |

Just for the record, I should mention the other verb forms in the poem, if only to give reasons for not having dealt with them before now.

> *drew* (line 13): specific and transitive and finite. A clear break in the pattern that I have been describing, but in a demoted clause. Note that the nearest F clause paraphrase is
>
> the legs were drawn … (passive intransitive).
>
> *stopping, frightening* (lines 14 and 15): two words derived from verbs, but used as nominal modifiers.
>
> *being* (line 16): general intransitive.

Do not overlook the strange fact that these last four verb forms occur in the same stanza, stanza 4. By expanding on this observation one can see a little of the mechanism of elongation which draws out stanza 4. One way of filling out a clause is to make use of rankshifted, demoted materials, and *drew* and *being* are the verbs of the only two rankshifted clauses in the poem. The subject of a clause can be as brief as one unstressed syllable, and so can the object. In stanza 4 perhaps we should not talk about physical elongation only. It is a feature, of course, but the complications introduced into the syntax by rankshifted structures will produce a similar effect to straightforward elongation.

Another easy way of elongating structures is to make sure you fill some of the optional places. The subject of a clause could be a single noun only, or perhaps an article and noun. But numerals, adjectives, and so on, could always be added to spin it out. They tend to be rather shortish words, so one could choose instead verbal participles, which create rather more syntactic interest anyway. *Never-stopping* shows how you can elongate still further by developing the participle structure, in a modifying position. (*Frightening* is only dimly connected with verbs nowadays, as we can see, because it has a comparative and superlative, just like an adjective [more frightening, most frightening].)

The classification of stanzas (see Section 10) is reinforced by the evidence of nonfinite verbs just presented. All the nonfinite verbs occur in the three 'drawn-out' stanzas – 2, 4, and 7 – but in 4 they are slightly different.

I have risked spending too long on minor points because they show an advantage of a rigorous technique. On the face of it, the clustering of the residual verbs into stanza 4 and the distribution of non-finite verbs were not obviously connected with the meaning of the poem. I doubt very much if even a sharp reader would notice them. But when one finds relevance in such patterns to the total strategy of the poem, one gains confidence in the value of the analytical technique.

## 7.15 Verbal group structure

Our comments about the verbs have been mainly about their vocabulary patterns, and the way they fit into clause structure. Now we must cast a glance at the grammatical patterns within the verbal groups.

Nearly all the finite verbs are 'simple past tense': *was, led, gurgled*, and the like. Nearly all the non-finite verbs are present participles like *coming, pausing*, etc. The exceptions are

1. *go* (line 26). A solitary example of a second predicator in the clause.
2. *could see, could hear, might be*. Modal verbs; verbs which express hypothetical states of affairs, etc. For 30 lines the description is given as objectively as possible, with the simple past tense. Then at line 30 we start hearing, not about what the legs were doing, but what they were able to do. The change must be significant since the word *did* could easily replace *could*, maintaining the tense. Then in the next stanza come the verbs *dizzied* and *wondered*, and the only question in the poem. Just for eight lines we depart from the neutral description (superficially neutral, that is) and enter the realms of speculation and deduction. And in the last stanza we return to normal.
3. *had run* in line 39. The occurrence of this form shows another component of the rather bewildering shifts of focus in the last few lines of the poem. Compare it with the following:

| | |
|---|---|
| a. They ran in twenty puddles<br>Before I regained them. | b. They ran in twenty puddles<br>And then I regained them. |

The 'pluperfect' tense appears without warning. So averse is the narrator to the direct description of anything actually happening that he tells us about the crucial action only in retrospect. An explicit introduction to the tense would run like this: "And then, before I realized what was happening, they had run…." The words of the paraphrase lay bare the effect of the surprising tense.

This device has a lot in common with the use of the definite article noted in Section 13, because the reader again has to wait until he has read some more before understanding the full significance of the verb tense.

## 7.16 Nominal group structure

In Section 9, I made a tentative suggestion that the edges of this poem, the beginning and the end, were structurally a little different from the middle. The point was made in connection with the over-running of lines by clauses. Now, as we look at the nominal groups in the poem, we see two other supporting items. They are

1. The referential pronouns. The pronouns *it* and *they* are common enough in most English texts, but not in the central stanzas of this poem. Backward reference is carried by the definite article in all but the first and the last stanzas.
2. Prepositional phrases. The first preposition is *from* in line 6, but they don't come in any bulk until the middle (eleven in stanzas 3 to 7). Stanzas 9 and

10 have one each while stanzas 5 and 6 have three each. (The hyphenated adverbs *up-hill* and *down-hill* in stanza 1 are not considered prepositional phrases, because they are now fossilized: it is not possible to construct **over-hill, *round-hill*, etc., on the same model.)

Quite a number of the important points about nominal group structure have already been made. What follows is little more than a mopping-up operation. Table 7.5 summarizes the structure of nominal groups according to their place in clause structure, that is, whether they are subjects, complements, objects, appositional groups, or prepositional objects.

Among the nominal groups which are subject, there are no adjectives at all, and no modifiers other than *the* and *my*. There is only one instance of a qualifier. So these are rudimentary nominal groups. We are told, for example, that there are legs, but there is virtually no circumstantial detail given us; whether they are fat or thin, long or short, etc. The minimal structure of the subject groups (and most of the other groups) almost certainly contributes an effect of bareness about the description.

The complements are also simple. The two adjective-head groups in stanza 8 remind us of the very small number of adjectives in the poem as a whole. Those two, along with those of stanzas 4 and 7 make up the list, which must be as short a list as any 40 lines is likely to produce.

The structure of line 24 deserves a word to itself. It is not a common type of structure, but I suggest in the analysis that *entire* is complement and *I stood* is SP. *Entire* is not a normal complement, and is rather restricted in its occurrence. The meaning of this important line is studied below.

The complements are a mixed bag, ranging from single adjectives and nouns to the long group occupying lines 14–16. The clause objects all refer to the legs:

> *the legs; the unstoppable legs; my shins;*
> *them* (my shins); *them* (my shins)

This point adds to the restriction on transitive already noted: transitive clauses, then,

a. are very few in number;
b. in F or B clauses, occur only in the last stanza (other examples in lines 13 and 25);
c. all refer to *legs* by synonym or pronoun reference, or the word itself.

**Table 7.5** Nominal Group Structure

| No. of groups | Structure | Headword components | | No. of headwords |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| *21* | | | *Subject* | |
| 9 | h | pronoun | h: I | 5 |
| | | | it | 1 |
| | | | there, what, they | 3 |
| 1 | hq | pronoun | q: too | 1 |
| 9 | dh | noun | d: the | 5 |
| | | | my | 4 |
| 1 | dhq | noun | line 11 | 1 |
| 1 | c | clause | line 13 | 1 |
| *8* | | | *Complement* | |
| 2 | h | noun | | 2 |
| 3 | h | adj. | | 3 |
| 2 | dh | noun | d: this, a | 2 |
| 1 | de + deehq | noun | lines 14–16 | 1 |
| *5* | | | *Object* | |
| 2 | h | pronoun | them | 2 |
| 2 | dh | noun | d: the, my | 2 |
| 1 | deh | noun | d: the | 1 |
| *3* | | | *Apposition* | |
| 3 | hq | noun | | 3 |
| *12* | | | *Prep. Object* | |
| 3 | h | noun | | 3 |
| 8 | dh | noun | d: the | 5 |
| | | | both, a, possess | 3 |
| 1 | | noun | n: twenty | 1 |

h: headword q: qualifier – after *h*
d: deictic (determiner) e: adjective
n: numeral

All 3 appositional groups have *legs* as headword and post-head qualifiers, which are otherwise rare. There is a possessive in line 10, and finally, the prepositional

objects, which are very simple in their structure. In fact, simplicity and restriction is the keynote of nominal group structure. The most common type of group throughout is *the* + *noun*. Quite a number of the exponents are restricted in occurrence, for example the pronouns and the single noun headwords. *My* is restricted to subject position except in the last stanza.

And so on. There are intricate and interesting relationships between the choice of headword (*legs, I, road*, others) and the syntactic role of the nominal group, but I shall not attempt to follow each one through.

## 7.17 Adverbial groups

Some points have already been made concerning adverbial groups, and what follows is merely a few notes on the residue.

The usual things to note are the structure of the groups, their position in the clause, and their distribution in the text. Their overall distribution has been mentioned, and the effect of the five adverbs of stanza 1 has been made clear. There is little of complexity in their structure, so there is only the clausal position to comment on. One can say of most adverbs or prepositional groups that there is a place in clause structure where each is most likely to appear. So if it turns up somewhere else it gives an effect of surprise and draws attention to itself. Examples of this unusual placement are (I add to these the complement *entire*, which behaves similarly.)

1. *Blindly*, line 12. Remember that we are waiting for some reason for the definite article in *the sticks*…. The occurrence of *pavement* helps but does not explain. *Blindly* does, however, and links up lexically with *tapped*.
2. *Gently*, line 37. Perhaps the main effect gained by this front-placing is yet another of surprise to add to the acceleration. We have to read on before we can fit in the adverb to a sense-pattern.
3. *On grass by the roadside, Entire*. The clause here is the most odd (as regards sequence) in the whole poem. The contrast is being made between *the legs*, bits of people with their own impetus, and the *I* of the poem, whose body, he thinks, is whole and integrated and under his control. The first occurrence of *I* is carefully insulated from mention of parts of the body, even the legs. *My legs* starts the stanza, and between it and the *I* there comes 3 lines' worth of padding. The oddity of the word *entire* being used in a slightly wrong word-class (it is not normally a predicative adjective) plus the positional oddity, plus the occurrence of *entire* at the beginning of a line – all these points help to throw the word into prominence.

## 7.18 Part versus whole

The *my* + *noun* groups keep drawing attention to the 'detachability' (in terms of control at least) of parts of the body. Stanza 8, for example, might have run like this, without distortion of the paraphraseable meaning; but with quite a different effect.

| | |
|---|---|
| 29 | I smiled broadly |
| | But the legs could not see; |
| | I laughed loudly |
| | But the legs could not hear. |
| 33 | I felt dizzy, then … |

So stanza 6 has the seeds of the unchaining built in to its first two words. The only *I* which refers physically to the whole person is in line 24, insulated as we have seen. The other instances of *I* are all in the immediate environment of a *my*-group or a pronoun which refers to it (*the knees* does duty as a *my*-group in line 36).

| | |
|---|---|
| 33 | My head |
| 34 | I wondered |
| 35 | Might I too be a walker |
| 36 | From the knees down |
| 37 | Gently I touched my shins |
| 40 | Before I regained them |

In the very last line, the *I* of the poem says he regains control of his legs. Is the statement fully convincing? Is the reader left with a final impression of rest and reassurance at the happy ending, or does the feeling linger that there is, perhaps, merely a temporary respite, and the experience of the poem has brought it home to the over-confident *I* of stanza 6, how little he actually is in control? Here are the main points of the linguistic evidence:

1. The *I* regains control.
   a. The rhyme in the last stanza, the only one in the poem.
   b. The structure of the stanza. This stanza, like 1, 5, and 9, is a 'sting-in-the-tail' one. The others have all been considered earlier: the unexpected plunge into acceleration in stanza 1, the ironical puncturing of the symmetry in stanza 5, the complete table-turning of stanza 9. The reader may reasonably expect that in a stanza of this type the final line may be the tail that wags the other three lines. Our previous experience with this type of stanza leads us to place great weight upon the final line.
   c. The return to nonmodal verbs, after the excursus in stanzas 8 and 9.

2. The *I* barely regains control.
   a. The last line is a subordinate clause. If it was to carry the resolution of the whole poem, an F clause would seem more appropriate.
   b. The words in the line reinforce separateness, as we have just seen. *I* and *them*. In a way, the grammatical and lexical structure of the line denies what the line says.
   c. The poem is accelerating in the last stanza.

The reader is left to weigh up this evidence and compare it with the general impression he gets of the final mood of the poem. Certainly there is conflict between the two interpretations, and to plump for either of them wholeheartedly would be to oversimplify the meaning of the poem. The author uses a simple narrative style most of the time. He gives the impression of detachment, and he maintains it right to the end, by avoiding saying whether the experience he describes was or was not resolved for the *I* of the poem.[8]

## 7.19 Conclusion

I have described some of the main points raised by the application of my techniques to the text. I won't attempt to summarize. Rather I would like to leave an impression of how little of the structure of the text I have managed to cover. Almost all of it is grammar. Occasional glances at the vocabulary, metre, etc., have been only in support of a grammatical point. The grammar itself has not been detailed; a few ideas raised by crude analysis have been pursued, in the belief that their analysis deepens our understanding of the poem.

The reader who has arrived at this point may well feel that too many words have been spent on 40 lines of verse, and he might shudder at the suggestion that this is just the tip of the iceberg. I hope that the reason there is so much to say is Graves' fault, not mine. But some of the clumsiness is necessary because of the lack of an accepted terminology and technique of presentation, and the absence of explicit theoretical backing, so that the 'stylistic categories' of acceleration, dislocation, and the like, exist in some limbo without visible means of support.

My concern has been to show some of the *meaning-bearing mechanisms of the poem*; not to interpret it, defend it, or classify it. An explication, line-by-line, of

8. This point was made by Robson: it does not arise from a purely grammatical analysis of the text.

the text, would note some different points. It could not miss the curious phrasing of line 28 for example, where even the successivity of steps is avoided (compare:

1. Between one step and the next; or
2. Between one step and another.)

On a tiny scale, the line reinforces the general contrast between directed, controlled walking, and pointless, dislocated leg-moving.

There is no end to the detail that is potentially relevant. There are no rules, as yet, to this game. What's more, it is traditional to credit a literary artist with almost magical powers of meaning several things simultaneously, making one and one add up to three or more. A careful analysis of his work would have to show the same features. It seems like an invitation to irresponsible comment. Consider the points that have been made about the word *stop* in the poem.

a. Its two occurrences are at the ends of lines (14, 25) which are not end-stopped.
b. The morpheme immediately preceding *stop* is in both cases a negative which directly modifies *stop* (adverb to verb, and prefix to root).

On the level of argument pursued above, both points fit neatly into the notion of the legs' perpetual motion, pushed from behind, so to speak, which is the major effect created by the poem.

But the two points contradict each other: in (a) one ignores the negatives, which precede *stop*. Is (a) then, a point which arises from the analysis, but is not a real effect of the lines? Linguistic analysis of a text is a disentanglement of components of complex meanings. It does not automatically assign priorities. In a 'downward' analysis like the one in this chapter, which begins with the largest units in the least detail, and proceeds to the smallest units in the greatest detail, there is the obvious danger of asserting the relevance of a feature which – in the text as a whole – is nullified by some other feature or set of features. At present the only safeguard against this is the common sense and integrity of the analyst, just as in literary criticism.

The hypothesis behind this and similar studies is that it is possible to bridge the gap between the total public meaning of a text and the individual patterns of linguistic items in it, by means of intermediate stylistic categories. These categories must constitute a satisfactory analysis of the total meaning of the text (at a given level of detail) and they must be exactly defined in linguistic terms. Where two distinct patterns of language are assigned to the same stylistic category there must be some organizational similarity between them. Just what blend of aesthetics, psychology, and linguistics turns out to be the best specification for a stylistic category remains to be seen, and in fact awaits an adequate theory of literature.

CHAPTER 8

# Lines about "Lines"*

## 8.1 Introduction: Focats

In this chapter I want to argue, or at least assert that:

a. in stylistics the fashionable contrast between subjective (literary) and objective (linguistic) standpoints is unrealistic. It is equally unhelpful to view a text as a communication between individuals subject to no rules, or to see it as a rigid pattern with a known communicative value. Extreme positions of subjectivity and objectivity both fail to account for the meaningful patterning of a literary text, or indeed any text at all.
b. stylistics need not have an unfortunate air of *ad hoc*-ness, sleight of hand. This arises from a failure to devise an adequate theory of literature. The present corpus of stylistic comment consists of applications in search of a theory.
c. in the explication of the relationship between linguistic details and literary interpretation there are intersection points of particular interest, which we shall call focusing categories or *focats*.

The example I have chosen is Wordsworth's "Lines Composed a Few Miles above Tintern Abbey". From a fairly full analysis, I shall select some important features.

## 8.2 Metrical and meaningful units

The metrical units and the meaningful units are offset against each other. Most sentences end mid-line; only half the lines are end-stopped: the comma is the popular end-line mark, semicolon mid-line. Contrast this with heroic-couplet poetry,

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* This article appeared originally in Kachru, B., Stahlke, B. & Herbert, F.W. (eds). 1972. *Current Trends in Stylistics*, 252–261. Edmonton: Linguistic Research Inc. Reprinted in Carter, R. (ed.). 1982. *Language and Literature*, 163–176. London: Allen & Unwin.

where most lines are end-stopped, most sentence boundaries are also line boundaries; commas are the regular mid-line mark, with semicolons ending lines.

An effect of offsetting grammar and metre is that there are very few places in the poem where all the reader's current expectations are met. Whenever the grammar allows a break, the metre presses on, and vice versa. A text in this grammetric form may be better suited to mood-creation than to argument.

## 8.3 'Tight' to 'loose' structures

If one were to range English structures on a single scale from 'tight' to 'loose', this text would show a prominence of 'loose' structures – structures like simple co-ordination, apposition, addition. Here are some typical examples; to list exhaustively would be to reprint the text. (Quotations are from the Oxford Standard Authors edition, text 5, 2nd edn, 1936.)

A *Co-ordination*

| | |
|---|---|
| (i) sentences: | And now (58) |
| | And so (64) |
| | Nor perchance… (111) |
| | Nor wilt thou then (155) |
| (ii) clauses: | and in thy voice I catch … (116) |
| | and read/My former pleasures … (118–19) |
| (iii) groups: | A lover of the meadows and the woods, (103) |
| | In darkness and amid the many shapes |
| | Of joyless daylight; (51–2) |
| | Faint I, nor mourn nor murmur: (86) |
| (iv) words: | many recognitions dim and faint (59) |
| | these steep and lofty cliffs (5) |

B *Apposition*

These plots of cottage-ground, these orchard-tufts, (11)
I bounded o'er the mountains, by the sides
Of the deep rivers and the lonely streams,
Wherever nature led! (68–70)
When these wild ecstasies …
when thy mind/Shall be …
oh! then,/If solitude. … (138–43)

C *Addition* – non-defining relative clauses, e.g. lines 6, 12, 81

these orchard-tufts,/Which, at this season
with their unripe fruits,/Are clad in one
green hue (11–13)

## 8.4 Copying

From even these few examples it can be seen that many of the 'loose' structures in the poem are further organised by a type of superficial parallelism which I shall call simply *copying*. Through the partial repetition of words and structures, pairs, triples and larger units are formed. The repeated items form a frame within which some new items are introduced. This feature pervades the poem.

> Felt in the blood, and felt along the heart; (28)
> An appetite; a feeling and a love, (80)
> And all its aching joys are now no more, (84)
> And all its dizzy raptures. (85)

An examination of these copied strings shows that the second or subsequent item tends to be longer and/or more complex than its predecessor. Again, one is spoilt for choice of examples.

> With warmer love – oh! with far deeper zeal
> Of holier love. (154–5)

> The sounding cataract
> Haunted me like a passion: the tall rock,
> The mountain, and the deep and gloomy wood,
> Their colours and their forms, were then to me
> An appetite. … (76–80)

> neither evil tongues,
> Rash judgements, nor the sneers of selfish men,
> Nor greetings where no kindness is, nor all
> The dreary intercourse of daily life. … (128–31)

Note that *copying* can assert itself without dependence on syntax: for example, in the opening phrases of the poem.

> Five years have past; five summers, with the length
> Of five long winters! (1–2)

Here copying takes over from syntax to give a repetition of *five* to which is added *long*, cognate with *length* in the head-phrase. It is not clear whether *with* means 'plus' (that is, one summer plus one [long] winter equals one year), or describes an attribute of the previous five summers (each of the previous five summers has dragged on like a winter). It doesn't matter which, since the repetitive effect of the *five* and the elongation afforded by *long* suggests clearly enough that it has been a long time.

## 8.5 Arrest

Let us establish, roughly at first, a distinction in the stylistic patterning.

> these steep and lofty cliffs,
> That *on a wild secluded scene* impress
> Thoughts. … (5–7)

The italicised prepositional phrase is front-placed in its clause. The conjunction *that* leads us to expect a clause, and *wild* may be subject or adjunct in such a clause. Prepositional phrases are optional in most clauses, but in a relative clause introduced by *that* a verb is obligatory. The reader must somehow store the memory of the structure so far while he is interpreting *on a wild secluded scene*, and then when he comes to *impress* he can confidently allocate *that* to the role of subject, since the subject must precede the verb in a relative clause, and no other item has presented itself.

One effect, then, of the sequence of elements in this clause is what I shall call *arrest*. The category of arrest – a focusing category or focat – is in general terms the introduction of an optional element at a place in structure where the structure is syntactically incomplete. If, in the structure AXB, A predicts B, but not X, then X is an arresting element.

There are many complications. For one thing, we cannot hold to an absolute requirement that A predicts B without any possibility of an alternative continuation of the structure. At the end of line 6 *impress* is a verb which is nearly always transitive. The preposition *on* gives confirmation of this; if the preposition was *with*, there is the possibility of the structure terminating at the end of line 6 – a remote possibility. It is, then, a subjective choice of the critic whether the example below puts the prepositional phrase into a position of arrest:

> He impressed with weighty rhetoric his point that. …

A second major difficulty is shown in the phrase *a wild secluded scene*. *A* predicts the noun; *wild* is rarely a noun and, if so, is uncountable and so cannot have *a* as its deictic, so *wild* is an adjective; *secluded* cannot be a noun, so must be another adjective. It would seem that the simple definition above forces us to see this fairly regular structure as heavy with arrest, and a focat that arose so frequently and naturally would be of little value in stylistic description. So we add the following to the definition of arrest:

> If (in the same structure AXB) X is a regular selection in the structure (that is, in its normal position), and is of a different grammatical class from A, then it is not an arresting element.

One or two questions are still begged; 'regular' is not exactly clear, and grammatical classes may be set up at different depths of delicacy, or detail. But the effect of

this rider is that *secluded* is an arresting element, since it is a member of the same grammatical class as *wild* (that is, it is understood here as a quality adjective), but *wild* is not considered to be arresting. This adjustment is, I hope, satisfactory to one's intuitions.

## 8.6 Extension

What of the structure ABX, where neither A nor B predicts X? Again we must except the cases of structures developing in their normal way, and pick out those where additional elements extend the structure beyond expectation. Take the case $ABX_1X_2$, where $X_1$ and $X_2$ are members of the same grammatical class. $X_2$ is an *extension* of the structure.

Now we need a gloss on 'normal'. Adjuncts and prepositional phrases following the S-P-O part of a clause are normal; adjectives in front of nouns, and so on; distinctive elements of a particular structure. But there are a number of recursive devices in English grammar which operate fairly generally; co-ordination, juxtaposition, apposition are examples. Such structures will be classified as *extensions* whenever they occur.

There are marginal cases. The relative clause is one. A recursive structure, it cannot, however, be selected at any point but is normally dependent on a closely preceding noun. The conventions followed here are: (*a*) 'non-defining' relative clauses, being totally unpredicted, are always extension; (*b*) a single 'defining' relative clause is normal, but subsequent ones in the same structure are extensions. Convention (*b*) applies to prepositional phrases ("Tell me the price of the toy on the shelf in the window of that shop across the street"), strings of possessives ("It used to be the gentleman's wife's mother's dog's"), phased predicators ("I found him helping her watch them spy on me"), and other recursive structures which require a particular syntactic environment.

## 8.7 Rank

Language structure is layered: there are structures within structures; clauses within sentences, words within groups, and so on. Since arrest and extension can feature at any layer, it will be possible to have arrest within arrest, extension within arrest, etc. Each combination will produce a distinctive effect.

There follows in Figures 8.1 and 8.2 an analysis of two sentences of "Tintern Abbey", in terms of the two focats of arrest and extension. The grammatical layer, or *rank*, is noted, and the nature of the environment of a focat. Embedding of one

focat within another is shown. First-order arrest is in square brackets, second-order in diamond brackets. Extension is underlined with the boundaries marked by small vertical lines. Items framed by the copying structures noted above are asterisked.

The first sentence (Figure 8.1) starts with two brief arrests and then embarks on a series of extensions by apposition. The second appositional nominal group, *that blessed mood*, introduces a non-defining relative clause. At this point (line 38) the structure is fairly extended; the relative clause continues the appositional group which is all an extended explanatory gloss on *another gift*. Then the structure changes. The relative clause is arrested between subject and predicator by a second clause (line 39) which begins in the same way as the first, and in fact turns out to be virtually a rephrasing of the first clause subject. But it is substantially longer and contains within it another arrest – *and the weary*. (The descriptive system adopted here does not formally recognise the use of long words like *unintelligible*, which obviously increases the effect of arrest at the end of line 40.)

There is a break in the patterning at *is lightened*; all the syntactic predictions are fulfilled; but the sentence develops a further extending appositional group, so off we go again. This one carefully follows the words of its predecessor, with *serene* framed in the structure, reminding one of the similar adjective arrest two lines above: however, the remainder of the structure does not involve arrest; line 42 is a simple relative clause with only initial resemblances to lines 38 and 39.

The sentence changes into its second phase at the beginning of line 43. *Until*, makes it clear that a new main clause is on the way, and its comma notes that the following nominal group is not the subject, but a digression as regards the predicted elements of the clause. It turns out to be a participial structure, but by the end of line 43 all we know is that it is an arresting nominal group. There is then in the following line a further arrest as the co-ordinate nominal group develops, copied from the first; and one need not wonder at the occurrence of *suspended*, just before the subject *we* that was predicted by *Until*. As before, the major arrest is followed by a period of modest extension in line 46, but the pressure builds up again with *While*, (47), which has the same predictive power as *Until*. In this case the arresting structure is a front-placed prepositional phrase within which there are surprises; *made quiet … joy* is a rankshifted qualifier of *an eye* which itself is governed by *with*. *Of harmony* is a further stage in rankshift and therefore constitutes further extension; there is then even more extension in the co-ordinate nominal group, a copying structure framing *deep*. At the end of line 48 the syntax is pushed very hard; an extension of an extension within an arrest which stretches the arrest out; that whole pattern being an extension

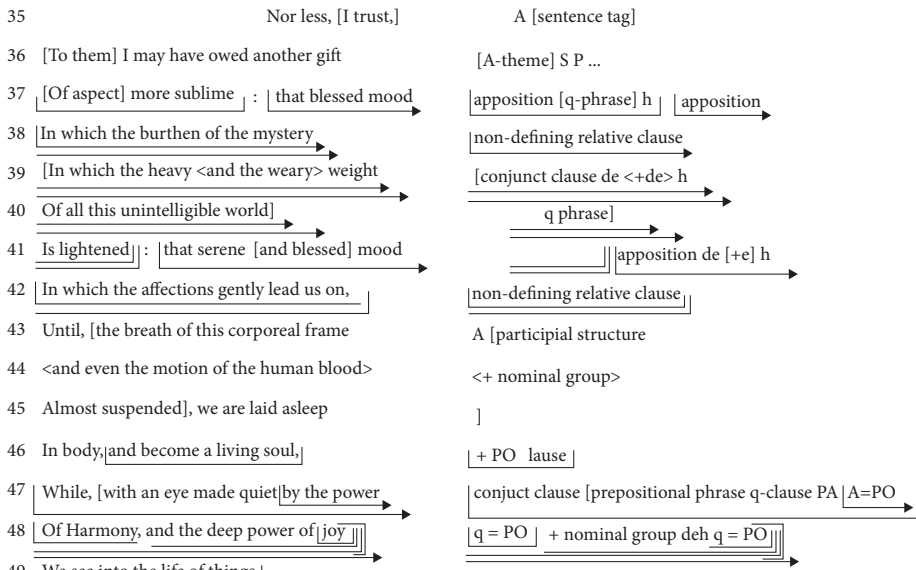


**Figure 8.1** Structural Analysis, lines 35–49

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 93 | And I have felt | (whole sentence is co-ordinated by *and*) |
| 94 | A presence that disturbs me \| with the joy → | defining relative clause SPO A = P \| Q → |
| 95 | Of elevated thoughts \|\| a sense sublime → | double rankshift \|\| appositional object dhe → |
| 96 | Of something \| far more/deeply/ interfused, \| | q = PO; o = h \| q /double degree adverbs/ double rankshift \| |
| 97 | \| Whose dwelling is the light of setting suns, → | \| non-defining relative clause → |
| 98 | \| And the round ocean \| \| And the living air, \| → | \| co-ordinate complement \| \| co-ordinate complement \| → |
| 99 | \| And the blue sky \| , \| and in the mind of man: \|\| | \| co-ordinate complement \| \| co-ordinate complement \|\| |
| 100 | \| A motion, and a spirit \| , \| that impels → | \| appositional object \| co-ordinate object \| \| non-defining relative clause → |
| 101 | All thinking things, \| all objects of all thought \|\| → | co-ordinate object \|\| → |
| 102 | \| And rolls through all things. \|\| | \| co-ordinate relative clause \| |

*Note: and* (102) at first sight seems to co-ordinate with the objects in 101, but is assigned as co-ordinate with *that impels*...(100).

**Figure 8.2** Structural Analysis, lines 93–102

which is the third time that a highly arresting structure has been developed in the sentence. All this accumulated energy spills over into the last clause, *we see into the life of things*.

A rather weak clause, the last one. None of the fine rolling phrases of the rest of the sentence. And yet the whole sentence has been building up to it. The sentence, having arrived at its main point, might have continued expansively for several lines as many of the sentences in "Tintern Abbey" do – but no. One short clause, mainly composed of frequent grammatical words and the almost empty noun *things*. The effect, as I see it, is to invite the reader to attach greater profundity to that little clause; to see it as a visionary distillation of the message. Wordsworth has had several false starts in trying to describe the vision; first by developing the noun mood, then switching to a description of a state of being, and having two stabs at that.

Assume that Wordsworth had finished at the end of line 46. Then the last few words of line 46 would suddenly assume great importance: they are powerful words, too, but somehow their individuality is not fully felt when one reads them as contributory to the effect of the sentence as a whole.

Such an interpretation of the sentence assumes a link between the detailed linguistic facts of the text and the impression the text creates. We are entertaining the suggestion that Wordsworth's syntax accurately models his meaning; suspends itself when the meaning is suspense; builds up a tension by repeating the same arresting devices several times, and then in the quiet last clause suggests an ultimate depth of meaning. Lines 39 and 40 are presumably only present to assist the syntax – they scarcely add anything to the meaning; 44 adds very little, and so on. These are cases of copying, where in addition to the syntactic patterning there is close similarity to a previous structure, so that the two are almost compared to each other.

The poet, in effect, harnesses the process of decoding, interpreting, understanding the language, and makes it work to his purpose. The meaning of the text is supplemented by the reader feeling himself acquiring the meaning.

Not all the sentences in the poem are of this particular type; more commonly they have some arrest at the beginning, and then develop into multiple extensions. Some are exceptionally extended, and I have chosen the sentence at line 93 (Figure 8.2) as a contrasting example. It is a description of the all-pervading Spirit of Nature.

The sentence begins with extension by rankshift; extends at *a sense sublime* by apposition and repeats the rankshift extension, tacks on a non-defining relative clause and within that begins to extend the complement. There are four extensions to the complement, three of them sharing *and the* (*adjective noun*). The last is slightly different. Next the sentence returns to its original appositional extension with *A motion*, parallel to *a sense* and *A presence*, and extends it to

*a spirit*. A third relative extension follows, and its object is extended through apposition. Finally a co-ordinate clause to the relative clause rounds off the sentence. Twice, at the end of lines 99 and 102, three extensions are simultaneously operating.

Again it is a short, simple clause, *And rolls through all things* – an attempt to express the ultimate generalised perception of a personification of the energy in the universe. Again it is the build-up, the movement of the sentence, that charges the words and phrases with most of their meaning. The sentence is almost intolerably extended – there are more than a dozen places where one could sensibly put a full stop, but on and on it goes.

The list of nominal groups in lines 97–9, if isolated, runs close to bathos with the hoary old cliché *the blue sky*; but, since its value here is mainly to pull out the triple extension, we do not experience any let-down.

Poetry, it is sometimes argued, tries to say the unsayable – and succeeds, paradoxically. We see Wordsworth wrestling with ideas for which words are too limiting; concepts perhaps not precisely grasped by the poet. We can avoid this paradox by a hypothesis that poetry, in common with many varieties of a language, uses two routes of communication: one conventional, where words are built into phrases along accepted lines, decoded in a manner that in principle could be automated; and the other a problem-solving system, where unique combinations are suggested that have no conventional meaning. Though they are latent in the structure of the language, the language does not typically make use of them. By this route the meaning of a latent pattern is assessed in relation to the conventional, precise and basic meaning.

In fact the two routes are not separate and extreme. Continuous variations can be observed between writing that relies heavily on the conventional patterns and writing that is virtually governed by the latent patterns.

For simple presentation in the above account, I followed a linear decoding technique as if a reader read a text word by word and received the meaning at each word space. This is unlikely to be what actually happens, and in any case we assume that a sensitive interpretation of a text requires that the reader knows the whole text intimately. In which case his reading relates the linguistic details to his total knowledge of and feeling for the text.

## 8.8 Process of analysis

I have tried in Figure 8.3 to flow-chart the process of analysis. First of all there is the reading and full critical understanding of the text. This is an essential step; stylistics may be heavily descriptive but its analysis must be interpreted through the impressions created by the work as a whole.

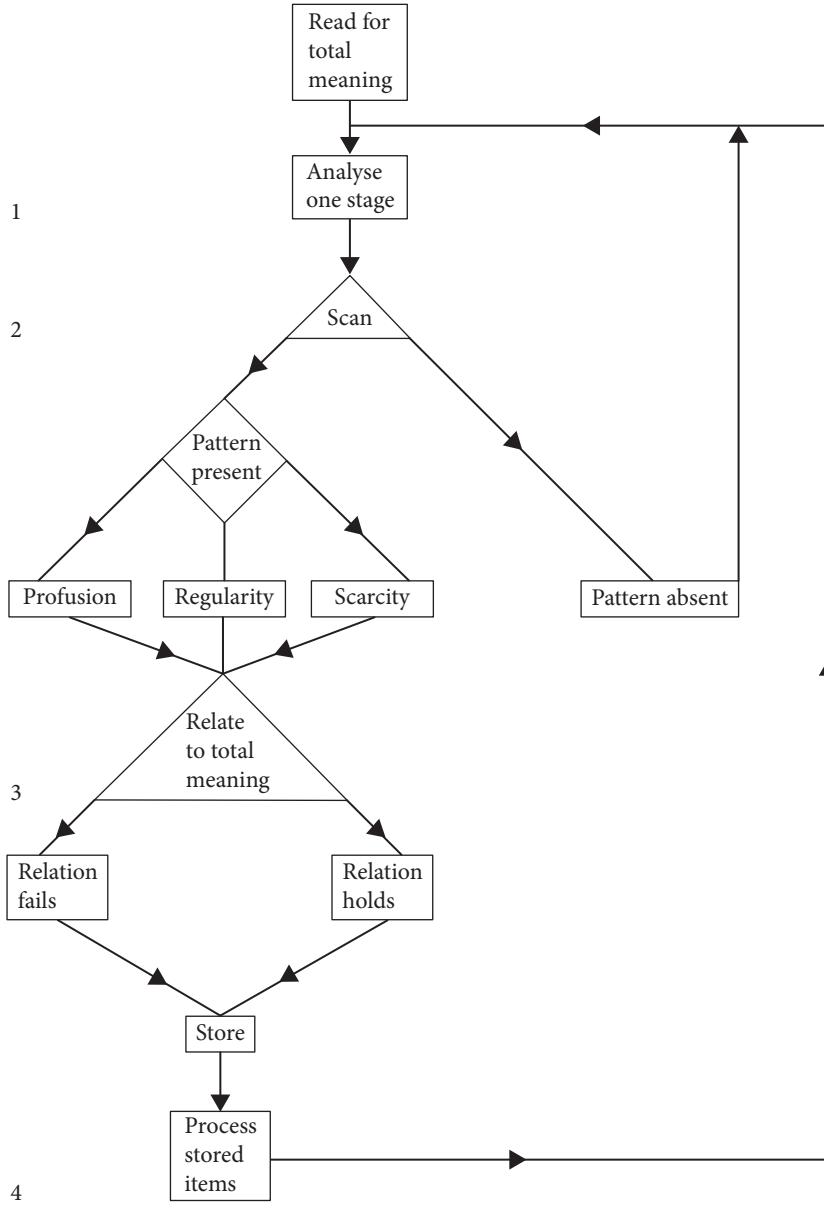


**Figure 8.3** Procedural chart for analysis and interpretation

This 'total meaning' is not normally written out, since any verbalisation of it would involve selection and ordering, and thus would preempt areas of great concern to linguistics. Any 'critical reading' or explication set out at the beginning of a study would give guidelines, which, however accurate, could not be demonstrated to be relevant, comprehensive and sufficiently detailed.

The second stage of the process is the analysis of one area, perhaps sentence structure, rhyme or antonymy. In practice, the larger grammatical units offer the more fruitful starting-point, but there is no restriction. The procedure is independent, too, of which analytical system is followed.

The third stage is called *scan*. The analytical data are examined for patterns to see whether any aspects of the symbols in the display is worth following up. A decision is made: namely, a return to further analysis if no likely lead arises from the analysis, or a description of some aspect of the patterning. Three initial categories are suggested: *profusion* and *scarcity*, which cover the disproportionate occurrence of a symbol in the text, and *regularity*, which covers the distribution of the symbols in repeated sequences. What is profusion in one portion of a text may of course be identified as one of a regular sequence of profusions in the text as a whole.

At this point the nature of the patterning under attention should be described exactly. The next step is to consider how it relates to the unanalysed 'total meaning'. It is used in fact as a possible category for analysis of the total meaning. If the patterning is not accidental, but is meaning-bearing, then the attempt is made to establish what meaning can be assigned to it. There is another decision, then, as to whether or not such a relationship can be at least provisionally suggested. If the decision is negative, the pattern is stored for future use. If positive, then a focat comes into existence – a category which relates latent linguistic patterning to meaning. At times it has value only for the particular text, and only its frequent recurrence in other texts gives it generality. It, too, is stored.

Whether or not a focat is established, the store is now processed. The existence of a focat may suggest how other stored data might be displayed to add to the original data. Since authors do not normally follow comprehensive and rigorous stylistic rules, it is likely that a focat will attract evidence from several structural areas. Also, new data, not yet assigned to a focat, may provide missing parts of a pattern and relate other unassigned data still in the store.

When work on the store is finished, the process repeats itself, and continues until there is no data from the linguistic analysis left. If the analysis were perfect, and the judgement of the analyst infallible, then the process should end with the store empty, and the total meaning of the text analysed into focats.

Judgement is required at four points in the process: since some of them are similar to critical evaluative statements they merit a brief view. The points are marked in the figure.

1. Which area to analyse. In any piece of work, the analyst will play hunches and follow clues, but since the whole text will be fully analysed and processed it does not matter in which order the analysis is examined. Hence the method is not suitable for long texts.

2. Is there a latent pattern present? This is a matter for individual judgement and clearly involves the interpretation of the text. Notice, however, that the decision is recoverable; it is possible to locate disagreements about the meaning of texts by comparing decisions at this stage.
3. Does the pattern analyse some of the total meaning? Again, this is a subjective decision; and, if the answer is positive, the meaning must be accurately defined in a focat specification. Evaluation of a literary nature is more important here, but note that the process specifies the points at which decisions are made, and this puts an effective limitation upon the critical statements that result.
4. Processing the store. At this stage ingenuity is limited least by evidence, and decisions are at their most tentative.

## 8.9 Summary

With these points in mind, we return to the original assertions.

a. Subject-object. I have here presented an argument based on the objective description of a text. There are no intended deviations in the basic grammatical description from the way I would describe any text written in English. The observations have led to groupings inspired by
   i. a generalised, subjective analysis of syntactic forms, e.g. 'tight' and 'loose';
   ii. a subjective perception of the communicative value of the poem. There is room to manoeuvre with criteria of this nature, and the main danger is over-plausibility – discovering relationships between (i) and (ii) which arouse suspicion in other critics. (The other side of the coin is to convince linguists that they cannot describe human communications adequately without having recourse to subjective decisions. But that is not an aim of the present chapter.)
b. The special language of literature. One is reminded of the old story of the rabbit running for its life through the forest because it was unable to prove to Senator McCarthy that it was not a squirrel. All the stylistic features that I have described in this chapter and previous papers are to be found in a full range of texts; arrest is commonplace in oratory, extension is a major feature of conversation. Some literary text may deviate statistically in its density of usage, its particular exploitation of features; but such deviation is itself commonplace.

*c* and *d*. The *ad hoc* nature of stylistic comment. If the text under analysis here is the only one which provides evidence for setting up the focats of arrest and extension, and each successive text requires a unique focat apparatus, then there is no defence against the charge of *ad hoc*-ness. But, if further work suggests, and it does, that a great proportion of stylistic analysis can be effected through a small and finite set of focats, then the groundwork of a theory of literary communication emerges. Most of the other levels of language have yielded to analysis based on the assumption of a set of configurations of a rather small and finite inventory of elements. There is every chance that style will be similarly describable.

CHAPTER 9

# The linguistic basis of style*

## 9.1 Introduction

It is proposed here that literary style, its techniques and its very possibility, arises from the existence of certain properties common to all natural languages. Six properties are outlined and exemplified; the properties are believed to be definable and distinct from each other but they do not form an exhaustive list. The properties are:

- *arbitrariness* between sign and referent
- *arbitrariness* between proposition and exponence
- *structural superfluity*
- *derivational hierarchy*
- *idiom*
- *reference*

All these properties have been noted many times before, indeed several are all commonplace, in literary criticism. The main aim of this chapter is to present them in a way which may clarify them as linking concepts between the two disciplines. In conclusion, some more general comments are made on these properties in relation to literary structures and genres.

## 9.2 Arbitrariness

### 9.2.1 Between sign and referent

This has been a cornerstone of linguistic theory since Saussure. Linguistic signs have referents outside language, and the relationship between sign and referent is the essential link that allows the language to mean. This relationship is abstract, arbitrary, unpredictable. The learner of a language cannot guess accurately on the basis of the physical features of the signs, what they refer to. The fringe area of

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* This chapter appeared originally in Ringbom, H. (ed.). 1975. *Style and Text*, 75–89. Stockholm: Språkförlaget Skriptov AB and Abo Akademi.

moos and miaows, and even some involuntary noises, is language-specific and subject to the normal laws of historical change. There are no direct links from noises within a language system, to noises outside it, or to anything else outside it.

But despite this firm position, speakers of a language persist in sensing an appropriateness of sound to sense, prefer one phrasing to another, and argue from a point of view that seems to be opposed to Saussure's. Far from assuming the theoretical norm of arbitrariness, they seem to work on the principle that the physical features of items in a text can stand in a richly symbolic relationship to their referents. Virtually any quality which can be related to the physical substance of an utterance can be related to the meaning. The relationship may be appropriate, or specifically inappropriate. At a basic level, a contrast may be pointed by the selection of alliterating words, and though we know as readers that the initial sound of a word is not semantically significant at all, we assign meaning to the pattern.

It is not enough to talk of brilliant selection and ordering by writers, or to construct a concept of formal meaning, separate from the usual decoding, where these arbitrary features may become significant. Assuming that there is virtually no total synonymy in natural language, and that literary texts are careful, self-conscious constructs, a linguistic sign cannot be presented simultaneously with full regard to its reference (i.e. arbitrarily in respect to its substance) and meaningfully in terms of its substance. If it appears that something of this nature actually happens, then the descriptive categories are in need of revision.

If it can be argued against the above that the enormous choice available in a language provides enough leeway for signs to be chosen with an eye to their creating additional patterns, it is not clear how the readers or listeners perceive both types of ordering simultaneously. It is unlikely that the total sound wave is retained for examination along a very large number of possible parameters, and so some activating devices must be supposed. Also, we could take a hint from an important feature of visual ambiguity that may well be characteristic of other senses.[1] That is the impossibility of reaching more than one interpretation of an ambiguous figure simultaneously. In the famous duck/rabbit type of drawing, the figure has to be reassessed to move from one interpretation to the other.

It would be a digression to pursue the analogy with visual perception much further at this stage, but possibly helpful to add one or two brief observations. An ambiguous drawing, like a pun, has to be marked out for study or it will be

1. There is a succinct and up-to-date account of visual illusion in R. L. Gregory. 1973. "The Confounded Eye" in Illusion in Nature and Art, ed. Gregory and Gombrich, London. See also G. Leech. 1969. *Linguistic Structures in Poetry,* London, p. 217–220, and A. Cluysenaar, 1976. *Introduction to literary stylistics: a discussion of dominant structures in verse and prose*. London: Batsford

assigned one of its meanings without further ado. For it to be artistically effective, the viewer would have to assign a synthesising interpretation to the phenomenon of the same lines suiting two different simple interpretations. The duck/rabbit would be an unlikely starter, but the famous 'wife and mother' might lead to a reflection about beauty ageing, or the Athenian boys wrestling may suggest the physical contact which is prominent in the sport. Several artists, notably Escher in representational and Vasarely in geometric forms have exploited some of the possibilities of the visual ambiguity. But note that in studies of visual perception each interpretation seems to be made by the same set of rules in the same medium. In literature the rules whereby we decode the conventional meaning of linguistic signs are at least superficially different from the processes whereby we find meaning in the patterns of language substance. The pun is not typical of the battery of possibilities inherent in a language whose development has followed the Saussurean principle of arbitrariness.

One of Jakobson's pronouncements seems to go contrary to this position on arbitrariness, since he talks of the *identity* of sign and referent and stresses that the language patterns in literature must break this identity.

> The function of poetry is to point out that the sign is not identical with its referent. Why do we need this reminder? Because along with the awareness of the identity of the sign and the reference (A is $A_1$) we need the consciousness of the inadequacy of this identity (A is not $A_1$); this antinomy is essential since without it the connection between the sign and the object becomes automatized and the perception of reality withers away.[2]

It is clear from the latter part of the paragraph that Jakobson means by identity the conventional association of sign and referent which the literary language must disturb, and that the movement from sign to referent or vice versa is still across an arbitrary relationship (Figure 9.1).

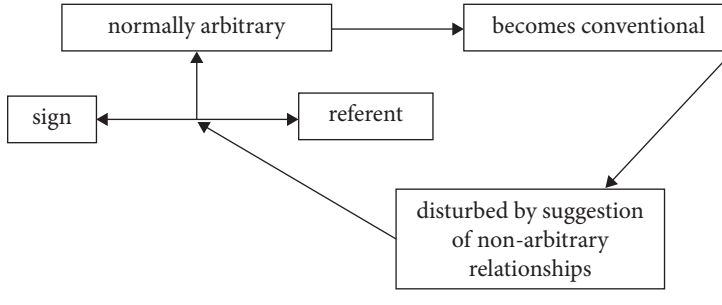


**Figure 9.1** Sign and referent relationship

2. R. Jakobson, "Ce je poesie?" *Volne smery* 30, 1939–1940, pp. 229–239, quoted in V. Erlich. 1969. *Russian Formalism: History, Doctrine*. The Hague: Mouton, p. 181.

### 9.2.2 Between proposition and exponence

This property differs from sign/referent arbitrariness in several particulars, although in some respects it is similar. It is the relationship between the propositional content of an utterance and its exponence, or realisation. The main differences are:

a. propositional content is paraphrasable so that there are many options in realisation. For example, *X is hotter than Y = Y is cooler than X; X is Y = X is not W, and not Z* (*in a set WXYZ*). *X kicked Y = Y was kicked by X*.
b. the scale of exponence relevant here stops short of the physical substance, but remains within the areas of lexis and syntax.
c. Whereas in sign-referent arbitrariness the normal expectation in non-literary language is that the relation remains largely arbitrary, in this type, which I shall call *congruence*, the normal expectation is that the 'overlaying' propositions will support the underlying (deep) propositional content. So in terms of the native speaker's reactions, congruence and appropriateness are complementary features deriving from properties located in different areas of the descriptive model of language.

The stylistic feature of congruence, or incongruence, can be seen very roughly as a relation between deep and surface structure. Deep structure generates the conventional meanings, but during the unfolding of surface structure it is possible to suggest various surface structures which, although ultimately abandoned, may leave a trace of their embryonic meanings. So that, in a sense, *X is hotter than Y* suggests that X is hot and Y is hot; *X is not W* suggests by collocation that X and W are more closely related than by denial of their identity, *Y was kicked by X* suggests that Y did something. If the last example is hard to accept, one can recall an old teaching grammar that said of the sentence

> The missionary was eaten by savages

that the missionary performed the action of being eaten by savages.

Shakespeare's Sonnet 116 is one of many poems which proceed largely by negative statements. In a poem about the constancy of love there are the following negative statements (italicised in the text):

> *Let me not to the marriage of true minds*
> *Admit impediments. Love is not love*
> Which alters when it alteration finds,
> Or bends with the remover to remove.
> O, no! It is an ever-fixed mark, 5
> That looks on tempests *and is never shaken;*

It is the star to every wand'ring bark,
Whose worth's unknown, although his height be taken.
*Love's not Time's fool*, though rosy lips and cheeks
Within the bending sickle's compass come; 10
*Love alters not* with his brief hours and weeks,
But bears it out even to the edge of doom.
If this be error, and upon me prov'd,
*I never writ, nor no man ever lov'd.*

Except for the second quatrain, all the main clauses are negative, and *love* is collocated with *impediments, alter, alteration, Time's fool*, and *alter* again. Perhaps the quasi-legal language of the first two and the last two lines conceal the basic absurdity of argument by negative assertion. The expected 'resolution' of the negatives by subsequent positives does happen – lines 5–8, and line 12. But the strong reciprocating pattern of cognates *alter – alteration* and *remover – remove* is hardly compensated for; the subject becomes *it* rather than *love* so that sabotage by negatives continues in *never shaken* and *worth's unknown*, relegated to the subordinate clauses. One must also point to the brevity of the main negative assertions, leaving much of the text to positive comment on the instability of things in the passage of time. The second positive main clause, in line 12, is not nearly prominent enough to counterbalance 9–11; the subject is understood so that *love* again does not collocate with *bears it out*; the line is even-numbered which, in the way sentences fit lines in this sonnet, suggests a subordinate role.

In the second quatrain the words *ever* and *never* appear, words that one might expect in assertions of constancy. By an effect of the arbitrariness feature, the word *every* in the line 7, bolstered by the superficial similarity of

| *syllables:* | 6 7 | 8 9 | 10 |
|---|---|---|---|
| line 5 | ever | fix-ed | mark |
| line 7 | every | wandring | bark |

reinforces the presence of *ever* in the quatrain.

The last line is so packed with negatives that it is difficult to understand fully. The final clause

*nor no man ever loved*

is the first place where *love* and *ever* collocate, but the negatives dominate, and, by a neat reversal, the negative moves to the subject position and the word *love* moves to the verb. This parallels the reversal of the sentence syntax. From lines 2–12 the characteristic sentence is main clause first, followed by all sorts of subordinate material eroding the main statements – in contrast line 13 is the only case where a subordinate clause precedes the main clause.

The effect of the negatives in this poem is to exemplify the difficulties of constancy. *Love* and *not* and *alter* are never far apart, the negatives are not adequately balanced by positives and they dominate the last line.

The possibilities under the heading of congruence are very wide – as wide as the range of options from proposition to realisation. The example of negatives sketched out above shows a gross discrepancy, or incongruence, between what we understand of the propositional meaning of the sentences and the effect created by their realisation. But many less obvious tactical choices, from word order to matters such as voice and transitivity, are capable of similar modification of the total impression made by a text.

Of course, in a deep structure that fully specifies the eventual surface forms, such matters would be decided at the outset, but it would be an exceedingly difficult task to recognise them from the deep structure formulae. The problem of how these different strands of meaning are perceived, related, and interpreted remains as obscure as the similar problem for sign-referent arbitrariness. And since congruence and arbitrariness may both play a part in the same stretch of text, the situation is further complicated.

## 9.3 Structural superfluity

We turn to the well-known feature of poetic licence, and the important question of how a rule-bound system can interpret rule-breaking. The property of language that gives rise to this possibility is the asymmetry of linguistic networks. Not all combinations of symbols are possible. Categories are properly set up in descriptions to account for necessary differences, but only a few of the possible sequential strings are actually assigned status in the descriptions. The stylistic feature of *deviation* fills the gaps.

There has been much exploration by generative grammarians of the boundaries of grammaticalness,[3] and some suggestion that deviant structures might be assigned analogical meaning on a sliding scale. The fuzzy edges of syntax remain fuzzy, despite the clear requirement of Chomsky's model that grammatical sentences must be sharply distinguished from non-grammatical ones.

It is unprofitable in practice also to retain a concept of 'more or less grammatical', because that obscures the issue that arises in stylistics of how deviations are interpreted. The assumption remains that a 'fairly grammatical' string will be

3. A convenient statement of the starting position of this work is found in three papers, by Chomsky, Ziff and Katz, in Fodor and Katz (eds). 1964, *The Structure of Language*, New Jersey, p. 384–416.

interpreted principally with reference to wholly grammatical strings, and the evidence for this is not conclusive. Experimental subjects can probably be shown to normalise slightly deviant strings, but that process in relation to literature would be a kind of misinterpretation.

Let us turn from the disputed area on the borders of grammaticalness and consider the general case. Suppose a language has (or its description requires) elements of structure A, B and C at a certain point, and the following structures are grammatical:

ABC, AC, BC, BCA, C

Then suppose one generates BAC, AB, B, AAC or any of the other possibilities. What sort of meaning can be imagined for these?

The answer seems to be – a great deal, often of a particularly evocative and intriguing type. Once again the native speaker finds interpretations for items which have no recognised meaning. There is certainly an urge to assign a tentative syntax to any string, however random, and no doubt that is a natural extension of the everyday process of decoding, where the raw sound waves or line shapes are assigned structure and meaning, often despite interference. The following casual example was concocted by opening a book on language teaching five times and each time picking a word, all without looking.

Of grading be language grammar

Immediately it has some sort of structure; an intonation pattern is assigned to it. *Of grading* will be some sort of initial adjunct; *be* is the main verb, and its lack of inflexion gives, with the curious word-order, a slightly archaic flavour. The subject might be *language, grammar* or *language-grammar*. Certainly none of this structure was put into the selection of the word-string, and it remains nonsense. But the mind keeps turning it over and over to see what meaning it might yield.

In cases where the interpretation finds meaning, the process is far from merely rewriting the string into an acceptable form. The obvious point is that we assume that a literary author could have written grammatically if he had wished. Norman McCaig is a ready source of small scale deviations, for instance:

A ruined chain lies reptile

Leaving aside the exact meaning of *ruined*, the word *reptile*, normally a noun, is glossed as an adjective or past participle – *lies hidden* or *lies quiet*. Some adjectives end in *-ile*, like *facile, nubile*, and some readers might think *supine* is being hinted at, though the process of interpretation need not be conscious. These suggestions and half-echoes arise from the arbitrariness feature and point the way towards a

tentative syntactic structure. But the clause retains its unique form, and does not fit the pattern. We are not so much asking "What is the grammar of this clause?" as "What would a grammar be like if it could cope with this clause?" We are asked to extend our grammars, imaginatively and provisionally, to handle the otherwise meaningless entity.

A skilled speaker of a language, then, retains some sort of agile acquisition mechanism to cope with the deviations. However, it is doubtful that the simple technique of relating a deviant utterance to the 'nearest' grammatical one is likely to provide a satisfactory account of the literary effect of deviance. Almost certainly more than one route will be suggested, and the decision about which is either 'nearer' or more satisfying is not always going to be easy.

Another point concerns the special status of the syntactic decoding process, in contrast with the other dimensions of meaning discussed here. When faced with a deviant passage where the normal syntactic decoding does not fully apply, the claim for attention by stylistic patterns increases and the total effect of the passage may have little to do with similar non-deviant passages. The motivation in a person to understand and to impose order and meaning causes him to explore possible extensions of his grammar, and other dimensions of meaning. He becomes, momentarily, a speculative linguist. The speed and naturalness of this process should not disguise its character or importance. Once again the skilled speaker finds meaning in an aspect of language patterning that has no meaning, officially. Presumably some of the rich meaning that can arise from deviation is a product of the adjustments in his linguistic co-ordinates giving rise to all sorts of concomitant possibilities.

## 9.4 Derivational hierarchy

The literary feature that arises from this property includes most types of parallelism, antithesis and the like – those that do not rely on aspects of arbitrariness. Again it concerns the meaning-potential of formal similarity, but whereas arbitrariness consider only the final outcome, the linguistic sign, the feature we shall call *matching* considers all similarity on a realisation scale within a grammar.

In one sense all sentences are the same – just in the fact that they are sentences. And each sentence is a unique combination of choices, at least slightly different from all others, sharing perhaps a lot of similarities of structure with certain other sentences, not so much with others, and so on. The derivational tree of any pair of sentences will show points of divergence and possibly later convergence. Since all the choices that are made lead to meaning in the eventual sentence, the fact

that similar patterns appear in adjacent structures is quite incidental. However, given circumstances which draw attention to the matching, it becomes a powerful source of further meaning.

In Pope's famous dismissive couplet about women[4]

> A Fop their Passion, but their Prize a Sot,
> Alive, ridiculous, and dead, forgot!

the matchings provide much of the structure. The metre, rhyme and alliteration provide a framework; the repetition of *their* and *a* indicate a chiasmus in the first line, and although the structure is reversible the line tends to be paraphrased *Their passion is a fop*. … Between the two lines, the linkers *but* and *and* suggest another similar structure but so compressed that each word in the second line except *and* is a full clause.

The antonymic matching *alive-dead* shows that the selection of semantic features is also relevant, and there is a separate comment later about lexical and semantic patterns. Note that *alive* is a member of the class of adjectives that must be headwords and not noun modifiers, though *dead* is ambiguous. *Forgot* is slightly difficult for the modern reader, but easy to match with *ridiculous*. So three adjectives and a past participle in a row can be paraphrased as

> When they are alive, they are ridiculous,
> and when they are dead, they are forgotten

The effect of the matching is to take two words, *ridiculous* and *forgot*, which have nothing semantically to do with each other and not much syntactically, and to invest them with a fairly comprehensive pejorative meaning, as if they were complementary concepts that between them summed up the folly and fate of women.

Pope's verse paragraphs often start with a clear matching and develop it gradually, keeping it an important structural feature of the paragraph. Early in the "Epistle to Arbuthnot", Pope writes:

> Is there a Parson, much be-mus'd in Beer, 15
> A maudlin Poetess, a ryming Peer,
> A Clerk, foredoom'd his Father's soul to cross,
> Who pens a Stanza when he should *engross?*
> Is there, who lock'd from Ink and Paper, scrawls
> With desp'rate Charcoal round his darken'd walls? 20
> All fly to *Twit'nam*, and in humble strain
> Apply to me, to keep them mad or vain.
> *Arthur*, whose giddy Son neglects the Laws,

4. *Moral Essays*, Epistle II *To a Lady*, lines 247–8.

Imputes to me and my damn'd works the cause:
Poor *Cornus* sees his frantic Wife elope, 25
And curses Wit, and Poetry, and *Pope*.

Line 16 gives the match most succinctly: indefinite article, modifier and noun. The *a* and the *p*-alliteration include line 15 although the noun modifier is more elaborate, comes after the noun and has its own subtle alliteration. This makes a fairly common 3-part couplet, similar to lines 9–10. The model of line 15 is developed in 17–18, where the noun modifier takes up most of the couplet, and various local matchings appear. Lines 19–20 start by repeating the first two words of 15, then proceed like lines 17–18, with parallels such as *foredoom'd/lock'd*, and the slight matching of 18 develops into the fourpart pattern of 20. Line 20 in turn recalls the original model of 16.

Line 21 changes the framing syntax from interrogative to declarative, though the sequence *all, Arthur, poor Cornus* retains at least the selection of nouns referring to human beings. The remainder of each couplet creates a distinct pattern with only slight echoes, e. g. 23–4 and 19–20. Line 25 shows the first main clause that fits the line, and this simple correlation is rounded off, in typical fashion, with a line displaying a 3-noun list.

The way in which matchings are perceived and processed is no clearer than the harnessing of arbitrary similarities or differences, and they may best be considered also as types of illusion. It is clear from the examples that the meaning which can be created through matchings is varied and not necessarily of a different order from that of syntax and semantics – except of course that it is quite local, and is created on the instant of reading by the total environment.

One important feature of visual illusions such as line distortions is that the perceiver can convince himself intellectually that a line is straight, by measurement for example, but still cannot *see* it as straight when it is placed in a distorting environment. The presence in literary texts of similar but separate ordering devices may lead to 'distortions of meaning'.

The examples of deviation and matching have been predominantly syntactical, but the vocabulary of a language allows similar effects, though less accessible to description at present.

Deviation in vocabulary is unusual collocation, where words occur together that we do not normally associate. This phenomenon is the basis of many literary figures, which may combine with syntactical ones to make complex effects. In the McCaig quotation above

a ruined chain lies reptile

there is a lexical interest as well as the unusual syntax. *Ruin* and *chain* might have general medieval collocations, but *reptile* is unexpected in that environment.

The lexical equivalent of matching is the familiar thesaurus organisation, particularly the development of that known as structural semantics.[5] Word meanings can be analysed in terms of relations like synonymy, hyponymy, and antonymy, and the occurrence of related words in literary text can create a similar effect to the syntactic matching relations. Another line from Pope's *Arbuthnot* is sufficient to demonstrate:

> If Foes they write, if Friends they read me dead (line 32)

The lexical matching patterns, with supporting alliteration, balance exactly, and they isolate the last word most strikingly. The syntax is deviant also, so the last two words are unexpected.

## 9.5 Idiom

The syntactic way of understanding language is through assumptions about the choices that lead up to the final text. Text is evidence of routes through choice networks, and, in that sense each linguistic item is independently selected, according to a known and completely general set of rules. The definite article selects a route as shown in Figure 9.2.

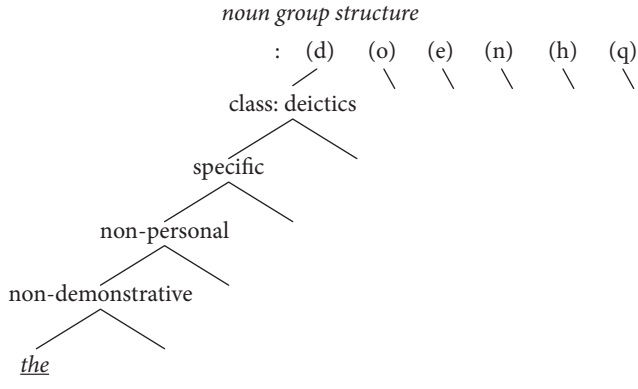


**Figure 9.2** Definite article network

The progressive narrowing down of classes is also a progressive accretion of elements of meaning, and the grammatical value of an item is the total record of its choice pattern. (This statement is generally correct whether or not it is supposed

5. See particularly Lyons, J. 1963. *Structural Semantics*, Oxford.

that all choices originate in deep structure and predetermine the route to an item.) In the complexity of syntactic networks lies the main organising power of language.

We are also, however, aware of another type of organisation that involves the same linguistic items, and that can roughly be called idiom. In this type, a single unit of meaning is realised by several items in sequence, not always contiguous and constrained in their variation by rules of a highly specific nature (Figure 9.3).

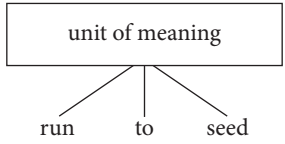


**Figure 9.3** Idiom
(Notes: *run* can be inflected fully; *to* and *seed* are fixed; sequence is fixed; members of the adverb class including *completely utterly quite* can occur between *run* and *to*, but nothing else can.)

This is a very different process from the typical syntactic one, and may even be considered opposite to it. One characteristic of syntax is that it allows for each utterance to be novel and original, because of the enormous range of combinations of a large number of small elements. In our ordinary language experience, it is a superior stratagem to assume that a sentence is new, than to search for whether one has encountered it before. Idioms, clichés and the like are pre-packed language, within which the apparent syntactic signals serve purely to identify the item. They are like letters in words rather than words in sentences, and by pre-empting syntactic choice they reduce the information content of comparable passages.[6]

The task of understanding a text is complicated by having two opposite principles of interpretation available, and in literary texts this tension can be exploited in several ways. One major technique is to create idioms within a text, by repetition in various environments. Refrains, as well as their regular position, can gather text-dependent meaning in this way. The phrase *honourable man* in *Julius Caesar III*. 2 is a famous example. Recurring several times in the early part of Mark Antony's series of speeches, it becomes a jeer taken up by the crowd.

> *Fourth Plebeian:* They were Traitors: Honourable men?

Another productive technique is akin to punning but whereas the pun contrasts alternative meanings, this contrasts idiom and syntax. The idiom *make free (with)*, meaning 'take liberties with' has come a long way from the early English meaning

6. See Makkai, A. 1972. *Idiom Structure in English*. The Hague: Mouton, for a thorough account.

of *free* "not in bondage". Vachel Lindsay, in "General William Booth Enters Into Heaven" writes (stanza 2)[7]

> Hallelujah! It was queer to see
> Bull-necked convicts with that land make free.

Freedom from sin, from the world, etc. is a central theme in the poem and in the evangelism it mimics. The convicts being made free requires that *free* is understood in the sense 'no longer in prison'. The convicts playing havoc at the Pearly Gates requires the idiomatic meaning.

This effect often involves a slight deviation, to draw attention and make the idiom analysable. In the example above, the word-order is odd because *with* doesn't normally precede *make free*.

The popular game of literary echo comes under the general heading of idiom, though it has a wide range of applicability. "The Waste Land" is a monument to echo, and in a modest way the Lindsay poem uses a line from evangelist cliché to telling effect.

Lines 2 and 4 of the first stanza are:

> [Are you washed in the blood of the Lamb?]

Isolated by brackets, they become part of the jingle, recurring sporadically (last line stanzas 1, 2, lines 6 and 8, st. 5). Lines 6 and 7 of st. 2 are:

> Tranced, fanatical they shrieked and sang:
> "Are you washed in the blood of the Lamb?"

This further reduces the meaning of the line since it is hardly an appropriate question to ask of the angels and saints. But the last 3 lines of the poem run

> He saw King Jesus. They were face to face,
> And he knelt a-weeping in that holy place.
> Are you washed in the blood of the Lamb?

The *you* suddenly refers out to the reader, who has no doubt been enjoying the fun, and the full syntactic meaning of the line returns to it. There are no brackets or speech marks, so the reader cannot escape.

## 9.6 Reference systems and their referents

A reference is a signal at one place in a text that points to another place in the text or to the non-linguistic situation. It is up to the writer or speaker to ensure clarity

7. Text from Williams, O. (ed.). 1947. *A little Treasury of Modern Poetry*, London.

of reference, to predict the ambiguity of 'John saw Clarence and then he hit him' or 'Shut the door' when there are three open doors.

If we now turn to the famous opening of Orwell's *Nineteen Eighty-Four*, we see the normal process reversed:

> 'It was a bright cold day in April, and the clocks were striking 13.'

The first clause, to the comma, describes a normal condition of the British climate and the reader, even if the title has alerted him, assumes that the opening concerns familiar times and places and reads on. *The clocks*. Which clocks? Certainly a bright cold day in April does not entail clocks. The reader imagines perhaps a small town – perhaps nothing so precise, but some area in a known world that boasts more than one large clock. The shock of *13* is all the greater for the reader now has to extend his conventional imaginary world to include a place where clocks strike 13. Present day readers, more accustomed to 24-hour timetable may be less surprised than the original readers.

The normal meaning of *the* is that the noun it modifies is identified. *The* does not actually identify it, but the reader should be able to discover the identification fairly easily. It may be there is only one, *the moon*, or only one relevant, *the queen*, or it may refer backwards in the text, as in *the comma* above, or forward, as in *the noun it modifies*. If there is no obvious referent, the reader has to imagine one, from an assumption of shared experience.

A piece of writing could begin:

> There are many design defects in modern houses.
> For one thing, the bathrooms are too small…

Writer and reader share an assumption that modern houses have bathrooms. If the second sentence above read:

> For one thing, the cellars are often damp…

there would be a problem of interpretation because modern houses in Britain do not normally have cellars.

Hemingway starts his story "The Short Happy Life of Francis Macomber" as follows:

> It was now lunch-time and they were all sitting under the double green fly of the dining tent pretending that nothing had happened.

The reader is a long way behind, and has to construct a provisional universe in which to locate all the hints put forward by the words of reference: *it, now, they, all, the*. There is also something that has happened. The reader must reverse his normal interpretations of the references, and construct the referents in his imagination.

The process can be seen as an extension of the 'shared assumption' convention, but it is a very considerable extension, and an author is free to manipulate the shared assumptions in order to create effects, of which the opening of *Nineteen Eighty-Four* is a small example.

## 9.7 Conclusion

The features that have been outlined arise from six properties of natural language, and so are latent in the structure of every language. Non-literary texts make limited use of them, at least to the extent of contriving their neutrality – by suppressing accidental effects where the writer chooses. Literary texts can develop them into major organisations of meaning.

If we assume that a language contains limitless potential for reasonably precise expression, then the development of these stylistic features must indicate that limitless precise expression is not the aim, and that the quality of mental process necessary to create meaning through these features is an important part of the experience of literature. They are characterised by notions of ambiguity, illusion, imagination, by the intellectual and emotional involvement of the participants.

Literary criticism has kept careful study of the nature of these meanings at bay for centuries, mainly by having names for most of them. Linguistics avoids the area by claiming it isn't there, despite the evidence of informants. There must be something fundamentally wrong with theories of linguistics which offer no explanation for language texts that are held to be the highest achievements of verbal expression.

A subsidiary proposal in this chapter is that each of the six properties can be developed until it replaces or almost replaces the recognised meanings as the basic decoding process. The associated features become part of literary structure, not incidental aspects of texts. Sign-referent arbitrariness (9.2.1), when elevated to this position, elicits the genre known as concrete poetry. Proposition – exponence arbitrariness (9.2.2) can give rise to an important type of irony. Deviation taken to extremes could result in utter nonsense, but on the edges of meaninglessness some artifice is possible – for example Beckett's short story 'Ping',[8] or the offerings of Herbert Read in 'Encounter' of March 1959. The possibilities of matchings arising from derivational hierarchy are well known to formal poets. Wordsworth in 'Tintern Abbey'[9] puts considerable weight of organisation on matchings, and of course

8. In *No's Knife* London 1967, p. 166.

9. See *Lyrical Ballads*, 1798.

heroic couplet poetry is structurally dependent on matchings. Idiom is the basis of ritualistic language (or ritual is the basis of idiomatic language). The exploitation of pseudo-reference is to be found in much folk-tale, science-fiction, and other places where the author is describing a state of affairs to which the reader has access only via the text, in which normal assumptions from experience are invalid.

This chapter deals only with stylistic features of a formal kind, arising from the formal properties of language. There is a great deal of work to do to specify them in such a way that particular devices can be analysed. Then there is a need to draft a theory of verbal perception which can explain the origin of their relevance in a text, their inter-relationships and the quality of meaning that they create.

But there are two other tasks that arise from this view of literary style. One is in the area of discourse – to provide a framework for the description of situationally sensitive language in fiction. In some ways this feature is similar to that of pseudo-reference, for the features that conjure up specific types of language are simply those that are characteristic of the type, and do not evoke stylistic meaning in their normal context. But the study of discourse is growing fast, and will be able to make a profound contribution to the elucidation of style.

The other task is to press further with the basic argument of this chapter. If the rather abstract properties discussed here can be shown to give rise to style features, what about all the other fundamental properties of natural languages? A sentence is a linear linguistic structure, and so is a novel or an epic or a tragedy. It would be reasonable to suppose that many structural features of literary works are capable of fruitful description by means of extended versions of the categories of grammar, lexis and phonology.

PART III

# Style and discourse

CHAPTER 10

# Mirror for a text*

## 10.1 Introduction

This chapter is an exercise in the description of written text, using a method of description derived from the analysis of spoken discourse. The first version was written in 1981 and circulated to a small group as a draft paper.

In the summer of 1981 a team was formed at the National University of Singapore to produce materials for a course in advanced writing skills (see Kwan-Terry, Cook and Ragan, 1989). This chapter started off as a contribution to that project.

It was decided that the materials should be based on the assumption that writing is an interactive skill. No matter that it is commonly performed in isolation; the competent writer is sensitive to his readers in a similar way to a competent conversationalist. In fact it can be claimed that a writer must be even more able to work interactively than a speaker, because the writer has to imagine the reader's behaviour, while the speaker is face to face with it. Also a writer has to allow for a considerable range of readership.

Against this, the writer does not have to contend with the actual reactions of other people; his imagined readers are as docile as he wishes them to be. However, if they are too docile, the work may be marred by failure to anticipate some point that loses the sympathy of many actual readers.

## 10.2 The model

In order to give an initial shape to the matter of interaction in writing, I offered a simple and very general model, intended as an aid to composition. After the

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* This chapter appeared originally in a manuscript in 1987. In the manuscript, Sinclair writes the following acknowledgements: "I am grateful to Judith Lindley of the National University of Singapore, who selected the text that is analysed in this paper; to her and her colleagues, led by Anna Kwan-Terry, who developed the ideas into the book called *Interactive Writing*; to colleagues and students in Birmingham, particularly Pam Morgan and Adriana Bolivar, for fruitful discussion during the long gestation of this paper." The manuscript was later published in *Journal of English and Foreign Language* (1988) Hyderabad, India: 15–44.

team had used and discussed this model in planning sessions, I decided to flesh it out by turning it into a model of analysis. I worked on a text that had been selected by one of the materials writing team; it is not claimed to be either representative or extraordinary. Since the original workouts presented below in a revised form, there has been further analysis of a range of texts using essentially the same model. Although this work in no sense constitutes validation of the analytic method, it is encouraging to find that so simple and abstract a model is of some practical use.

The most extended application of the model is in Morgan (1987), where it is used as a tool for the appreciation of children's writing.

| Para No | Sentence No | Flashbacks |
|---|---|---|
| | | TANGSHAN: THE DEATH OF A CITY |
| 1 | 1 | For weeks in the winter of 1976, residents of China's north- |
| | | eastern cities were told to get ready for a major earthquake. |
| | 2 | Using information from their far-flung network of seismo- |
| | | logical stations, experts estimated a quake was likely on |
| | 3 | February 11th. As the date approached, people were told to |
| | | sleep in their clothes and to be on the lookout for strange |
| | | phenomena: chickens refusing to return to their coops, hiber- |
| | | nating snakes coming out of their holes, flashing red lights |
| | 4 | on the horizon. But the quake never came, and people soon |
| | | forgot the warnings. |
| 2 | 1,2 | That is, until July 28. On that day, at 3.42 a.m., a massive |
| | | quake registering 7.5 on the open-ended Richter scale hit |
| | 3 | Hebei Province. Lasting only 70 seconds, the tremor struck |
| | | the industrial city of Tangshan (pop. 1 million) with apoc- |
| | 4 | alyptic fury. "The entire city was destroyed", recalled Yukio |
| | 5 | Toyama, a Japanese engineer visiting the city. "Everything |
| | 6 | that was there a minute before had gone." Tall buildings were |
| | | split in two, chimneys collapsed, streets cracked open, and |
| | | tiles hailed down on the streets. |
| 3 | 1,2 | There was no time to get out of doors. For most, death came |
| | 3 | in a sudden crush of collapsing walls and ceilings. By the |
| | | time the shaking subsided, the entire city, site of impor- |
| | | tant steel, chemical and machinery factories, had been |
| | 4 | transformed into a heap of rubble. The eventual death toll: |
| | | 700,000. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 4 | 1 | At the same instant that Tangshan was being devastated, the port city of Tianjin 100 kms to the southwest felt the first |
| | 2 | shock waves. Within seconds one-third of the city's buildings had collapsed and another third were rendered uninhabit- |
| | 3 | able. The disaster left 200,000 families homeless and forever transformed the face of the historic city, third largest in |
| | 4,5 | China. In Peking, the quake was also felt. Equal in energy to 10,000 Hiroshima atom bombs, the shock reached the capital one minute after Tangshan, cracking walls, snapping electric cables, and rattling windows. |
| 5 | 1 | Barely 16 hours after the first impact, with rescue work in full swing, a second, more severe quake (Richter scale: 7.8) hit |
| | 2 | Tangshan. Over the next five days, 125 minor tremors shook |
| | 3 | the area. By the time it was finally over, an estimated one million people were dead or injured and an untold number homeless. |
| 6 | 1 | The toll would probably have been higher had it not been for China's highly efficient rescue squads whose achievements |
| | 2 | were loudly trumpeted in official bulletins. One report praised a People's Liberation Army unit for working through lunch |
| | 3 | to rescue a small girl from under a collapsed house. "Defying starvation and fatigue," the report said, "they dug her from the ruins and, cuddling her, shouted "Long Live Chairman Mao!". |
| 7 | 1 | The slogan may have inspired the soldiers, but it didn't help |
| | 2 | Mao much. Just six weeks after the Tangshan cataclysm, |
| | 3 | the Great Helmsman died at 82. To superstitious Chinese, his death so soon after the earthquake was no surprise. |
| | 4 | Traditionally, natural calamities were believed to signal the |
| | 5 | disfavour of Heaven with the ruling dynasty. Floods, earthquakes and other portents were supposed to precede the demise of the emperor. |
| 8 | 1 | To more practical minds, the Tangshan disaster had a differ- |
| | 2 | ent meaning. It showed that despite the imaginative efforts of Chinese seismologists, the science of earthquake predic- |
| | 3 | tion was still very much a hit-and-miss affair. Since 1976, the Chinese have therefore redoubled their efforts to understand |
| | 4 | the titanic forces beneath the earth's surface. Those studies, they hope, will one day enable them to forecast quakes with greater accuracy – and prepare for the next Tangshan. |

The text is presented as a complete artefact. Therefore it must have three properties:

(a) a *location* with reference to some event in the world
(b) a *meaning* deducible from internal analysis
(c) a *value* to the participants in the writing-reading discourse, to its readers.

In this case the location was indicated fairly clearly by the physical surroundings of the original format. There is a photograph immediately above the text with a caption:

> City centre before the quake. "Everything that was there a minute ago had gone"

There was a heading immediately above the title:

> FLASHBACKS

and at the top of the page is a running head:

> SCIENCE

The page is from a well established journal which has regular sections and features, so that readers can place the components of each edition into a framework of experience. The present text is thus an artefact within another artefact, in that each issue of *Asia Week* is designed as a whole, and has the properties of location, meaning and value. Within it, each separate feature, article, advertisement etc. is a small artefact with the same characteristics.

The photograph and caption provide references for some of the words and phrases in the text; they thus support the content. The feature heading *flashbacks* refers to the established practice in journalism of reviewing and re-assessing past events for the present; the heading *SCIENCE* classifies the content and aids the reader in finding a section of interest. These points suffice to locate the text.

The meaning of the text is the property which is associated with the patterns of language. Most of this chapter concerns aspects of the meaning, and beyond the limited analysis here is a mass of grammatical, lexical and stylistic detail that all constitute elements of the meaning. In this sense, *meaning* embraces matters of content, organisation and presentation of the language text.

The value of the text is the impact it has on its readers. In some way the reading of this text in its original format will have added to the experiences of its readers; their future actions, judgments and attitudes will in some way be influenced in the reading. A small journalistic piece like this is not likely to change the world perceptibly, but in whatever small way it does make an impact, its readers will ever so slightly change. The text has an impact on the writer as well, but I do not propose to elaborate on that in this chapter.

Any linguistic artefact is interpreted as being the central element in a three-part structure; the first and third parts are characteristically non-linguistic. The

first part is whatever action, state or event gives rise to an artefact – whatever the text is a reaction to. Texts are not in the main spontaneous, and in many cases their stimuli may be complex and only partially retrievable. Often there are clues in the text itself to its likely location in the world.

The third part of this structural link between linguistic and non-linguistic events is the set of actions, states and events that are occasioned by the text. Again these may be difficult to identify, and in many cases the text may only be a contributory factor. Since written text can be read indefinitely often for as long as it physically lasts, its total value can never be finally assessed; in the particular case of a weekly magazine one could divide 'current' readings from readings after the next issue has appeared.

The location and value of a text are thus found by observation of essentially nonlinguistic events; although many texts make frequent reference to the world outside, these are all provisional until the artefact is finished. Texts also frequently attempt to predetermine their own value, so that there are often clues as to the author's anticipation of the value within the language text itself.

All linguistic artefacts have these three properties. The three-part structure is reminiscent of a central structure in spoken interaction, the *exchange*, though the exchange is a minimal unit whereas the artefact is a maximal unit. In an exchange one participant makes an initiation, in which, making a large number of assumptions, he hazards an attempt to get something done. A second participant, in the simple model of interaction, reacts to this in one of two ways:

(a) he accepts the assumptions and *responds* in terms of the initiation. For example:
  A What is going to be your next move, Prime Minister?
  B I shall take further steps to reduce the money supply.

(b) he *challenges* one or more of the assumptions. For example:
  A What is going to be your next move, Prime Minister?
  B Now you should know, Robin, that no politician will give you a straight answer to a question like that.

A challenge initiates a new exchange, and the cycle begins anew. But even if, as in (a), the second participant provides a fitting response, the process is not complete, because the participants, whether co-operating or not, have not compared their separate understandings of the dyad. Working within conceptual systems which we suppose to be unique to the individual, they have each made a contribution but they have not determined the significance of this interaction. So the first participant has the option of commenting on his or her appreciation of the response. If the option is not taken up, it is assumed that the dyad is taken at its face value. If the third utterance passes without challenge, we assume that the responding participant, A, accepts the interpretation of B.

(c) A What is going to be your next move, Prime Minister?
B I shall have to take further steps to reduce the money supply.
A I see.

There are other places in the structure of spoken discourse where a three-part structure is appropriate, and we find similar patterns in written discourse. From these observations arose the suggestion of a very generalised model of discourse and text structure, applicable to both speech and writing and largely independent of the size of linguistic units beings described.

**P** stands for *posit*, whether proposing, imposing, opposing, or just positing.
**R** stands for *react* – reacting to a posit.
**D** stands for *determine* – determining the previous posit-react pair.

It is possible to represent verbal interaction as a sequence of P-R-D at various levels, arranged in a hierarchy of the following type:

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| P | (location) | P |
| R | Artefact | R |
| D | (value) | D |

The criteria for identifying P-R-D structures will differ according to the level at which the cycle is operating, and also to some extent according to the particular text. Conformity to an underlying P-R-D structure is suggested as a basis of well-formedness in texts.

## 10.3 Verb tense

In this text, working downwards, the first clues are to be found in the changes in verb tense. The primary set of choices in a finite verb group comprises:

past
present
modal

These choices refer to the form of the first (or only) word in the verb group.

The normal tense for reporting is the past, and most of the verbs in the passage are indeed past (by definition above, *past* includes the pluperfect, e.g. *had gone*, but excludes the perfect, e.g. *have gone*. Note the following variations. (Numbering refers to paragraph and sentence).

2/1 *is* (This choice is significant, but discussion of it will be deferred until at a later stage in the analysis)
6/1 *would*
7/1 *may*
8/3 *have*
8/4 *hope*
8/4 *will*

The first five paragraphs, then, are almost exclusively concerned with reporting events. Paragraphs 6 and 7 introduce some speculation through modal verbs, and Paragraph 8 changes the time reference to the present, and finally the future, through *will*.

This pattern can be interpreted within the framework proposed by Bolivar (1986). Describing the particular nature of newspaper editorials, she notes that the normal progression of the structure is:

actual events
possible events
desirable events

The text in front of us is not an editorial, but it does display this progression. Paragraphs 1–5 are a description of something that happened. Paragraphs 6 and 7 open with speculations. Paragraph 6 continues with praise for the rescue workers, and Paragraph 7 continues with a discussion of the interpretation of natural calamities. Paragraph 8 deals with how future behaviour will be improved as a result of the lessons of the earthquake.

This would suggest an initial P-R-D structure as follows:

P Paras 1–5
R Para 6
D Para 7–8

The assignment is highly provisional at this stage of the analysis; the patterns of lower units must also be examined. But there is certainly a *prima facie* case for division of the paragraphs into P, R and D.

It cannot be generalised from the success of this application either that verb tense distinctions carry clues to the highest structuring in an artefact or that the particular structuring noted by Bolivar is relevant to all or even most texts. But analysis of a wider range of texts suggests that both these features are important at the higher units of artefact description.

## 10.4 Attribution

Having explored the structures that are suggested by the choice of verb tense and modality, we now move to another criterion. This is the matter of attribution – of who is the sayer of what is said, the writer of what is written.

In a published paper, the ultimate responsibility is taken by the named author, where this is the case, and the editor and the publisher. They in turn may involve other people in the process – copy editors, layout and design executives, typesetters etc. We shall put all these together and, taking them as a constant in all such documents, move them out of the way. They do not appear in any text, and are assumed to 'aver' each and every utterance in the text. To avoid confusing them with the participants in the rhetoric of the text, I shall call the unmarked case 'text averral' – i.e. attributable only to the ultimate authorial responsibility.

Even in a first person narrative, the person referred to as 'I' is a linguistic construction, without any necessary existence outside the writing. In fiction the 'I' is specifically part of the fiction. Even in signed documents there is no necessary contact with the real world unless the signature is declared genuine. The external identification of whom the 'I' refers to is made via the signature.

In a third person narrative, there is indeed no reference to the ultimate, external author, but frequently there are attributions made to other sources of what is said or written. These are reports in the text which have the effect of transferring responsibility for what is being said. The text avers that such and such a statement was made, but is not responsible for whether or not the statement was accurate. That responsibility is passed on to the attributed speaker or writer.[1]

Within this general picture, there is a threefold distinction to be made into primary, secondary and tertiary attributions. Primary attributions contrast with the unmarked averrals of the text and so provide a kind of simulated dialogue. In the passage described here, it is only in the last two paragraphs that primary attributions are made – see Figure 10.1.

Most of the attributions here are secondary; reports of what was said or written by others, but passed on silently, the silence indicating acquiescence by the ultimate author in the reliability of the report. There can be many layers of secondary attribution, reports within reports. One instance is in 6.3. The ultimate author avers that an official bulletin reports that members of the People's Liberation Army shouted "Long Live Chairman Mao".

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1. This point is treated in some detail in Sinclair (1987a), reproduced in a revised version in Chapter 13 in this volume.

| REF | EXAMPLE | LEVEL | IDENTIFICATION | NOTES |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1.1 | were told | secondary | anonymous | passive |
| 1.2 | experts estimated | secondary | identified | |
| 1.3 | were told | secondary | anonymous | passive |
| 1.4 | forgot | | | not reporting |
| | warnings | | | not reporting |
| 2.4 | recalled Yukio Toyama | secondary | identified | official |
| 5.3 | estimated | tertiary | anonymous | |
| 6.1 | were…trumpeted | secondary | identified | official |
| | official bulletins | secondary | identified | official |
| 6.2 | one report praised | secondary | identified | refers to official |
| 6.3 | the report said | secondary | identified | refers to official |
| | they…shouted | secondary | identified | within secondary narrative |
| 7.3 | superstitious Chinese | primary | identified | |
| | surprise | | | not reporting |
| 7.4 | Traditionally | tertiary | identified | |
| | were believed | primary | anonymous | passive |
| 8.1 | more practical minds | primary | identified | |
| 8.2 | it showed | primary | identified | refers to *minds* |
| 8.3 | understand | | | not reporting |
| 8.4 | they hope | secondary | identified | refers to *The Chinese* |

**Figure 10.1** Instances of Attribution

Tertiary attribution includes all the instances of reporting and similar activities which are referred to rather than articulated in clauses. For example, contrast *estimated* in 1.2 with the same word in 5.3. In the first occurrence it is a finite verb introducing a reported statement; the statement is not controversial and so this is an instance of secondary narration. In its second occurrence it is a modifier of a number in a noun group, and the report would have to be reconstructed from detailed analysis of the sentence. There is no sentence in this text like "Experts estimated that one million people were dead….".

Tertiary attributes are noted in Figure 10.1 for the sake of completeness, so that all cases of report, indirect speech, *that* clauses, and relevant nominalisations are dealt with. Finally, words and phrases which can be used in attribution but are used in a different way in this text are also noted, as 'not reporting'. For the purposes of description, at this point only primary attribution is considered further.

Also in the matter of averral and attribution, 8.1 is clearly a primary attribution elsewhere and it is predictive of what follows through the phrase *a different*

*meaning*. The rules of prediction (Tadros, 1985) makes us expect that 8.2 has the same discourse origin as 8.1. So these two sentences constitute a P. Sentence 8.4 contains a primary attribution (*they hope*) – but placed in an unemphatic position so that it does not contrast sharply with 8.3. Hence 8.3 and 8.4 are fitting realisations of R and D at this level.

There is then a mass of different evidence for the analysis proposed. Words like *therefore* often compose a complete analytical level in a text, but since the bulk of this text is reporting, there is only one such item. The single instance comes in a typical place, in the last major component of the structure and in the R element. The choice and change of subject is a weak criterion because it is so commonplace, but it gives general support to the analysis.

We shall move backwards from the end of the text towards the beginning, taking account of the remaining attributional information.

The reactions and beliefs of traditional and supertitious Chinese, as reported in 7.3, 7.4 and 7.5 make a structure of secondary attribution.

7.3 reaction of superstitious Chinese
7.4 traditional beliefs
7.5 particular supposition

The attributions in 7.4 and 7.5 being secondary do not contrast with each other, nor with the primary attribution in 7.3. So although they give a neat pattern, it is a superficial one and we should look for another rhetorical structure that the passage carries at this point.

Like 8.1, sentence 7.3 makes a fairly clear prediction through the phrase *no surprise*. We can expect an explanation for the lack of surprise, and 7.4 gives it in a general way, referring to tradition. 7.5 is more specific, relating earthquakes directly to the death of the ruler.

This is a device of written language – a use of attribution which is strictly unnecessary, but which maintains the reader's interest through a simulation of interaction. There are further instances below. We shall leave, for the moment, more detailed description of 7.1 and 7.2, and go on to Paragraph 6.

We find that the three sentences of Paragraph 6 form a P-R-D structure based on the secondary attributions. They are introduced in a subordinate clause in 6.1, which is otherwise an instance of text averral. Sentence 6.2 is the beginning of a switch to the secondary source; it sets up the apparatus but does not actually make the report, merely summarises it. Actual quotation distinguishes 6.3, and another layer of secondary attribution through the quotation of what they shouted.

6.1 text averral
6.2 announcement of secondary attribution
6.3 quotation from secondary source

In the analysis at Figure 10.1 all the relevant instances have been retrieved from the text. Where different narrators are introduced, and there are no signals of ordinary text averral, we must in an act of interpretation decide where the narrative reverts to its unmarked state of text averral. This is a common type of textual mechanism called 'default' – a term borrowed from computer jargon.

However, an unmarked sentence can fill two functions in the default choices. It can be seen as a continuation of an attribution to someone else, or it can be seen as a reversion to ordinary text averral. There can be substantial ambiguities as a result of this.

| | |
|---|---|
| 1.1 | secondary |
| 1.2 | new secondary |
| 1.3 | secondary (revert to 1.1 attribution) |
| 1.4 | REVERT to text averral |
| 2.1 | maintain text |
| 2.2 | maintain text |
| 2.3 | maintain text |
| 2.4 | secondary |
| 2.5 | maintain secondary |
| 2.6 | REVERT to text averral |
| 3.1 | maintain text |
| 3.2 | maintain text |
| 3.3 | maintain text |
| 3.4 | maintain text |
| 4.1 | maintain text |
| 4.2 | maintain text |
| 4.3 | maintain text |
| 4.4 | maintain text |
| 4.5 | maintain text |
| 5.1 | maintain text |
| 5.2 | maintain text |
| 5.3 | maintain text |
| 6.1 | maintain text |
| | secondary within subordinate clause |
| 6.2 | secondary |
| 6.3 | secondary |
| | secondary within secondary |
| 7.1 | REVERT to text averral |
| 7.2 | maintain text |
| 7.3 | primary |
| 7.4 | primary |
| 7.5 | primary |
| 8.1 | new primary |
| 8.2 | primary |
| 8.3 | REVERT to text averral |
| 8.4 | primary |

**Figure 10.2** Attributive structure

Figure 10.2 lists all the sentences, notes primary and secondary attributions, and for those which are not marked in this way it allocates them to *maintenance* of whatever attribution is going on or *reversion* to the textual averral.

We can now apply the evidence of attribution to the discourse structure of the text. It is convenient to begin with the primary attributions in Paragraphs 7 and 8.

Sentences 7.3, 7.4 and 7.5 are taken to be attributed to traditional and superstitious Chinese, and in contrast with the authorial stance, which is not at first revealed. 8.1 and 8.2 are attributed to another group, people of more practical minds, Chinese included. The choice of *showed* in 8.2 suggests that this was a generally accepted position, and we would not expect the author to disagree with it. 8.3 reverts to text averral, and 8.4 gives a non-controversial conclusion.

We can propose a P-R-D structure as follows:

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| P | 7.1, 7.2 | death of Mao averred by the text |
| R | 7.3, 7.4, 7.5 | reactions of superstitious Chinese, etc. |
| D | 8 | reactions of more practical minds, etc. |

Within the D of Paragraph 8, we can discern a further 3-part structure as follows, bringing in a further instance of primary attribution:

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| P | 8.1, 8.2 | interpretation of those with more practical minds |
| R | 8.3 | resultant action of the Chinese averred by the text |
| D | 8.4 | future hopes of the Chinese |

The verb tenses of Paragraph 8 are consonant with this division (past, past, present/modal = *will*). The word *therefore* in 8.3 indicates a step in an argument or explanation. The subject of the main clause changes in accord with the suggested analysis. (*The Tangshan disaster/it, the Chinese, those studies*). We shall return later to Paragraphs 3, 4 and 5. Their structure does not depend on attribution and averral. We shall also leave for the moment sentence 2.1 and note the remainder of Paragraph 2. From the point of view of attribution, it divides neatly into three parts.

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 2.2 and 2.3 | text averral | P |
| 2.4 | secondary attribution, identified | R |
| 2.5 | secondary attribution, maintained | R |
| 2.6 | reversion to text averral | D |

After two sentences of text averral there is a quotation (2.4) attributed to Yukio Toyama. This is a secondary attribution because it does not contrast with the other sentences round about, even though they are instances of text averral. It introduces an eyewitness to corroborate events, and turns the narrative into a kind

of conversation where two people are cooperating in telling a story. The quotation marks and the attribution could however be omitted without losing coherence, because there is no change of position. The attribution is largely cosmetic, and occurs within the narrative.

Note that, as in Paragraph 6, there is a move towards detail during Paragraph 2. Hebai Province (2.2), Tangshan (2.3), the entire city, (2.4) everything that was there (2.5) and buildings, chimneys, streets and tiles (2.6). The structure 2.2 – 2.6 is part of this longer pattern, and the rest forms part of a structure that will be proposed later.

Note also with respect to this structure 2.2 – 2.6 and the one which occupies Paragraph 6 that they would not be appropriate at the end of an artefact. The third element does not so much conclude as continue, and attribution remains with a secondary source. No matter how cosmetic this attribution may be, it is structurally marked as non-final.

There remains Paragraph 1, where the first three sentences form a simple P-R-D structure. Secondary attributions show a passive in 1.1 and 1.3, with the same subject referent (residents…, people). 1.2 gives a mild contrast, with the experts estimating.

1.1 secondary attribution
1.2 new secondary attribution
1.3 previous secondary attribution

All this is P to sentence 1.4, which, although we finally interpret it as an R, has a concluding aspect that more suggests a D. This, and its position at the end of a paragraph, gives the impression of a false ending to the piece. The structural ambiguity is explained by the oddity of 2.1, in its relation to the previous sentence.

There is a clear breach of a rule of written discourse in sentence 2.1. The reader is entitled to assume that the whole piece is written from a consistent position, and that it will not change position so violently as to contradict itself in successive sentences. The statement in 1.4 "But the quake never came" is unequivocal, and is averred by the text itself; it cannot be sensibly associated with the secondary attributions of 1.1, 1.2 or 1.3. The word *never* covers the period February 11th 1976 until the date of the published article.

The short sentence 2.1 makes clear that the writer has deliberately hoodwinked the reader. He goes on to replace *never* by *July 28*. The same person at the same time could not aver both 1.4 and 2.1.

Spoken discourse has an existential quality about it. Adjustments of the type under discussion are commonplace in speech, where the utterance is good for the moment when it is uttered. In writing, it is a cheat and it has to be very sparingly used to avoid a loss of credibility in the text.

The phrase used to mark the changed posture of the writer's averral is *That is*. It was noted above that a present tense verb is used, though the phrase is so conventional that it hardly counts as the main verb in a clause. But in passing we may note that this adjustment of the discourse refers to the moment of reading, as the discourse unfolds in front of the reader. An alternative phrase is *that is to say*, where the verb *say* underlines that this is tinkering with the discourse *in progress*.

At this point, before taking up another analytic criterion, we shall review the state of our description in Figure 10.3.

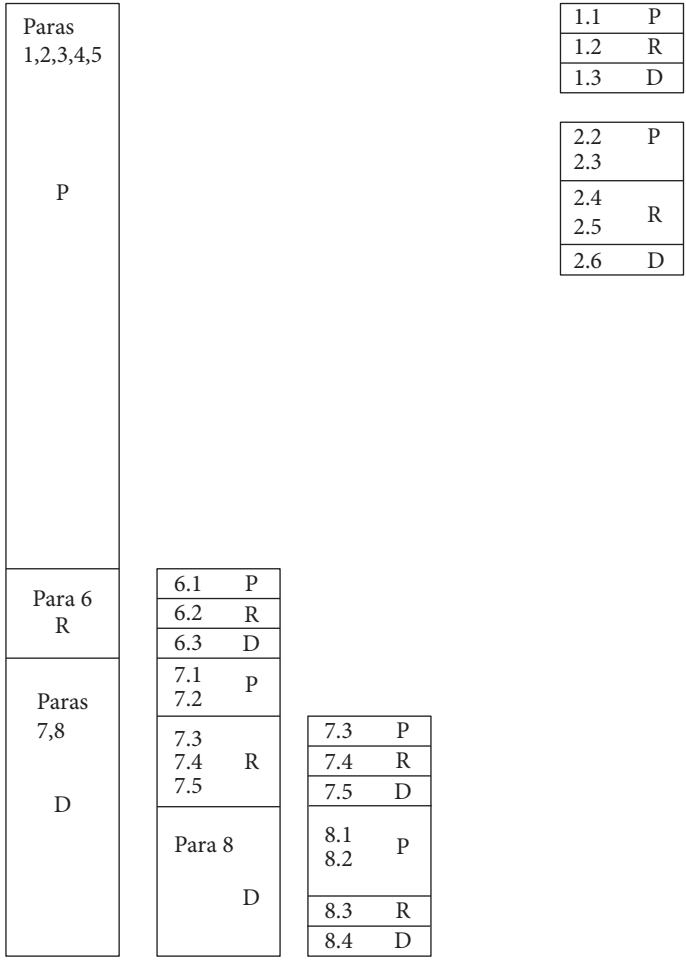



**Figure 10.3** Partial analysis (*Continued*)

| *Ref* | Element | Criteria | Category |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1,2,3,4,5 | P | simple past tense | story |
| 6 | R | modal verb | consideration of story |
| 7,8 | D | modal verbs<br>present tense | determination of story |
| 6.1 | P | text averral | story start |
| 6.2 | R | announcement of<br>secondary attribution | change of story teller<br>step down in detail<br>– event |
| 6.3 | D | secondary attribution<br>quotation | step down in detail<br>– event |
| 7.1<br>7.2 | P | text averral | associated event |
| 7.3<br>7.4<br>7.5 | R | secondary attribution | one reaction |
| 8 | D | new secondary attribution<br>coincides with text | |
| 7.3 | P | primary attribution | subjective statement<br>– prediction |
| 7.4 | R | anonymous primary | explanation in<br>fulfilment of prediction |
| 7.5 | D | anonymous primary | step in detail<br>– explanation |
| 8.1<br>8.2 | P | primary attribution<br>past tense verb | subjective statement |
| 8.3 | R | revert to text averral<br>change to present tense<br>verb argument adjunct<br>*therefore* | explanation |
| 8.4 | D | secondary attribution<br>modal future verb | future projection |
| 1.1 | P | secondary attribution | statement |
| 1.2 | R | new secondary<br>attribution | step down in detail<br>– time |
| 1.3 | D | revert to original<br>sec. attribution | step down in detail<br>– content of 1.1 |
| 2.2<br>2.3 | P | text averral | story start |
| 2.4<br>2.5 | R | secondary attribution<br>quotation | change of story teller<br>story result |
| 2.6 | D | revert to text averral | original story teller<br>story result |

**Figure 10.3** (*Continued*)

## 10.5 Integration

From the study so far, an *ad hoc* strategy of interpretation is emerging to give structure to passages that seem to be somewhat weakly distinguished – though we have not marshalled by any means all of the evidence.

We anticipate, or *prospect* a 3-part structure similar to the structure of conversation. This influences the way in which we interpret the linguistic patterns, and allows us to assign significance to them tactically. This may sound a bit like stacking the cards in one's favour, but language text has such opportunities for ambiguity that only the imposition of a strong interpretive strategy is likely to be successful.

In the general case, we encounter a sentence (1) and provisionally decide that is all or part of a P element of structure. The next sentence (2) is therefore either a continuation of the P or the beginning of R. Let us assume that it is interpreted as a continuation of P. In that case we must now re-examine sentences 1 and 2 along with 3, looking for a criterion which will suggest a P-R-D pattern which is subsidiary to the P which may include all of 1, 2 and 3.

Now let us assume that the decision about sentence 3 is that it does not support the hypothesis. Sentences 1 and 2 constitute a P and we should look into their particular relationship. Sentence 3 is the beginning of R.

Meanwhile sentence 4 is considered as either a continuation of R or the start of D. If it is thought to continue R, then sentences 3, 4 and 5 get the same treatment as sentences 1, 2 and 3, that is, they are examined to see if there is a case for a subsidiary P-R-D structure.

Some but not all of this interpretation is linear. While we know that people do not read in a straight line, but jump back and forth, it is also significant that signals of a possible change in text posture often come at the beginning of a sentence, especially when they are not always finally interpreted as being postural.

'Posture' is a useful concept in our interpretation. The comparison of one sentence with the next yields evidence of changes in orientation of different aspects. Some seem to be fairly minor, others seem to be quite dramatic, like 2.1. This evidence is partial and often inconclusive. Alongside it we place the predictive power of a hierarchical PRD model, and thus put syntagmatic and paradigmatic evidence together. In many cases a change in posture is then interpreted as a signal of a boundary between P and R, R and D, or D and a new P.

## 10.6 Time

To proceed with the analysis, we shall consider the time expressions in the passage. In Figure 10.4 they are listed, with systematic notes on their position and content type:

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1.1 | For weeks in the winter of 1976 | initial | duration |
| 1.2 | on Feb. 11 | non-initial | point |
| 1.3 | As the date approached | initial | duration until |
| 1.4 | never | non-initial | general |
| 1.4 | soon | non-initial | duration until |
| 2.1 | Until July 28 | non-initial | duration until |
| 2.2 | on that day | initial | point |
| | at 3.42 a.m. | initial | point |
| 2.3 | lasting only 70 seconds | initial | duration |
| 2.6 | a minute before | non-initial | point (relative) |
| 3.1 | no time | non-initial | general, complement |
| 3.3 | by the time (subordinator) | initial | duration until |
| 3.4 | eventual | non-initial | duration until modifier |
| 4.1 | at the same instant | initial | point (relative) |
| 4.2 | within seconds | initial | duration |
| 4.3 | forever | non-initial | general |
| 4.5 | one minute after Tangshan | non-initial | point (relative) |
| 5.1 | Barely 16 hours after the final impact | initial | point (relative) |
| 5.2 | Over the next five days | initial | duration |
| 5.3 | By the time it was finally over | initial | duration until |
| 7.1 | Just six weeks after the Tangshan cataclysm | initial | point (relative) |
| 7.3 | so soon after the earthquake | non-initial | point (relative) |
| 8.2 | still | non-initial | duration |
| 8.3 | Since 1976 | initial | duration from |
| 8.4 | one day | non-initial | point future vague |

**Figure 10.4** Time Expressions

Paragraph 5 is characterised by a sequence of initial time adjuncts:

5.1 point time
5.2 duration
5.3 terminal

This pattern is also discernible in Paragraph 4, and on a bigger scale in the long Section 2.2–3.4. Paragraph 5 is thus the third and last time that this structure is used; it is naturally brief and simple as a summing up of the passage so far and the end of the simple narrative, the end of the largest P element. Details are no longer necessary. The first quake is recounted in 15 sentences, the second – more severe – in one sentence and another 125 tremors are dealt with in a single short sentence.

Paragraph 1 shows a different picture. The initial adjuncts of 1.1 and 1.3 are both durational, and, contrasting with the point time in 1.2 give a minor sequence duration – (point) – duration until. This reinforces the rather weak suggestion of a PRD structure already made on grounds of attribution and the alternating subject

of the main clauses. So three separate syntactic/rhetorical features identify 1.1–1.3 as a P-R-D structure, and because the third sentence returns very closely to the structure of the first, we may speculate that such a structure has a different role in discourse from those where a third element is sharply distinguished from the first. The evidence is summarised in Figure 10.5.

| Feature | 1.1 and 1.3 | 1.2 |
|---|---|---|
| attribution | secondary, anonymous | secondary, identified |
| verb form | passive voice | active voice |
| topic/subject | residents/people | experts |
| timing | duration | point |
| position of timer | initial | non-initial |

**Figure 10.5** Comparison of sentences 1.1, 1.2 and 1.3

We can characterise 1.1–1.3 as generally durational in its time reference. In contrast 1.4 is very general, and 2.1 is a specific date. Although the time expression is non-initial, the rhetorical thrust of 2.1 is exclusively to contrast this precise point time with the generalities of *never* and *soon*. Hence another P-R-D structure based on timing.

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 1.1, 1.2 and 1.3 | P | duration |
| 1.4 | R | general |
| 2.1 | D | point time |

This is reinforced by other indications of changing posture. *But* at the beginning of 1.4 always signals change, and *That is* has already been commented on. *People* is the general subject of 1.1–1.3, and *the quake* is the leading subject of 1.4. Sentence 2.1 has no subject. Once again we observe a convergence of different strands of evidence to support this structural interpretation.

After this point, initial timing is more sporadic, and combines with other features to indicate the P-R-D structure. The remainder of Paragraph 2 (2.2–2.6) has already been divided on the evidence of attribution, and sentences 2.2 and 2.3 form the P-element. They both also have initial time adjuncts, which the other sentences do not have.

In Paragraph 3 there is only one initial time element, in sentence 3.3. The conjunction *by the time* is appropriate to a D-element, which indeed will be proposed for it below.

The first two sentences of Paragraph 4 have initial timing, but unlike 2.2 and 2.3 they show the story progressing, and therefore are assigned P and R respectively, with 4.3 being the D-element. The episode of what happened to Tianjin is covered in 4.1–4.3, whereas the same episode in relation to Tangshan occupies

the whole of Paragraphs 2 and 3; hence the structural features at different levels of analysis.

This concludes the examination of time adjuncts. The analysis is now as given in Figure 10.6.

There are a few initial adjuncts which are not to do with timing. In 4.4, *In Peking* is a point place adjunct, and in 4.5 *Equal … bombs* the front placing gives dramatic prominence to an adjunct of dimension. These two sentences remain outside any P-R-D structure, and we shall return to them.

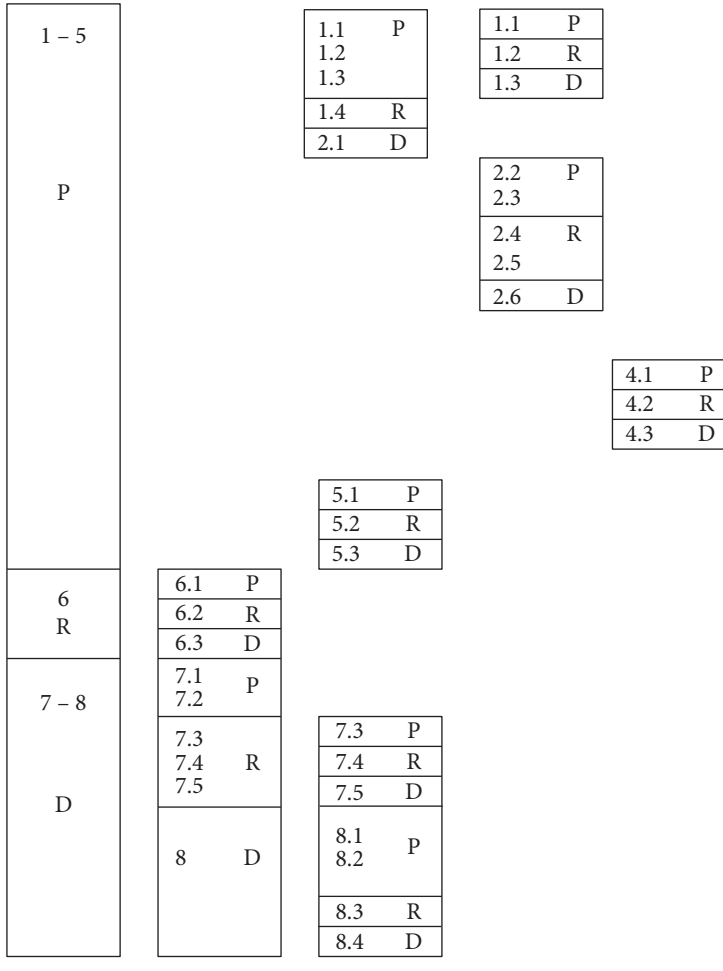



**Figure 10.6** Partial Analysis incorporating Time Expressions (*Continued*)

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1.1<br>1.2<br>1.3 | P | Initial time expressions: duration | narrative progression |
| 1.4 | R | general relational time expressions<br>argument adjunct: *but* new subject | conclusion<br>change perspective |
| 2.1 | D | initial time expression: duration until<br>argument expression: *that is*<br>present tense verb | narrative conclusion<br>reorientation |
| 1.1 | P | (secondary attribution)<br>initial time expression: duration | (statement)<br>narrative |
| 1.2 | R | (new secondary attribution)<br>point time expression<br>new subject | (step down in detail<br>duration to point<br>time |
| 1.3 | D | (revert to original secondary<br>attribution) initial time expression<br>- duration until original subject | (step down in detail)<br>narrative conclusion |
| 2.3 | P | (text averral)<br>initial time expressions: point | (story start)<br>narrative progression |
| 4.1 | P | initial time expression: relative point | narrative progression |
| 4.2 | R | initial time expression: relative duration | narrative progression |
| 4.3 | D | initial time expression: duration unitl | narrative conclusion |
| 5.1 | P | initial time expression: relative point | narrative progression |
| 5.2 | R | initial time expression: relation duration | narrative progression |
| 5.3 | D | initial time expression: duration until<br>(otherwise as in Figure 3) | narrative conclusion |

**Figure 10.6** (*Continued*)

## 10.7 People

The remaining initial adjunct is *for most* (3.2). This makes prominent a curious feature of the central story in Paragraphs 2–5; the absence of direct reference to people. Before, in Paragraph 1, there are *residents*, *experts*, and *people* twice. At the very end there is the phrase *one million people dead* (5.3). After that the text is full of people. But between 2.1 and 5.3 only the lone Japanese naked in 2.4 appears as a person, and he is presented as a commentator rather than a participant.

How, then, are mentions of people avoided? In some cases, the word *city* or the name of a city is used (though the city can also mean the buildings). A word like *people* is absent when it can be taken for granted, like after very large numbers preceded by *pop.* or *death toll*. The absences in 3.1 and 3.2 are a little more subtle. Figure 10.7 summarises the evidence:

2.2 Hebei Province (the verb is *hit*)
2.3 The industrial city of Tangshan population 1 million (the verb is *struck*)
2.4 the entire city
3.1 syntax – absence of mention of *who* should get out of doors
3.2 For most (absence of noun = people)
3.3 the entire city
3.4 the eventual death toll: 700,000
4.1 Tianjin (the verb is *felt*)
4.3 200,000 families
5.1 Tangshan (the verb is again *hit*)

**Figure 10.7** References to People in Paragraphs 3, 4, 5

The special feature of Paragraph 3 is that it is all about people and how large numbers of them died, yet there is no actual mention of any of them. This distinguishes Paragraph 3 from Paragraph 2, which is mainly about the quake and its physical manifestations, and Paragraph 4 which returns to the same sort of description. Consequently Paragraph 3 is offered as a P-R-D structure in itself.

| | |
|---|---|
| 3.1 | P |
| 3.2 | R |
| 3.3, 3.4 | D |

## 10.8 Narrative

The analysis presented so far is patchy. Paragraphs 1.5 have been identified as the main narrative, and the story proper is seen to begin in 2.2, after the smoke screen of Paragraph 1. Within the section starting in 2.2 there is a repeated 3-part pattern, approximately as follows:

| | |
|---|---|
| P | timing and placing the event, and briefly identifying it. |
| R | some details about the progress of the event |
| D | a concluding statement |

This pattern fits 2.2 – 2.6, 3, and 4.1–3. It also nearly fits Paragraph 5, except that 5.2 brings in more events rather than says more about the second Tangshan quake. This means that 5.3 can be seen as concluding not just the event of 5.1 but the whole sequence of events that started in 2.2. Paragraph 5, then, makes a suitable D-element to the narrative section as a whole. The following structure is proposed:

| | |
|---|---|
| 1, and 2.1 | P-element, setting the story |
| 2.2–4.5 | R-element, the main narrative |
| 5 | D-element, the conclusion of the narrative |

Within the R-element, the story proper, we can propose a structure which intervenes between this level of analysis and the more detailed matters, close to sentence level, which have already been put forward.

The intervening structure follows the paragraphing, with the exception of sentence 2.1, which has already been shown to be exceptional. Paragraph divisions are part of the evidence; like other linguistic features they are available as indications of changes in posture, at an intermediate level of structuring, but they may not always be used as such.

Sentences 2.2–2.6 tell the story of the earthquake hitting Tangshan. Paragraph 3 tells the same story, but from another perspective – the effects on people and their work places. Note that the *buildings* of 3.6 have become *factories* in 4.3.

Paragraph 4 puts the Tangshan story into another perspective – what happened to other places hit by the earthquake. The details are not repeated, and we have to transpose what has been said about Tangshan to Tianjin and, with adjustments, to Peking.

A P-R-D structure is therefore proposed as follows:

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| P | 2.2–2.6 | the Tangshan story |
| R | 3 | another perspective on the story |
| D | 4 | the rest of the story |

Notice that 'the story' has been identified at several different levels.

| | |
|---|---|
| Paras 1–5, | P |
| 2.2 – 4.5, | R |
| 2.2 – 2.6 | P |

As an 'event', rather than a story, we can add

| | |
|---|---|
| 2.2 – 2.3 | P |

Sentence 2.2 states the whole event, which serves as topic until the end of Paragraph 5. Sentence 2.3 concerns Tangshan only, and serves as topic until the end of Paragraph 3.

## 10.9 Mopping up

Reviewing the analysis to date, we have suggested a 3-part structure for a number of segments of text each containing three or more parts. There remain a number of two-part leftovers which we shall consider, or reconsider, sequentially in the text.

It should not be supposed that because of the a priori assumption of a three-part structure, these pairs are bound to be anomalous or defective. Some may be, but we must also expect the language to find some uses for two-part structures.

(a) Sentence 2.3 is a rewrite of 2.2, forming a fairly clear parallel structure

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| on that day at 3.42 a.m. | a massive quake . . . . . Richter scale | hit | Hebei Province |
| Lasting only 70 seconds | the tremor | struck | the industrial with… city of Tanghsan |

It seems reasonably in line with juxtaposition, apposition and co-ordination that two sentences as similar as this could jointly realise one element of structure.

(b) Sentences 2.4 and 2.5 are also close, within the quote marks

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| the entire city | was | destroyed |
| everything that was there a minute before | had | gone |

By the same reasoning as in (a) above, we allocate these together as forming a single element of structure with the introductory phrase outside the quotations.

By recognising such structures, we abandon the notion that all text at all levels aspires to the 3-part PRD pattern. Hence it is important to keep track of the circumstances under which this takes place.

i. it is available for pairs left over after a thorough PRD analysis
ii. the pairs are of the smallest unit of analysis, in this case the sentence
iii. the propositions realised by the sentences are almost identical
iv. the surface structure and sequence of elements of the two sentences are very similar

(c) Sentences 3.3 and 3.4 form a pair realising a D-element but in this case the connection between them is not straightforward. The propositions are not alike, nor are the sentence structures.

We must refer back to the peculiarity noted in Paragraph 3 in order to find a reason for justifying this analysis. It was pointed out above that the paragraph is mainly about people, but is ostensibly about walls, factories and rubble. Sentence 3.3 is a suitable match for the superficial patterning of 3.2 and sentence 3.4 is a suitable conclusion to the underlying subject matter.

It may be felt that this argument does not give sufficient justification for the analysis, and that there remains a feeling of clumsiness or ill focus about Paragraph 3. Other analyses are possible, for example:

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2.2 | P | | |
| | | 2.3 | P |
| | | 2.4 | R |
| | | 2.5 | |
| 2.3–3.3 | R | 2.6 | D |
| | | 3.1 | P |
| | | 3.2 | R |
| | | 3.3 | D |
| 3.4 | D | | |

The shape of this structure, with an R which is seven sentences long as against P and D which are one sentence each, is unlikely; also it crosses a paragraph boundary. Furthermore, the death toll in 3.4 refers only to Tangshan, which is introduced in 2.3 and not in 2.2; the end of the story begun in 2.2 is not made explicit. Hence the original analysis is to be preferred.

The discussion of alternatives is one of the most important processes associated with this analysis. Since the P-R-D structure is very simple and very abstract, it is only of general guidance in analysis, and we must not expect all text to slip easily into that structure. But it does focus attention on why some stretches of text do so easily, and others do not; why some of the analytic proposals are unsatisfactory and why in some cases the analysis cannot be made to fit.

If problems arise in the analysis of passages which seem utterly straightforward, even on close inspection, then doubt must be raised about the relevance of the analytic system; if on the other hand it frequently happens that a doubtful analysis correlates with a subjective impression of confusion or lameness or flawed structure, then the analysis is to that extent supported.

(d) Sentences 4.4 and 4.5 finish the geographical angle of the story, but do not provide us with any kind of summing up. No notes of casualities, or heaps of rubble. This structure lacks a D element, and the passage would have been improved by it. This is a case where one might easily get an impression of weakness of structure and wandering, and the P-R-D analysis offers an explanation of how this impression arises.

The analysis proposed here emphasises the lack of a concluding element also at a higher level of structuring. Paragraph 4 as a whole divides into two, with sentences 4.1–4.3 concerning Tianjin, and 4.4–4.5 about Peking. That finishes the geographical agenda, but there is no final sentence to tell us, for example, what other places were badly hit. "Hardly any town in the North East of China escaped" would suffice. From the above arguments a strong case is made for Paragraph 4 being defective. The reader must judge whether there is a D element missing on either or both levels.

(e) Sentences 7.1 and 7.2 are left over from the P-R-D analysis and constitute a different kind of problem. Essentially we are tempted to suggest that for once in this analysis we divide a sentence into two elements of structure. 7.1 is so clearly in two halves, and *but* is the ideal divider. It is a transitional sentence between one state of the text and another, and each of its halves does a distinct job. It thus makes a neat P-R-D cycle with 7.2

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 7.1 | (1st half) | conjecture about inspiration of soldiers |
| 7.1 | (2nd half) | contrast of soldiers and Mao – prediction of reason |
| 7.2 | | point time adjunct<br>announcement of Mao's death |

It is ultimately a convenience to preserve the sentence boundary. Instances of this kind of proposal should be rare; we should expect the discourse structure to respect sentence boundaries as well as paragraph boundaries. It is to be hoped that further analytic experience may lead to clues as to when it would be proper to split a sentence, and when not (see Tadros, 1985).

(f) The last couple are 8.1 and 8.2. These make a typical Tadros predictive structure which is a two-part structure and an occasional alternative to P-R-D structures.

The complete analysis is to be found in Figure 10.8.

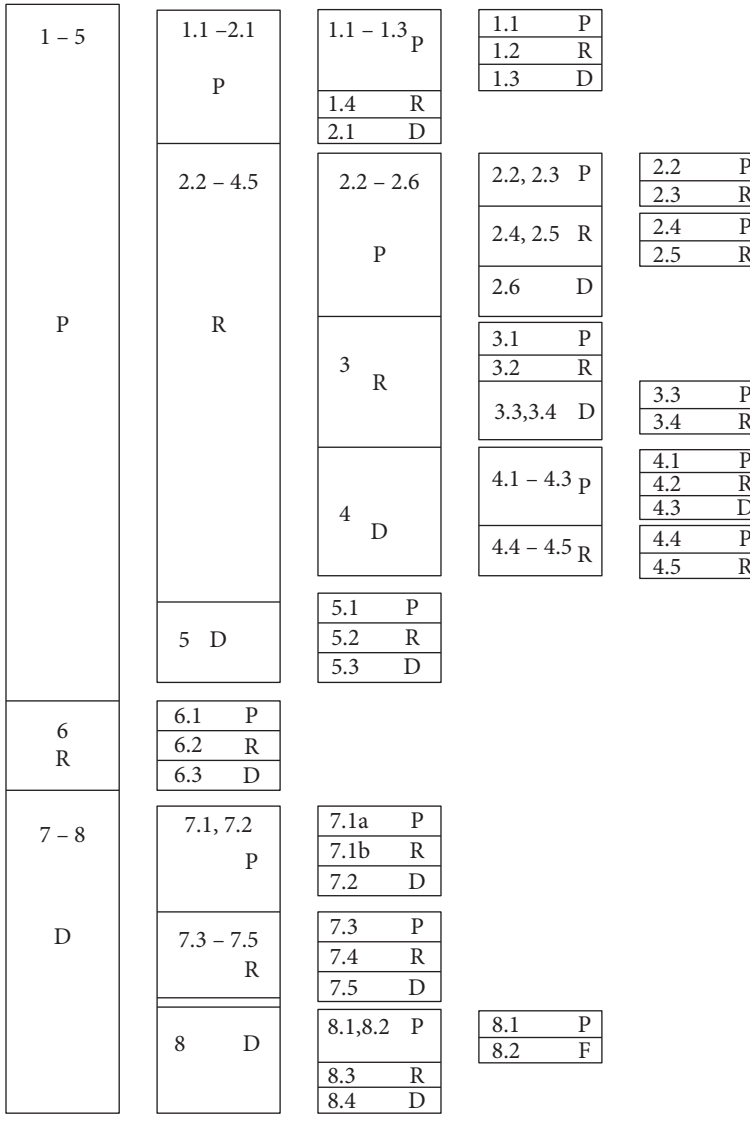
## 10.10 Conclusion

The idea of searching for an analysis of written text as interaction – or as quasi-interaction – arises on good theoretical grounds. The 3-part basic model suggested here is modelled on exchange structures in spoken language (Sinclair & Coulthard, 1975) and is very abstract; its accuracy is not critically tested by applications of the type presented here.

The style of analysis, in any case, is not intended to lead to definitive results. Rather, it accepts that much text is not very well written, and that some is defective by any standards. It offers a systematic way of discussing text structure, with an inbuilt bias towards the kind of structure that seems to be the underlying norm.

The 3-part structure is robust and pervasive; the contrast between the third element and the preceding two allows the discourse to progress overtly – to reach a new position in the light of what has just been said.

If writers do not always conform to it, or to the 2-part structures that are also recognised, it is nevertheless a valuable pattern for the teaching of writing. Student efforts can be examined in the light of P-R-D analysis (Morgan, 1987) and can be




| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Outermost Layer*: | | Whole artefact | |
| 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 | P | Simple past tense | story |
| 6, | R | modal verb | consideration of story |
| 7, 8 | D | modal verbs<br>present tense | determination of story |

**Figure 10.8** Final Analysis (*Continued*)

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Second Layer*: | | Story analysis, and reactions | |
| 1.1–2.1 | P | prominent time expressions<br>passive verbs<br>change from past to present tense | story setting<br>– false start |
| 2.2–4.5 | R | prominent time expressions<br>active verbs<br>maintenance of past tense | main narrative |
| 5 | D | prominent time expressions<br>– duration until<br>active verbs<br>past tense | extra story<br>– conclusion |
| 6.1 | P | text averral | story start |
| 6.2 | R | announcement of<br>secondary attribution | change of story teller<br>step down in detail |
| 6.3 | D | secondary attribution<br>quotation | step down in detail<br>– event |
| 7.1<br>7.2 | P | text averral | associated event |
| 7.3<br>7.4<br>7.5 | R | secondary attribution | one reaction |
| 8 | D | new secondary attribution<br>coincides with text averral | |
| *Third Layer*: | | averral, prediction, etc. | |
| 1.1–1.3 | P | initial time expressions:<br>duration | narrative progression |
| 1.4 | R | general relational time expressions<br>argument adjunct *but*<br>new subject | conclusion<br>change perspective |
| 2.1 | D | initial time expression: duration until<br>argument expression: *that is*<br>present tense verb | narrative conclusion<br>reorientation |
| 2.2–2.6 | P | topic: Tangshan | the central narrative |
| 3 | R | topic: people (hidden) | another perspective |
| 4 | D | topic: Tianjin, Peking | associated information |
| 5.1 | P | initial time expression:relative point | narrative progression |
| 5.2 | R | initial time expression:relative duration | narrative progression |
| 5.3 | D | initial time expression:duration until | narrative conclusion |
| 7.1a | P | modal verb | conjecture |
| 7.1b | R | simple past tense verb<br>argument adjunct *but* | contrasting assertion<br>– subjective judgment |
| 7.2 | D | initial time expression – point | narrative statement |

**Figure 10.8** (*Continued*)

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 7.3 | P | primary attribution | subjective statement – prediction |
| 7.4 | R | anonymous primary | explanation in fulfilment of prediction |
| 7.5 | D | anonymous primary | step in detail – explanation |
| 8.1, 8.2 | P | primary attribution<br>past tense verb | subjective statement |
| 8.3 | R | revert to text averral<br>change present tense<br>verb argument adjunct<br>*therefore* | explanation |
| 8.4 | D | secondary attribution<br>modal future verb | future projection |
| *Fourth Layer*: | | story details | |
| 1.1 | P | secondary attribution | statement |
| 1.2 | R | new secondary attribution | step down in detail – time |
| 1.3 | D | revert to original sec. attribution | step down in detail – content of 1.1 |
| 2.2–2.3 | P | text averral | story start |
| 2.4–2.5 | R | secondary attribution quotation | change of storyteller<br>story result |
| 2.6 | D | revert to text averral | original storyteller<br>story result |
| 3.1 | P | absence of notional subject verb *be* | setting |
| 3.2 | R | absence of notional subject | central statement |
| 3.3–3.4 | D | initial time expression<br>– duration until<br>conclusive vocabulary e.g. *eventual* | conclusion |
| 4.1–4.3 | P | topic: Tianjin | extra story |
| 4.4–4.5 | R | topic: Peking<br>initial dimension expression | extra story – another persepective |
| [NB no D element] | | | |
| 8.1 | P | advance labelling<br>*a different meaning* | prediction |
| 8.2 | F | explanation: *showed* | fulfilment: subjective judgment |
| *Fifth Layer*: | | minor structures | |
| 2.2<br>2.3 | P<br>R | structural parallelism | statement<br>step down in detail – event |

**Figure 10.8** (*Continued*)

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2.4 | P | structural parallelism | statement |
| 2.5 | R | within quotation marks | restatement |
| 3.3 | D | topic: buildings | first conclusion |
| 3.4 | D | topic: people (hidden) | second conclusion |
| 4.1 | P | initial time expression: relative point | narrative progression |
| 4.2 | R | initial time expression: relative duration | narrative progression |
| 4.3 | D | initial time expression: duration until | narrative conclusion |
| 4.4 | P | initial place adjunct | extra story |
| 4.5 | R | initial dimension adjunct | step down in detail – event |

[NB no D element]

**Figure 10.8** (*Continued*)

encouraged to compose in a hierarchy of such structures (Kwan-Terry et al. 1989) or to justify their departures from the norm. It is simple enough for most students to learn to visualise, and so to apply to their own work.

CHAPTER 11

# Poetic discourse

## A sample exercise*

### 11.1 Introduction

This chapter describes the main structural features of a short poem, and then considers the contribution they make to the meaning and effect of the poem. The terms of the description are those of language as *discourse*.

The choice of poem was unusual. The opportunity occurred to interest a leading writer in SE Asia, Edwin Thumboo, and he picked one of his own poems. No contact was made with him until the analysis was complete, and then a carefully structured interview focused on the following topics:

1 points of potential ambiguity (Section 11.5.5);
2 points of interpretation of the Hindu myth (Sections 11.2, 11.5.5.4, 11.5.5.6, 11.8.4).

**Krishna**

1 Before he became a god
2 To tidy up the world, Krishna
3 Searched a thousand years,
4 Along the peaks, the lesser hills,
5 Each sudden plain, persistent star,
6 The columns of his thought,
7 Down deeply anxious limbs
8 And great inclines of the heart
9 To the rim of the world at sunset…
10 Searched among the maidens of the day,
11 The maidens of the night,
12 A face for Bindavan.

13 Under her consequential sun,
14 The computations of every rising moon,

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* This chapter appeared originally in van Peer, W. (ed.). 1989. *The Taming of the Text*. London: Routledge.

15 That face grew, asserted
16 All his love, his dreams,
17 Destinations, softly magical.
18 She gazed upon him
19 With a look of morning lotus,
20 Till each stood within the other
21 So the blue god, his votive flute
22 Multiplying his love, the gopis,
23 Sporting with them all,
24 He sported with but one.

25 Perched upon a chord of time,
26 His yearning flute unfolds
27 The lovely burden of her eyes
28 To feed his nimble fingers.
29 Within the radiance of each note
30 So bound to her answering look,
31 The world revives, quickens,
32 Renews itself, turns whole,
33 Adores their love unparalleled.
34 And so they sit, ever moving,
35 Ever still, in stone,
36 In ivory, in us.

Edwin Thumboo

## 11.2 General commentary

This section is an informal commentary on the poem as a whole. Each statement arises from the consideration of the detailed analysis presented in the succeeding sections. Forward references are given, where a point is summarized.

The poem concerns Krishna, his lover or lovers, the effect on the world, and the effect on the reader (11.8, 11.9). The love relationship is permanent. The first stanza is a dramatic expression of the long and careful search that Krishna made (11.9). The second stanza tells about their developing relationship (11.5.2, 11.5.6.2), and points out that there is no distinction between a single lover and many lovers (11.8.3, 11.8.5). The third stanza concerns the typical manifestation of the myth in statuary (11.8.4), its value to the world, and particularly to the reader (11.5.5.4, 11.9).

The poem shows an alternation of predictive structuring, where the reader's attention is held because something important is yet to come, and continuative structuring, where a potentially complete structure is extended by the addition

of optional items (11.5.1, 11.5.2, 11.5.3, 11.5.6, 11.6, 11.8.1). Additionally there is no clear structure to stanzas (11.4), and the late position in the clause of continuative structures suggests that syntax does not provide the skeleton of the poetic form (11.5.1).

Meaningful units in the poem vary greatly in size, but average just under one line length (11.3.2.) Later units tend to be shorter than earlier ones, and there is a marked contrast in the two halves of stanza 3. The effect is of a quickening of pace (note the verb 'quicken' in line 31) especially in the last sentence. Whereas other runs of short units lengthen towards their end (e.g. lines 4–9, 15–17, 31–33), the units in the last sentence do not, and get very short indeed.

The poem may be interpreted structurally as, in general, preparing for its final sentence. It begins with the word 'and', which has only occurred once before (line 8). It is normal in a list like lines 3–8 for the last item to be prefaced by 'and', but the other lists do not have this feature (11.5.1, 11.9). This fact correlates with the absence of other linking adjuncts except for the concluding signal 'so' (line 21). In the last sentence is the only combination of two such adjuncts, 'and so'. It is appropriate as an introduction to the concluding statement in the poem.

The main clause subject is 'they' (11.8), which refers to the protagonists of the narrative, and their coming together in one pronoun has been heralded in a dramatic way in line 20. The verb 'sit' has a meaning which contrasts with the activity-oriented verbs that mainly occur elsewhere, and particularly those of the previous sentence. The contrast is eventually consolidated in an interpretation that the mythological story lies outside time (11.5.5.2), reminiscent of Keats's "Grecian Urn".

'Ever moving' contrasts with 'sit', and 'ever still' contrasts with 'ever moving' (11.5.6.1). When such incompatible statements occur, we seek an interpretation that resolves their incompatibility. The poem has already given us some practice in this. Line 20 implies two statements which are incompatible (11.8.5) (compare 'each was bigger than the other'), and lines 23–4 are paradoxical, but serve to resolve the lover/lovers problem (11.5.5.4, 11.5.6.1, 11.8.4).

'Ever moving' and 'ever still' form a minimal list of two items (11.5.1). They are followed by another list, consisting of two similar items ('in stone, in ivory'), and a final odd one ('in us'). Although 'in stone' and 'in ivory' do not contrast, they form a parallel pair to the preceding list, and further isolate 'in us'.

If the lovers are statues in stone or ivory, they cannot be moving. Our first level of interpretation is that a well-carved statue can appear to be alive; beyond this the incompatibility reinforces the notion of 'outside time' (11.5.5.2).

The final two words appear superficially to make a third item in a fairly trivial list (11.5.6.2), but there are surprises.

1 The word 'in' has a different meaning from 'in stone'; it can be paraphrased as 'within', where the other can be paraphrased as 'out of' (11.7.3). The contrast is sharp. There has been some earlier indication of this kind of switching, e.g. the move from literal to figurative in lines 5–6.
2 The poem in its very last syllable changes from objective narrative to subjective ('us' involves both writer and reader) (11.9). The reader is pressed to participate, but has not been warned in advance and so has to readjust his perspective of the entire poem, and to take a personal message from it.

## 11.3 Layout and punctuation

### 11.3.1 Constant features of layout

Constant features of layout are:

1 three stanzas with twelve lines in each;
2 left-alignment;
3 capital letters initial in the line.

### 11.3.2 Punctuation

#### 11.3.2.1 *Mid- and end-lines*

There is end-line punctuation in twenty-six out of thirty-six lines, evenly distributed. There is mid-line punctuation in thirteen lines. Lines which both mid- and end-line punctuation increase in frequency as the poem proceeds, and stanza 3 shows a contrast between the first half and the second half (see Figure 11.1).

0 0 0 0 0 0 1 1 0 1 1 1

1 = line has both mid- and end-line punctuation

**Figure 11.1** Stanza 3

#### 11.3.2.2 *Chunking*

We can count the number of syllables between punctuation marks, noting separately the line breaks (see Figure 11.2). Note the long chunk in stanza 1, lines 7–9, and stanza 2, lines 14–16 and 17–18.

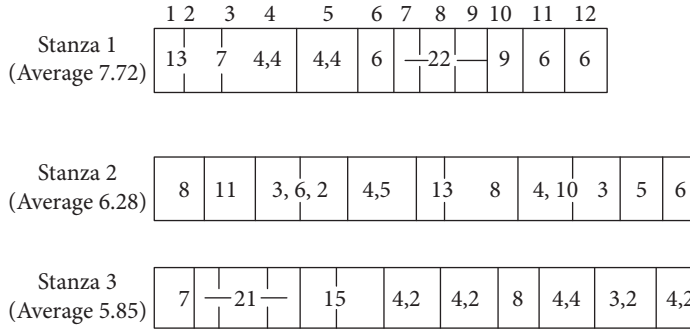


**Figure 11.2** Syllable distribution relative to punctuation. Each box represents a line. A break in the dividing line between boxes means that there is no end-line punctuation. Mid-line punctuation is shown by commas. The numbers refer to syllables between punctuation marks

Average no. of syllables in a chunk = 6.5

Average no. of syllables in a line = just over 7

## 11.4 Metrics

### 11.4.1 Line length

Line length varies between five and eleven syllables, most commonly six or eight. Stressed syllables on my reading vary between two and five per line, with a strong tendency towards three. There is no rhyme.

There is a suggestion of a stanza form, in that the last two lines of each stanza are shorter than the average, and noticeably shorter than the preceding two lines (see Table 11.1).

### 11.4.2 Commentary

Stanza and line are features mainly of layout rather than of metrical form, though lines are commonly end-stopped. There is considerable variety in the chunking, as shown by the distribution of punctuation marks.

The distribution of these features over the poem shows little patterning, but we should note:

1. the hint of stanza form in the length contrast between lines 9–10 and 11–12 in each stanza;
2. the tendency towards smaller chunks as the poem proceeds, with a marked pattern in stanza 3. The average length of a chunk in lines 25–30 is 14.3 syllables, and in lines 31–36 is 3.5 syllables.

**Table 11.1** Syllable distribution in final lines to stanzas

| | Line average (whole poem) | No. of syllables 7.11 |
|---|---|---|
| Stanza 1 | 9 | 9 |
| | 10 | 9 |
| | 11 | 6 |
| | 12 | 6 |
| Stanza 2 | 9 | 8 |
| | 10 | 9 |
| | 11 | 5 |
| | 12 | 6 |
| Stanza 3 | 9 | 8 |
| | 10 | 8 |
| | 11 | 5 |
| | 12 | 6 |

## 11.5 Syntax

The main characteristics of the syntax are as follows.

### 11.5.1 Lists

A list is defined as a replacement of a syntagmatic choice by a paradigmatic one. The syntactic structure is not developed, but instead there is a reselection of the same element of structure. The lists are shown in Table 11.2.

List I features adjuncts occurring late in the clause; the adjuncts are realized by prepositional phrases and so the major surface effect is the introduction of strings of nominal groups. List II is similar; in list III the same structures occur, but initially in the clause.

Lists IV and V feature predicators and their transitivity options. List IV moves from a second choice of predicator to three choices of nominal groups as object. List V lists predicators, moving from intransitive to transitive.

So in all the lists except III the extension occurs late in the clause structure (late means after the minimum required choices of mood and transitivity have been made).

**Table 11.2** Lists

| List | | Items | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| I | along | the | | peaks |
| | | the | lesser | hills |
| | | each | sudden | plain |
| | | | persistent | star |
| | | the | | columns of his thought |
| | down | | deeply anxious | limbs |
| | | and | great | inclines of the heart |
| | to | the | | rim of the world |
| II | among | the | maidens of the day | |
| | | the | maidens of the night | |
| III | under | her | consequential | sun |
| | | the | | computations of every rising moon |
| IV | that | face | grew | |
| | | | asserted all his love | |
| | | | his dreams | |
| | | | destinations | |
| V | the | world | revives | |
| | | | quickens | |
| | | | renews itself | |
| | | | turns whole | |
| | | | adores their love unparalleled | |
| VI | they | sit | ever moving | in stone |
| | | | ever still | in ivory |
| | | | | in us |

### 11.5.2 Arrest

Whenever an element of structure can be predicted (from normal rules of syntax) but does not occur immediately, the elements which do occur are said to *arrest* the progress of the syntax. Arresting elements can be the realizations of optional choices, or positional choices. Arrest can be initial or medial in a structure (see Table 11.3).

The last sentence of stanza 2 will be discussed below. At present we note that each stanza is initially arrested, and there is very little subsequent arrest.

The pattern of arrest is enhanced by the selection of verbs which have objects in the text, but are not decisively transitive. At this point only 'searched' in stanza 1 is relevant. In a weakly predictive fashion, the whole of stanza one apart from the last line thus has the quality of arrest.

When listing occurs in an arresting pattern, the effect of arrest is intensified, and this is found clearly in stanza 2, line 14 and stanza 3, line 30. It is called *stretch*.

**Table 11.3** Syntactic arrest

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| Stanza 1, | lines | 1–2 | Subordinate clauses arrest main clause |
| Stanza 2, | lines | 13–14 | Prepositional phrase arrests mood choice |
| Stanza 3, | line | 25 | Subordinate clause arrests main clause |
| | lines | 29–30 | Prepositional phrase and subordinate clause arrest main clause mood choice |

### 11.5.3 Continue

A label is needed for a grammatical structure which just goes on, beyond the minimal needs of a complete unit. In an earlier account (Sinclair, 1982) this category and that of *list* were together labelled *flow*; but the effect of developing a text by means of paradigmatic choices (list) is quite different from development through further syntactic choices (continue).

Clear instances of *continue* in this text are stanza 2, lines 18–23, and stanza 3, lines 26–28.

### 11.5.4 Transitivity

Continuing the point about *search* and its transitivity (made in Section 11.5.1 above) we must note:

1 there are three other verbs of indecisive transitivity at line ends:

   15 *asserted*
   26 *unfolds*
   31 *quickens*

2 there are very few decisively transitive verbs anywhere in the poem; 'adores' (line 33) is the only clear case among the finite verbs, and 'tidy' (line 2) is the only other example. The verbs 'grow' (line 15), 'multiply' (line 22), 'feed' (line 28), 'revive' (line 31), 'renew' (line 32) and 'turn' (line 32) all have an ergative quality (cf. 'He turned the wheel', 'The wheel turned') which they share with 'assert', 'unfold', 'quicken'. The other verbs in the poem are intransitive (if we overlook the rather infrequent use of 'sport' as transitive in, e.g. 'He sported a tartan tie' and 'stood' in 'He stood a round of drinks.')

### 11.5.5 Obscurity

This is not intended as a pejorative term. It covers areas of potential ambiguity, and areas where normal expectations are not confirmed. In the ambiguities, the various options are set out below with my own decisions. In poetry, it is not necessary to decide upon a particular option; more than one can be held as relevant, even if they are incompatible with each other. In some cases one's overall interpretation will assign priorities without excluding less likely possibilities.

The places which merit consideration are as follows.

#### 11.5.5.1 *Stanza 1, line 2*

'To tidy up the world'

This is a subordinate clause introduced by an infinitive, and it can be associated with the previous line, also a subordinate clause, or the main clause starting "Krishna". The question is whether we understand that Krishna became a god in order to tidy up the world, or whether Krishna searched a thousand years in order to tidy up the world. My preference, and the author's, is for the first reading. It may be significant that a comma at the end of line 1 would have tipped the balance towards the second reading.

#### 11.5.5.2 *Stanza 1, line 3*

'Searched a thousand years'

Because of the absence of 'for', it is possible to consider this as a transitive structure. Priority is given to the obvious meaning of 'searched for a thousand years', but the secondary meaning is worth attention. Someone godlike could be located outside time, and so 'a thousand years' could be the location of his search as well as the time it took.

#### 11.5.5.3 *Stanza 1, line 5*

'persistent star'

This is taken as a branched structure; read as 'each persistent star'. Alternatives, like apposition or vocative, seem irrelevant.

#### 11.5.5.4 *Stanza 1, lines 10–12*

'Searched … a face for Bindavan'

Again there is no 'for' to guide the reader, so we have several possible interpretations following structural choices. The two questions are whether 'searched' is transitive or not, and whether 'for Bindavan' is part of the noun group 'a face for Bindavan' or a separate adjunct in the clause, meaning roughly 'on behalf of Bindavan' or 'to find Bindavan'.

**A Transitive verb, final adjunct**

1 'Krishna looked all over a face on behalf of Bindavan'.

2 'Krishna looked all over a face to see if he could find Bindavan there'.

**B Transitive verb, with line 12 a single noun group**

3 'Krishna looked all over a face which was destined for Bindavan'.

**C Intransitive verb (meaning 'searched for') and final adjunct**
4 'Krishna searched for a face on behalf of Bindavan'.
5 'Krishna searched for a face to give to Bindavan'.

The fourth possibility (intransitive verb with line 12 a single noun group) does not yield a sensible interpretation.

The meaning of the A and B choices seems secondary though not entirely irrelevant; the main choice is between 4 and 5. Since Bindavan is a garden, 5 is the preferred choice, though there is a residual ambiguity centred on the meaning of 'for'.

5 (a) 'a face to stand as a symbol of Bindavan'. Krishna has a vision of Bindavan that could be matched in a face.
5 (b) 'a face that would grace the garden'.

**11.5.5.5** *Stanza 2, lines 16 and 17*

This is a branched structure capable of several interpretations depending on the branching. List IV in Table 11.2 gives one version, which I prefer; others are in Table 11.4. The author prefers list A.

**Table 11.4** Interpretations of lines 16–17

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| A all his love | B all his love | C all his love |
| all his dreams | all his dreams | his dreams |
| all his destinations | destinations | his destinations |

A list of this kind can be interpreted as a simple concatenation, each item being separate, or an appositional list, where items in that relationship have the same referent, or a mixture of both. The only likely ambiguity here is whether or not 'dreams' and 'destinations' are appositional, that is his dreams are his destinations. I am not tempted towards this meaning, nor is the poet.

This decision clarifies the clearly appositional relationship with 'softly magical'; only the destinations are.

**11.5.5.6** *Stanza 2, line 22*

'The gopis'

The gopis were milkmaids who sported with Krishna in Bindavan. Krishna is the blue god, and played a flute. So presumably 'the gopis' is appositional to 'his love', despite the clash of grammatical number; the clue is in 'multiplying', and the interpretation is supported by the paradox in lines 23–4.

The last sentence of this stanza has an unexpected syntactic form. After 'So the blue god' we would expect a verb and the remainder of what is predicted as a main clause. But it never comes, and we have to interpret 'So the blue god' as a complete main clause.

#### 11.5.5.7 *Stanza 3, line 30*

This line is a subordinate clause introduced by a past participle, and could refer either back or forwards. Is it each note (or the radiance of each note) which is so bound, or the world? My preference is for 'the radiance of each note' as referent, suggesting that the quality of Krishna's playing is enhanced by the audience reaction. As in 11.5.5.1 above, a comma at the end of line 29 would have favoured the second alternative.

#### 11.5.5.8 *Stanza 3, line 32*

In 'turns whole', 'whole' could be interpreted as complement ('becomes a unity') or adjunct ('resolves completely'). There is nothing to guide the choice; I prefer the first interpretation, and the author agrees.

#### 11.5.5.9 *Stanza 3, line 33*

'Unparalleled' could be a postmodifier of 'their love', equivalent to 'their unparalleled love'. Alternatively it could be interpreted as an adjunct in the clause, suggesting that the world's adoration was unparalleled. The first, and more straightforward version is preferred, and the syntax also echoes Shakespeare's 'lass unparalleled' (*Antony and Cleopatra*, V.ii.317). The poet confirms the interpretation and the reference.

### 11.5.6 Commentary

#### 11.5.6.1 *Parallelism*

This is a perceived surface effect, brought about by various co-selections of syntax and lexis. One type is based on a list with sufficient similarity among members of the list to invite the effect of parallelism. Lists II and VI in Table 11.2 show such an effect. In list II, the syntax is identical and the actual words are the same except for the antonyms 'day' and 'night'. List VI is in two parts, each of which also varies in just one word: 'moving' and 'still' are antonyms and the sequence 'stone', 'ivory', 'us', is one which has been explicated in Section 11.2.

Parts of lists I, IV and V show a less distinct parallelism, but in list III only the striking selections of 'consequential' and 'computations', although in different syntactic positions, suggest any parallel effect.

Another type of parallelism can occur when successive clauses incorporate lexical repetition at similar places of syntax. The only clear case in the poem is stanza 2, lines 23–4, where the pattern 'sport … with' plus the similar syntax and rhythm, and the antonym 'all-one' make the parallel obvious.

A case could be made for an indistinct parallel effect in stanza 3, lines 26, 27 and 28. Each contains a noun group of similar structure and rhythm.

#### 11.5.6.2 *Text shape*

The sentences in this poem, in general, do not have strong endings from a syntactic point of view. If the verb 'searched' in stanza 1 had been decisively transitive, then the last line would appear as a climax of a stretched syntax (list within arrest). However, the reader is certainly anticipating that the objective of the search will be identified, and the last line has a substantial effect. In stanza 2, only the last sentence is rounded off (with a two-line parallelism), and the effect of that is weakened by the unexpectedness of the main clause syntax. In stanza 3 the second sentence has an air of conclusion because the last item in the list (line 33) is twice as long as the others. In the final sentence there is a distinct tailing off, as another list concludes with a very brief item, 'in us', formed of apparently humdrum little words.

The power of the poetic form in this case is not delivered through the syntax.

## 11.6 Grammetrics

Having picked out points in both syntax and metrics, it is helpful to consider them together, to see how the syntax is distributed in line and stanza. We shall plot the state of syntax at line ends only, using the following analysis:

1 *arrest* there is a clear prediction of more to come;
2 *continue* the structure appears to be complete but continues with optional syntactic choices;
3 *complete* the structure appears to be complete;
4 *list* the structure continues with further paradigmatic choices;
5 *stretch* an already arrested structure is subject to further arrest.

This analysis is applied twice at each line end:

1 to the state of the line at its end, without looking ahead;
2 to the relationship between this line and the way the syntax develops in the next. (This is blank if line-end and sentence-end coincide).

The analysis is shown in Table 11.5. A number of points can be made, building on previous observations. The only sentences without initial arrest are the two short ones, with three lines apiece. Stanza 1 is dominated by *list*, stanza 2 by *continue*, and stanza

3 by *continue* in the first half and *list* in the second half. As noted above (11.5.4), lines 15, 26 and 31 end with a verb of indecisive transitivity and ergative quality.

## 11.7 Lexis

Unusual collocation can be grouped as follows.

### 11.7.1 First grouping

'sudden plain'
'persistent star'
'rim of the world'
'yearning flute'

This is an assortment of lively juxtapositions, each of which can be interpreted fairly easily: a low-flying aircraft encounters sudden plains after the peaks and hills but the stars are constant above. 'Rim' is an interesting substitution for 'edge' or 'end': 'yearning' is a transferred epithet.

### 11.7.2 Second grouping

'consequential sun'
'computations of every rising moon'

As well as unusual collocations, these examples each contain a long word which is usual in lyric verse and draws attention to the expressions; 'multiplying his love' is possibly a third example, and 'destinations' in a list with 'love' and 'dreams' draws some attention to itself. All these patterns are in the second stanza. Elsewhere only 'unparalleled' has more than three syllables, but it is sufficiently poetic to blend in well.

### 11.7.3 Third grouping

(Along) Each sudden plain, persistent star
The columns of his thought,
Down deeply anxious limbs
and great inclines of the heart

Perched upon a chord of time,
His yearning flute unfolds
The lovely burden of her eyes
To feed his nimble fingers.

in stone
in ivory, in us.

**Table 11.5** Grammetric structures of the poem

| | line | End-line state | Next line development |
|---|---|---|---|
| Stanza 1 | 1 | arrest | stretch |
| | 2 | arrest | complete |
| | 3 | complete | continue |
| | 4 | list | list |
| | 5 | list | list |
| | 6 | list | list |
| | 7 | list | list |
| | 8 | list | list |
| | 9 | list | complete |
| | 10 | complete | continue |
| | 11 | list | complete |
| | 12 | complete | |
| Stanza 2 | 13 | arrest | list |
| | 14 | stretch | complete |
| | 15 | list | list |
| | 16 | list | continue |
| | 17 | continue | |
| | 18 | complete | continue |
| | 19 | continue | continue |
| | 20 | continue | |
| | 21 | arrest | continue |
| | 22 | continue | continue |
| | 23 | continue | complete |
| | 24 | complete | |
| Stanza 3 | 25 | arrest | complete |
| | 26 | complete | continue |
| | 27 | continue | continue |
| | 28 | continue | |
| | 29 | arrest | arrest |
| | 30 | stretch | complete |
| | 31 | list | list |
| | 32 | list | list |
| | 33 | list | |
| | 34 | continue | list |
| | 35 | continue | list |
| | 36 | list | |

These extracts show metaphorical usage. The middle one does not contrast with literal expression, and indeed there are traces of metaphor throughout the first nine lines of stanza 3. It can be considered purely lyric despite the pun on 'chord'.

In the other two examples, a list switches abruptly from literal to metaphorical. The searching in stanza 1 is topographical at first – 'along the peaks', etc., and then without change of preposition switches to metaphor 'along the columns of his thought', and maintains this for three lines, before returning to topography in line 9.

At the end of the poem there is a small-scale pattern that is similar. A literal use of 'in' meaning 'made of' starts a list, but the third and final use of it is quite different, 'they sit in us'. The closest literal meaning is '*within*', and that has to be interpreted metaphorically just as is necessary in line 20.

## 11.8 Information structure

Table 11.6 shows one of the main patterns of information structuring in the poem. The subjects of main clauses are a grammatical reflection of 'topic'; so, for example, the fact that Krishna is prominent as a main clause subject means that a number of statements are made concerning Krishna. From the table we can take the following points.

### 11.8.1 Pattern 1

All the items which are subjects of main clauses are introduced before they occupy this position. There are two types of introduction:

1. pronoun reference forwards, anticipating the occurrence of the item (line 1, with a secondary pattern in line 11);
2. first occurrence of the item as another structural element (lines 2, 12, 26).

### 11.8.2 Pattern 2

'Krishna' is the only main clause subject of the first stanza. In the second, Krishna (as 'the blue god') and the face (as 'that face', 'she') share subject position and are combined in 'each' (line 20). In the third stanza, 'His yearning flute' and 'the world' are new subjects, and the final one, 'they', is a reference to Krishna and the face.

### 11.8.3 Pattern 3

Reference to 'Krishna' occurs frequently in non-subject position (lines 1, 6, 16, 18, 21, 22, 28) and so does reference to the face (lines 12, 13, 22, 22, 23, 24, 27, 30). 'World' has two other references (2, 32) and 'flute' one (21). The combination of 'Krishna' and 'the face' has a referent in lines 20 and 33.

### 11.8.4 Pattern 4

I have used 'face' for one of the two dominating main clause subjects, because that is its first form. However it is a complex meaning which can be singular ('that face', 'she', 'one', 'her') or plural ('the gopis', 'them'), and means more than we normally mean by 'face'. It seems to mean something closer to 'partner(s)'; the ambiguity of number

suggests that any partner represents them all. This point is important in interpreting lines 23–4, which might otherwise suggest that Krishna feigned even-handedness with his affections, but secretly preferred one girl and was constant to her.

**Table 11.6** Information structure of the poem

| Subject | Line Reference | Syntactic position |
|---|---|---|
| | 1 *he* → Krishna | subject of subordinate clause |
| | 2 *the world* → world | object of subordinate |
| | 3 | clause |
| *Krishna* | 6 *his* ← Krishna | modifier of prepositional object |
| | 12 *a face* → face | object |
| | 13 *her* ← face | modifier of prepositional object |
| *that face* | 15 | |
| | 16 *his* ← Krishna | modifier of object |
| *she* ← face | 18 *him* ← Krishna | modifier of prepositional object |
| *each* ← Krishna/face | 20 *the other* ← Krishna/face | prepositional object |
| *the blue god* ← Krishna | 21 *his* ← Krishna | modifier of subordinate clause subject |
| | 21 *his votive flute* → flute | subordinate clause subject |
| | 22 *his* ← Krishna | modifier of object |
| | 22 *love* ← face | object of subordinate clause |
| | 22 *the gopis* ← face | apposition to main clause object |
| | 23 *them* ← face | modifier of prepositional object |
| | 24 *one* ← face | modifier of prepositional object |
| *his yearning flute* | 26 *his* ← Krishna | modifier of main clause subject |
| ← his votive flute | 27 *her* ← face | modifier of prepositional object |
| | 28 *his* ← Krishna | modifier of object |
| | 30 *her* ← face | modifier of prepositional object |
| *the world* | 31 | |
| | 32 *itself* ← world | object |
| | 33 *their* ← Krishna/face | object |
| *they* ← Krishna/face | 34 | |

→ forward } { Indication of the location of the co-referential main clause
← backward } { subject

### 11.8.5 Pattern 5

Clauses which include references to both 'Krishna' and 'face' are interesting, because they relate them to each other. In lines 3, 10 and 12 ('Krishna … searched … a face') there is the first example; then a block of them in 18, 20, 23 and 24. These occurrences are all in the second stanza, on either side of the remarkable line 20:

> 'Till each stood within the other'

In other examples (lines 15–16, 21–2, 26–7) the reference is at a less important syntactic place, in the modifier of the noun group.

## 11.9 Discourse structure

The abstract, underlying pattern of human discourse has a three-part structure which we shall label

| | |
|---|---|
| **Posit** | **(P)** |
| **React** | **(R)** |
| **Determine** | **(D)** |

The structure may not be physically realized in every instance at every stratum, but it is hypothesized that we interpret discourse with reference to such a model. However large or small are the units being described, they should:

1. be analysable in terms of a P-R-D underlying structure;
2. be derived from P-R-D analysis of a superior structure in a hierarchy of the type shown schematically in Figure 11.3.

To explain Posit-React-Determine, let us assume that at any point in a discourse there are two, and only two, *participants* (one participant may be several people or may be a writer's construct like 'It is commonly held that …'). The *posit* element is something put forward by one participant which is substantially different from what has gone before. The *react* element is understood as a reaction to the posit from another viewpoint. The third element is produced by one of the participants on behalf of both of them, clarifying, concluding, evaluating, naming, etc., what has been achieved in the previous two contributions. If that is not challenged, then it stands as a determination of the unit of discourse.

The largest unit of discourse is the *artefact*, or complete text or discourse, and the smallest is approximately the *clause complex* (one main clause with its attendant subordinate clauses).

Let us work downwards in seeking P-R-D structures in this text. It is convenient that it has three stanzas, though that is not necessarily a clue to its discourse

structure. However the main clause subjects strongly support a division by stanza. The first concerns Krishna, the second concerns his relations with the gopis, and the third provides a further relationship between the lovers and the world. The identification of stanza 3 as *determining* is confirmed by the change in finite verb tense from past (lines 1 and 2) to present (line 3).

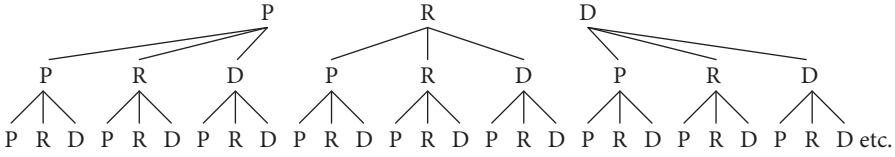


**Figure 11.3** P-R-D structures

Things cannot be done in the past, or in the future, or in a hypothetical world. They can only be done at the moment we call 'the present', and so verbal actions are normally expressed in the tense which expresses the moment of their utterance. However, the present tense in English can refer to a moment, or to a habitual or permanent state of affairs. Perhaps an initial reading of lines 26–33 will suggest a momentary event (though line 25 is a strong hint that it is not); the paradox in lines 34–5 keeps us guessing, but the 'stone' and 'ivory' of lines 35–6 refers to typical statues of Krishna and his lover, and asserts permanence.

We can expect each stanza to suggest a P-R-D structure internally, and we are not disappointed. In stanza 1, lines 1–3 introduce Krishna's search and time it; lines 4–9 place it, and lines 10–12 express its conclusion. Lines 4–9 do not have the surface structure of a clause complex, and surface grammar may well be overridden by interpretation of the discourse. This is an important technical matter, but one which would divert the main argument if pursued here.

Stanza 2 divides into three sentences, one about her in relation to him, one about her and him in relation to each other, and one about him in relation to the more complex notion of her/them. The third sentence begins with the word 'so', which marks it as a conclusion, explicating the previous pair of sentences.

The third stanza also obligingly contains three sentences, differentiated by main clause subject. The final sentence begins 'and so', signalling a determining unit. (Note that the other occurrence of 'so' in line 30 is a degree adverb and quite different). Furthermore, the last word of the poem alters the whole discourse structure, which has been entirely in the third person. The pronouns for direct verbal interaction are first and second, marking the status of the two participants at any moment of the discourse. It would be fair to say that 'us' is the least expected or predicted word in the poem. Suddenly, the author involves his readers directly.

We conclude that the poem fits well into a P-R-D model, as shown in Figure 11.4.

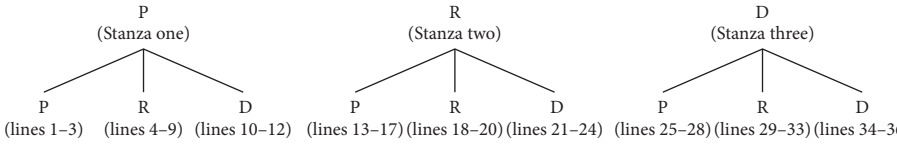


**Figure 11.4** P-R-D model of the poem

## 11.10 Final comments

The neatness of the previous section makes it important to stress that the text was not chosen by me. Elsewhere, the analytic points which are made have been selected from a fairly comprehensive study. Care has been taken to distinguish internal evidence from external, and to bring out secondary meanings which, although rejected on the grounds of the coherence of the text as it unfolds, may play a part in the overall experience of the poem. The presentation cannot avoid some repetition of observation, but it has been kept to a minimum.

If one assumes that everything in the text is there for a purpose, one finds ready confirmation either in one or other of the following.

1. In the unfolding of the poem – in mimetic effect. The search takes a long time, and it takes a long time proportionately to tell it. The reciprocal development of the lovers is reflected in the syntax of the second stanza; the contrast between time moving and standing still creeps up on us in the last stanza and is put clearly in a paradox at the end. The last, totally unexpected word drives the whole poem into a fleeting moment of direct interaction with the reader, reversing the general tendency for sentences and stanzas to end on a quiet note.
2. In the structure of the poem seen all at once; the balances, contrasts, predictions, resolutions of obscurity, etc. In particular the poem seen as a learning experience for the last sentence suggests great care in composition.

CHAPTER 12

# The exploitation of meaning*

## Literary text and local grammars

Words are like Leaves; and where they most abound,
Much Fruit of Sense beneath is rarely found

Alexander Pope, *An Essay on Criticism*

### 12.1 Introduction

It is an honour and a pleasure to give an invited talk on my first experience of PALA, and I hope you will indulge me for a few moments while I explain why I have not been here before.

When I first went to University, PALA had not been founded and there was no organisation like it. In the UK universities, 'Language' was taught in a strongly diachronic tradition, rarely venturing into the modern period. Linguistics did not exist as an undergraduate subject. Most youngsters opted for Literature. Literature was presented in historical slices, related to ideas and classical influences, and there was some study of texts. Contemporary and recent literature was left undisturbed. Drama was seen as text, and I recall that my Head of Department was uneasy about his students presenting actual performances of Shakespeare in case the plays might be mistaken for entertainment.

I believe that my *alma mater*, Edinburgh University, was the first to take English literature seriously. An appointment was made in 1762 of Prof. Hugh Blair to a new chair of Rhetoric and *Belles Lettres*. The early emphasis on rhetoric continued, and perhaps helped to pave the way for stylistics some two hundred years later.

The structure of the honours degree in Edinburgh in the nineteen-fifties required a student to take subjects from at least two departments to a final honours

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* This chapter originated in the keynote address delivered at the conference "Challenging the Boundaries", Poetics and Linguistics Association (PALA) and Bogazici University, in Istanbul, 2003. As an article, it appeared originally in Bas, I. & Freeman, D. (eds). 1994. *Challenging the Boundaries*. Amsterdam: Rodopi.

level, which meant in practice that the literature specialists found themselves with at least one finals paper in the dreaded language area.[1] By the time I came to finals, an agreeable accommodation of this requirement had been reached, and a special paper had been devised for the literature stream. It had a long, unmemorable name, like 'English Language – literary and colloquial usage from 1350 to the present day', but was universally known as 'Paper Eight'[2]

I bring this to your attention partly because there is in the story a link with our host country for this PALA conference, Turkey. The lectures for Paper Eight in my year, 1954–5, were given by the language Professor, the brilliant and innovative Angus McIntosh, and a promising young scholar just up from Oxford called Jim Ure. After an unavoidable absence on Her Majesty's Service, I returned to Edinburgh as a research student and soon became involved in the work of Paper Eight. Jim Ure meanwhile had taken a year out as a British Council Lecturer in Turkey, and was so charmed by this country and its people that he secured a permanent job with the Council, left academic life and returned to Turkey.

So this is my first reason for being grateful to Turkey in my career: Turkey lured away Jim Ure, and I got his job – and with it a substantial role in Paper Eight. Linguistics, meanwhile, was on the move. Edinburgh had appointed a lecturer, Michael Halliday, and had attracted J. R. Firth from retirement to support the establishment of linguistics courses – Firth had just published "Modes of Meaning" and was keen on applying his contextual theory to literary texts, and Halliday adapted to his new surroundings with some powerful stylistic analyses.[3]

The view that was commonly taken by linguists in those early days was that there was nothing sacred or even ultimately mysterious about the way in which literary texts made meaning. No text was exempt from conventional linguistic analysis, and indeed it was claimed that such analysis would reveal relevant insights into how the texts were constructed and how the special effects were created. The long-term aim was to build a bridge between the objectively-oriented disciplines of grammar, phonology, etc. and the subjective responses made in a sensitive critical

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1. The story about this arrangement that passed among the students was that it was established by the last literature Professor but one, Herbert J. C. Grierson, who felt that a strong dose of language work added intellectual backbone to the literature course.

2. For information and confirmation of the content of this section I am indebted to another survivor of the period, Norman McLeod. For perceptive comments on the paper as a whole I am most grateful to Sonia Zyngier.

3. This cryptic account omits even mention of the parallel developments in Phonetics with David Abercrombie and Applied Linguistics with Ian Catford, both with star-studded casts of colleagues, who projected Edinburgh into a commanding position in language studies by about 1960.

reading. In simplistic terms, the linguists pointed out that literature was written in language and that the known conventions of language patterning were at least the starting points for any discussion of the meaning of the text. Even if it was to be shown that literary text communicated in an unorthodox fashion, the ordinary meaningful patterns of the language were inescapable and had to be addressed. Although it was conceded that the ordinary patterns might in some circumstances be downgraded, the idea of dismissing them as irrelevant was not a serious option for descriptive linguists of the period.

The reactions of our literary colleagues ranged from occasional cautious interest, through scepticism to hostility, and there were some tense moments in discussions at both local and national level.

Edinburgh, of course, was not alone in this development. Randolph Quirk in Durham, then London, and Roger Fowler, first in Hull and then in East Anglia, were also probing the potential of grammar and phonology beyond the previous borders. In the USA, A. A. Hill was a pioneer in the late fifties, and the most revered linguistics scholar of his generation, Roman Jakobson, published a paper in 1960 which served as a rallying point for some years afterwards, and no doubt is responsible for the P in PALA.

By the mid-sixties, stylistics in UK was flourishing. Conference sessions were devoted to it and journals started to appear. Then it slowly declined in popularity; it remained as a minority interest and kept a place in the intellectual map, supported by the emergence of PALA, but it has never, in the eyes of some, realised its potential.

There are all sorts of reasons that can be adduced to account for this. Those who take a gladiatorial view of academic controversies can point to the bruising criticism of, for example, Stanley Fish (1973), but the scholars who were striving for a measure of linguistic rigour, such as it was, were well aware of the shortcomings of their methodology. An evolutionary explanation of the decline would be that the study of literature evolved from within to make it resistant to voices of reform from outside. Western European scholars were developing a structuralist position from within the literary discipline, which played the role of an antidote to the infection of stylistics, and this reform received powerful support when important advances in the USSR became known. Although written in the thirties, the work for example of Mikhail Bakhtin filtered through to the West a generation later and was very influential.

However, the main reason for the decline of stylistics was that linguists were not principally engaged in an attack on literary criticism, nor in a takeover bid, nor even in the preparation of a toolkit for literary analysis; their key concern was to develop their discipline to account for the particularly complex and powerful medium of literary text. The reason for the decline in stylistics was the failure of

this enterprise, and the failure was pretty comprehensive. There was, and is, no lack of ingenious application of linguistic categories to literary works, with penetrating insights and fascinating comparisons, but there is no theory to explain how the patterns relate to meaning, no guarantee that the same patterns in another text will create the same effects, no detailed, comprehensive descriptive apparatus that is flexible enough to accommodate the extremely varied language of literature. Given this insecurity, and the locus of stylistics as perilously reliant on sensitive interpretation, it is not surprising that a set of techniques soon grew up, seamlessly connecting rigorous linguistic analysis and pretty straightforward subjective impressions. This was *not* the bridge that the first adventurers in stylistics were aiming to build – quite the contrary. Rather than a bridge, this was a crude causeway that muddied the waters considerably.

As well as the essentially *ad hoc* nature of a stylistic description,[4] most of it was also small-scale. Lexis was hooked on the word, and grammar on the clause; the phonological units were also small. But worst of all, it was common to come across a stretch of text that clearly had an emotional effect, perhaps gloomy, perhaps uplifting, perhaps threatening, but the linguist had no means of explaining why it was so. Stylistic analysis was, and is, irretrievably patchy, and has kept going because of the attraction of working with texts that have their own fascination, and the perceived need for organised commentary despite the shortcomings of the theoretical side.

Like many scholars and teachers of language of my generation, the initial impetus that I had to take up language work was a flight from literary study rather than a positive yearning for mainstream language work as it was presented at that time. I tried an experiment after graduation – I wrote (just for myself) a literary appreciation of an important poem, using biographical and circumstantial evidence and arguing convincingly an interpretation that I did not believe in for one moment. I concluded that this was a game rather than a serious intellectual pursuit, and that I had undergone years of laborious training in order to become a kind of superior snake-oil salesman. Like the last Edinburgh Professor but one, I sought a discipline where it was normal to argue systematically from data.[5]

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4. For a recent confirmation of this point see Stubbs (2003), who quotes Toolan (1996).

5. Very soon after this many linguists, led by Chomsky, moved away from giving pride of place to actually occurring language, in favour of hypothetical representations of sentences, thus leading back into a more subjective domain. My resistance to the siren call of "TG" may well have been influenced by the way in which I came into linguistics, as a flight from subjectivity.

The new availability of electronic computers gave promise of good things to come, and were beginning to be used in authorship studies, but they were hopelessly crude for anything to do with meaning. But meanwhile the philosopher J. L. Austin (1962) had given the initial impetus to the study of discourse, and linguists began to glimpse the possibilities of describing language above the sentence – discourse and text structure. This occupied me in the seventies, and the serious study of large corpora started in the eighties. After ten years or so corpus evidence began to find its way into literary explication, e.g. Louw (1993), but there was still no theoretical underpinning – only more reliable evidence, especially about word combinations.

During the nineties I was developing a rather technical piece of software with Geoff Barnbrook, having no idea at the time of the broad-ranging relevance this might have. The umbrella notion is that of *local grammars*, derived from very modest suggestions by Maurice Gross in 1993. Gross was not alone in noticing that general grammars were inherently incapable of coping with many small but perfectly normal constructions that appear in corpora, often as simple as sums of money, addresses and phone numbers, names and titles. Gross suggested that small, dedicated grammars, which could be quite unlike the large general ones, were the kind of supplementary arsenal that was needed to make a comprehensive account of language in use. What is now known as 'named entity recognition' is the kind of descriptive area that arises to cope with structures that require special attention (Grishman 1997).

Once proposed, it was clear that the idea of local grammars was one that could run and run, and it has developed strongly over the last decade. In this chapter I suggest one of the ways in which local grammars can be applied to the systematic study of literary texts.

From a PALA perspective, then, my career has been a long odyssey starting from dissatisfaction with the methods of literary study. From there I worked in stylistics until frustrated by lack of a sound theory and a good toolkit. Searching for these, I developed a descriptive framework for spoken discourse, and made several attempts, not very successful, to generalise from this interactive model of conversation to the structure of written documents. I have returned to that venture recently, but at the time I moved on to work in a more focused fashion with text corpora, and in particular the development of software for corpus research and applications. The situation as of now is that I have assembled the components of a descriptive apparatus that, if not fully adequate as yet for literary description, is at least more firmly footed than when I started. I feel I can now face PALA with something to say.

It sounds all neat and tidy and purposeful, but of course it wasn't. It was the usual hurly-burly, grasping opportunities as they arose, and riding research on top of teaching and commercial contracts.

## 12.2 Objectivity

One theme that you can detect from the above is my preference for research that is founded on principles of maximal attainable objectivity, procedures which are as replicable as possible. While I think we should always be guided ultimately by our own personal taste and intuition, the more of our reasoning that we can place in the public domain, the better. 'Ferocious empiricism' was Patrick Hanks' phrase for my attitude to research (1997) and I am proud to wear that tag. Even within empirical linguistics, we are much too quick to take our eye off the language text in front of us and replace it by something like it but a little more abstract and manageable, or to look *through* the language to some separate arena of meaning instead of looking *at* the language and seeing the meaning being created in front of our eyes.

The computer has no taste, nor intuition, and so it has to be instructed explicitly in its searches, and the accuracy of its output reflects precisely the accuracy of the understanding of language of the researcher who programs it. To work at this level of explicitness is laborious, slow and demanding, but it is a refreshing counterbalance to the slow slide back into subjectivity that we so often see.

The pressure to abandon replicable analysis is constant and strong. It is very tempting to follow the clear promptings of one's intuition, cut a few corners and get down to an issue which is socially or politically important, but too subtle for our current tools of objective description. Or we can just conjure up the evidence in our imagination, since we can claim command of a language, rather than checking it out, despite the frequent demonstrations that our intuitions cannot recover natural cotext. 'Discourse Analysis' morphs into 'Critical Discourse Analysis' to allow the researcher to adopt a subjective position, and after a while 'critical' can be dropped. The attempt to develop objective, replicable description of the way people converse with each other is subtly replaced by records of unique personal responses to text, usually driven by some ideology.

## 12.3 Computing methodology

The computer requires a set of instructions which are exact and comprehensive, so that each piece of data that it encounters can be immediately identified and processed according to its identification. This requirement highlights the gulf that exists between a string of characters and the meaning that can be derived from them. For a user of the language concerned, the bridging of the gulf is effortless, and the meaning springs from the text, spoken or written, even in poor receptive

conditions; for the computer, there is as yet no reliable way of processing the text to reveal its meaning.

Since the beginning of linguistic computing, attempts to bridge this gulf have been many and varied, and the everyday software in use is typically full of short-cuts and partial fixes, leading to rather messy results. Statistical techniques are often used in order to sharpen the results, even in the knowledge that statistics is largely irrelevant in the elucidation of meaning. The overall performance of current tools is far from satisfactory, and it is understandable that many scholars are not prepared to wait, or to handle inexact results from computers, even as stages in a methodology.

In recent years we have seen the development of hybrid methodologies to cope with this difficulty, of which the most prominent is what one might call 'heavy annotation'. A sophisticated descriptive framework is elaborated and a coding system devised to instantiate the description through textual annotations or 'tags'.

Annotations provide an alternative view of the text from the text itself. Over the years they have grown from simple textual mark-up which recorded aspects of the typography and layout of a written text that would otherwise be lost in transfer, to an open-ended opportunity to add classifications and commentaries to the text. The strangest aspect of annotation is the placement of the tags in the stream of text rather than running them in parallel – as if the researcher's notes had to interrupt the text at all times. There were probably reasons for this way back in the dark days when communication with the machines was awkward and rudimentary, but it has somehow stuck in many projects.

There are two types of annotation – those produced automatically and those introduced by off-line, human analysis. Automatic ones do not add to the total information given in the text, and they are a matter of convenience; tags that arise from an independent human analysis – what I am calling 'heavy' tags – introduce new information to the system, of a completely different order from the information derived from the stream of characters. These are not replicable, because if they were the computer could do the job; they have a substantial element of subjective judgement tucked away in a cloak of apparently objective tag assignment.

The strangeness is not in the desire or need to make a fairly subjective analysis of the text – this is everyday practice, whether or not computers are eventually involved. It is in the alternation of text and tag, where two logically incompatible views of a text are shuffled together like cards in a pack. This is a quite unnecessary confusion which can lead to the fallacious view that the two versions of the text (the text itself and the tags) are somehow meaningfully merged; unfortunately accessing the tags obscures the text and vice-versa.

The main danger in the hybrid annotation method is that it looks more objective than it is, because the output is via the computer and the tagging looks very

professional, and no doubt conforms to pompous recommendations by grant-awarding bodies.

## 12.4 PALA priorities

Before coming to this meeting, I had wondered several times where PALA members, and where PALA itself, stood on methodology, whether computer-involved or not. I must confess that, having seen the programme and attended a number of sessions, I am no wiser. Also it seems that there is no PALA manifesto, no statement of topic area beyond the title, which is luxuriously broad, and no Terms of Reference, such as might be expected from an established and popular association in these days of Mission Statements. An inarticulate Association in the humanities is a rare creature, especially one apparently devoted to aspects of communication skills.

PALA members seem to be quite relaxed about this situation. Given its UK origins, the lack of an explicit *raison d'être* may seem rather superior, like the non-existent British Constitution. New members are apparently attracted to PALA by other temptations than a fine call-to-arms, and of the other temptations there are many, especially on a sumptuous occasion such as this one. It does, however, leave visitors somewhat in the dark.

I proceed in the hope that at least some of the members respect my aim of improving the explicit, the shared, the replicable areas of language description, despite the shortcomings, the patience required, and the slow progress.

## 12.5 Heroic couplets

My research topic of choice as a tender postgraduate was the eighteenth-century couplet poetry of which Alexander Pope was the master; in particular I thought *An Essay on Man* was much undervalued, as readers stayed with Pope's lighter satirical work, and no-one wanted to read the more solemn pieces like the *Essay* or the translations of Homer. The excuse that we all mouthed for ignoring the Homer was that the couplet was not the right medium for the grand sweep of Homer's verse, since the couplet focused on the half-line and not the verse paragraph.[6] Equally, it was felt that the couplet was not a convenient vessel for extended philosophical argument, although *An Essay on Man* won a prestigious prize for philosophical writing in Paris.

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**6.** This was not the perception at the time. The adjective 'heroic' was applied to the couplet because of the great classical translations such as Dryden's Virgil and Pope's Homer.

There were two toolkits that I had with which to study this complex language: the 'figures of speech' received from classical literature, and the emerging structural grammars; generative grammar was still in a primitive state at that time. The grammars made a tolerable job of dividing sentences into clauses, groups and phrases, and assigning structural values to the elements but took no account of the poetic form, and after an exhaustive syntactic analysis of the *Essay* it was not really clear what understanding had been achieved.

The figures of speech, chiasmus, anacoluthon, syllepsis, zeugma, etc. sounded like unfortunate things to happen to poetry, but they were in reality sketches for little local grammars. The most reliable crib was the long entry in Fowler's *A Dictionary of Modern English Usage* (1949), which offered a short definition of each figure and a good example, but applying this information to text was another matter. The definitions were informal and relied heavily on interpretation, and the putative instances that one encountered in text were in large measure problematic. There were as many gaps – patterns that the ancients had not included – as examples of *bona fide* figures.

The couplet especially in the strict control of Pope was a natural vehicle for making comparisons, and the property associated with these comparisons was called *antithesis*. In literary study the term originally meant a position directly opposed to another, the *thesis*, but it was watered down to become a label for anything from straight antonymy, through various kinds of contrast and opposition to anything placed in a framework of comparison. The couplet was a natural carrier of this kind of pattern, with its paired lines and its option of paired half-lines as well, against a background of the neo-classical milieu of balance, symmetry and order. The couplet has no monopoly of crisp antithetical statement. It is prominent in today's 'soundbites', and in much advertising. Consider a current Nissan advert:

WHAT OTHERS SELL AS EXTRAS
NISSAN GIVES AS STANDARD

The three contrasting pairs are clear when we put equivalent elements in a vertical relationship:

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| WHAT | OTHERS | SELL | AS | EXTRAS |
| | NISSAN | GIVES | AS | STANDARD |

The main contrast is the final one between *extras* and *standard*, the implication being that since the luxuries are in with the price they are good value. The middle contrast is subtle, and can slip past subliminally: *sell* and *gives*. Clearly, Nissan is giving away absolutely nothing to anyone, and from that point of view it is a blatant lie, but the ever-popular idea of getting something for free is popped in. The

tactic is the same as a bottle of cleaning fluid which boasts that the top 20% of its contents are 'free'.

In heroic couplet poetry there are frequent and regular stops, where both the metre and the structure terminate, and we start almost from the beginning again. A large number of lines terminate in this way, and every second one adds rhyme into the rounding-up process. Quite a lot of lines even have a pause in the middle, so that sometimes every two or three words we have a boundary of some kind. Among the rich rhythmic variation that combinations of these options give rise to, there is one general rule that Pope observes carefully; the second line of the couplet has end-punctuation. This is called the *closed couplet*, and at times leads to apparently superfluous punctuation marks appearing because they ought to rather than that they serve a communicative function. The end of line 6 could be an instance of this.

The closed couplet is utterly different from the blank verse style of Shakespeare before Pope and Wordsworth after him, where a number of techniques were developed so that boundaries were somewhat rare, and verse paragraphs went on for many lines with no hope of stopping. Offsetting the grammar and the metre was one technique, setting up syntactic prospections (*arrest,* see Chapters 6, 8, and 14 this volume, and Sinclair 1982) another, and adding more and more unexpected extensions to the structure was another (*release,* see Chapter 6). Since the Romantics loosened up verse structure we have not returned to the tight control of the neo-classical writers, and they are not easy to appreciate from a present-day standpoint.

The main way in which the couplet form is used is by successive couplets saying almost the same thing as each other. Instead of the meaning developing, changing and deepening as the poem progresses, the couplets pile up, all about equivalent to each other. Each one takes a slightly different angle on the central statement, fleshes it out a bit and adds some colourful images, but hardly progresses to another state. After several of these, there is a termination that expresses the central statement, now made powerful by the panorama of contributory statements.

In discussing Wordsworth's verse (see Chapter 8), I pointed out that the principal statements, coming at the end of verse paragraphs, were empowered by a kind of syntactic energy that came from the twin motors of arrest and release; the statements in themselves were, in isolation, somewhere between trivial and pathetic. In "Lines", usually known as "Tintern Abbey", one highly-charged verse paragraph ends "and rolls through all things." Another ends "we see into the life of things." In their proper places at the ends of formidable verse paragraphs they are sonorous and profound, not in themselves but as energised by the verse.

Pope's technique is more reminiscent of the repetitive nature of the dance. I recall Benjamin Lee Whorf explaining the way in which Hopi dancing gained

power through repetition; each repeat of the same movement gave it *gravitas*.[7] The repeats were never exactly the same, and the experience of each was slightly different, but they counted as repeats and so they added to the accumulation of power. If you just see them as the same thing again and again then they are pointless; Whorf said or implied that to a European a clock striking ten just tells you how many hours have passed; in Hopi culture this would be an impressive build-up of striking, more important than three o'clock.

## 12.6 A commentary on Pope's verses

Consider one of Pope's verse paragraphs in *An Essay on Man*, the opening of Epistle II.

> Know, then, thyself, presume not God to scan;
> The proper study of mankind is man.
> Placed on this isthmus of a middle state,
> A being darkly wise, and rudely great:
> With too much knowledge for the sceptic side,
> With too much weakness for the stoic's pride,
> He hangs between; in doubt to act, or rest;
> In doubt to deem himself a god, or beast;
> In doubt his mind or body to prefer;
> Born but to die, and reasoning but to err;
> Alike in ignorance, his reason such,
> Whether he thinks too little, or too much:
> Chaos of thought and passion, all confused;
> Still by himself abused, or disabused;
> Created half to rise, and half to fall;
> Great lord of all things, yet a prey to all;
> Sole judge of truth, in endless error hurled:
> The glory, jest, and riddle of the world! (Gutenberg text)

This is something of a test for a couplet writer, because the point Pope is making is that Man is hanging in the middle somewhere, neither one thing nor another. One of the criticisms made of the couplet is that it is ideal for contrasting things, and

7. "To the Hopi, for whom time is not a motion but a 'getting later' of everything that has ever been done, unvarying repetition is not wasted but accumulated. It is storing up an invisible change that holds over into later events." (Whorf, 1956). 'Unvarying' is a relative concept, since nothing is ever exactly repeated, so I think that Whorf's interpretation is close to my point.

ultimately polarising is a trivialising process. Pope was well aware of this danger, and tackles it neatly elsewhere in the poem:

> If white and black blend, soften, and unite
> A thousand ways, is there no black or white?

Note the subtlety of the chiasmus[8] – the unusual sequence *white and black* points up their separation, and contrasts with the verbs in the line; the second mention *black or white* integrates them again as a contrastive pair, and uses *or* as the linker to make the point.

Pope, handling a verse form that encourages bipolar contrasts, has to tackle the middle ground. The opening couplet does not set up a strong pattern and this is normal – there is an obscure chiasmus in the first line (*know…thyself – God….scan*), while the second line has no mid-break and reaches apparent finality with the similarity of *mankind* and *man*. There is another vaguely chiasmic pattern over the two lines – *God….scan – study…man(kind)*. A full stop underlines the finality, but a single couplet is rarely a complete verse paragraph so we interpret the first couplet as an introductory positioning.

The second couplet is rhythmically the reverse of the first, with another undivided line in line 3 and a four-way comparison in line 4. In line 3 the word *isthmus*, backed up by *middle*, sets the semantic sights of the paragraph – and note that Pope places the word *isthmus* in the middle of the line.

Line 4 is a characteristic structure, which has three components; two pairs of words in a common environment. The shared elements are *A being*, and the adverbs *darkly* and *rudely* have something in common, as have the adjectives *wise* and *great*. The adverbs are unusual in combination with the nouns, and detract from them; *darkly* hints at primitive and uncomprehending impulses, which jar with wisdom, while *rudely* suggests a lack of sophistication and a serious limitation on greatness. Man, then, is neither really wise nor great, but somewhere in between.

This couplet ends with a colon, a substantial break but one that raises the expectation that the following lines will be illustrative of the preceding; the gnomic phrases of line 4 may be elaborated.

The third couplet is one where the two lines follow the same pattern, down to syllabification and alliteration. There is a frame, common to both lines, *With too much X for the Y Z*, and a contrast on the Y elements, *sceptic* and *stoic*. The X elements, *knowledge* and *weakness* do not seem to compare along any coherent

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**8.** Chiasmus consists of two pairs of elements in comparison, organised in the sequence ABBA rather than the more straightforward ABAB.

dimension, nor do the Z elements, *side* and *pride*, which are little more than carriers for the Y elements. The couplet as it stands does not make an impact because there are no clear lines of contrast. No doubt the greater awareness of classical notions and stories in Pope's time would make the Y elements an interesting comparison, but there is nothing else beyond a similar mismatch between the X and Y elements, similar to the jarring of *darkly wise and rudely great*. Stoics have a reputation for toughness; perhaps sceptics were thought to be ignorant – I do not know but it is clearly implied here.

The point is that the same technique is used as before, juxtaposing meanings that, if not antonymic, certainly do not mix well. But in this case the couplet does not round off the structure; both the lines are prepositional phrases, and they prospect the rest of their clause, which comes in line 7a (the first half of line 7) – a clear case of arrest. The punctuation at the end of line 6 is merely a comma, like line 5, and there is some build-up of structural energy from the very marked pattern of repetition in this couplet. In an almost Wordsworthian way, the brevity of line 7a following this build-up makes it seem important, and in a distinctly Popeian way the words enact their meaning.

A brief digression to explain this last phrase. Pope's *Essay on Criticism* is justly famous because of the bravura with which he makes his words dance to their own meaning, especially in the famous passage beginning:

> But most by Numbers judge a Poet's Song,
> And smooth or rough, with them, is right or wrong;

and containing gems like:

> And ten low Words oft creep in one dull Line[9]

---

9. An Alexandrine is a line containing two extra syllables, sparingly used for special effects.

> But most by Numbers judge a Poet's Song,
> And smooth or rough, with them, is right or wrong;
> In the bright Muse tho' thousand Charms conspire,
> Her Voice is all these tuneful Fools admire,
> Who haunt Parnassus but to please their Ear,
> Not mend their Minds; as some to Church repair,
> Not for the Doctrine, but the Musick there.
> These Equal Syllables alone require,
> Tho' oft the Ear the open Vowels tire,
> While Expletives their feeble Aid do join,
> And ten low Words oft creep in one dull Line,
> While they ring round the same unvary'd Chimes,
> With sure Returns of still expected Rhymes.

Back with the *Essay on Man* we see that the word *between*, like *isthmus*, is close to the middle of the line, hung there by the word *hangs*. *Between* is a preposition and prospects that two points will be specified, 'between X and Y'. It is within the conventions of poetic licence that these do not need to be supplied, but the expectation is aroused and contributes to the suspense and suspension. The semi-colon in the middle of line 7 suggests that the resolution of Man's unfortunate suspension will shortly be resolved.

The fourth couplet is then faced with something of a problem of what Pope would call *numbers*, the measure of the verse, its sophistication and the way it highlights the meaning. How is he going to steady the couplet in a line and a half? It is not a big problem however, and Pope repeats the frame technique, this time using the frame *in doubt to X or Y*. The frame is modified in line 8 to *in doubt to Z X or Y*, where Z is *deem himself a*, conveniently taking up the extra syllables available in the full line. Here the contrasts of paired words begin to show more clearly than in the earlier couplets; the first XY pair are *act* and *rest*, which are *prima facie* antonyms, and the second pair, *God* and *beast* are seen as points on a cultural continuum on either side of *man*. The message of each phrase is always the same, but the technique has moved from juxtaposing words uncomfortably together, to seeing Man as in tension between opposites, hanging between them. Each line at this point closes with a semi-colon; each statement is essentially the same and is given the same status in the sentence.

The *in doubt* frame is used once more in line 9, and this reduces the impact of the couplet end because it signals another of the same, the third in a row; the frame is further varied to *in doubt X or Y to prefer*. The verb, which was the point of contrast at first, is now part of the frame. Line 10 does not repeat the pattern, and so is a kind of summing up of where we are now. The four part pattern of line 10 is a favourite of Pope's, often used to devastating effect; the frame is *X but to Y*, and the first XY is a conventional antonym, *born* and *die*. The second XY is not so obviously antithetical to us nowadays, *reasoning* and *err*; we will return to this point later.

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Where-e'er you find the cooling Western Breeze,
In the next Line, it whispers thro' the Trees;
If Chrystal Streams with pleasing Murmurs creep,
The Reader's threaten'd (not in vain) with Sleep.
Then, at the last, and only Couplet fraught
With some unmeaning Thing they call a Thought,
A needless Alexandrine ends the Song,
That like a wounded Snake, drags its slow length along.

Let us have closer look at the fragment 7b-10. Three *in doubt* frames build up strength in repetition, and line 10 signals a change, briefly to a new frame *X but to Y*. We interpret line 10 as a rounding-off of the fragment, making generalisations from the instances above it. The generalisation seems to be an awareness that any action, impression or preference is perpetually cancelled out by its opposite, and line 10 makes a physical and mental summary of the position.

Depressing though the message may be, the verse is in good shape, and has returned from the slight turbulence of line 7 to the measured, balanced and familiar line 10. The end-line punctuation remains the semi-colon, however, indicating that there is more to come.

The sixth couplet loosens up the verse, which had been becoming progressively more patterned in the previous fragment. The couplet again aligns with the antithetical patterns after the excursion in 7b – 10. There is a sense of restarting, while still pursuing the main point.

The main point is that Man is still hanging between. Once again the punctuation, the least noticeable part of the structure, indicates with a colon at the end of 12 that we have returned to a similar situation to line 4; the paradoxical difficulty of Man's thought processes is the next topic to be addressed. The next four lines each end in a semi-colon, as did lines 7,8,9, and 10. Although the repeated pattern is less regimented, the couplet is low key and non-terminal, so we can expect that another build-up is on the way.

There is a trace of a chiasmus in line 11 – *alike, ignorance/reason, such* – but while *ignorance* and *reason* certainly contrast in the semantics of this verse, the other pair is trivial. Line 12 has another fairly banal contrast, between *too little* and *too much*.

The seventh couplet is rather similar; there is a hint of chiasmus again in the odd-numbered line, and line 14 closely follows line 12. Let us examine lines 13 and 14 in turn. *Chaos* at the beginning of 13 is echoed by *confused* at the end, and *thought* and *passion* in the middle make it look superficially balanced, but the meaning does not follow the surface patterning. If the comma had been placed after syllable 4 rather than 7, it would have been an unmistakeable chiasmus, but it would not mean the same:

*Chaos of thought and passion all confused

It is always perilous to underestimate Pope. Was he aware of the underlying regularity that has just been presented in my tinkering with the line, but since he was talking about chaos and confusion, he placed the comma to create quite a little turbulence, a little chaos in the all-important Numbers? After the quotes from the *Essay on Criticism* one might imagine that this is just what he would do.

Line 14 is opaque to me, perhaps distorted by our unavoidable reaction to the word *abuse* in current English, with its overtones of sex, drugs and children. I have not had the opportunity to explore the likely meanings of the two words at the time they were used, but it is fairly unlikely that *disabused* was the opposite of *abused* at that time any more than in the present day. So the meaning is probably once again slightly at odds with the verse. In terms of pattern, line 14 is very close to line 12:

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| Whether he thinks | too little, | or | too much; |
| Still by himself | abused, | or | disabused; |

The second and fourth segments carry sharp antonyms. So the sixth and seventh couplets have a lot in common, though it is not all just on the surface. The indistinct chiasmus patterns in the first lines; the commas after syllables 6 and 7 respectively, giving a similar feel to the rhythm; the close parallel structure of the even-numbered lines as shown above. It is worth noting again, however, the difference in the end-line punctuation. The comma at the end of line 11 indicates that there is a syntactic dependency relationship between the two lines of the couplet; in fact line 12 is a subordinate clause to the main clause which is still elaborating 7a, *He hangs between*. All the lines from 7 until 16, with the exception of 12, take off from 7a, so we understand, say, line 13 as 'He hangs between ? and ? in a chaos of thought and passion, all confused'. The punctuation at the end of line 13 is the first of the string of semicolons that mark the build-up to the final couplet in the paragraph.

The next couplet, the eighth, consists of two more lines each of which makes a simple opposition; *rise* and *fall* in line 15, and *lord of all* versus *prey to all* in line 16. Whereas *lord* and *prey* are not exact opposites, the repetitive structure of the verse is sufficient for them to fit in.

The pattern, and the build-up, continues in line 17, which parallels 16 quite closely:

| | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Great | lord | of | all things, | yet | a prey to all; | | |
| Sole | judge | of | truth | , in | endless error | hurled: | |

The couplet break is made to feel unimportant at this point, compared with the build-up that started in line 7 and restarted in line 13. For line after line we have been expecting the balanced, simple two-term comparison, usually a fairly obvious pair of opposites; line 18 completely foils our expectations of pattern by comparing three terms, *glory, jest* and *riddle*. Prominence falls on *riddle* because it is last, the other two form a pair, and it falls on syllables 6 and 7 with only a trite phrase to end the paragraph.

From the point of view of the meaning, this all starts with the word *isthmus* in line 3. Pope is exploiting the very structure of the heroic couplet; this verse, as we have seen, naturally falls into half lines which effortlessly carry contrasts and comparisons. By gradually highlighting a third way, hanging between any pair of *God* and *beast, reason* and *error,* etc., Pope prepares the way for occupying the part of the line that is normally empty, the break in the middle. This is the location of his topic, Man – and sure enough there is *Man* in the middle of the last line, the riddle of the universe. The technique is akin to the Polo Mint company making a constant fuss about the hole in the middle, as they do.

## 12.7 A local grammar for the *Essay on Man*

We have now been through a not very erudite *explication de text* of a verse paragraph from this poem. I did not want to wheel out the complete critical apparatus because of the risk of being sidelined from the main issues. It is not possible to say for sure that this passage is 'typical' of the *Essay*, and indeed there are aspects of it which are almost certainly unique to it, as one would expect in any live communication. However, a general acquaintance with the poem and the genre suggests that the verbal techniques employed here are reasonably representative of its kind of writing. A local grammar which fitted this paragraph, then, should need little revision in order to account for other verse paragraphs in the poem, then in other poems by Pope and his contemporaries, and ultimately to the whole genre of the heroic couplet. In fact, such are the fuzzy edges around the categories of genre that a good description will also function as a gatekeeper to the genre, as description drifts naturally into prescription.

What are the rhetorical units into which the verse paragraph divides? First there are *segments*, of indeterminate length, which retain some of the characteristics of the verse paragraph as a whole. Segments may be sequential with respect to one another, but can also be embedded within each other. So we can make a start by saying that a paragraph consists of one or more segments arranged either in the order:

segment – segment – segment …

or in the order:

segment (segment (segment …

and these two orders can be combined.

Segments are not necessarily made up of whole couplets or even whole lines, but can start and stop at any point in the verse structure. So the couplet pattern,

which dominates the superficial appearance of the style, is not in a taxonomic relationship to the segment.[10] Segment and couplet operate in parallel, with the segment usually larger than the couplet, but with the opportunity for counterpoint in various places, as we have seen, for example, in line 7.

A couplet consists of two lines. A line optionally divides into two half-lines, and occasionally into smaller units, marked by internal punctuation.[11]

The paragraph and the segment have approximately the same structural possibilities; a distinctive opening, a central passage and a distinctive closing. In our sample passage, the first couplet is a distinctive opening – it is a whole sentence and it sets the topic for the paragraph. The second couplet is the opening of a segment, and is also distinctive, the colon indicating that what follows is an elaboration of the statement in the couplet. This segment introduces the idea of Man's in-between position, with *isthmus* and *middle*, and with the paradoxical juxtapositions of line 4. Then there follows the central passage of this segment, where the repetitive patterns begin to be developed. The third couplet functions in this way, and line 7a breaks the pattern and provides a termination for the segment. A new segment starts at 7b. Note that if the mid-line punctuation had been just a comma, it would have been difficult to justify a segment boundary. The semi-colon indicates that 7b is not just an expression of the points between which 'he' hangs, but starts another repetitive series.

In this second segment there is no distinctive opening passage, and I interpret it as being embedded within the first and not sequential. As we noted in the discursive explication, line 7b is required to make sense of *between*, yet the semi-colon separates it and places it in a new clause. And then we find that 7b is not alone, but is the template for 8 and 9 as well. The pattern is broken at line 10, which forms a distinctive closing passage both for this segment and the first one (see Footnote 12).

The third segment begins at line 11, and it is sequential. The sixth couplet, lines 11 and 12, constitutes something of a distinctive opening, though we have noted that the pattern of line 11 is not strong, and that there are quite strong affinities between the sixth and seventh couplets which tend to obscure their different structural roles. Perhaps a sharply distinctive opening at this point in the

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**10.** There were, of course, all kinds of variations on the couplet, both before and after Pope and among his contemporaries. The tighter kind of writing always had a new verse paragraph starting with a new couplet.

**11.** I will not go into the details of how the units are physically identified except for some attention to the segments. Nor will I engage at this time with the metrics of heroic couplet poetry, though these are integral parts of the whole.

paragraph would be too much of a break, so openings are muted as the paragraph develops.

The central passage of the third segment continues until line 17, leaving the last line as a highly distinctive closing, not only to the segment but to the paragraph as a whole.[12] It is marked off by the colon at the end of 16 and the exclamation mark at the end of 17.

Notice that the length of the central passages rises as we go through the paragraph. In the first segment it is just one couplet; in the second it is a couplet and half a line; in the third it is three couplets and a line. The gradual emergence of the repetitive pattern over lines 11–17 suggests that Pope was aware of the long haul, and made sure his early blows were muffled, as we saw in lines 11–14. Lines 15, 16 and 17 show the verse razor-sharp and highly concentrated in meaning.

We can now turn to the smaller scale patterns of the couplet and below, and I will first deal with the patterns found most prominently in the central passages.[13] This is where the patterns called *antithesis* are to be found, and we must be careful of this potentially misleading term. As previewed above, an antithesis is essentially a comparison of two items or more within a *frame*. The frame is either *common* to the elements of the comparison, or *matched* by sufficient actual recurrence of words to make it stand as a repetition; if it has features of both we will call it a *mixed frame*. So in line 4, the frame is *A being…..and*, which occurs once only and so is common, while in lines 5 and 6 the frame, *With too much….for the* is precisely repeated, and the only structural difference between the two lines is the possessive morpheme *'s* in *stoic's*. Line 15 has a mixed frame, with *created* common and *half to* matched.

Comparisons are mainly of simple *pairs*, but occasionally more complex patterns like *double-pairs*, and with some special cases, like the *triple* in the last line. Line 15 is a simple case of a pair, *rise* and *fall*, within the mixed frame just described. The pair is *antonymic* in that it can be claimed that users of the language are immediately aware of this relationship if the two words are presented in

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**12.** The separation of paragraph and segment is not absolute, and it is perhaps inaccurate to suggest that they are in a hierarchical relationship. I cannot open up the argument here, but there is reason to suspect that our familiar hierarchies of sentence, clause etc. are also not as neatly boxed within each other as is normally supposed. So the paragraph-section relationship is not necessarily unusual, and for the moment I propose that any segment closing can also be seen as closing another open segment (in the case of embedding) and/or the paragraph as a whole.

**13.** Lines 4 and 12 are the second lines of couplets whose first lines open segments, they have structures more associated with lines from central sections. This is further evidence that passages are not necessarily made up of whole couplets.

isolation or in a frame of this kind. The frame does not create the semantic opposition, but merely points it up.

One of the main exponents of the comparisons is the expression of coordination. Small words they are, but *and, or, but, yet* delineate most of the comparisons, and they are just as carefully chosen as any of the other words. These words are not part of the frames, but indicate the nature of the separation of the items compared, the axis of comparison.

Other antonymic simple pairs are *act/rest, god/beast, mind/body, little/much, abused/disabused, truth/error*. We also admitted *ignorance/reason* in the explication above.

We are left with couplets 1, and 3 and lines 4, 10, 13 and 18. Let us work upwards from the end. Line 18 is a triple; *glory* and *jest* are close to antonymic, and in the environment of the rest of the paragraph they would count as another simple pair; here the pattern is extended to a third word which is not antonymic to either of them and so requires special interpretation. The theme of the passage is the in-between state of Man, and so the notion that a riddle is somewhere between glory and jest arises, and since part of the riddle could be its precise position in the scheme of things, the line creates a unique and *ad hoc* meaning which triumphantly rounds off the paragraph, as the exclamation mark demands. Man is simultaneously a glorious creature, a butt of jest, and above all a mystery and a puzzle. And hence, returning to line 2, a proper object for self-study.

Line 13, we have already noted, has the superficial appearance of a chiasmus, but with a comma that breaks up the comparison. *Thought* and *passion* make a good antonymic pair but there is no frame; *Chaos* and *confused* would do fine as a frame matched by synonymy, and they even alliterate, but such an interpretation has to remain very much in the background, and the line itself is confused in its pattern.

Line 10 is one of the more powerful lines because it is a double-pair. Each of its pairs is probably an accepted antonym, so it is not trying any playful semantics, but we are invited to interpret the two pairs together as well as singly. When there is more than one pair there is more than one possible axis of comparison. There is a kind of equation,

> *born* is to *die* as *reason* is to *err*

This kind of pattern is very common in heroic couplet poetry. We interpret it as 'Just as being born raises the inevitability of dying, trying to reason raises the inevitability of making mistakes.'

This double-pair is the most deadly weapon in the arsenal of the satirist, but is kept sheathed in the philosophical poetry. To whip it out, the second pair should not be an accepted antonym, but a pair of words which are obliged to find whatever

contrast they can, from which arises the fun. So, in *An Essay on Criticism*, there is a couplet:

> Yet let not each gay turn thy rapture move,
> For fools admire, but men of sense approve;

The accepted antonymic pair, *fools* and *men of sense* form a *pair-frame* against which *admire* is contrasted with *approve*. Moderation in all things.

Line 4 in the second couplet gives us a neat double-pair, with both horizontal and vertical possibilities. Because there are no recognised antonyms among the pairings, the effect of the line is to introduce the idea that Man may be a bit tricky to pin down, a bit inconsistent, not falling into the ready-made categories.

The third couplet is the most elaborate comparison in the paragraph, and in the discussion above it was pointed out that it does not make a strong impact. Each line provides a matched frame within which there are three pairs, but none of them are strongly antonymic, though *sceptic* and *stoic* may be close.[14] There is another mild contrast between *knowledge* and *sceptic* in line 5, and *weakness* and *stoic* in line 6. The function of the couplet seems to be mainly to set up several somewhat opposing poles between which *Man* can hang in the next line; hence the pairs in this couplet are not making a separate statement with pithy content. We will call the contrast of *knowledge* and *sceptic* a *horizontal* contrast, and that between *knowledge* and *weakness* a *vertical* contrast.

The first couplet shows little meaningful pattern, though it lines up the vocabulary for the passage – *know, God, man*. In the earlier discussion we saw that there are two patterns of chiasmus present, but not very clear, like a limbering up exercise. But since we have neglected the several chiasmuses in the paragraph, we will finish this pattern review with a brief account of them.

A chiasmus is one of the double-pair comparisons, with the ABBA order that we have noticed. If we take *know, scan* and *study* to be tolerable synonyms within the conventions of the verse, then *thyself* and *God* are put up as antonyms in the first line. Since *thyself* stands for Man, and God and Man are accepted antonyms, the line is neatly turned but unremarkable.[15] In the second chiasmus line 1b is

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**14.** We lack reference books to help us judge which pairs would be felt to be antonymic by the original readers of this poem, but the growing ease with which language resources can be accumulated and managed nowadays may eventually provide us with evidence.

**15.** The word *then* recalls the latter part of the first Epistle, which is a fairly ruthless attempt to cut Man down to size, terminating in the blast:

> One truth is clear, whatever is, is right.

re-used, and *study* replaces *know* while *mankind* replaces *man*. Again, not very clearly marked.

Line 11 is another weak chiasmus, hardly there at all, and we have already tackled the pattern of the fascinating line 13, the other possible chiasmic pattern. The conclusion must be that this kind of comparison is deployed only in a very muted way in the paragraph. Along with the single instance of a double pair (line 4), and the punch of line 10 firmly pulled, the general tone of the poetry is established.

## 12.8 The Couplet

The couplet has taken a back seat in our discussion of the antithetical style, which has ranged over line and half-line as well, and grouped couplets, and bits of couplets, together. Because the general view seems to be that the couplet is the pivotal unit of the verse, and not just one rank in the metrical hierarchy, we will round up the description by characterising each couplet in turn. The labels here are not intended to be as firm as technical terms because of the smallness of the sample.

In couplet 1, the first line is broken up by punctuation into half-lines, while the second line is free of mid-punctuation. We will call this pattern *halved-whole*. A similar contrast is made in the two halves of the first line, which consists of three single words all separately punctuated. The overall effect is a gradual smoothing of the rhythm, and we will add the word *accentuated* to account for the movement of the first line. This couplet, then, is of the *accentuated halved-whole* type. We must beware of hindsight in assigning function, but such a line seems to be well-suited to an opening.

The second couplet is opposite in its dynamics, and so the label *whole-halved* will suffice. Its first line runs without pause, and its second has mid-punctuation. The first line is preparatory, setting up expectations of something significant to come, and the second line is a double-pair, which we have identified as a powerful antithetical structure. As we have seen, this couplet is the beginning of an *arrest* that runs over to line 7, so the possible punch of the second line is dissipated, but the basic function of the couplet is clear; it is similar to the launch of a weapon in the physical world, with a stage of preparation followed by the firing of the weapon.

In the third couplet, the two lines share a strongly marked matched frame and within that the compared items also show similarity of syllabification. The second vertical pair, *sceptic* and *stoic's*, also alliterate, and the slightly different grammar is

a minor matter.[16] We shall call this kind of pattern an *aligned* couplet. Two successive lines with identical characteristics are likely to be used in building up an effect, and with three antithetical elements in each there are plenty of opportunities for smaller points to be made in passing. Here the function is to build up the arrest pattern that we noted in the central passage of the segment, and the prominent initial prepositions make this function very clear.

The fourth couplet is superficially of the same kind as the first, a *halved-whole* structure. The structure is also *accentuated*, but by a different pattern, in this case the strong similarity between the second half of line 7 and the whole of line 8. Where there are loose chiasmus patterns linking the two halves of line 1 and the whole of line 2, there is a sharp break in the middle of line 7; we have already noted that this is a segment boundary. Where there is such a cross-cutting of units, the larger structures tend to dominate, and we should perhaps postulate an *ad hoc* unit, the *residual couplet*, in order to label the function of this one minus its first half line. The appearance of an antithetical pattern first in a half line and then in the following full line is a powerful *expansion*, and that will do as a label for the present.

The fifth couplet is of the opposite variety, a *whole-halved* structure with a strong double-pair antithesis in the second line. This recalls the second couplet quite a lot, and exposes yet another underlying chiasmus that I had not noticed before; it is on the verge of fanciful, but *mind* does go with *reasoning*, and *body* with *born* and *die*. The function of the couplet is very similar to that of the second, like the preparation and launch of a weapon; in this case line 10 generalises the preceding build-up, and is the closing passage of its segment, so the effect is enhanced.

The sixth couplet is the first in which both lines have a mid-break. Without the comma in line 12 the couplet would be quite similar to the first one, and it is also an opening passage with a very similar function; presumable the little phrase *or too much* is not weighty enough to contrast with the rest of the line without being pointed up. We will call a couplet with a break in both lines, and with nothing else to distinguish it, a *halved-halved* structure.

The seventh and eighth couplets are similarly unremarkable as couplets, seeming to operate more as individual lines; for the record they are halved-halved structures, and the final couplet is an unusual one; line 17 is halved like the six above it, but line 18 contains a list of three items and a final phrase which applies

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**16.** Pope could, I imagine, have just as easily used *sceptic* as a noun and written *sceptic's*, but would then have had a problem with the *s* sound. Robert Graves (1955) criticised Pope for having no control over his *s*'s, and perhaps the poet was aware of this weakness.

to all three of them. I will not attempt to characterise this kind of line with only a single example; it is not unique in the poem so it is best to wait until we have several examples to work from.

We have done our best to respect the couplet the central unit, as it appears to be in the verse structure. But in the rhetorical structure it is on several occasions set against the argument, and rhetorical units take up more than a couplet and less than a couplet. In the last third of the paragraph the couplet all but disappears, except for its rhyme, in favour of the line. The reader may refer to Table 12 at the end of this chapter to see a summary of the way in which the various units are, and are not, related.

## 12.9 Conclusion

This study has brought out all the elements and relationships we need for an adequate local grammar of this paragraph. Hopefully it will suffice with minor variations to cover a lot of other paragraphs as well, and with some generalisation to be a good fit with the poem as a whole. Similar work on the satirical poems will show a great deal in common, and it is not possible to say with confidence at this point exactly what text types will be explained by a local grammar that starts with *An Essay on Man*. We can add variables as we build a corpus, such as other philosophical poems by the same author, similar poetry by his contemporaries, other kinds of poetry of the time, such as satirical, epic, lyric, all in the couplet form; earlier and later examples of these forms. If a step in expansion costs a great deal in elaboration of the grammar, then perhaps for that text type we should start again and write a simple grammar for it.

Local grammars reflect the *ad hoc* nature of stylistic analysis; rather than trying to ignore the textual complexity or squashing it into predetermined categories or abandoning rigorous description, local grammars can overlap with each other and compete for offering the most salient analysis of a passage. If this sounds like a recipe for anarchy, then imagine trying to elaborate all the possibilities in a single general grammar. That has all the attributes of an Abercrombie *pseudoprocedure* (1965).

We have no reason to believe that text is created by a coherent process from a single point of origin. The weight of expert opinion is that this is an illusion, an interpretation from hindsight as the individual tries to account for what he or she has just done (Singer 2004a). So while the final result of a poet's composition session may be some lines of polished verse, the composition process has probably involved several local grammars jostling together, barely under control; sometimes their demands may modify or divert the original communicative intent.

The descriptive scheme that I have sketched above relates four principles of organisation to each other; each of the organisational strands has the potential to create meaning independently from all the others; even though this potential is only occasionally realised it is one of the major features of the poetry.

One organisation is that of the *verse structure*. There we see a taxonomic hierarchy of:

poem
epistle
paragraph
couplet
line
part-line

Each unit consists of one or more than one of the unit next below. Note that the last and smallest rank is not always invoked, but it is necessary to account for in-line punctuation.

The second organisation that we have identified is the *rhetorical structure*. This is where the argumentation of the text is organised and expressed. Because the extract that we are studying is a single verse paragraph, we keep an open mind about higher ranks of rhetorical structure, but within the verse paragraph there is a hierarchy:

paragraph
segment
passage

This is another taxonomic hierarchy, which does not fit well with the first. While there are general implications of relative size of the units, and a general tendency to respect the boundaries of the verse structure, a passage can consist of several couplets, or, as we have seen in line 7a, it can be less than a line in length.

The sentence and its parts form a third taxonomic hierarchy of a familiar kind, much of its organisation being drawn from a general grammar of English. The main differences come from *poetic licence*, which consist of some relatively minor relaxations of general rules. Again the syntactic units do not fit neatly with the verse structure or the rhetorical structure; there is an example of the lack of correspondence below.

The metrical and phonological units form a fourth organisation, which we will not examine on this occasion. The scheme that is sketched here is the intersection of a local grammar for this kind of poem, a general grammar and a verse structure.

Notice that the sentence grammar is but one of the components of the meaningful organisation of the poetry. It does not dominate, and very often the meaning

created in one of the other hierarchies takes precedence. Consider the following passage, from earlier in the poem:

> Men would be Angels, Angels would be Gods.
> Aspiring to be Gods, if Angels fell,
> Aspiring to be Angels, Men rebel:

I have restored the original practice of capitalising most of the nouns to point up the dominating pattern:

> Men – Angels – Angels – Gods
> Gods – Angels – Angels – Men

There is quite an elaborate repeated frame, both in the first line and the couplet. The *if* in the second line is important in the grammar, because it subordinates line 2 to the main clause in line 3; but relative to the idea of spiritual ascent and descent it might as well not be there.

Firth (1957) put forward the notion of a spectrum of meaning, with all levels of language patterning contributing; at times the meaning was made via the taxonomic hierarchies of and within phonology and grammar, but any level could create meaning directly at any time, and bypass the hierarchies. The holistic approach that is required of a local grammar of couplet poetry fits well with Firth's proposals and also with his recognition of *restricted languages*, where special conventions mark special varieties.

We have discussed each of the obvious antithetical patterns of couplet, line and half-line; but also we have tried to account for the lines which have less clear pattern. Often there is a trace of what could have been a chiasmus – even line 3, if we concede that *perched* and *state* have something in common, while *isthmus* and *middle* we have already noted are similar in meaning. It does not really matter how far we wish to push the recognition of these less than distinct patterns, because it is clear that the couplet and the line are ideal vehicles if the poet wishes to mould a sharply-delineated chiasmus, so muted and vague patterns are there for another purpose.

We recognise these lines as a kind of *continuo*, not drawing attention to themselves but fitting in with the general kind of expression of the poem. And they occur in the places where according to our description we should expect patterns which are somewhat different from the central passages, i.e. in the opening passages. These are lines 1, 2, 3 and 11. The closing passages are also expected to produce something different; in this paragraph they are lines 7a, 10 and 18, although 10 and 18 are at least as strongly patterned as the ones they follow, the pattern changes; in line 10 to a double-pair, and in line 18 to a triple.

Note that the differentiation is more apparent in the paragraph as a whole than in the individual segments, and that the embedded segment has no opening passage. This may be a general trend, but until this analysis has been extended to the poem as a whole and beyond, we cannot be sure; these are not texts that yield their secrets to a casual glance. Also the verse paragraph is not the highest unit of patterning, because there are at least two higher units on the surface of the text – the *Epistle*, which is made up of numbered *sections*. These units may be too large to show immediately perceptible patterns, and so their principal function may be to organise the general argument; also there may be rhetorical units between the paragraph and the epistle, identified by their carrying a supra-paragraph pattern.

There is still much to be done; after all, this research is still in its first half-century. It is too early to attempt a more rigorous statement of the local grammar even though the main components may well be in place. Too early, too, to assess how computable the grammar will be, though I am optimistic about that within certain limitations.

The research began with the literary view of this kind of poetry as centring on the couplet, and the linguistic view of text as centring on the sentence and its parts. After close study it would seem that, while the couplet is the most obvious unit, it is also rather superficial, and often forms a counterpoint to the meaning rather than a delineator of it. The details of conventional sentence grammar are normally observed with great care, almost obsessively, but in many places it seems as if the poet is carrying out a duty rather than making meaning, and when the patterns of antithesis, in the broad sense of the literary term, cut across the grammar, as they often do, there is no doubt that they carry the principal meaning.

The main argument of this chapter is that we can identify four principles of organisation in the sample passage, all capable of independent meaning-creation, and by no means in a regular relationship with each other. Of these, three are well-known in the description of poetry, and can be seen as specialisations of more general types of apparatus. The fourth, the rhetorical structure, is the one that controls the meaning and arranges for its expression through the other, more superficial, hierarchies. It does not and cannot cancel the meaning that is carried by the others, but it prioritises and juxtaposes and sometimes almost suppresses meanings in order to create the special meaningful effects for which the poetry is noted.

We can summarise the 'local' nature of this descriptive approach as follows:

a. the verse structure and metrics are highly specialised in order to cover this kind of poetry and only this; however their categories and conventions are drawn from a general pool that is used in the description of a very large amount of traditional verse.

b. the syntax is a general grammar, slightly modified to cope with poetic licence.
c. the rhetorical structure is a local grammar specially designed for this kind of poetry; no doubt with connections to other local grammars, but whose generality is at present unknown.
d. the rhetorical structure controls the way in which meaning is expressed in the other three types of organisation; it has great freedom in squeezing and stretching the other units, and in superimposing meaningful patterns like antitheses on the other three. The particular way in which the rhetorical structure disposes the others is the main distinguishing characteristic of the poetry.
e. meaning is latent in the patterns of all four of the hierarchies, and to some extent they compete and offer alternative meanings; interpretation is guided by the rhetorical structure, though ultimately it is an individual response to the text.

It is difficult to see how a single co-ordinated structural algorithm could cope with the flexibility, precision, uncertainty and open-endedness of the creation of meaning in a text of this kind. The descriptive apparatus has to be loosened up, so that full weight is given to every tiny detail of the character string and the various abstractions that are made of it to align it with meaningful categories. Local grammars offer a theoretically sound way forward; they were not designed for stylistics nor were they originally conceived of as likely to confer any benefits in interpretation; but they present a sound model for the literary language as for many other varieties.

This research is part of a broader attempt to assign meaning its proper place in a linguistic theory and description. We have tended either to lose sight of meaning as we elaborate grammars, or to take it for granted in writing programs for assigning structure. Despite all the talk about 'living language' and 'dynamic text', the principal tools of the analyser, grammars, dictionaries, thesauruses, etc. are collections of information that have three qualities:

a. they are very general in nature, so that they have a good chance of being correct in a wide range of textual circumstances
b. they are largely insensitive to specific verbal environments.[17]
c. they are organised to smooth over variation by assigning unusual patterns to the nearest regular one, not to assign meaning to the unusual patterns.

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17. The many lexicons for computational use give information about the cotext in generalised, categorial terms, but not usually concerning actual word forms. Some recent dictionaries and usage guides, derived from corpus research, come closer to the specific needs, but are far from comprehensive.

That is to say, most current theories have no place for the kind of meaning that is clearly under negotiation all the time in everyday speech and writing, far less in literary texts. Any resource book that claims it can capture meaning accurately, especially in a single word, is capturing only a fraction of the meaning that is being created, and any computational grammar that decides on meaning by statistical weightings must have taken a wrong turning, and finds itself having to make categorisations that are not supported by the text.

Analysers which boldly go where they should not, i.e. attempt to account for meaningful patterns with inappropriate apparatus, obscure the issue. A substantial proportion of the meaning of any text is created *ad hoc*, by the particular combinations and juxtapositions of the text at one particular point; these are in all probability unique patterns that are not enshrined in the reference collections and indeed should not be so documented because they are not established patterns of the language; in small ways or big ways they are *exploitations* of the established patterns. I am not just referring to the highly mannered poetry that we have been looking at closely above, but to almost every utterance beyond the most phatic of communions. The *ad hoc* nature of stylistics, far from being an embarrassing feature of the discipline, could, in a renaissance, become its foundation stone.

Here an analyser must give way to an interpreter. The analyser looks for familiar patterns for which it has stored meaning assignments; the interpreter looks for unfamiliar patterns for which it has to propose a meaning. The jobs are complementary, but the initial information is the same – a clear and comprehensive account of the established meaning-bearing patterns of the language. The more precise this can be, the easier will be the task of the interpreter in judging how far a combination is from one or more normal ones. And precision comes from assimilating and summarising as much corpus data as possible.

## 12.10 Coda

There is one pattern that I have left to the end; not because it is particularly important but because it illustrates the almost parasitical nature of the rhetorical structure, ready to make use of any aspect of the metrical or syntactic structure. The pattern was not easy for me to isolate, so it may be rather subliminal for most readers.

When we were reviewing the forms and functions of the couplet, we had rather little to say about the later ones from the sixth to the end. Line 11 is an opener, and line 18 a closer, but in between we have a succession of lines all with vaguely similar pattern and meaning. They clearly constitute an important build-up to give

punch to the last line, but aside from their general repetitive quality it is not easy to see the gathering of poetic energy during the passage.

But consider the position of the mid-line punctuation. The number of the syllable after which the punctuation mark occurs is, for lines 12–17:

7 7 6 6 5 4

And the first comma of line 18 occurs after syllable 3. So the first half-lines are getting progressively shorter, anticipating the onset of the final line. In the first half of each of these lines we see also a move from a rather murky situation in lines 12–13 to a repeated pattern in 14 onwards where the first half-line expresses a most positive quality about *Man*, and the second half gives the paradoxical opposite position. It is the positive phrases that are getting shorter as they get grander and more pompous (*great lord of all things, sole judge of truth*) and a kind of irony arises as it seems that they may be engulfed by their lengthening and unfortunate antonyms. The last line comes to the rescue here, and first miniaturises the patterns of the previous lines by packing the positive side into three syllables and the negative side into one, *jest*. This reverses the length balance and leaves most of the line for the rather comforting middle ground, the balance of the opposing states.

Unless one dismisses this evidence as coincidental, which is a dangerous position to take with Mr. Pope's work, it is clear that the rhetorical structure switches its priorities gradually from the drumbeat of lines 7b-10 to a more subtle manifestation, controlling the build-up through a succession of lines which are unremarkable in themselves but which together create a powerful meaning.

**Table 12.** Analytical Summary

| | line | couplet | passage | segment | para |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Know, then, thyself, presume not God to scan; | (chiasmus) | (chiasmus) | opening | | |
| The proper study of mankind is man. | (chiasmus) | accentuated halved-whole | | | opening |
| Placed on this isthmus of a middle state, | (chiasmus) | whole-halved | opening arresting | first | |
| A being darkly wise, and rudely great: | double-pair | | common frame | | |
| With too much knowledge for the sceptic side, | (pair) | aligned | central | | |
| With too much weakness for the stoic's pride, | (pair) | | matched frame | | |
| He hangs between; | | | closing | | central |
| | | | end arrest | | |
| in doubt to act or rest; | pair | residual | central | second | |
| In doubt to deem himself a god, or beast; | pair | | embedded | | |
| In doubt his mind or body to prefer; | pair | whole-halved | matched frame | | |
| Born but to die, and reasoning but to err; | double-pair | | closing, release | | |
| Alike in ignorance, his reason such, | (chiasmus) | halved-halved | opening | | |
| Whether he thinks too little, or too much: | pair | | | third | |
| Chaos of thought and passion, all confused; | chiasmus? | halved-halved | central | | |
| Still by himself abused, or disabused; | pair | | shared frame | | |
| Created half to rise, and half to fall; | pair | halved-halved | | | |
| Great lord of all things, yet a prey to all; | pair | | mixed frame | | |
| Sole judge of truth, in endless error hurled: | pair | unclassified | | | |
| The glory, jest, and riddle of the world! | triple | | closing, end release | | closing |

CHAPTER 13

# Fictional worlds revisited*

## 13.1 Introduction[1]

If we stand back and observe our own behaviour, then fiction appears to be a strange condition. We speak and write things which are not the case, though both speaker and listener, writer and reader, know that what they are communicating is not the case. Far from this practice being discouraged, it is often much applauded and some of those who make a habit of it are accorded extremely high places in society.

Yet it must be part of the normal social contract that, within broadly agreed limits, we mean what we say. Fiction apart, we have quite unpleasant words like 'lies' for statements which do not accord with the facts.

Any competent theory of language must be able to account for this phenomenon – how the status of fiction is granted to some counterfactuals but not others. A comprehensive theory of language will go further, because it will account for literary texts, many of which are fictional. It will explain how fictional utterances are interpreted, and why people bother to communicate in this odd way.

In general, theories of language ignore fiction, theories of literature take it for granted, and philosophical works take up a variety of positions. This neglect is reflected in a tendency for fiction and non-fiction to be confused. There are celebrated cases of apparent duplicity (like Mandeville's *Travels*), dubious allocation (*The Pied Piper*), and doubtful categorisation (*Robinson Crusoe*). The verisimilitude of radio, television and film increases the likelihood of such

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1. As its title indicates, this chapter is based upon an earlier one, "Fictional Worlds", which appeared in *Talking About Text* (Coulthard 1987), but which is no longer available. This is an opportunity to improve and enlarge the arguments of the original paper. Also, while it was in press an important book with the same title appeared (Pavel 1986). This book is recommended highly to the reader who wishes to delve further into the subject. I have benefited from both its breadth and detail in rewriting my paper for this volume, but my discourse-oriented approach is sufficiently distinct from Pavel's to remain in parallel to it.

confusions and fictional characters are treated as factual by a lot of aficionados. It is said that Ronald Reagan, when President of the United States, while praising the war efforts of the Americans, recounted an incident which to everyone's embarrassment turned out to have originated in a film and not a battle.

## 13.2 Fact and averral

I shall begin with the normal accounts of meaning in non-fiction. This is the area of truth and falsehood, propositions, assertions and a number of other tricky concepts. For the purposes of this argument I require only two contrasting terms, and one relationship.

A state of affairs in the real world around us will be called a fact. A fact has no linguistic implications whatsoever. The vast majority of facts would exist whether or not language existed. Each one of them may be relatable to a large number of linguistic expressions, or it may blush unseen and attract no verbalisation at all. At any given moment, only a tiny proportion of the available facts are the foci of verbalisation.

The verbal assertion that something is the case will be called an *averral*. This slightly unusual term is preferred because 'assertion' in its normal use carries the meaning of emphasis. An averral is an utterance; therefore it is said by someone to someone on some occasion. It is relatable to other utterances in a discourse or a text, in that it may come after some utterance and be related to it by cohesive ties, or it may prospect forward to other utterances or possible utterances. It is also relatable to other members of the paradigm which it represents – the population from which it has been chosen.

An averral, then, is a linguistic item. It takes its place in the organised framework that has been built up to describe languages. Averrals contrast with facts as follows:

It is a fact that my left foot is slightly larger than my right foot. It is an averral when I say in a shoe shop "My left foot is slightly larger than my right foot," in order to be given left shoes to try on.

Every averral is also a fact, namely the fact of the averral, and that is a different fact from the fact which is being averred. But it is not necessary to continue this line in the present discussion.

## 13.3 Correspondence

The relationship between a fact and an averral is some sort of *correspondence*. Participants devise or deduce that what is being averred corresponds to a state

of affairs. There are two crucial points to establishing a correspondence. First, it must be accepted that an utterance can aver something which itself cannot be verbalised, and second, it must be possible for participants to agree broadly what the 'something' is that is being averred; in many cases it will be interpreted as a fact.

Correspondence is unlikely to be exact, for several reasons. For one, participants usually use a *default* strategy rather than an explicit strategy in order to establish correspondence; in other words, they tend to accept an obvious interpretation silently, and wait and see. Even attempts at precise use of language, as in legal documents, leave huge areas of uncertainty, and most everyday uses of language are much too casual for there to be any precision in the correspondence (Channell 1994). Another reason is that a fact and an averral are, as pointed out above, utterly different entities and therefore highly unlikely to map precisely on to each other. In the example given above, we rely on people interpreting 'slightly' on a suitable scale, since if the difference in size between my feet were microscopic then it would not affect my comfort; and if the difference were obvious I would not need to refer to it.

Several types of correspondence can be observed. One notable type is the pair true-false. This presumes an exact correspondence, or something very close to it, and a sharp distinction between that (*true*) and everything else (*false*). As noted above, such correspondence is untypical of averral, and indeed of our normal awareness and the level of attention that we normally give to communication.

What actually happens in language is a galaxy of half-truths, exaggerations, generalisations, expressions of feelings, and mistakes of all kinds. All these are regularly taken as positive correspondences by the default convention, unless challenged.

## 13.4 Discourse

Let us rephrase the discussion to date in terms of the description of discourse, beginning with spoken discourse. Interaction occurs in real time, and participants are obliged to make operational judgments about correspondence; essentially the addressee must choose to accept each move or explicitly challenge it. Participants have no opportunity to verify an utterance unless the conversation is about the immediate environment, and any introduction of that for purposes of verification will be taken as a challenge.

There is a basic presumption about speakers, that they associate themselves with what they say. If they make averrals, it is assumed that they believe that what they aver corresponds with the facts. A speaker cannot say:

> This costs £5, but it doesn't

The first statement would have to be attributed elsewhere:

> This is said to cost £5, but it doesn't

Or it would have to be made hypothetical:

> This should cost £5, but it doesn't

Or it would have to be qualified in one of various ways:

> This costs £5 normally, but it doesn't today

Or the utterance would have to show a sudden change in attitude:

> This costs £5 – well, actually, it doesn't

We can represent the warranty that leads to these limitations as follows:

> (I aver that) this costs £5.

The other participants in the conversation must immediately decide whether to accept this averral as a positive correspondence, or to challenge. Thus a challenge would not be very likely if one knew that the object in question cost £4.95; or if one glanced at the object and felt that the averral corresponded to a reasonable estimate; or if one knew it cost £5.50 but one also knew the speaker fancied himself as a bargain hunter, and the difference was not significant in the context.

If it is not immediately challenged, then the participants are establishing operationally a positive correspondence. This can be made clear by all sorts of accepting responses. For example,

> Yes, I suppose so.
> Well, everything's going up these days.

Some responses which are accepting can appear at face value to be challenges, but paradoxically they reinforce positive correspondence by adding the feature of surprised reaction.

> I don't believe it!
> It didn't!
> You don't say!

Unless there is a challenge, the positive correspondence is assumed to be established by the end of the discourse unit called the exchange (which might include a third, follow-up element). One of the functions of the exchange boundary is to indicate the mutual recognition of the correspondence. All decisions in a conversation are provisional until the end of the conversation, however, and they can be referred to later on and revised.

Well in that case it can't have cost £5.
Didn't you say it cost £5?
What did you say it cost?
Do you remember earlier on I said it cost £5?
Let's do those sums again.

The challenges that can be made are many and varied (Burton 1980). One class of challenges serves to suspend the assignment of correspondence, rather than make a negative assignment.

A This cost £5
B How did that come about?
or B Where on earth did you buy it?
or B I thought they were less than that.

After some further discussion, the matter may be resolved and positive correspondence may be assigned.

So decisions about correspondence are mutual, and provisional, in that they can always be returned to; but the default condition operates so that correspondence is always assigned within a short space of time.

In the written language, there is no opportunity to negotiate correspondence, and so the responsibility is with the author to ensure that the default condition can be operated safely. From this point of view, the relation of correspondence has a strong evaluative element in it. It is not a neat and precise alignment of facts and averrals, but a continuously changing interpretation of the world according to the circumstances of the conversation at the time. It first has to be established that the positive correspondence of an averral is acceptable to both participants. Then the utterance has to be interpreted according to the conditions of its occurrence, which include relating it to the state of the discourse in terms, broadly speaking, of communicative acts.

Once again it is underlined that the factual correspondence of an averral is never the only factor in communication, and often not even an important one. This point of view contrasts with some studies of language in which it may be found helpful to distinguish between what seem to be 'objective' facts like:

Paris is the capital of France.

and expressions of personal taste like:

I feel sick.

In this view of discourse, such a distinction is not necessary, because either of the above averrals, unless challenged, will be used as the factual basis of the next stage of the conversation.

The factual correspondence of any averral can be stated explicitly, for instance:

> It is true that Paris is the capital of France.

but that averral (it is true that *P*) now becomes part of the discourse, with a correspondence which is presumably the same as the reported averral which now lies inside it. The example just quoted is normally used as a way of dismissing or devaluing the fact which is embedded in the subordinate clause; and there is an unlimited number of alternative prefaces like 'It is true that …'.

From the above discussion it can be concluded that objective reality plays no part in the distinction between fact and fiction. It is not the state of the world that matters but the conventions accepted by the parties to a discourse.

## 13.5 Misleading language

When an averral cannot be ultimately accepted as corresponding to a state of affairs, the speaker or writer is seen to be (usually with hindsight) either *misleading* or *misled*. They are misled if they believe that there is such a correspondence, but it transpires that the correspondence is not exact enough to be positive. They are misleading if they do not believe that there is a correspondence, but nevertheless make the averral.

Fictional statements are identical to misleading ones from this point of view. In order to distinguish them from each other, we have to consider the hearer's position. If the hearer makes the default assumption, and expects the averrals to correspond with states of affairs, then the hearer is indeed misled. If, however, the hearer also does not expect a correspondence, then the conditions of a fictional averral are met.

It is worthwhile summarising these conditions in a simple table in order to draw an important conclusion. 'Y' means that there is a correspondence between the averral and a fact.

**Table 13.1** Conditions

| | Speaker says | Speaker believes | State of affairs | Hearer expects | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Y | N | Y | Y | misleading |
| 2 | Y | N | N | Y | misleading |
| 3 | Y | N | Y | N | fiction |
| 4 | Y | N | N | N | fiction |

Note that the actual state of affairs does not affect the classification. In other words, when we decide to treat utterances as fictional we are not trying to establish their factual or counterfactual status. The condition of fiction is thus reserved for utterances which are averred by a speaker without regard for their correspondence, and where this curious relationship is recognised by other participants, who are expecting that the correspondence will be irrelevant.

Although the correspondence does not affect the status of the averrals, it is not by any means irrelevant to the interpretation of the fiction. Let us assume that the conditions for fiction are established as above. If a speaker says, under these conditions:

> My mother is ninety-three

then no-one assumes that this is necessarily the case. If evidence come to light that the speaker's mother is in fact ninety-three, then this does not affect the fictional status of the averral, though in practice it may occasion a request for reconfirmation of the fictional status. Equally, if it became obvious that the speaker's mother was nowhere near ninety-three, the listeners would make some sort of assumption about why such a fiction was necessary; the age of the speaker's mother would assume greater importance.

Thus the way in which the fiction is interpreted and evaluated may be affected by the relation between the fictional averrals and the reader or listener's awareness of their relation to fact.

If a writer inserts an obscure factual averral in his fiction, for instance:

> St Asaph is the smallest city in Britain

then it hardly matters whether or not a reader assigns it a positive correspondence since he or she will surmise that, within the fiction, it has verisimilitude.

The notion of verisimilitude reconciles fact and fiction in one respect. Verisimilitude is the evaluation of an utterance as fictional but close to a factual correspondence; the averral is therefore not assigned positive correspondence, though it is recognised as, in practical terms, virtually the equivalent of one which would be positively assessed. This almost paradoxical position leads to two important observations.

a. fiction and fact at the level of sentences are not in contrast with each other. If they were, they would be mutually exclusive, and verisimilitude would be something to be avoided at all costs. A writer of fiction would have to steer quite clear of anything he or she knew to be a fact. However, once a writer has established a fiction, he or she is free to introduce any averrals, no matter how close they are to fact, knowing that they will not overstep the limits of verisimilitude.

b. fictional status takes preference over factual, where both are possible. That is to say, verisimilitude does not confer the status of factual averral on an utterance. Once a fiction, always a fiction.

## 13.6 Artefact

Reviewing the discussion so far, we have arrived at a position that is both unlikely and impractical. It is on the verge of ludicrous to suppose that people will converse without being concerned about the factual status of what they say, and it is not easy to see how the assignment of status is made, utterance by utterance.

Nevertheless, the assignment of status is made, and it is not a trivial matter. Confusion of fact and fiction can lead to serious problems of understanding the world. We must seek a model which will make sense of this bizarre situation.

The solution proposed here is to postulate a unit of discourse above the sentence which will carry the distinction between fiction and non-fiction. This postulation will allow that

a. the assignment of fictional status does not conflict with the factual correspondence of individual statements. Lies and factual mistakes are confined to nonfiction.
b. the larger unit may lead us to a rationale for the existence of fiction, and an explanation of its privileged position.

The study of discourse has already (Sinclair 1981) put forward a suitable unit, called the *artefact*. The artefact is the highest linguistic unit, and all language behaviour is presumed to be a contribution to an artefact.

There is a special type of evaluation reserved for artefacts. Although lower linguistic units are assessed for their correspondence to fact, this is often provisional and tentative, as the previous discussion has shown. Only an artefact has an irreversible effect upon the world, and it is at the point of making its effect that the fictional status is relevant. The factual artefact will fit well with the real world, its origins clear and its contribution usually reasonably clear also. The filling of gaps in information will be fairly predictable, and few imaginative adjustments will be required. The fictional artefact, on the other hand, will have points of contact with the real world but will be seen as operating at best in parallel with it, because of some irreconcilable differences between the world subsumed in the fiction and the real world.

In fictions with high verisimilitude, the irreconcilables will be few and minor; in fantasy work the points of contact may be minimal. However, just one

irreconcilable state of affairs is enough to mark a fiction, and in theory a fiction could be entirely composed of averrals which looked extremely like facts.

It must be emphasised that in practice, whether in speech or in writing, the receiver of fiction is not likely to read with a critical attention to the correspondence between the statements and knowable states of affairs, and may well take up an attitude which only relates to the detailed verisimilitude in the most general terms. Such and such a novel is felt to be broadly in accord with the facts, for example.

We return to philosophy for guidance on how a fiction may be seen as operating in parallel with the real world – the theory of possible worlds (Lewis 1973: 84–5). The application of this theory helps to clear up truth-value problems.

Essentially, we assume the possibility of a limitless number of worlds, each of which differs from the real world in at least one state of affairs. With this hypothesis we can approach a variety of problems and explain how they can be understood and evaluated. Historical change, for example, gives rise to perfectly reasonable concepts like the King of France, who happens not to exist at present. But since there were several Kings of France in the historical period, it is not difficult to postulate a possible world where there might be a King of France, and where the averral 'The King of France is bald' will have a truth value.

Myth and legend can also be understood in terms of possible worlds. We can postulate a possible world where there are unicorns to be found, and entertain propositions about them; if there is doubt about the authenticity of King Arthur, or some of his doings, then we can conjure up a suitable possible world and then relate that world to our own. This would seem to be a happy home for fiction, if a fictional artefact is a set of averrals about a possible world.

What, then, is the mechanism that creates these fictions, and who avers them? We do not assign fictional status utterance by utterance, for we would not then be able to distinguish them from lies, etc. The assignment of status is made at the level of artefact. Participants in discourse associate themselves with the goal of the fiction at the level of artefact, but decline responsibility for the veracity of the individual statements.

It was said earlier that we presume that speakers associate themselves with what they say; but since they can have no direct experience of a possible world, their fictional statements cannot be expected to conform to this convention. So the speakers or writers are not in any sense authorities on the worlds they talk about, in the sense that they may be about the world of facts. This accounts for the strange quality of discourse which argues about features of a possible world. "But last night you said their eyes were green, daddy!"

The only expert on correspondences with a possible world is a denizen of the possible world in question. The case thus evolves for the construction of another default hypothesis – that since fictions must be averred by someone, then in the absence of such a narrator being identified by the real-world author, one must be postulated. The real-world author then reports what this abstract entity, called the Fictional Narrator, is taken to aver.

To recapitulate. If a speaker appears to aver something that is not the case, then

a. the speaker believes that it is the case, and is misled; or
b. the speaker is lying; or
c. the speaker is engaged in reporting a fiction, and the fictional averral is to be taken as consistent with a possible world inhabited by the Fictional Narrator.

The notion of possible worlds is clearly a matter of convenience; worlds are postulated according to the needs of particular arguments. It seems that the priorities and purposes of philosophy have led to some conventions which are not helpful to the student of fiction, and I wish to turn to a consideration of what would be the most appropriate application of the theory of possible worlds to the theory of literature.

## 13.7 Fictional worlds

In the philosophical tradition, the convention has grown up that possible worlds are identical to each other except for certain explicit differences. This is not a useful convention for fiction, because fiction is concerned with the play of the imagination, and the most suitable kind of possible world for fiction is almost the opposite; a world about which the only available information is what is stated in the text. The text as it unfolds forms an inventory of established correspondences, and all other decisions lie with the reader/interpreter.

So we require a model where a reader of fantastic fiction, having been told of several unusual facts in the fictional world, will assume that world to be full of unusual facts, and will build that assumption into the framework of interpretation of the remaining text. As the reader encounters each subsequent sentence, there will be adjustments, and at the end of the tale the reader will have constructed a fictional world which includes most of the facts given, and a very large number which have not been given. This is in contrast with the kind of reader envisaged in the philosophical convention – where each fact which cannot be averred simply replaces its opposite in a world which is otherwise identical to the real world.

I do not wish this to be construed as critical of the philosophical work that has accumulated. The aims of a philosopher discussing truth are quite different from those of a student of English discussing literature. It appears that for the latter the normal notion of a possible world is just not suitable, and that we should seek to define a special kind of possible world – a fictional world – with which the particular concerns of literary fictions can be studied.

There is a further point to be made in support of this position. It relates to the relation between a fact and an averral. In the real world when we aver something, we are not merely selecting a fact for expression; we are organising the world in a particular way, one of the indefinitely many ways in which we may order it. The fact is dependent on its expression, and not the other way round. The world is not a collection of facts waiting to be averred; however, when something is averred its correspondence can be confirmed.

In a fictional world, there are also no facts waiting to be averred. Not only is each 'fact' created by an averral, but, unlike the real world, we know nothing about anything which is not averred – we cannot say whether or not there is correspondence with a 'fact'. Consequently, since only the act of averral can create a 'fact', the selection of what is said assumes greater importance than does the same activity in ordinary discourse. Nothing else can be assumed to exist, and there is no procedure available for finding correspondences.

Let us adduce one or two examples to support this basic case. George Orwell's *Nineteen Eighty-Four* begins with the words

> It was a bright cold day in April…

The reader might be expected to relate this to everyday experience and interpret it as scene-setting. Orwell continues

> … and the clocks were striking …

Again, nothing unusual. One of the things clocks do is strike.

> … thirteen.

No clock, properly adjusted, has ever struck more than twelve. The reader is disorientated and alerted to the fact that this world is a strange place. The 24-hour clock is indeed in the modern, smart, digital, international idiom, so the indication of a future time setting is made. Few readers probably consider the impracticality of a clock striking, say, twenty-one.

Another example concerns the problem that children have in plays where characters converse 'aside'. If one is captivated by a performance, it is difficult to imagine that what the characters say is not necessarily relevant to the action and is unscripted. The indeterminate nature of the fictional world is starkly apparent.

Thirdly, there is a class of detective fiction where conventions apply that allow the reader to be kept uninformed about matters which would be inescapably obvious if the reader were able to use his own sense organs. Perhaps the most outrageous is Agatha Christie's *The Murder of Roger Ackroyd*, where the murderer is the narrator. This character documents the case in detail but omits his account of the actual murder until the obligatory confession at the end. My apologies to anyone who has not yet read this mould-breaking novel.

The writer has total creative initiative. No matter what has gone before or what it is reasonable to expect, the writer can do something else. The reader rapidly learns this and develops critical appreciation from the experience of being exposed to such arbitrary power. Also the way in which a fictional work is evaluated takes account of this power. If a story ends inconsequentially or unsatisfactorily, we assume that the writer chose that ending from all possible endings. Hence the same story – the same text – can have two quite different reader reactions according to whether it is read as fact or fiction.

## 13.8 Fictional narrator

Let us return to the postulation of a fictional narrator. In the previous argument, it was concluded that such an entity had to be postulated in order to combine the notions of averring and fiction. The real world author does not aver fictions – he or she merely reports them.

This extra narrative layer breaks one of the strongest of our normal communicative bonds – the way in which participants in conversation identify with each other. The Gricean maxim of sincerity is a name for a mass of conventions whereby we learn to trust each other (Grice 1975).

If someone is telling us a real life story, we identify with the real world speaker or writer. Just occasionally, if we know the people in the story very well, and the narrator starts complaining about one of them, we may switch to empathising with that person; then we have to monitor our reactions carefully, because they may not be appropriate to the narration.

If, on the other hand, someone is reporting a fiction, we have no need to identify with that person beyond the appreciation of the fiction as a whole, and the reason for its being reported. We then have a requirement to identify with one of the fictional characters (including the fictional narrator if that entity figures as a character through the use of the *I*-pronoun).

This creates an extra choice that is just not available under sincerity conditions, and one which in literary criticism is often significant in value judgments.

## 13.9 Communicative purpose

We can now approach the question of how a fiction achieves its communicative purpose, and I shall offer two complementary explanations, one technical and one cultural. For the technical explanation it must be reiterated that there are many facts that are unknown to a speaker at any time. If one such is averred, how is the speaker to distinguish it from a fictional statement? If someone says to me:

> Henry Smith is forty-two.

then I, as hearer, may know a Henry Smith and know enough about him for the averral to establish a correspondence with my experience. On the other hand, if no-one called Henry Smith comes to mind, and I have reason to believe that the statement is part of a fiction, then must create a fictional world about which I know only that there is a person there called Henry Smith, and that he (even the he is something of a presumption) is aged forty-two.

What if it is unlikely that I am involved in interpreting a fiction, and that there is merely a mismatch between what the speaker thinks I know, and what I do know? The speaker assumes I know Henry Smith, and that either I do not know his age or it is relevant to what follows that I am reminded of it. If I am really lost, and must explicitly clarify the position of our mutual knowledge before proceeding, then I must challenge the presupposition that I know Henry Smith. But I may not want to do this; mismatches of this kind occur all the time, and we would never get any business done if we demanded total alignment of our mutual knowledge. I have the option of riding along with the presuppositions of the speaker, trying to work out who Henry Smith is and why his age is relevant. A neutral response like 'Really' will do.

In these circumstances I am doing exactly what I would do if I interpreted the statement as a fiction. I create a world where everything is the same as usual except that there is a new character in it called Henry Smith and he is 42 years old. During the conversation I am using the same techniques as I would use to understand a fairy story, but by the end of the artefact I will have evaluated this information and adjusted my factual world to accommodate Henry Smith. If it had been a fiction I would at the end of the artefact evaluate the fiction for its general relevance to my affairs, not as a set of facts to be incorporated in my world knowledge.

Our everyday experience of language is actually a mixture of these two kinds of experience, because we are constantly making mini-creations when there is some perplexity in what is said or written to us. Many utterances, as we hear them, assume some knowledge that we do not share, or which we do not hear in full, because of accent, extraneous noise, lack of attention, etc.

The contention here is that fiction can be seen as an extension of an interpretive technique that we are using all the time anyway. Much the same skill is shown in sophisticated reading activities like finding one's place, skimming, scanning and speed reading. Only the status of the artefact causes the final evaluation to be different.

The cultural explanation of how we cope with fiction takes us up to the level of the artefact. There are fairly obvious conventions, and we must assume that people are alert, particularly at the beginning of a discourse, for signals that would indicate a fiction.

> Once upon a time
> Have you heard the one about …
> A Novel
> A Tragedy

There are situational factors, too, for example attendance at a place or event where fictions are known to occur. Libraries and bookshops are often sectionalised and explicitly labelled. In practice there is not often any doubt, because it is normally of great importance to writer and reader, speaker and listener, that the status of the discourse is clear. Any doubt is likely to be cleared up immediately.

It is improbable that a participant will continue a discourse without taking a decision on this fundamental issue. Since, taken sentence by sentence, ordinary discourse and fiction are identical with each other, and the techniques of interpretation are also the same, they are dangerously confusable, and it would hardly be tolerable to maintain a dual interpretation for long.

There is a body of opinion that maintains that much discourse is a blend of fact and fiction, often cunning and deliberate. 'Faction' is one class of such material. Many fictions claim to be 'based on fact'. The working of historical processes makes it possible for confusions to arise and even a shift in status. Of the works mentioned in the introduction Mandeville's *Travels* comes to mind as an example of a work which was accepted in its time as non-fiction, but is now thought to be fantastic.

I shall mention briefly some famous cases in order to map out the territory. Many works of fiction purport to be factual. With some it is for reasons of satire or ridicule, like *Gulliver's Travels*. With others it seems to be little more than a convention to give some verisimilitude to the fictional narrator, as in Scott. There is a class of modern realistic fiction which is strikingly true to facts and features long informative passages, like Frederick Forsyth's *The Day of the Jackal*. A celebrated case occurred in the United States some years ago when Orson Welles produced *The War of the Worlds* on radio and created a panic because listeners thought it was a newsflash. These remain fiction.

Some experimental authors of novels, from Laurence Sterne to John Fowles and David Lodge, appear to address the reader from within the text and again give verisimilitude to that particular portion of the fiction (the remainder – the actual story – is relegated by contrast to an irretrievably fictional status). In practice of course what is happening is that the author is trying to get the reader to merge the fictional narrator with the actual writer – and that divide cannot be crossed.

An autobiography or biography is non-fictional, even though it may be full of factual inaccuracies, reflecting to a greater or lesser extent the way we exaggerate, selectively inform and blunder in our ordinary discourse. On the other hand a historical novel is fictional even though most of the things it says are in positive correspondence with facts.

The powerful novella by Marques, *Chronicle of a Death Foretold*, deals with a ritual killing that no-one seems to have wanted, but honour and duty demanded. Not even the designated victim attempts to avoid his fate. The story is told as realistic fiction, close to journalistic reporting, keeping to chronology and with the narrator adopting very low profile.

Yet because of the strange, almost impossible story and the heavy progress of the forces of destiny, and the archetypal nature of the participants and what happens to them and what they are driven to do, this book assumes the status of a fiction which is on the margin of credibility. The simple, matter-of-fact style becomes a powerful weapon, because of its contrast with the grim and gripping events portrayed. It becomes allegorical. The people do not seem to be real people, but characters created by the author in order to tell a tale of universal and perpetual relevance.

A year or two after publication it emerged that the tale was substantially true – so close to fact that one of the characters was taking legal action against the author, not for getting the story wrong, but for getting it right.

This twist does not alter the status or critical place of *Chronicle*. It tells us something about the writers' craft, where they get their material from, how they process it and how they create various kinds of fictional illusion.

When there is such an essential and profound distinction as that between fiction and non-fiction, it can be assumed that all sorts of people – not just literary authors – will exploit it, manipulate, blur and confuse. It would be a diversion from the theme of this chapter to go into the various techniques found outside literary forms of persuading people to treat fictions as factual. But, however successful the myth-makers are, I am not aware of any circumstance when the distinction has actually lapsed into disuse, or does not appear to have arisen in a particular social group. If it ever becomes really unfashionable to hold to a distinction between fact and fiction, the opportunities for corporate illusion-making will become unlimited.

The fictional worlds and the real world obviously overlap in that they share many correspondences, but the point of this whole argument is that they remain discrete, since fictional status is applied only to an artefact as a whole. Hence no matter how doubtful is a decision, or how crafty an author's wiles, at any one time a competent reader or listener is interpreting in one mode or the other.

The value of the fictional option lies in the creative initiative open to writer and reader, speaker and listener. As has been mentioned already, the speaker/writer of fiction has total creative initiative, and can say anything whatsoever; he or she bears a corresponding responsibility because there is no recourse to the real world, the responsibility of crafting a fiction in which everything is significant, and nothing arbitrary. The hearer/reader, on the basis of the fictional messages, also creates a fictional world which begins with his or her raw imaginative responses to the messages, and gradually approximates to the fictional world of the speaker/writer.

Since fictional utterances are not averred in the real world, the whole of a fictional artefact becomes one large composite averral. People do not and should not respond to statements within the fiction where these appear to overlap with the real world.

A film of the mid-eighties, *The Purple Rose of Cairo*, explores what happens when the membrane between the two worlds is pierced. A minor character steps off the screen and tries to live in the real world. The various problems are amusingly handled, but the patent absurdity of the plot prevents any coherent composite statement getting through.

## 13.10 Conclusion

Our conventions of verbal interaction require us to settle at the outset of any artefact (in speech or writing) whether it is to be understood as fact or fiction. No matter how the individual utterances of the artefact may correspond with objective reality, the overall status of the text is not affected – though the original assignment may be challenged at any time. The relation of utterance to averral and to states of affairs is profoundly affected by this original assignment, as is the apportionment of responsibility and the method of interpretation of the artefact as a whole.

Seen in this light, the organisation of language is not dependent on things that are or happen in the world but rather on what people are willing to agree on, as a practical expedient, for the purposes of communication. This change of emphasis is valuable for the study of language in general, and particularly valuable for the comparison of fictional and nonfictional pieces.

It is argued that the factual or fictional status of an utterance has nothing to do with its correspondence or lack of correspondence with anything in the world.

Normally the status of the artefact will be determined early in its progress, but in any case since no participant has universal knowledge, appeals to factual correspondence are of no interest.

It is further argued that the mechanism by which we understand a fiction is identical to the way in which we cope with averrals that erroneously assume our awareness of some factual correspondence – hence fiction does not need people to acquire any additional interpretative skills.

This view of language is nevertheless consistent with claims made about the special status of literature; in particular the opportunity it offers to writer and reader to give play to their imagination. In this model of a fictional world, the hearer or reader assumes identity with the familiar world in all respects except those which are replaced by fictional statement or inference. Naturally, fantastic fiction will encourage the hearer/reader to abandon aspects of the familiar world much more readily than 'faction'.

The relationship between narrators within a fiction and the real-world author is clarified by the positing of a Fictional Narrator, who avers anything that is not presumed to in correspondence with facts; and the circumstances under which a reader of fiction is able to identify with one character or another are clarified.

CHAPTER 14

# "Passion speechlesse lies"*

## 14.1 Introduction[1]

Early reactions to stylistic analysis (in the late fifties and sixties) tended to sound like paraphrases of my title, whether it is interpreted word by word (Passion! Speechless! Lies!) or as a clause. Literary scholars found it difficult to relate the rather inert evidence of nouns and verbs, articles and prepositions to the unique event that was a poem; for many, the scientific approach had invaded territory for which it was quite unsuited.

Some critics tried to defend their freedom to ignore evidence by pointing out that poets do not need to be consciously aware of the linguistic mechanisms that they use with such skill. You can drive a car brilliantly without knowing what a tappet is. But the writers did not all take up this position. The reactions of Auden and Graves were quite different. They understood immediately the value of detailed and rigorous analysis and revealed how painstakingly they constructed and evaluated their own writings. They had elaborate personal linguistic theories in which they trusted.

The position of the writer-critics, the hybrids, was interesting. To some, like Blunden, stylistics was anathema; to Empson it was too confining, though he recognised the affinity with his own technique of extended semantic commentary. Richards thought it was just a tortuous way of conducting his own favoured close reading.

Edwin Thumboo in Singapore, writer, critic and academic, embraced it generously and allowed his own poetry to be used in experiment. He also saw that stylistics could be a cohesive factor in the development of a broad modern Department of English out of a traditional Eng. Lit. group.

Linguistics has developed substantially since the sixties, and while some of its more theoretical concerns have not been of immediate relevance to stylistics,

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* This chapter appeared originally in Tong, C.K., Pakir, A., Ban, K.C. & Goh, R. (eds). 1997. Ariels. Departures and Returns. Essays for Edwin Thumboo. Singapore: Oxford University Press.

1. Drafts of this chapter were commented on by Dr Sonia Zyngier and Dr Leticia Frossard of the Federal University of Rio de Janeiro, and it has been tightened up a lot as a result of their penetrating criticisms. I am also grateful to Mr. I.A. Shapiro of the University of Birmingham for help in the tricky job of isolating the indications of informality in the text. His vast experience of the writings of the time informed me and gave me confidence, but the responsibility for the decisions is mine.

other areas have opened up new opportunities. In this chapter a number of points are made from the perspective of discourse analysis, seeing the poem as highly sensitive to the conventions of spoken interaction.

## 14.2 The poem as record of verbal interaction[2]

Since ther's no helpe, Come let us kisse and part,
Nay, I have done: you get no more of Me,
And I am glad, yea glad withall my heart,
That thus so cleanly, I my Selfe can free,
Shake hands for ever, Cancell all our Vowes,
And when We meet at any time againe,
Be it not seene in either of our Browes,
That We one jot of former Love reteyne;
Now at the last gaspe, of Loves latest Breath,
When his Pulse fayling, Passion speechlesse lies,
When Faith is kneeling by his bed of Death,
And Innocence is closing up his Eyes,
Now if thou would'st, when all have given him over,
From Death to Life, thou might'st him yet recover.

The sonnet printed above was written over 400 years ago, in an earlier form of English. It is the only poem of its author that is really well-known, and it is considered to be a masterpiece of the Elizabethan sonnet.

It seems to have a directness about its language, and a modernness, for the first half at least. The modern reader does not feel the need to adjust, but can interpret the language in almost the same way as that of today. There is a period flavour, but nothing really puzzling, about the early part of the poem.

This is remarkable because a poem is one of the most 'context-free' of texts; it usually leaves a number of jobs of interpretation to the reader. People and places may not be clearly identified, and important events may not be described. Some poems thrive on obscurity and use the conventions to leave many interpretations available to suit the reader. This poem does not read as if it is dealing with deep obscurities, but rather that it is a racy account of a lovers' tiff. In any event, there must be features in the language of the poem that allow the reader to decide how closely it should be related to the world of normal experience; if closely, then the text should provide the evidence to allow the reader to conjure up appropriate contexts.

This chapter makes the assumption that a poem is related to the world of normal experience, though not usually directly; since for most readers a poem will

2. in Post, J.F.S. 1999. *English Lyric Poetry. The Early Seventeenth Century*, London: Routledge, p. 59.

be fictionalised (see Chapter 13, this volume), there will be at least one layer of interpretation between the world we live in and the statements of the poetic text. Of course, poems also occur as directly communicative in the real world, in which case the only poetic aspect of them is their form, but in the present case we can dismiss that relationship as absurd. Michael Drayton is not emotionally engaged with all possible readers of his poem down the centuries, trying to achieve a new love relationship with each of them. Michael Drayton does not need to be the *I* of the poem.

Nevertheless, the poem can be seen as a record of a verbal interaction. Readers are not direct participants in the interaction but observe its progress at one stage removed, where they are invited to identify with one or more of the participants, and to relate the experience of reading the poem to their own experience, perhaps to a similar incident in their own lives. The lack of clear identification of the participants and their circumstances then becomes a positive advantage of the poem, increasing its potential relevance and simultaneously drawing in readers because of requiring them to put their imaginations to work in order to compensate for the low level of detail in the text of the poem.

So whatever the relation between the poem, the reader and the various worlds they inhabit, a number of questions can be asked as a framework for interpretation:

Who is talking to whom?
On what occasion?
What about?
With what goals?
With what outcome?
How is the action presented?

To begin with, the textual evidence that helps in answering these questions will be assembled, using conventional linguistic categories most of the time. Then this evidence will be used in an interpretative reading of the poem.

The sonnet form was popular in the period, and the original readers would be able to anticipate a few basic facts about its structure. The rhyme marks off the first twelve lines into three quatrains, leaving a couplet as the last two. Because of the sharp break in style at line 9, this poem can also be interpreted as being divided into two major parts – the first two quatrains forming the octave (lines 1–8), and the remainder the sestet (lines 9–14).

## 14.3 Identifying and tracking participants

No personal names are given, and the major indication of participants is to be found in the pronoun usage. Other evidence is provided by imperative verbs, and the poetic convention of personification.

### 14.3.1 Pronouns

The speaker is indicated six times by first person singular pronouns in lines 2, 3 and 4, all in the first quatrain. The speaker includes the hearer in first person plural pronouns in line 1, and in lines 5,6,7,8 in the second quatrain. The hearer is indicated by the second person pronoun *you* only in line 2.

There are second person pronouns in the couplet, of the form *thou*, in lines 13 and 14. It appears (McIntosh 1963) that this pronoun is a marked contrastive choice, which can be used to reflect great formality, great intimacy or even contempt. At this point it is only necessary to note that a different pronoun is chosen in the couplet, and we will return to the significance of style choices later.

Third person pronouns, indicating relevant third parties, are found in lines 10, 11, and 12 in the third quatrain, and 13 and 14 in the couplet. They are all masculine singular. The pronoun *it* occurs in line 7, not as a personal pronoun but as an anticipatory pronoun leading to the clause that takes up the whole of line 8. The indefinite pronoun *all* occurs in line 13.

The distribution of pronouns is summarised in Figures 14.1, 14.2, 14.3, 14.4 and 14.7[3]

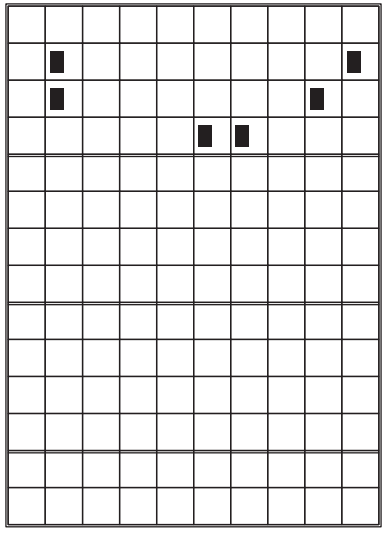

**Figure 14.1** First person singular pronouns

3. I have made a diagram of a sonnet as a matrix, with fourteen rows for the lines and ten columns for the syllables; the structural divisions are shown by double lines. The distribution of each major feature explained in the text is set out in a diagram, making it easy to visualise the structure of the poem and to compare and contrast the features.

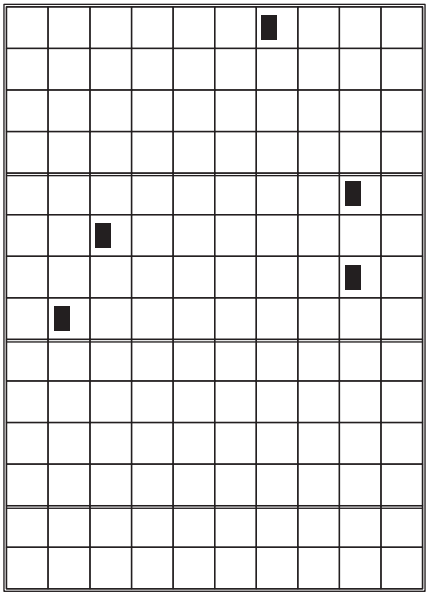

**Figure 14.2** First person plural pronouns

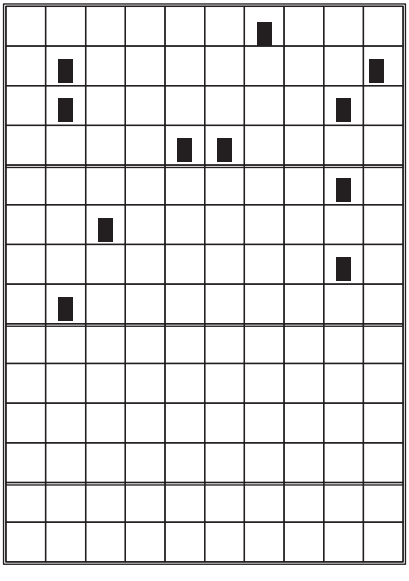

**Figure 14.3** First Person Pronouns (Figures 14.1 and 14.2 merged)

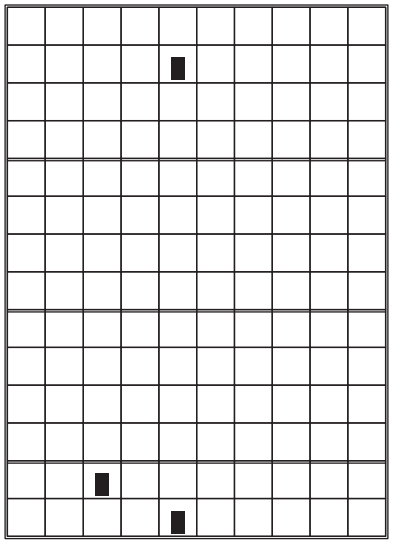

**Figure 14.4** Second person pronouns

### 14.3.2 Imperatives

Other indications of speaker and hearer are given by imperative verbs. Those in lines 1 (*Come*), and 5 (*Shake* and *Cancell*), are clearly addressed to the presumed hearer, and in traditional grammar would be supplied with '*you* understood'. *Let* in line 1 is immediately followed by the relevant pronoun *us*, and has no other implication for the participants, and *Be* in line 7 is followed by the pronoun *it*, which

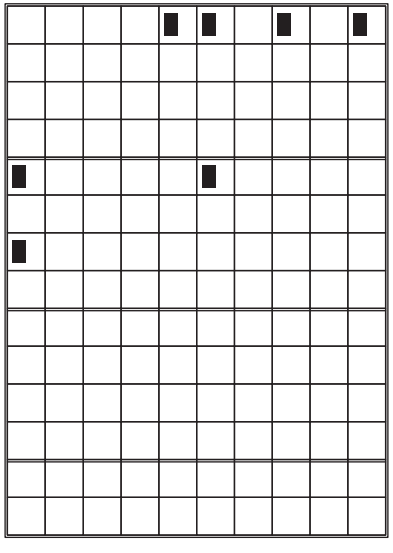

**Figure 14.5** Imperative verbs

anticipates the clause in the following line, and then by a prepositional phrase using the word *our*. The distribution of imperative verbs is shown in Figure 14.5.

### 14.3.3 Personification

It was a common poetic convention in Drayton's time to give participant status to abstractions such as *Love, Passion*. They were written with initial capitals, but

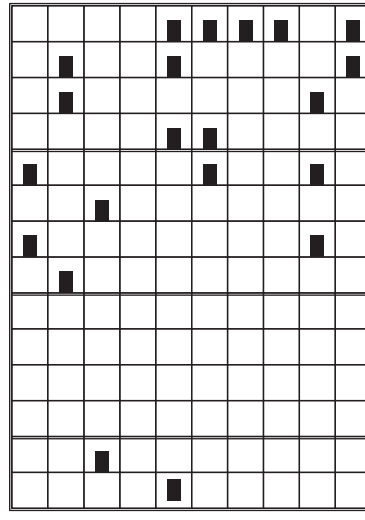

**Figure 14.6** Participants – indications of speaker and addres see (Figures 14.1. 14.2, 14.3, 14.4 and 14.5 merged)

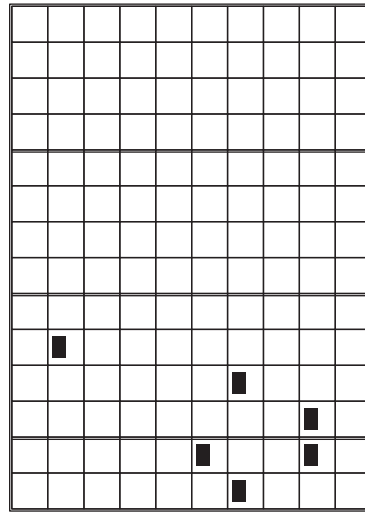

**Figure 14.7** Third person pronouns

that was not as distinctive at the time as it is now (for example *Love* in line 8 is not personified, though capitalised). They were given all the attributes of people, such as life and death, speech, action and physical form.

The use of personification had stylistic implications which are dealt with later. At this point the words are just noted as identifying third parties. They are *Loves*

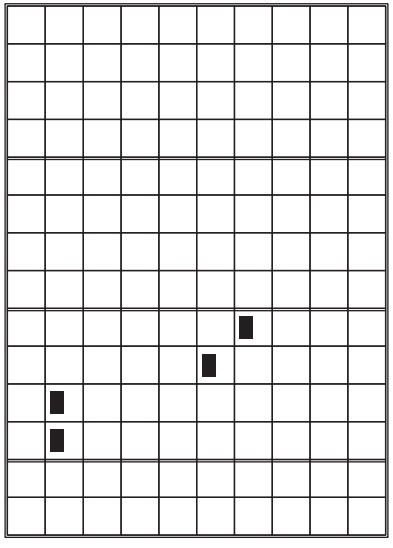

**Figure 14.8** Personifications

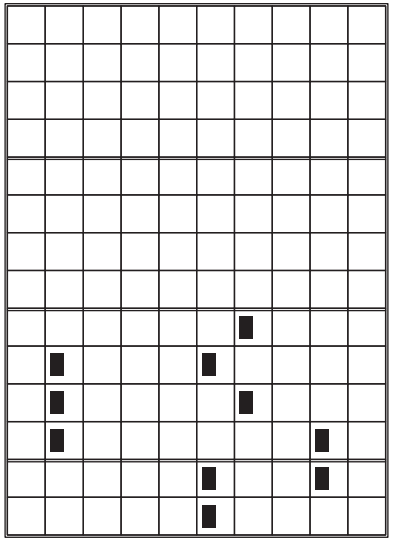

**Figure 14.9** Indications of third parties. (Figures 14.7 and 14.8 merged)

in line 9, *Passion* in line 10, *Faith* in line 11 and *Innocence* in line 12. All these are in the third quatrain.

The distribution of personifications is shown in Figure 14.8. Figures 14.6 and 14.9 contrast the distribution of references to speaker/hearer and the third parties.

### 14.3.4 Discussion

The distribution of these indications of participants is very informative. We begin to see why the poem is fresh and direct in its onset, and how it falls into clearly defined discourse units.

The first quatrain begins with imperatives and contains all the first person singular pronouns. So it is direct address. Imperatives mark the beginning of the second quatrain also, but the first person pronoun is now plural; the orientation has shifted from the expression of a personal position to instructions for co-operative action. The whole of the octave resembles a snatch of conversation, and we shall find this point supported by other evidence.

The third quatrain, however, is quite different. There are no first or second person pronouns, but for the first time we encounter third person pronouns, and personifications. The discourse is now narrative in nature, rather than conversational.

The poem returns to interaction in the couplet, but with many changes from the style of the octave. There are no more first person references, and the verbs are modal rather than imperative; the second person pronoun has changed from *you* to *thou*. The third person pronoun is carried on from the previous quatrain and thus provides a unifying perspective for the sestet. This is direct address about a third party, whereas before, in the octave, the discourse involved only the interacting participants.

No identification of the speaker or hearer is given. The third party pronoun can be associated with one or more of the personifications, depending on the interpretation adopted, but again, that is not an identification.

## 14.4 Narrative techniques in storytelling

There are three areas of language structure that contribute substantially to the way this story is told. One is the kind of verb forms and tenses used, because narratives are heavily dependent on this kind of choice; then there are the various other ways in which language refers to time – adverbs, phrases and clauses of time. Lastly there is the control over the presentation of the language and the exploitation of the speaker's natural expectations, where the stylistic category of *arrest* (see Chapter 6, 8 and 12) is used in explanation. These areas will be dealt with in turn, with a discussion at the end.

### 14.4.1 Verb Forms

The choice of verb forms usually tells us a lot about the way a story is told. An ordinary story is told by action verbs in the simple past tense, and any variation from that is likely to be important.

In this sonnet there are no simple past tenses. Imperatives are prominent in the first half, and the present tense is scattered throughout. Two modal verbs in the last two lines introduce a note of uncertainty.

Let us look into the distribution of verb forms in more detail, concentrating on the main clauses. The imperatives have already been pointed out for their role in indicating participants, and we must return to them as indicators of narrative style. There are six if we include the two *let* structures – called hortatives – of line 1. It could be argued that most of the other imperatives are also hortative in meaning, in that they are understood as applying to speaker as well as hearer. The phrase *Shake hands* is reciprocal, and implies a willingness of the speaker to shake hands as well; and in *Cancell all our Vowes* the word *our* makes it clear that the speaker will also be cancelling, and the vows were reciprocal. The structure at the beginning of line 7 *Be it not seene….* is equivalent to 'Let it not be seen'; and note the *We* again in the subordinate clause (see Figure 14.5).

The octave, then, tells the story as it is happening, and looks to the future rather than the past. The other verbs in main clauses are present tense: *have done* in line 2 is an idiomatic phrase meaning 'I am finished', and *get* is a very direct expression. The verbs *'s* in line 1 and *am* in line 3 are also in the simple present tense.

The only other verb in the first quatrain is *can free*. This form occurs in a subordinate clause, just after the word *thus*, and so refers to an ongoing action. In English the modal *can* is almost obligatory when one is describing an action that is going on as one speaks. Unlike the modals in the couplet, this carries no sense of tentativeness or future reference, and it is more a requirement of the syntax than a choice of modality.

In the second quatrain all the verbs in main clauses are imperative, and in lines 6 and 8 the verbs in subordinate clauses are simple present in form, though future in time reference, as is common in English.

There is a complete change in the third quatrain. To begin with, there are no main clauses in the quatrain, and no finite verbs at all until the last syllable of line 10. That, *lies*, is an action verb in the simple present (though one of the least 'active' of the action verbs). The quatrain continues with two verbs in a tense new to the poem, the present continuous. Continuous tense forms give a background to a narrative rather than further the action. The non-finite verb in line 10 – *fayling* – adds to this effect. The distribution of -ing forms is shown in Figure 14.10.

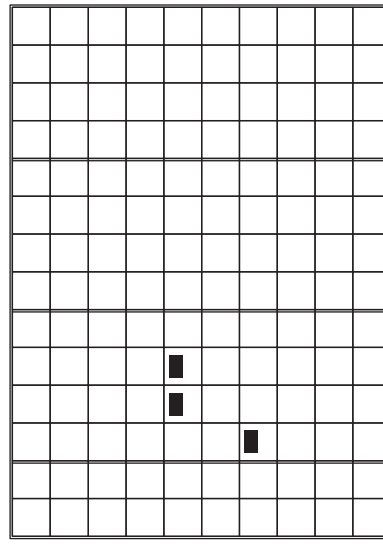

**Figure 14.10** *-ing* forms

The couplet makes another change, by featuring modals: *might'st* in the final main clause heralded by *would'st* in the initial subordinate clause. Here for the first time is speculation, hypothesis, possibility. The verb in the other subordinate clause of the couplet is *have given*, a present perfect form that works within the time frame of the poem.

### 14.4.2 Time frame

We come then to the time frame of the poem, aligning the heavily present-oriented verb forms with the time expressions – the adverbials and the timing clauses.

There are no pure time adverbs in the octave. *Thus* in line 4 entails immediacy because it refers to something happening as the speaker speaks. The timing clause that is line 6 refers to the future.

The first word of the sestet, repeated at the beginning of the couplet, is *Now*. Normal narrative, in the simple past tense, will often preface sections of the story by 'then', and 'now' is its equivalent in present tense narration. Since there is no sentence boundary between lines 12 and 13, and no main clause since the start of the sentence in line 9, the repeated *Now* gives a sense of urgency to the action.

The first *Now*, in line 9, is followed by two clauses starting with *When*. The dominant verb form is the present progressive tense, and this affects the meaning of the conjunctions *When* so that they express simultaneity. They could equally well be 'as'.

Most of the third quatrain takes the form of time expressions, all timing the last clause in the poem. The long prepositional phrase taking up most of line 9 begins with the timing preposition *at;* the participial clause in line 10 is also timing in its effect. Line 12 is co-ordinated with the timing clause that is line 11.

There is another *When* clause in line 13, following the second *Now*. Here the dominant verb tense is the present perfect, and the conjunction takes on a meaning similar to 'now that'. Finally the adverb *yet* in the last line adds still more to the tension of immediacy. This concentration on the here-and-now characterises the time frame of the poem, starting in a restrained way and building up to dominate the second half. The distribution of the time adverbs is shown in Figure 14.11.

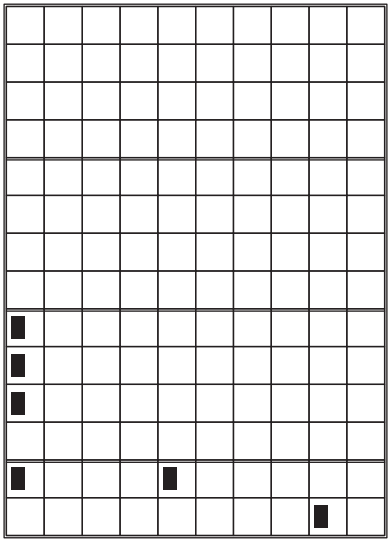

**Figure 14.11** Time adverbs

### 14.4.3 Arrest

Another means of handling the storytelling is in the structure of the sentences. By manipulation of the syntactic anticipations of the reader, the dynamics of the narrative can be made to deliver powerful effects. In particular here, the device of *arrest* (see Chapter 6, 8 and 12 in this volume, and Sinclair 1982) is heavily used in the second half of the poem. Arrest occurs when some structural element that is clearly predicted does not appear immediately, but another element is interposed. A straightforward example occurs in line 6. The word *And* signals that another main clause is to come, but instead it is followed by *when* and the subordinate clause. The syntax is arrested by this device until the anticipated main clause begins in line 7.

Other examples of arrest in the octave are sporadic. The first clause of line 1, being a subordinate clause, anticipates the following main clause and so is an arresting structure. In line 3, *yea, glad withall my heart* holds up the expected explanation of why the speaker is glad, which is given in line 4. Within line 4 the word order gives rise to several minor examples – perhaps the least marked word order would have been 'That I can free my Selfe thus so cleanly'. The front placing of *thus* and *so cleanly* arrests the expected subject of the clause, *I*, and the placing of *my Selfe* between subject and verb adds another small arrest.

The sestet is complicated because there are several layers of arrest, both of clauses and phrases. I shall enumerate them.

1. *at the last gaspe….Breath*. This prepositional phrase occurs just after the initial *Now*, which predicts the subject/verb complex of a main clause. Hence it arrests the sentence.
2. *when….Passion speechlesse lies*. This clause continues the arrest.

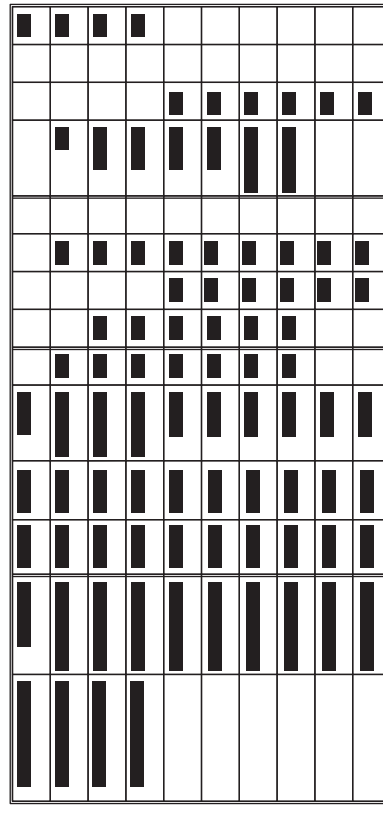

**Figure 14.12** Arrest

3. *his pulse fayling*. An extra layer of arrest is created by the positioning of this clause inside an already arrested one.
4. *when Faith….his Eyes*. Another two lines of text are in an arrest position because the main clause of the sentence has not yet appeared.
5. *Now* in line 13 picks up the earlier *now* and begins a new cycle of structures, although the previous clause complex has not been resolved. The arrest is intensified.
6. *if thou would'st*. Like (3) above, another layer is added to the arrest.
7. *when…over*. A further extension of the triple arrest.
8. *from….Life*. The prepositional phrase is placed at the front of the clause, thus further holding up the progress of the main clause. The unexpected ordering of *Death* and *Life* make a poetic conceit that holds the reader's attention momentarily and adds to the intensity of the arrest at its peak.

The patterns of arrest are shown in Figure 14.12. Where there is more than one arrest in progress, the symbol is elongated.

### 14.4.4 Discussion

At the beginning the story does not so much narrate events as depict them through the representation of what people are saying. The events are going on at the same time as the telling, and the text appears to be a report of just one side of a conversation. There are no time references other than to the present and some possible future times.

The narrative technique changes remarkably at line 9. The time frame is still the immediate present, but the interactive element is replaced by third-person narrative. Instead of time sequence, which is usually contrived by using the past tense, the sestet stresses simultaneity, with the prominent use of the words *Now* and *when*. The third quatrain also features the progressive tense, which is typically used to describe a background scene, and not the main story line. The only simple active verb is *lies*.

Modality enters prominently in the final couplet, as the discourse becomes interactive again. This later discourse is of quite a different flavour from that of the first quatrain – here the speaker is talking about a third party, and not just the hearer.

Throughout the sestet there is a complex and extended pattern of arrest, the main effect of which is to invest a large amount of poetic energy in the last half-line of the poem, *thou might'st him yet recover*. It has been anticipated, with growing intensity, since line 9. Since there is only one word of lexical interest in this phrase, *recover*, we must take a particular interest in the meaning and function of this word, and return to it in the interpretation in Section 14.6.

It should also be noted that the arresting pattern emphasises the unity of the sestet as one of the two major elements of structure in the poem – in particular by having no sentence break at the end of line 12. On the other hand the distinction between the third quatrain and the couplet is signalled by the indentation of the lines, and maintained by the repeated word *now* at the beginning of line 13 which indicates that a new, somewhat parallel structure is starting.

## 14.5 The poem and the context of situation

### 14.5.1 Informality

A poem is usually a fairly formal piece of writing, often governed by special codes and conventions that require interpretation on a different basis from the way in which the ordinary run of language is interpreted. The present poem is unusual in that it begins with what is apparently a very informal piece of talk and switches to one of the most typical passages of poetic 'high style' in the language, ending with a couplet which is difficult to place with respect to the other two styles.

What was formal or informal in the sixteenth century is not easy to recover today. Our reference works are not sensitive to such matters, and the passage of time may play tricks with a modern reader's assessment. Bearing this in mind, let us consider the octave for indications of informality.

line 1. *ther's no helpe*. I read this as a version of something like 'it can't be helped', with the same meaning of 'help', and with a distinctly colloquial air about it. Even if this should turn out to be a historically unwarranted reading it is still a valid modern reading of the text. Purists may wince at signs saying "Ye Olde Booke Shoppe" but they have their effect on their readers, and we should not have to apologise for that.

line 2. *have done*. Again the phraseology of the informal speaker shows. We still use the word *done* to mean 'finished'.

line 2. *you get*. The modern phrasing would more likely be 'you'll get…', but the informality of the phrase is probably constant.

line 3. *withall my heart*. I.A. Shapiro points out (personal communication) that to make sense we must read the first word as two – 'with all'. It sounds like a routine conversational way of adding emphasis to an expression, and in the context sounds almost too much of a cliche to be likely in a poem of this kind, unless to signal ordinary speech.

line 4. *cleanly*. This is on the limit of speculation; what were the collocates of a word four hundred years ago? When there are large reference corpora of literary and non-literary texts available to scholars it may be possible to support the notion that in talking of breaking a love relationship, *cleanly* is a very down-to-earth, almost clinical term to use.

line 8. *jot*. Certainly an informal word at present; possibly more widely used in Drayton's time; as far as I can ascertain, this is its first appearance in English verse.

line 13. *given him over*. Phrasal verbs are usually in the informal registers of English, and although this one is not used nowadays in the sense of 'abandon', it strikes the modern ear as colloquial.

It is rather artificial to pluck out words and phrases from a text in which the whole effect is of informality, but the distribution of these examples suggests strongly that the first quatrain is by far the most informal, and there is little elsewhere. The initial tone of the poem is set as informal, as can be seen in the summary in Figure 14.13.

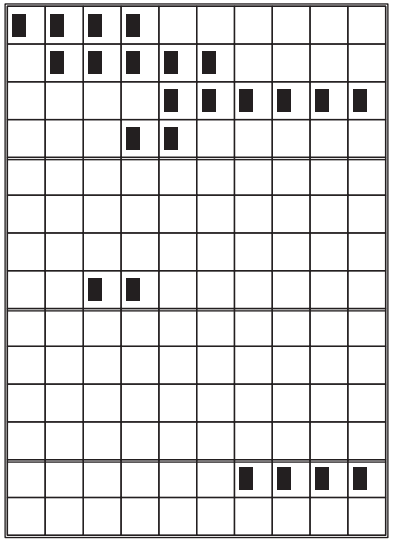

**Figure 14.13** Indications of informality

### 14.5.2 Interaction

To this we must add a parallel exercise concerning the indications of interaction. A private conversation between lovers should show us language at its most informal, and if the record of the conversation retains the flavour of the original, there should be evidence of the cut and thrust of impromptu dialogue.

It has already been noted that the octave is interpreted as one side of a conversation, and possibly the couplet also is. Let us pick out and note the placing of words and phrases that suggest actual speech.

line 1. *Come let*. Imperatives are closely connected with the interactive and spoken aspects of language.

line 2. *Nay*. This word begins a response to something that has just taken place in the conversation. Either the other party, whose voice we do not hear, has said something in response to line 1, or has made some gesture.

line 3. *yea*. The repetition of *glad* in this phrase indicates impromptu speech.

line 4. *thus*. This is a direct reference to the ongoing situation.

line 5. *Shake, Cancell*. More imperatives stressing the immediacy of the action.

line 7. *Be*. Another imperative.

line 9, line 13. *Now*. In considering time expressions above, it was noted that the repeated *Nows* gave an effect of immediacy and contemporaneity to the narrative. To this should be added the common function of 'now' in discourse, where it marks a boundary, and heralds a new initiative. A meaning such as 'at this juncture' is appropriate. In a complex discourse like this poem, a boundary may in fact signal a reorientation of the discourse, and this is what is found; the two major turning points of the poem are prefaced by *now*.

### 14.5.3 Poetic Diction

There is nothing very formal about the language of this poem, but there is a marked style change in line 8, easily seen by comparing the word *Love* in line 8 with the same word in line 9. In line 8 it has its normal modern meaning, but in line 9 it is personified, taking on the attributes of a person. This is a simple instance of one of the devices of poetic diction being used to achieve a change of mood.

### 14.5.4 Discussion

The main divisions of the poem are again structurally relevant, when we consider the diction of the text. The octave is highly interactive, the third quatrain is not, but the couplet returns to an interactive stance, in a different tone. The octave is rather informal, especially in the first quatrain. By contrast the third quatrain adopts an obvious device of poetic diction. The couplet is not specially marked for formality, but in its place in the poem it is different again from either of the other styles.

## 14.6 An Interpretation

Who is talking? Let us call him or her A. He or she begins as a participant in a conversation. After eight lines the discourse changes to a narrative, returning to conversational mode for the last two lines. Is it the same person throughout, or does the speaker change?

Firstly we must make an assumption about the first eight lines. Are they all the contribution of one person, or are there speaker changes? One possible interpretation makes the assumption that the speaker changes at various points, for example at the beginning of line 2. Against this there is the consistency of position in lines 1–8, which I find convincing evidence that there is a single speaker, and the reader has to fill in what else was being said or done by using the imagination.

One advantage of assuming only one speaker is that in that case there can be great flexibility of interpretation as between what was actually uttered, and what was just thought, or muttered below the hearing threshold. After line 8 this becomes important, because there is a complete change of narrative style and posture, and no indication in the text of whether or not the speaker has changed.

Let us assume that the speaker does not change throughout – that the articulate participant of the octave suddenly starts to describe a deathbed scene in which the characters are personifications. The abruptness of the break between lines 8 and 9 make it likely that there is some continuity of story in the poem. Otherwise, if the style change is accompanied by a new plot, set of characters and setting, it is difficult to see why they are in the same short poem. The repetition of *Love* in lines 8 and 9 provides the link; the love between A and B is fast dying.

It is very unlikely that this third quatrain is part of the conversation that has been established before, but we may try to interpret the poem by assuming that these lines are composed by A but not uttered out loud.

In the couplet, the conversation can hardly be on the same basis as before because the pronoun of address has changed from *you* to *thou*. If we again assume consistency of speaker, then A is in a very different kind of conversation at the end than at the beginning of this poem.

It is also open to interpretation that the couplet is not articulated as part of a conversation, but, like the third quatrain, is part of the private thoughts of participant A. It would then be in the nature of a silent plea.

This interpretation then gives us the octave, where A speaks his or her mind, followed by what might be a vision of death, and brought together by a final couplet that expresses a contrasting position of A, but which is probably not articulated because it does not belong in the conversation recorded in the octave. A public posture versus a private posture.

Of course the paradox of poetry is that the unsaid is said, and if the poem itself is used as message in the real world then the private thoughts of A are actually articulated. This possibility provides us with an outer layer of meaning to which we will return later.

Who is participant B, the unrecorded one? There is one other person, shown by the word *either* in line 7, whom we shall call B. The erstwhile partner of A, to be sure, but we know little else. If we assume that A and B are or have been in an intimate relationship, then the use of *thou* in the couplet signals an attempt by A to regain the intimacy of address that the more public *you* excluded in the early part of the poem.

Who is the third party? He is male, and is identified as possibly Love or Passion (*his*, 10). It is not necessary to speculate how many dying characters there are, since the grammar would allow Faith as well, and even Innocence, to be on the point of death. Rather we can interpret this as a conventional poetic tableau, where Love/Passion is attended in his last moments by Faith and Innocence.

What is the occasion of the discourse? It is a meeting between lovers. The topic is the announcement by A that they are to part. We have to deduce B's attitude and contribution to the discourse, because this is like hearing one side of a telephone call; for that reason we will go through the octave line by line.

A is clearly trying to get it over with quickly. In line 1 A deals with serious matters in a brisk and heartless way. B must make some sort of reaction, perhaps even a physical approach, because *Nay* at the start of the next line is clearly the rejection of something. Perhaps A's invitation to kiss has been taken up too enthusiastically by B, and prolonged until A has to insist that it is a parting kiss only. Whatever we assume to have happened, A clearly wants to rub in a cruel message – for it is already fairly obvious that A is much keener on the parting than B. Line 2 shows A warming to the subject. The dramatic gesture of physically breaking free symbolises the ending of the emotional relationship.

But in this account we have not managed to accommodate the meaning of the contrast between the colloquial coolness of A's utterances and the heavy emotions that lie under the surface (to be graphically expressed in the third quatrain). Perhaps we have not fully taken into account the almost ludicrous image of *Shake hands for ever* in line 5, where the quick routine gesture of shaking hands is frozen by juxtaposition into bathos. Shaking hands is the most formal and routine of parting gestures, and it jars with *for ever* in the kind of irony so well described by Louw (1993). The final end of the relationship is proposed in four words, and in another four the whole fabric of their passionate intimacy is dismantled. If readers sense a discrepancy between the story and the way of telling it, then some interpretation, however tentative, must be proposed.

Just possibly, A is saying things to try to make them true. There is a brittleness in A's stated position. The rush to get the parting over and done with, the stress on the finality of it, raise the prospect that for A the decision is fragile, and it must be implemented straight away in case A's resolve does not hold out. We may posit a contrast between A's stated goal – to wind up this relationship in a quick and tidy way – and a hidden goal, which may even be the opposite. Something has happened to force A to break off the relationship, but secretly he or she would like it to continue.

If this interpretation is giving shape to the message of the poem, then the reinforcement of *glad* in line 3 is one of the best clues to what lies beneath A's blustering. The highly impromptu nature of the repetition has a hint of provocation about it, even if we posit that B reacts emotionally to the use of the word *glad* on such an occasion. *Thus* in line 4 again suggests a physical action, a pushing away.

The second quatrain sets out the new contract being offered, replacing the old lovers' relationship. Whereas in line 1 the imperative is more of a proposal than an order, in this quatrain A is laying down the law. There are several examples of absolutist language, not found elsewhere in the poem: *for ever* (5), *all* (5), *at any time* (6), *one jot* (8), all have this quality, and even *either* (7) reinforces the effect. Finality is stressed as the octave comes to its end.

At the beginning of line 7 there is another imperative, maintaining the stance of A, but the impetus has slowed down. Whereas line 5 demolishes the relationship in a couple of verbal slashes, lines 6–8 are more reflective. It has been noted that arrest features in these lines, and there is only one main verb, and that the verb *be*. There is no hint, however, of any weakening in A's position. Indeed the extended nature of the expression of lines 6–8 tend to reinforce and steel the resolve. After a somewhat tempestuous line 5, the pace slows down and the determination shows more quietly, but not less effectively.

It is up to the reader how much of this is interpreted as bravado, especially when contrasted with the third quatrain, where the writing contrives almost the opposite effect from the octave. Time is suspended, and the many time expressions include *when* three times indicating simultaneity. The use of arrest, progressive tenses, subordinate clauses and poetic conventions creates an atmosphere of suspended animation, almost a tableau, in marked contrast to the brisk activity of the octave. The slow and solemn rituals for the dying are being carried out by shadowy figures; the interaction is suspended, and nobody speaks.

The time frame continues to be the immediate present, and we are invited to consider the two main parts of the poem as occurring simultaneously, the octave in public and the sestet in private. As A's discourse drives towards a swift, clean break, A sees that this behaviour is causing the imminent end of something very precious. A is getting desperate.

The tension of the arrested structures spills over into the final couplet, where the discourse changes again. We now have A as speaker, although the lines are no doubt 'said' only internally. B is addressed as *thou* in the language of intimacy. The use of *him* in this conversation unites the physical world of the octave and the poetic world of the third quatrain. The couplet contains a proposal, hedged about with modal uncertainty, and in an arrest structure that has been building up for six lines. A lot is invested in the last word of the poem.

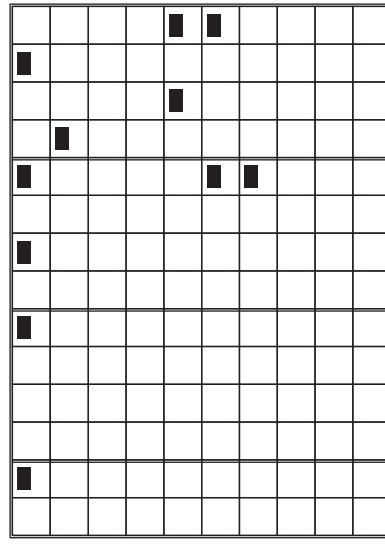

**Figure 14.14** Interaction

At this point let us recap on the goals that we can presume the participants have. A is outwardly bent on terminating the relationship quickly, but is torn by internal doubts, and invites B to save the relationship, without specifying how. B appears to be reluctant to end the relationship, and indeed may be trying to cling on to A physically.

The last word is *recover*. The OED records that in 1600 this word had two meanings as a transitive verb – to get something back, in the same sense as it is used today, and also to restore to life or consciousness, which in current English is confined to the intransitive. If, as a final act of interpretation, we fuse the characters of A and Love, the last half-line suggests that B might simultaneously restore Love to health and regain the relationship with A. Since these two events are the same, expressed in different terms, the sestet can be reinterpreted with A as the person who is emotionally dying, thus confirming the brittle, if not desperate, edge to the phrasing of the octave.

The sex of A can then be determined, since Love is almost certainly referred to by the masculine pronoun in the sestet. The sex of B is irrelevant.

In this interpretation, I have entered the shady area between recording linguistic evidence and doing literary criticism. In linguistics, controversy tends to centre on one's descriptive apparatus and theoretical stance, rather than the details of the application of theory and description to text. In literary commentary, the only criterion is fidelity to one's subjective integrity, and text structure plays a minor role in the evaluations of different reactions to a poem.

I have argued throughout from the initial systematic observation of text structure. It would have been easy, and a lot safer, to avoid putting forward specific personal interpretations; for example I could have pointed out the contrast between A's racy talk in the octave and the heaviness of the third quatrain, insisted that it constituted an irony, and left the matter at that. But since an ironic statement is normally interpreted as the opposite of what is says, there is linguistic justification for moving a step closer to the subjective.

Similarly, the identification of A as Love is subjective, and there are a number of other possible choices. The most available one is that Love refers to the relationship that is coming to an end, and the use of the masculine pronoun is conventional. Nevertheless, the reader of a text is bound to assign the reference of pronouns, according to rules which are not yet satisfactorily described, and the dual assignment of *him* in the couplet makes possible a dual interpretation of the poem as a whole that satisfies the expectation that a finely-wrought text of this kind is likely to have layers of meaning beyond the superficial propositions.

Another possible assignment of the third person pronoun is that it refers to a genuine third party. Suddenly, in the middle of his account of a lover's quarrel, the poet starts talking about someone else, and continues for the rest of the poem. The participants in the octave are simply abandoned. It is, I hope, unlikely that many readers would come to this conclusion, but at a crude linguistic level it is as reasonable as any other. In fact, for a narrator to switch from first to third person narrative with himself or herself still as the referent of the pronoun is a rare and remarkable event, far more difficult to justify than the assumption of a change of topic in the story. To insist on this interpretation one has to invoke notions like the unity of a poetic text, where the simple co-occurrence of items in a poem confers on them an assumption of co-relevance; obscurities and apparent confusions, such as we have with the pronouns here, have to be interpreted as having underlying coherence. Armed with such concepts, the linguist projects the gaps and problem areas in the objective evidence into a subjective arena.

Since an early stage in this chapter, we have been working under the assumption that the poem is read as fiction. Let us, as a final act of interpretation, place it in its possible context as a communication – possibly its original context. A writes

it and sends it to B, presumably at a critical moment in their relationship. Perhaps A has taken offence at something, or his honour has obliged him to offer to terminate the relationship. Inside himself he is deeply unhappy about breaking off, and this is his way of telling B that he or she can save the day by a positive move. Alternatively, B may have been the one who used the harsh words of the octave, and A was too proud to beg. He reconstructs the quarrel and sends the poem to try to soften B's position, mimicking B's style in the octave and presenting himself piteously in the sestet.

For the reader of the present day, the poem appeals as a reminder that in a love relationship the partners may sometimes say things that are much harsher and more final than they really mean; that insecurity can prompt actions that may be regretted if taken at their face value. The blustering hustler of the octave may conceal the fragile invalid of the sestet, and the loved one may have to overcome some hurt in order to redeem the situation.

CHAPTER 15

# Coda

## Unlearning the intuitive analogue as Sinclairan digital proofs transcend stylistics by Bill Louw

"If literary comment is to be more than exclusively personal testimony, it must be interpretable with respect to *objective analysis*." (Chapter 2.4: 18) (my italics)

"It seems almost certain that the teacher will have to avoid reference to difficult linguistic abstractions in most of his teaching. He is therefore *reliant on some kind of inductive process being established (or tapped)*." (Chapter 10.1: 10) (my italics)

"Every English teacher needs to learn about the *present state of linguistics* to be able to follow developments in *theory* and *description* throughout his teaching career." (Chapter 1.6: 7) (my italics)

### 15.1 Introduction

My association with John Sinclair and his approach to stylistics began in about 1980, although I had met him earlier than that during a brief visitorship provided by The British Council to the UK. We noticed at once that our professional background was similar: when we were first appointed to permanent university posts, we were both regarded as linguistic 'appendages' to departments of English Literature. The stylistics that we wrote about bore the marks of our association with colleagues who, largely under sufferance, watched us as we attempted to follow the latest trends in the 'lang-lit' debate. The integration of language and literature both in the curriculum and as a teaching method was a major priority, both nationally, and as part of 'English overseas', as the slogan ran (for a historical survey, see Zyngier & Fialho 2016: 212–216). Departmental involvement was altogether more dismal as we witnessed the ruination of countless literature classes that had degenerated into language lessons.

Sinclair's papers in this volume may quite readily appear to fit in with the latest trends as these unfolded; but, in this closing chapter, I wish to concentrate instead on the ways in which his work not only prospected but furnished the methodology

for the future of the type of stylistics which his research in computational lexicography brought about. Corpus stylistics began when he gave me a full set of concordances on microfiche that were used by the large team of lexicographers in premises on the Bristol Road in Birmingham, UK, and not far from the Gun Barrells pub, where the acronym COBUILD was arrived at during one gloriously bibulous lunch hour in the summer of 1986.

It was in this domain of photocopies of concordances that emerged dripping wet from a microfiche reader that John offered me his customary generous encouragement. I returned to Zimbabwe and obtained, for free, a microfiche reader from a company that sold motor spares. They boasted about their new XT computer with its 20 mb hard drive. Things moved quickly. I obtained a login for an antiquated mainframe computer and The British Council sent us Tim Johns, who spent a morning programming new gadgets for the staff at the University of Zimbabwe Computer Centre. But the thing that we hardly noticed at the time was that stylistics discarded its textbooks almost immediately, while the Cobuild dictionaries took ten years and two editions to abandon their paper format. By 1987 even Ron Carter's British Council Seminar at St Hilda's College Oxford had seen and touched authentic concordances and tittered about what I called corpus stylistics (Louw 1989). By 1991 (and recently revived in Louw & Milojkovic 2016), my paper for the ELR Journal had made use of the KDEM scanner to digitise a Zimbabwean novel and the paper's title contained a reference to the delexicalisation-relexicalisation debate. Two years later saw the emergence of the irony-insincerity dichotomy.

In his entry for the name John Sinclair in the Chapman and Routledge (2005: 255) reference work on famous philosophers and linguists, Mike Scott refers to John as a catalyst. John defended me against the worry expressed by former Cobuilders that terms such as *delexical* had very specialised meanings within lexicography and he advised me in an email to "make hay" with such terms in order to take stylistics into new and uncharted territory. My article in 1991 came out in the same year as his *Corpus, Concordance, Collocation.* His notion of a 9-word window of collocative power was an immediate success and was proved for the first time in poetry in a special edition, Volume 4 of the *ELR Journal*, edited by Tim Johns and Philip King.

In the same way, with the advent of Semantic Prosody [SP] (a term we agreed upon in Zimbabwe), John concentrated on producing a flawless taxonomy in another well-named book, *Trust the Text* (2004), and encouraged me to unveil the power of SP in literary texts. We shared a platform, chaired by Guy Aston in Bologna for the conference hosted by Professor Donna Miller, on the theme 'Verbal Art Re-Visited' to celebrate the contribution to stylistics of Ruqaiya Hasan (see Louw 2007b). At this event, members of the general public readily accepted

the role of collocation in establishing verbal art, while academics, mainly from the Forli campus, vociferously demanded that collocation be regarded as merely conceptual, connotative and a form of mentalism. To have done so would have been a grave personal error and a retrograde step for stylistics. However, members of the audience were easily convinced that collocation showed all the promise of a nascent form of science, or as I put it in a closing keynote address at the TaLC6 conference in Granada in 2004, '…language as its own instrumentation' (Louw, 2007a). That term was accepted more fully at a BAAL Workshop at Coventry University in 2015.

## 15.2 The latent debt to philosophy

A lesser-known detail about John Sinclair is the fact that the other major subject for his MA degree in Edinburgh was Philosophy. I only probed this matter with him on one occasion. It produced an immediate and enthusiastic reaction. He told me that in his final year, his long essay was entered for and won the prize for all of Europe.

Once we realise this fact, some of the developments within his stylistics become more obvious. He once asked me which of his papers I liked most. I told him that "Fictional Worlds" was far and away the most exciting. This may have prompted him to create a second version of that paper (see Chapter 13 in this volume). During the same conversation he was busily editing my falsification of the Truth and Reconciliation Commission [TRC] (Louw 2003). But he was careful not to articulate what may have turned into a situation in which *inductive* reasoning could 'go viral'. I had written the paper in the hope that I might be asked to contribute for a *Festschrift* on his 70th birthday. No invitation arrived, so several months later, I sent him what I called an *ad personam* one-man *Festschrift*! He wrote me an email two days after receiving my monograph. He endorsed my reasoning. For any legislation stemming from Truth and Reconciliation to be valid there would need to be a recoverable prior relationship between those two terms. The machine returned a message: 'no matches' in the Bank of English except with 'Commission'. He particularly appreciated the manner in which the corpus as a 'living document' (Sinclair 1991; Renouf 2007) had taken a snapshot of a provably fake institution. A new form of stylistics had arrived. By the time the corpus and inductive reasoning had apparently freed Simon Mann in 2009, John was sadly already deceased.

The TRC example led predictably to fairly crass restrictions of access to corpora. These are today not only worse, but are now conspicuously built into departmental planning in some universities and may even account for some of its policy of recruitment. If Google operates almost entirely by means of induction, why

should better-sampled, corpus-based searches be disallowed and written out of the curriculum? The last paragraph of my article that juxtaposes *irony* and *insincerity* (Louw 1993) mentions radical stylistics with a sense of optimism that even 23 years later we are unlikely to experience very soon. The profound discomfort that collocation studies have generated ought, now, 74 years after the breaking of the codes at Bletchley Park (in December 1942), to dissipate as part of the expiry of the 70-year rule. The less dissipation we see will need to be matched by further and better public research in this area, lest a *modus operandi* take the place of prescription (as we shall see later in this chapter).

Matters of philosophy cannot but resurface because they are not only crucial to the future of stylistics, but to the very notion of bivalent truth in logic and metaphysics as departments of philosophy come to value corpus-based proofs. The detection of falsehood may be considered deplorable by some in the external world: Manning, Assange and Snowden are all still under pressure. But where literary worlds are avowedly *fictional*, more grace may be forthcoming. The primary school looks like a place where the techniques of lexicography and basic literacy might interact. Surely deep reading is to be allowed and especially where the machine may prompt it. We look next at the interface between basic literacy and the tools of the lexicographer. The broader research of Sinclair has at last freed the stylistician from the tyranny of the textbook and, in so doing, he created potential scientists instead.

## 15.3 The developmental link with literacy and lexicographic instrumentation

Oddly enough, in the case of the Cobuild dictionaries, there was hardly any mention of literature beyond its representation within a well-sampled corpus; and no mention at all of the verisimilitude that obtains between fictional worlds and a dictionary for use by literate persons with a 'command of the language'.

The withdrawal of support for Sinclair's proposed *Cobuild Dictionary of Collocation* and the sudden appearance of a rival dictionary in the form of the BBI may well have put a damper on any attempt to use collocation outside of literary stylistics. Where then does the restless spirit move in order to promote collocation, especially as it drafted the entries for two editions of the Cobuild dictionary (Clear 1993)? The answer in a perfectly logical world could be high-key, expensive and open to criticism or low-key and a child-oriented human right. Both would create highly literate human beings with a deep appreciation for meaning as instrumentation based upon collocation. Their products would be walking, living, critical 'stylisticians of life'. Sinclair's Project LUCID

would have been an 'adult' rather than a 'developmental' intervention. It would, if implemented, have affected the lives of adults and would even now have had platforms in social media. He estimated that LUCID would cost two million pounds to develop. The amount was more than he could muster (Sinclair, personal communication).

However, the fallback position was far better. CANAN[1] was to have operated in the primary school in Scotland and set out to accomplish several key objectives for the future of every child. It would demonstrate the scope and limits of intuitive opacity, the basis of contexts of situation and co-texts, and it would make the child-investigator wary of *concepts*. This is because the machine works only in co-selection mode and its output will always outperform and revise concepts to the point that the disillusioned holder of concepts will always prefer the outputs of the instrumentation rather than guess. This project was approved for all of Scotland and the implications and benefits for the first tranche of pupils would have been massive. The project seems to have had its plug pulled shortly after Sinclair's untimely death.

The picture shows (back, l–r and front, l–r): Patricia Kemp, Paddy Patterson (LT Scotland); Professor John Sinclair (Tuscan Word Centre); Professor Ian Hunt (CANAN); Jim Henderson (LT Scotland), Evan Brown (CANAN) and Donella Beaton (CANAN).

1. This project was to have been introduced in all primary school classrooms in Scotland, in Grade 1 with each child having three years of exposure to it (Clear 1993). Objectives are stated in the quotation overleaf.

Outlining the benefits of the resource, Sinclair explained "In the case of PhraseBox, it is like giving each pupil real-time access to a huge memory of all the different ways in which thousands of people have expressed themselves over several years, all instantly available in a highly organised presentation. Gradually, students are expected to internalise what they need of the resource and gather confidence in their ability to express themselves publicly; but the resource will always be available when it is needed (Sinclair 2006).

What the text does not say is that the machine requires *two* expressions to be entered and that the product of this co-selection is almost always something that the child-user does not expect. The method puts old heads on young shoulders by allowing the user to sift and restructure the *concepts* they are being fed during their early lives; and this method is used with a view to having them question the ideologies they are yet to encounter during their adult lives. If, as Frank Palmer (1976) maintains, the task of concepts is to explain data, then inductive reasoning would be likely to argue correctly that exposure to more data, computationally, than one might be exposed to in a lifetime, is likely to make radical adjustments, if not falsifications, to any concepts that happen to appear on the same subject matter as the empiricism of Phrase-box © and its logic.

I have included this expanded reference to the CANAN Project because I believe that if it had been implemented for, say, a period of 20 years, it would have laid the cognitive to rest finally and effortlessly and may even have escaped notice until that task had been completed. If that had been achieved, the English language in Scotland would have been the first to have attained the status of *instrumentation* for language. That accomplishment alone would have produced nations of citizen-stylisticians and would have been markedly more impressive than all of the accomplishments of Cobuild in Birmingham, where today, corpus work is apparently on a retrograde course.

## 15.4 'Difficult stylistics': Grammar *vs* Subtext and the example of "The Legs" by Robert Graves

At the beginning of Chapter 7, John Sinclair offers a disclaimer in respect of the choice of the poem "The Legs" for stylistic analysis at the Dartmouth Conference in 1966. He says emphatically that he did not choose the poem for analysis and that he would not have done so because it did not interest him. The poem was written by Robert Graves, a poet often regarded as obscure and recalcitrant when it comes both to interpretation and analysis. Sinclair comes very close to the insight that prompted the discovery of subtextual access to literary texts: he

remarks upon the uneven ratio between lexical and grammatical words, noting that the latter are more plentiful. And yet, we see no move to drive his interpretation of the poem's vocabulary (metaphysics) rather than from its grammar and logic. His concentration upon grammar yields as much as it can, given that it is, on its own and with only sparse reinforcement for the poem's lexis, always steeped in intuitive opacity.

In what follows, I attempt to show how a deeper 'take' on the vocabulary and the logic of this admittedly often unyielding poem may be obtained through a *subtextual* search. In particular, I begin with a method that I unveiled at a conference in Moscow roughly three years ago (Louw 2013). My paper there suggested that the first lines of poems often *prospect* both the themes and transitions of the rest of the poem and its conclusions [see also Milojkovic and Louw (2016) where Milojkovic uses the same method to prospect aspects of students' submitted assignments]. In what follows I use a small corpus of 44.5 million words of *The Times* newspaper for 1995 that was created for me by the late Tim Johns. It yielded only two lines for my analysis. However, both of the expanded contexts take up the notion of sexual impropriety; in one case an improper joke about the celibate clergy and in the other the morbid fascination of the public with a heterosexual friendship, precisely because it involved no sexual activity at all.

Here are expanded contexts for those concordance lines:

Search Line: **there+was+this+*+and**

1 "Then <u>there was this interesting and pathetic</u> handling of my friendship with Limahl. It received an extraordinary amount of attention for a relationship that was not sexual."
2 "The story began as a sort of bad yuletide joke <u>there was this monk and this nun</u>, see, and they got lost in a storm when suddenly lo, they came across a rude hovel replete with inviting hay and fragrant clover. Anyway, he promised to kick the habit if she'd waggle her wimple…"

Even this small amount of sexual innuendo is enough to provide a symbolic meaning for the *puddles* that get splashed in, in the final stanza, as the persona's legs (once doubted by their owner) take off on a frolic of their own. They manage twenty indiscretions before they can be controlled! But it is the subtext of *from the knees down* that contrasts most vividly with what legs are *fated* to do, controlled as they are, from *above* the knees. Note that in the concordance that follows there is some reference to nudity, but that there are no matches for ill-fated knees that are always on the move.

```
MicroConcord search SW: from the *down
80 characters per entry
Sort: 1R/SW        shifted -1 characters.

 1 ne of which had been vaporised from the waist down. A large pool of blood lay co
 2 ess but is blind and paralysed from the neck down.   According to Mr Zarifeh, Dr
 3 , the Superman actor paralysed from the neck down after a riding accident, could
 4  UNIVERSITY graduate paralysed from the neck down after a birthday prank allowed
 5 hs. However, she was paralysed from the neck down and spent the rest of her shor
 6 Christopher Reeve is paralysed from the neck down and fighting  for his life afte
 7  18 years ago she is paralysed from the neck down and became totally dependent o
 8 These decisions have been made from the top  down and not the bottom up and good
 9 head, but he remains paralysed from the neck down and breathing through a respir
10 is it?" Now he's only grinning from the nose down and he says in a voice that im
11 rch 21 two girls were stripped from the waist down and indecently assaulted. The
12 er way in, and then pose naked from the waist down.   At the installations centr
13 ke for someone with no feeling from the neck down but a very sharp brain. For th
14 reet hospital where, paralysed from the neck down but mentally alert,  she died.
15  into the first half, well away from the play. Down by the corner flag,  Ray Wilki
16 uperman role who was paralysed from the neck down by a riding accident last summ
17 om up rather than be delivered from the top down by our political masters.   Par
18  accident leaves her paralysed from the waist down. Chantelle (Alfre Woodard) is
19  0, Mayfield has been paralysed from the neck  down, confined to a wheelchair, and
20  Experimental chemical weapons from the Porton Down military research laboratori
21 son Fadi, 11, is now paralysed from the waist down by transverse myelitis, a rec
22  re hit by blizzards and floods from the Grampians down to Suffolk, Essex and Ken
23 ction to restore its fortunes, from the boardroom down to the shopfloor.     This
24 nel to take a breather: "Again from the fields down below the mist there came  th
25  but there was so much support from the women down below." Caroline will also cl
26 art restaurant where everybody from the owner down is a fanatical  poker  player
27 rr Schauble has been paralysed from the waist down and  confined  to a wheelchair
28 art restaurant where everybody from the owner down is a fanatical  poker player.
29 art restaurant where everybody from the owner down is a fanatical poker  player.
30 he next royal icing as I skied from the Hoyfjellshotell down  towards the frozen
31 art restaurant where everybody from the owner down is a fanatical  poker  player
32.   One in five households rents from the council, down from one in three in 1983.
33 een months on she is paralysed from the chest down, and will be in a  wheelchair
34 mplain. Not only do ministers, from the highest down, often prevaricate, but the
35  dependent on clear commitment from the directors down, both to the need for,and
36 i-skirted hitch-hiker are seen from the waist down, jiggling absurdly as he driv
37 wave after wave of im-migrants from the Huguenots down, and he came back with hi
38 s of sterling. While everyone, from the Chancellor down, had agreed by the end o
39 t only naked but painted green from the waist down, braved winter weather to lan
40 ot only horizontally, but also from the captain down.   Even more crucially, bot
41  will be permanently paralysed from the neck down, forever imprisoned in the cir
42 f his life, left him paralysed from the chest down, he continued to do his tribu
43 a philandering solicitor naked from the waist down, his wrists bound by neck-tie
44 cident on Sunday, is paralysed from the neck down, his doctors said last  night.
45 ation of executives to control from the top down. However, these management stru
46 ng task of humanising the LAPD from the top down. If he succeeds, a major source
47 LADY TEBBIT, who was paralysed from the neck down in the Brighton bombing of 198
48 e, who was similarly paralysed from the neck down in a riding accident in May, s
49 he accident left him paralysed from the waist down. "Initially you don't realise
50 servants to roll up her tights from the waist down into  the shape of a sausage.
51 ciation. She warned: "Football from the top down is becoming increasingly  selfis
52 hort-track champion, paralysed from the chest down, meant that O'Reilly had  the
53  our view of Michael Heseltine from the chest down not blocked by a big table wi
54 ses said the collapse occurred from the top down. One motorist said the  streets
55  representative team and build from the top down."   Sarfu is also to  implement
56 as almost completely paralysed from the neck down, she cared for him with a self
57  Even though she was paralysed from the neck down "she led a very full life befo
58   ven. Irma had been paralysed from the neck down since the explosion and had re
59 it was trying to impose change from the top down,rather than trying to bring peo
60 sh-faced 21-year-old paralysed from the neck down, that he spent months in a ful
61 injury that left her paralysed from the chest down.  The letter-writer had never
62 oyd is now blind and paralysed from the neck down.   The High Court at Christchu
63 rom a horse left him paralysed from the neck down, the  American actor described
64 speak, and virtually paralysed from the neck down the condition in which he surv
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65 justice was to be administered from the top down.   The trial itself revealed th
66 sked how energy is transferred from the Sun down through the atmosphere, the exp
67 ingredients of supper and walk from the farm down to the river where, on a coupl
68 Cunarders. The gaunt stairwell from the bar down to the dining room is livened b
69  95</Date>  <Headline>A lesson from the mates Down Under</headline>   <byline>Ma
70  Britain while Irma, paralysed from the neck down, was nursed at Great Ormond St
71   French say, the fish perishes from the head down…     Well, the reader may demu
72 nd up looking slightly plaited from the waist down." When she takes off her heel
73 ong bone. He was anaesthetised from the waist down  while the surgeon went about
74 ooks like a history professor. From the neck down, with legs that have the girth
75 Although he was left paralysed from the neck down  with injuries consistent with
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Data from TIMES95.TXT

It is worth noting that the persona prizes his freedom as an observer in lines 23–24 ("On grass by the road-side/Entire I stood"; see Chapter 7 for the reproduction of the poem). He has escaped the atomism of the poet's vivisection of the human race (into mere legs) and refers to himself in the language of the Jockey Club as an *entire* (ungelded) on stationary legs that are apparently immovably under his control. But entires are, of course, ironically, always *standing at stud*! Their sexuality is planned, civilised, controlled and remunerative. The poet plays with the empiricism of *paralysis* twice in the course of the poem, but especially during the stanza where the persona speculates about the potential for the erring and straying of his own legs. A gentle erotic touch of the ankles sets them off. It involves the sovereign issue of autonomy: are not my legs my own? Is their fate decided, senseless and frightening because they are always on the move of their own accord? There is potential in Stanza 2 for blindness to assume a moral dimension within the theme of handicap and paralysis. Sinclair handles the slogans in lines 17 and 18 ("Legs for the road,/The road for legs") especially well, and the phrase 'resolutely nowhere' (line 19) lampoons what politicians actually accomplish if the slogans succeed in getting them elected.

By the time we reach Stanza 8 ("Though my smile was broad/The legs could not see,/ Though my laugh was loud/ The legs could not hear") the legs are stubbornly impervious to smiles and laughter. The sad irony is that legs do not stray inexorably, by themselves. They *implicate* their owners. With all the frantic movement, we now reach an example of what Sinclair calls 'arrest' and to herald it, the theme of paralysis returns, before 'arrest' ends and the persona is sucked into the behaviour of the rank and file, ostensibly a reprisal for the narcissism of loving his own ankles. The technique is akin to the manner in which Milojkovic handles the expansion by David Lodge of devices where matters of shocking import are handled in language that is emotively unmarked to the point of banality (see Chapter 9 in Louw & Milojkovic 2016).

33 My head dizzied then, then…
Might I too be a walker
From the knees down?

In a positive semantic prosody in the final stanza, the persona has all of his many dignified aspects restored to him (with no further mention of any equine prowess) as we see in the following shortened collocation list for *regained.*

**Table 15.1** Lexical collocates for the poem "Legs"

| node | lexical collocates |
|---|---|
| regained | lead; control; consciousness; initiative; composure; title; paradise; poise; form; advantage; position; power; confidence; eventually; breath; status |
| unchained | superman; love; melody; passion |
| resolutely | disorganised; failed to lift off; ignorant; ignored; stuck; unambitious; undistinguished; unremarkable |

Source: The 1995 *Times* newspaper corpus

## 15.5 Corpus-derived Subtext: A stylistic theory that 'wags the dog' and itself becomes a new linguistic theory

How shall we know when we are dealing with a new linguistic theory? There are several indicators. A major one involves being able to find aspects of the same result by different means. So, suppose we are interested in devising a corpus-based means for finding what is (a) a situational context and co-text from a single sentence or fragment of a sentence which we will call the *given*, using *co-selection* of its lexical contents; and (b), in spite of intuitive opacity, searching for the fragments of its grammar string, having wildcarded all lexical items (see Louw 2010b; Louw & Milojkovic 2016). And suppose we use a famous line like that of J.R. Firth, *One meaning of *is its *with *;* in the case of the following line as a search line in a reference corpus such as the British National Corpus? The wildcard that occupies the position just before *with* in the given is the term *collocability.*

**is+its+*+with+***

This is what the search reveals:

```
MicroConcord search SW: is its *with *
80 characters per entry
Sort: 1R/SW   unshifted.
 1 er in Section 3.6. </p> <p> One is its association with the rather  questionable
 2 er feature of the rural economy is its relationship with urban labour markets. T
 3 everal attractive features. One is its con-sonance with  what  is  generally  ac
 4  has come through to the public is its preoccupation with sex. The idea that dre
 5 inguishing feature of the model is its concern with the secular development of t
 6 e developed from these sketches is its interaction with social forces — literall
 7 ion). At the deepest level this is its symmetry with the social order within whi
 8 eat strength of 123 For Windows is its compatibility with all the earlier versio
 9  mathematically, but that, such is its concern  with the quantitative aspects of
10 along a bay. What sets it apart is its situation, with the  massive range of the
11  set the TG100 apart.  The first is its conformity with the  General MIDI Specific
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12 p> A common image of later life is its association with residential care and ins
13  integral part of Eo's strategy is its partnerships with the companies, it says,
14 st strength, on the other hand, is its compatibility with Windows. It's a streng
15 n important feature of research is its concern with the nature of the event unde
```

Source: BNC

To the right of the node we find in the BNC all of the variables of the wildcarded *collocability*. This is a feat that no cognitivist can achieve because of *intuitive opacity*. This discovery places us in a uniquely powerful position, because it assists us in getting past opacity and in defining, refining and sharpening our terminology. This in turn allows us a theory that not only 'legislates' the admissibility of variables in relation to the logic that it extracts from grammar strings, but we notice something unique in relation to the term: *collocability* in the given. All of the variables in the concordance refer to things that are exophoric or *outside* of language itself, but *collocation,* alone, operates endophorically, i.e. *inside* language as a system.

In this way, the term *collocability* is offered *partial* definitions, most of them relevant, by means of the *inductive* use of the corpus. But notice that we used the *grammar words that are opaque to our intuition* in order to obtain the concordance. The words to the right of the node are the lexical variables as collocates of the *logic* of natural language. And, even though as vocabulary terms, they are what we would call intuitively *metaphysics*. They are not 'pure metaphysics' as the phrase often runs, but *entailed* metaphysics of a grammar string that we know must also entail natural language logic in addition to what is, for our purposes, irrelevant details of *grammar*. So, we are now in a unique position: we can (1) use the lexis of the given in the form of co-selection to obtain a reading that is based around vocabulary (our intuition can see some of it), and (2) we can obtain all the lexical variables that entail the logic of the sentence and are hence bound with it (and our intuition could see *none* of it). And because these latter forms are so bound, they may be deemed to be *interpretive* of a *given* that nobody would have guessed, intuitively, they had any association with at all and that nobody might have visualised mentally in its entirety. Notice also a hint of the nature of the *a priori* is also present: the collocates of natural language logic are resistant to semantic change in ways that the collocates of metaphysics are not! Prior is prior.

This makes it less plausible and impossible for variables to be 'made up' intuitively as we go along, except perhaps in the case of poetic licence; but even then our theory is robust enough (thanks to John Sinclair) for us to know that *ladder* is a *person, a valued and missing human being*, in the poem "The Circus Animals' Desertion" (Louw & Milojkovic 2014) to which we shall return. There are important 'deaths" within theory caused by this type of experiment and there are trivial ones, such as the possible death of the *cloze* test (we sigh: 'About time, too'); an

important one, the demise of the cognitive. At this point, vistas open up for stylistics and they are only available because John Sinclair put the instrument in place.[2]

However, he unwittingly played a major role in establishing in my mind an *argument* for splitting the atom of the Vienna Circle: parting in natural language logic from metaphysics. Members of the Circle were, after all, in terms of 'schools of philosophy', *realists.* This fact assists in helping us to regard discrepancies between grammar and logic as capable of being 'smoothed' as the philologists' term was always used to suggest. Whether an item belongs to grammar or to logic is less important in the case of realist philosphers than in the case of non-realists.

Sinclair's rationale that helped settle my method in 2008 is one that is of great relevance to stylistics and I shall call it the 'Willis and Willis Argument' (named after those who bore a similar but less complex argument out in a set of Cobuild ELT books (see Willis & Willis 1988).[3] Requiring from stylisticians a 'command of the language', Sinclair forwarded that if a learner of English were to be exposed to all of the uses of all of the most frequent 2,000 items on the descending word-frequency list of the Bank of English corpus, then *that* learner would have a desirably fluent level of proficiency in the language. It operated as a deeper dimension than his earlier notion (see Sinclair & Renouf 1988) that a Lexical Syllabus had become a possibility after the publication of the first edition of the dictionary.[4]

I adapted Sinclair's notion to my conjecture for splitting logic and metaphysics along the lines suggested by Russell (1956: 197) that a perfectly logical natural language would have a grammar but no vocabulary at all. But I turned his model on its head: there are no vocabulary items between THE at the top of the frequency list and TIME at position 70. None of the forms between 1 and 69 and their combinations within that range could qualify for use as wildcards in a subtextual search. Of course, this method mixes grammar and logic, but these are easily separated because the output is to the concordance, and its lines (taken as shared logical form) produce contexts and co-texts of situation that have a shared logic in common with all other lines of the resultant concordance, which has: (1) the *a priori* and one end of a cline and (2) a form of *paganism* at the other end.

Now, in case this looks either trivial or complex, or simply confusing, we need to show the power for stylisticians and for citizens of the products of the 'Willis

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2. See Milojkovic's work on authorial intention in Pushkin and subtextual stylistics (Louw & Milojkovic, 2016)

3. See also ⟨http://www.birmingham.ac.uk/Documents/college-artslaw/cels/lexicalsyllabus/intro.pdf⟩

4. Sinclair, J.M. & Renouf, A. 1988. A lexical syllabus for language learning. In *Vocabulary and Language Teaching,* R. Carter & M. Mccarthy (eds). Harlow: Longman.

and Willis Argument' in the context of subtextual stylistics, as this is entirely unwittingly stated at the end of his computerless career by the renowned Wykeham Professor of Logic at Oxford, the late Michael Dummett. He is interviewed in the appendix to his book on analytic philosophy (Dummett 1993).

## 15.6 Do Sinclairan corpora provide for stylisticians what Dummett needed in order, fully, to settle his view of the philosophy of language?

When do we *know* that we have a new linguistic theory that represents bivalent truth? We know it when we can see that everything that we have and to which we have access comes together and satisfies every detail demanded by the philosophers and does so to the point of over-provision, leaving no doubt.

Such a philosopher is Michael Dummett and we are privileged to have his interview with Joachim Schulte, recorded in October, 1987 (ironically at the time that the first edition of the Cobuild dictionary was being launched). Let us see what he *wants*, and what he *asks for* and what he *hopes for* and then *show* what the entire output of John Sinclair provides. We enter the interview as Dummett the non-realist is being asked about the contributions of Gottlob Frege and separately about the Vienna Circle. I propose to make the material and corpus-based responses to it quasi-dialogic.

1. Dummett writes:

"Frege held that truth and falsity are the references of sentences… if we substitute for a singular term occurring in a sentence another singular term with the same reference, but a different sense, the whole sense of the sentence …changes" (1967: 49)

2. We reply:

If we provide *proof* in the form of access to reference corpora, we realise at once that the substitution we wish to make is disallowed by the whole of the language itself. In Popper's terms, we have a more robust theory than those that have preceded it (Magee 1985: 35). It is a theory that derives its power authentically from the whole of the language.

3. Dummett writes:

"The only thing which it appears *must* in these circumstances remain unchanged is the truth-value of the sentence… the truth value is …rather like that between the sense of a definite description and the object for which it stands."

4. We reply:

The truth-value is provided by the empiricism of the logical aspect of the *given* sentence as discovered from a reference corpus. However, because of intuitive opacity we cannot see the precise *variables* that the language attests. In the case of a line provided by the poet W.B. Yeats we see in the *given* that the language disallows:

> 'Now that my *ladder's gone,* I must lie down…'

Stylistics alone now satisfies Dummett's requirements to the point that we need to resign any title that we may claim for ourselves, such as that we *are cognitivists,* because our intuition and that of any human being simply cannot supply the *true variables and their frequency* for the slot in the given containing 'ladder'. The Google Books (Davies 2011-) corpus provides two sets of variables in the slot of 'ladder', (a) a significant person ('father', 'mother', 'son', 'husband', 'brother', 'wife', 'daughter', 'master', and b) a quality essential to (honourable) existence ('mind', 'life', 'heart', 'time', 'hair', 'innocence', 'name', 'honour'). Clearly, the first set indicates a sense of human loss. Hence, the type of search that uncovered the unattested variable is *subtextual* (Louw 2010a; 2010b; Louw & Milojkovic 2014; 2016). A search of this kind satisfies the Verification Principle of the Vienna Circle; or as James Ladyman puts it, "… the meaning of a non-tautological statement is its method of *verification*; that is the way in which it can be shown to be true by experience" (2002: 151). Yeats assists our feeble intuition by providing a hint in the terms *gone* and [Maud *Gonne*].

5. Dummett writes:

"The fundamental fact… is that our understanding of language is the *grasp* of a system or structure… I mean the existence of multiple inter-connections, so that the understanding of one sentence will in general depend on the understanding of a *great deal else* of the language, according to the overt or implicit complexity of the sentence. (My emphasis) (1993: 191)

6. We reply:

A subtextual search for the natural language logic of the given provides, from a large reference corpus, essentially the same broad contexts as a search of the metaphysics (vocabulary) of the same given. But where the vocabulary is a deviant literary device such as 'ladder', the *subtext* provides its true meaning, not in the form of *truth as averred*, but *truth as required by the language itself as a whole.* (Louw & Milojkovic 2014)

7. Dummett writes:

"There is a very strong drive to take a realist view, and I by no means want to commit myself to dismissing it as a mere error of the human mind… I find it hard to believe that the arguments against realism are as strong as they give the appearance of being… It may be that there is some intermediate standpoint, but I cannot see just what it would be." (1993: 192)

8. We reply:

Amen! Corpora, correctly used along the lines suggested indirectly by Russell (before computers were strong enough to carry out the task), satisfy the verifiability criterion of meaning *empirically*. Concordances that we used to use to examine 'word meaning' can now be made to display *shared logical form*; and among the many current benefits that this type of search is producing are corpus-derived *empathy* (Louw & Milojkovic 2015); the disclosure of the *synthetic a priori*; and the ingredients of an impressive collocation-based 'Imitation Game' (Turing 1950), to name but a few. Perhaps most importantly since December 1942 (and with the now completed effluxion of the 70 year-rule) proof that *collocation* (so dear to Firth and Sinclair) is involved in the process of the *Consilience of Inductions* (Whewell 1860). Consilience from Latin, *con+salire* means a leaping together. It is common cause that aspects of language that are syntactic are less likely to 'leap', but collocation is unconstrained and hence free to leap, to the point that the ability of collocation to chunk contexts of situation as it drafts separate entries for a Cobuild dictionary must be considered a form of consilience, as we see in the small table below:

**SYNTACTIC vs 'ABSTRACTED AT THE LEVEL OF SYNTAX'**
(Firth 1957)

| | |
|---|---|
| LOGIC | COLLOCATION |
| GRAMMAR | |
| MATHEMATICS | |

The 'abstraction' (Latin: *abs+trahere*, to 'draw + away') of collocation also frees it to thread together the 'possible worlds' of contiguous sentences, something which Siobhan Chapman (personal communication) has hitherto considered a major stumbling block within realism in philosophy. The shared collocation of contiguous sentences can now be demonstrated to be 'entailed' even when the collocates involved are not actualised in the given. The insights of a French literary critic like Roland Barthes who refers to *absences* are now borne out.

## 15.7 Conclusion

When we examine the papers in stylistics collected in this volume we are immediately struck by the accuracy of the last lines of Mike Scott's entry for John Sinclair (Chapman & Routledge 2005: 255): "He has throughout his career always been one step ahead of his contemporaries, often two or three, in seeing possibilities and questioning accepted theories. He has acted as a sower of seeds and a catalyst."

And yet, in his refreshing work in stylistics, Sinclair remained loyal to grammar and generous to others who set out to create applications for his ground-breaking work in corpus studies. In spite of the huge breadth and scope of the OSTI study (Sinclair et al. 2004), he shows disarming levels of candour in his interview by Wolfgang Teubert.

> The underlying problem of collocation is a very simple one, and because it is so simple, I never, as far as I remember, actually wrote it down on paper, and I never took it up with Firth or Michael Halliday. Collocation, I reasoned, restricts the meaning of the words involved, it does not enhance it. Now if collocation is a reduction in meaning, then *dark night* is not one of the meanings of *night* but a reduction of the meaning of *night*. This cannot be the answer. But it took a long time to give up the traditional concept of the word as the unit of meaning. Once we accept that words can be co-selected, not chosen always one at a time, then there is no longer a problem with *dark night*… The phrase *dark night* has its own meaning; roughly speaking, the notion "dark" is already present in the notion "night" (though not all nights are dark, it is a characteristic of a night to be dark)… (Sinclair et al. 2004: xxi)

The notion that *night* contains *dark* is Wittgensteinian and means, because of that form of entailment, that the occurrence of the free-standing collocates of both forms can now be predicted either on the basis of one form on its own or of both forms co-selected. We now return briefly to the motive and fabric of John Sinclair's stylistics and move to a conclusion that shows how his computational instrumentation provides a flawless and truthful path into the future of stylistics as a discipline.

### 15.7.1 Trends within Sinclair's stylistics

Sinclair's legacy is multi-faceted and needs careful unpacking and interpretation. His primary motive in stylistics is always personally recreational and publicly entertaining with a didacticism that comes as a surprise. Many of the surprises, although based upon the task in hand, leave the reader amazed or even agreeably troubled. For example, they often turn upon an obvious point of interpretation that the reader has missed. The introduction to Chapter 13 (p. 209 in this volume), a revised version of a paper written in 1986, opens with a paragraph

that creates a deductive argument: if we spend our lives telling lies, how can we expect the external world to be anything other than *fictional*? Within the short space of a few pages, a linguistic theory that is to be mastered within its exceptional rules has taken shape with headings such as 'Fact and Averral' and 'Correspondence' that evince a deep understanding of philosophical truth. We are brought to a theoretical statement that no extant linguistic theory has either planned, let alone mastered:

> What actually happens in language is a galaxy of half-truths, exaggerations, generalisations, expressions of feelings, and mistakes of all kinds. All these are regularly taken as positive correspondences by the default convention, unless challenged. (Chapter 13.3: 211).

From oblique allusions to Russell and Frege to Tarski and Dummett, we are whisked through some very plausible Wittgensteinian discourse-based truth tables, and finally pointed in the direction of… *ourselves*: *we are what we agree to*. The philosophy is finally paraded very deftly as argument (Chapter 13.10: 224). Sinclair always leaves something for the audience to ponder: how much have we gained or missed out on simply by agreeing?

### 15.7.2 The debt to scholarship and to theory

I alluded earlier to John Sinclair's desire to entertain an audience through his stylistics, either in print or in person. But there was always a more serious side to this. Many of his now legendary clashes with The British Council [BC] were caused because he felt a need to reach as many teachers of English as possible. This was done by means of links with various countries, but the content of the teaching was always uniquely based upon his empathy with teachers in two main ways: (1) What teachers needed to be and to become; and, (2) what linguistic theories needed to emphasise in order to be of material value and assistance to them. He kept the answers simple but effective. Teachers needed to read around all of current linguistic theory in the libraries of the BC; and teachers needed to drop bookish solutions to teaching problems by engaging with language situations drawn from real life that allowed teacher-talk to be recorded and analysed, placing more emphasis on the pragmatic aspects of linguistic description.

This often meant that his work in ELT engaged more deeply with classroom teaching than many linguistic theories allowed for. His stylistic output was deliberately run in relation to particular problems of theory and praxis, such as what teachers need to know, the mismatch between theories and the classroom. and the main areas of language awareness. In 1992, the latter area brought about the launch of a research journal on the subject. He was Chair of *Language Awareness* (his position was honorary and lasted about ten years).

He told me that he found classroom aspects exhausting and, about five years before his Scottish Schools (CANAN) project. He informed me that he had withdrawn completely from classroom approaches. This proved premature. His lively book co-authored by Professor Anna Maurenen operates almost at the level of a massive literacy movement, and the CANAN Project was, as I stated earlier, arguably the most original piece of work ever to have been brought into Primary schools anywhere.

The schools played a major role in every aspect of his work, from segmentation ('chunking') to semantic prosody and the use in TEFL of large corpora. Everything that was taught towards accomplishing a 'command of the language' was regarded as being of use in stylistics and the teaching of literature. This often had dramatic results. One of his favourite examples was a public lecture on *Measure for Measure* that he had attended around 1960. It was delivered by J.R. Firth at the University of Leeds and he had used collocation alone to unravel all of the intricacies of the play, to the delight of the audience who rose to give him a standing ovation. Sadly, all copies of that lecture have been lost.

Once the corpus of spoken data had been gathered, Sinclair produced what is arguably the best interpretation of "La Belle Dame San Merci" by Keats (see Chapter 5). It is especially powerful when taught in countries that have a strong oral tradition because Sinclair has produced an almost formulaic dramatic monologue within that tradition. It is universally transferable. Although he does not use the term *relexicalisation* about the poem, he captures the same sense when he holds that "There is no evidence of a 'watering down' of the poetic effects in this area, since many of the changes [brought by the pupils themselves] represent something more like a 'concentration' of meaning.' (Chapter 5.3.2: 54)

But true to Sinclair, the scientist, he would always bring to his papers in stylistics his own simple but powerful terminology, as many chapters in this book show. Sinclair's eye as a stylistician is unerringly cinematographic. But I want to conclude this subsection by showing how his paraphrase in Chapter 6 (p. 64) anticipates a definition of a semantic prosody as a *fractured* context of situation.

> The snow will not grow, but *something*
> Else will, and when it does it will grow
> to look utterly unlike the snow. (my emphasis)

The term 'growing' in the poem is part of a negative semantic prosody crafted by Larkin. The occasion of the birth of young lambs is meant to be joyful, but it is tinged with menace here because the term 'something' is both unspecified, nasty (because of the appearance of 'utterly') and on the move. The ability to find semantic prosodies is also growing here in John Sinclair's awareness and is incorporated into his stylistic method (see later chapters in this volume).

At this point, it is worth setting out definitions for two terms that I have used to describe this closing chapter. They are, of course, drawn from the second edition of the Cobuild Dictionary of which John Sinclair was the Editor-in-Chief. Between them they define the paradox of Sinclair's stylistics:

*Unlearn*

> If you unlearn something that you have learned, you try to forget it or ignore it, often because it is *wrong or it is having a bad influence on you*.
> (my emphasis) (1995: 1831)

Dr. Rosamund Moon (personal communication) found the first day of her work on the Cobuild team most memorable because John Sinclair asked all of them to forget everything that they had ever learned about dictionaries and to see the work as a new start.

*Transcend*

> Something that transcends normal limits or boundaries goes beyond them, *because it is more significant than them.* (my emphasis) (1995: 1779)

Both of these terms involve the maxim that Sinclair used as the title of *Trust the Text* (2004). And as there can be no subtext without the text and all of its recoverable empiricism, 'trusting the subtext' may now be seen as a rider to this slogan of scientific truth.

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